

Patrick Carroll (Order #46211587)



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LEAD DESIGNER
Rickard Antroia

PROJECT MANAGER AND EDITOR
Kosta Kostulas

CONCEPT DEVELOPMENT
Rickard Antroia, Mattias Johnsson Haake, Nils Karlén, Kosta Kostulas

COVER ART
Martin Grip

ILLUSTRATIONS
Gustaf Ekelund

GRAPHIC DESIGN & LAYOUT
Christian Granath

PREPRESS
Dan Algstrand

TRANSLATION
Tim Persson

MAPS
Rickard Antroia, Christian Granath

PROOFREADING
Brandon Bowling

PR MANAGER
Boel Berman

EVENT MANAGER
Anna Westerling

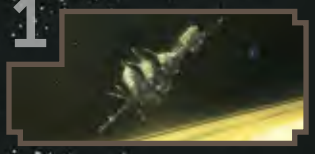
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INTRODUCTION

Welcome to **Wake of the Icons**, the third and final installment of the **Mercy of the Icons** campaign. The fleets of the Eternal Emperor are about to cross the dark between the stars, and the Emissaries are preparing to resist their ancient nemesis once more. Will the peoples of the Third Horizon unite or be destroyed as old prophecies unravel and the cluster is set aflame?

WAKE OF THE ICONS consists of three main parts made up of scenario locations and events that will change the Horizon for good. The opening scenario brings the PCs back to the ruins of Coriolis on a quest to find the lost Emissary, part two contains the beginning of the Old Horizons' invasions, while the third and final part unleashes the Horizon Wars through a series of shorter adventures.

The struggle for the Third Horizon brings the PCs to both familiar places and previously unknown star systems; will they dare to step out into the light and shoulder their burden as the Chosen Ones, destined to unite the Third Horizon – or will they fail? The suite closes with an epilogue outlining the aftermath of the invasion. Although the wounds go deep, there is still hope – the survivors try to come together to rebuild the Coriolis station.

Below is a summary of the events bridging the gap between *The Last Cyclade* and this book. The PCs will learn hidden truths, see behind the masks of the Icons, and finally confront the threat from Ardha.

BACKGROUND

Wake of the Icons begins in the segment of the Messenger in Cycle 164 (CC65) when a familiar voice calls the PCs back to Kua and the remains of Coriolis. Suddenly, the portal between Rigel and Dabaran is shut. Two ships carrying agents from the Warriors of the Holy Light manage to make it through with butterfly ships in lethal pursuit, carrying a message of enormous importance addressed to the cult's former enemies: the PCs. To give you some context for these and future events, the road to war and the scenarios in this book are described below.

THE THIRD HORIZON

Kuan core space is still a neutral zone despite the events in the finale of *The Last Cyclade*. Aqbar Rakiv Fatiman's corsairs and the remaining Legion fleets now contracted by the independent space station Djachroum (see the Rulebook p 296) have so far managed to keep the peace. Laws barring any factionary military vessels from the system without clearance from the Horizon Council are strictly enforced, but lately an increasing number of merchant freighters, Nomad clan ships and smaller colonization vessels have started seeking entry to the forbidden sector around Xene – the space now known as the Quiet Zone. Rumors say that several of the Emissaries have gathered on the old Foundation Station FS-7, protected by the blinding quiet and by unknown weapon systems. A few foolish skippers have dared to enter the Quiet Zone never to be seen or heard from again.

THE ZENITHIAN FACTIONS

The division of power in the Third Horizon has shifted dramatically since the destruction of Coriolis. The Consortium, the Zenithian

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Hegemony and the Syndicate have pooled their remaining resources and fleets in Amedo and taken over the dome city of Xhi from the expatriates (the Rulebook, p 225). Some families sought refuge in Sadaal but quickly became isolated from the siblings due to new and more strict immigration policies. Only the Syndicate appears to have maintained a good relationship with the ruling elite of Sadaal, Aremerat and the eight high priests of the Amesha Spenta. The faction has moved much of its operations to the system and especially the founding Birbasil and Nyala families seem to be thriving. Through the Syndicate and their trading fleet, the Astûrban are trying to negotiate with the Sadaalian leadership for access to the recently constructed Nadir Flotilla, currently in unstaffed orbit above the Daharab dockyards in Bahram, Sadaal's second star system.

Some of the Zenithian families have approached the Horizon Council diplomatically and managed to secure two seats at the table: one for the Consortium's Sonya Dayal in exchange for new weapon systems for Djachroum and an expansion of the reactor core to meet the energy demands of a growing population, and one for Dinad Abarren-Quassar, the nephew of the late Abarren Quassar whose name he and the rest of his remaining family members have chosen to adopt. The appointment of Dayal has caused some friction within the Zenithian ranks, primarily with the Yriedes and Sidonna families, because the former regard themselves as a founding family with a better claim to the seat and because the latter – a family with powerful Foundation interests – greatly desires research access to the mythical Mouth of Kandah.

LOST FACTIONS

The events of *The Last Cyclade* changed most of the earlier factions for good.

- **The Zenithian Hegemony:** Although both the Hegemony and the Consortium suffered enormous losses in the destruction of the Monolith and Coriolis, the Consortium came out on top thanks to the wider spread of their power base. What's left of the Zenithian project has therefore largely been incorporated into the Consortium's hierarchies – many neo-Zenithians have married into established Consortium families and in exchange, the well-respected captain clan from the Zenith has been offered a seat on the board of the newly-formed Zenithian Coalition. The Astûrban has become a division within the Special Branch,

FOR GM EYES ONLY

The entirety of this book is meant to be read by the GM only.

SUMMARY

- **THE THIRD HORIZON** is governed mainly by an uneasy alliance between the Order of the Pariah, the Church of the Icons and the Horizon Council on Djachroum. The different fleets are still struggling to come together and are all plagued by mutinies and defections by mystics drawn to the Emissaries. The factions argue over who now has a rightful claim to the abandoned Nadir Flotilla and are all trying to negotiate with the Sadaalian clergy.
- **THE SECOND HORIZON** gathers a ragtag fleet of devotees around Xene as a defense force for the coming war with the First Horizon, but their efforts jeopardize the stability of the Third Horizon as a whole. The Quiet Zone around the gas giant slowly grows and a mysterious weapon mercilessly protects the faithful from any and all attacks.
- **THE FIRST HORIZON'S** fleets wait patiently for an opening into Taoan but the portal remains unstable. The Vestals begin kidnapping the Kahin – the Nomads' star seers – from portal stations around the cluster, forcing them to predict when the fields are stable enough to start allowing passage. New humanites are being produced in factories in Uharu, bionically perfected for warfare, and then sent to Sadaal to staff the Nadir Flotilla onboard a seized bulk hauler, the Waha-Najima. Meanwhile, a weapons test is being prepared by the Vestals for a strike against Dabaran that will isolate the system completely.
- **THE PCS** are initially blissfully ignorant of the underlying conspiracies but will soon learn more of their own role in an ancient prophecy, as the song of the Machine Icon calls out once more, with dream messages luring them to the remains of the Spire deep in the Kuan jungles...

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THE TRAITORS

The Syndicate operates on the fringes of the new Zenithian Coalition and primarily works to establish local alliances throughout the cluster. The faction's smugglers and traders are highly sought-after for their ability to evade the Horizon's often cluttered trading bureaucracy. Secretly, however, they keep a close eye on the Ardhan threat and are prepared to join the Vestals and the Imperial fleets in the event of a takeover. The Syndicate's flexible views on the rule of law are well aligned with the nihilist principles of the First Horizon.

CURRENT FACTIONS

The Legion and the Free League have split into local groups and are no longer considered factions. The remaining factions of the Third Horizon are:

- **THE ZENITHIAN COALITION – a union between the Consortium and the Zenithian Hegemony**
- **THE SYNDICATE – secretly looking for an alliance with the First Horizon**
- **THE DRACONITES – have absorbed Ahlam's Temple**
- **THE CHURCH OF THE ICONS – allied with the Order of the Pariah but have lost the Circle of Seekers**
- **THE ORDER OF THE PARIAH – allied with Mira and the Church of the Icons**
- **THE NOMAD FEDERATION – looking for allies among the other factions**
- **THE FIRST HORIZON – Vestals and surviving Nazareem cells**
- **THE SECOND HORIZON – the Emissaries, the new mystics, and the Circle of Seekers**

but the two agencies still haven't learned to cooperate fully and infighting hampers the efficiency of the work.

- **Ahlam's Temple:** The Temple chose to leave the Council of Factions and close their courtesan academy on Coriolis before the station's destruction but has since then fully merged with the Draconites. Whispered rumors claim Black Lotuses prepare for war together with the Draconite warrior monks, the Sôhai, in a hidden system beyond the known Horizon.
- **The Free League:** The hands and stevedores' faction broke down and dissolved after the Zenithian smear campaign and its former members now form local alliances with the powers that be on whatever planet, colony or station they happen to work. The League captains formerly contracted by the Colonial Agency or the Foundation have either taken up piracy or become free traders.
- **The Circle of Seekers:** The Circle chose sides during *The Last Cyclade* and left the Church of the Icons and Mira. They have joined the followers of the Emissaries and retreated to remote, forgotten temples to seek contact with their Symmetry masters.
- **The Legion:** The Consortium's former watchdogs have torn up their old contracts and retreated to their own secret bases or taken up arms for Djachroum, Consortium mining colonies in the Quadrant of the Pillar or new employers among the many local rulers throughout the Horizon (see *The Last Cyclade*).

⚙ THE FIRSTCOME ALLIANCE

The erupting tension at the end of *The Last Cyclade* led to major changes for most of the Firstcome factions. The people are in mourning after the fall of Coriolis and pilgrims and former Kuan colonists flock to Mira's bustling Temple City and growing jungle towns, desperately longing for safety and community. The ruling matriarch and patriarch of the Church of the Icons preach to their growing congregation through sermons distributed along all the major trade routes via countless probes and drones.

The Emissaries are painted as false prophets and their control over the new mystics is framed as a serious threat. Increasing numbers of mystics leave their old lives behind to go to Xene and wait for the Emissaries to reveal their next truth. According to the Church, all who follow the Song are being led astray by dark forces. The one true faith is said to protect against the Song's corruptions, if only the afflicted

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come to Mira and repent. The ugly truth, however, is that many mystics are jailed on arrival and transported to internment camps out of the public eye, or shuttled to Zalos for indefinite holding in research facilities deep underground.

The Order of the Pariah have opened their system again after forming a pact with Mira, but the issue is still a matter of much debate in the Martyr Council. The Miran Chain is once again full of free traders and bulk haulers as well as a seemingly endless flow of pilgrims looking for new lives on Mira. The increased traffic has captured the attention of both the heretics of Zalos-B and the more aggressive corsairs. The new main route through the Horizon stretches from Dabaran to Mira, via Kua and Djachroum, and Zalos and the trading post of Karrmerruk. The Alabaster Council on the dwarf planet Marakanda in Altai fears a weakened position and has threatened to make portal use more difficult unless the Nomad Federation is invited to take a more active part in trade negotiations. The Mogul star seers, the Kahin, have an innate ability to understand and calculate safe portal vectors and have therefore taken over much of the Foundation's former portal station responsibilities along the trade routes. Threats of higher jump taxation forced both Zalos and Mira to add Altai to their new cross-cluster trade route, at least for the time being. Although the Nomad Federation is spoken for on Djachroum in the new Horizon Council, the disappearance of the Janhagir fleet has weakened the Nomads and they are still being left out of the more delicate diplomatic issues.

MILITARY MIGHT

The First Horizon's attempts to sunder the factions, manipulate the Zenithians and provoke a war with the Order were only a partial failure. Although the Nazareem have been all but wiped out, the Symmetry's attack on Coriolis destroyed Sky City, the Council of Factions and much of the fleets of the Legion and the Hegemony. It also led to the disappearance of the Janhagir fleet. The factions who still control functioning fleets now protect their own and bide their time. The fleets are described more thoroughly on page 191.

THE SECOND HORIZON

After the Symmetry's attack on the heart of the Zenithian power complex and the destruction of Sky City and Coriolis, the Santulans know the First Horizon can't be far away. The Santulans who chose to astral project into new host bodies in the Third Horizon and become the Emissaries now gather to plan their defense.

THE JUDGE'S LEGIONNAIRES

After the collapse of the Legion, the Judge Emissary takes control over its jailers. They return from a secret Legion base far out in the darkness of Border Space and seize Foundation Station FS-7 in orbit around Xene. Rumors have it that the Emissary returned from the dark with a mighty weapon – the Legion flagship Shahrazad – but no one has yet been able to get close enough to Xene to confirm this. What has become evident, however, is

THE HORIZON COUNCIL

Several of the Council members and central characters either died or lost their power after *The Last Cyclade*, but some have claimed new seats at the Horizon Council. It's up to you as the GM to populate the nine seats of the new Council as you please, or make adjustments as you see fit to the list below depending on previous events in your campaign. The factionary representation is more important than which individual holds which seat.

1. **RAKIV FATIMAN – Djachroum Aqbar (council president)**
2. **MANDRAGOR HO – Draconite (or Terminos Lete) – Ahlam's Temple**
3. **NIGELIA OR ARLAIN KURAHAN – Exiled Zenithian**
4. **SISTER ROBWAH – Samaritan (or Samesh Alim) – The Order of the Pariah**
5. **ABYEIA GOHARSHÛD – Spokesperson for the Nomad Federation**
6. **DARI-MEFTI RAHMALAN – Dabaran dar**
7. **AREM VES-ARIN – Vestï humanite from Odacon**
8. **SONYA DAYAL – Neo-Zenithian**
9. **DINAD ABARREN-QUASSAR – Hegemonist**

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that all the surviving Emissaries that rose from within the gas giant are now back at the site of their birth. With their combined strength representing four of the Icons, they open the bridge to the Second Horizon to seek aid from the siblings there.

THE RESONANCE BRIDGE

The resonance patterns created at Xene – and which can also partly be found in Erequ – form a bridge between the Second and Third Horizons, a bridge used by the Symmetry to create and enslave more and more mystics. The ruling Santulans' most trusted generals are the Dakin – blindly devoted resonance warriors and gurus trained to split their minds and travel from mystic to mystic in the Third Horizon. The Dakin operate as spies, assassins and insurgents and may strike at a moment's notice almost anywhere in the Horizon – the strength of the resonance bridge allows them to invade the mind of practically any mystic in the cluster, turning them into unknowing but lethal weapons.

THE QUIET ZONE

The space around Xene is now a forbidden sector from which no ship returns. The Emissaries have made FS-7 their base and use a resonance weapon (page 141) from within the gas giant's atmosphere to disintegrate any ship that gets too close. The Quiet Zone originally extended 1 AU from the station, but as the resonance patterns stabilize and grow, so too does the Quiet Zone. When the first scenario in this book begins, the Quiet Zone envelops everything within 3 AU in all directions.

THE MYSTIC THREAT

After the Symmetry's attack on Coriolis, the mystics have become feared throughout the Horizon. Suspicion turns into persecution as both the Order and Mira ramp up their search for the new mystics, albeit under the pretense of helping and protecting the "infected". The new mystics as a group are, however, a potent threat as the Song calls on them to turn



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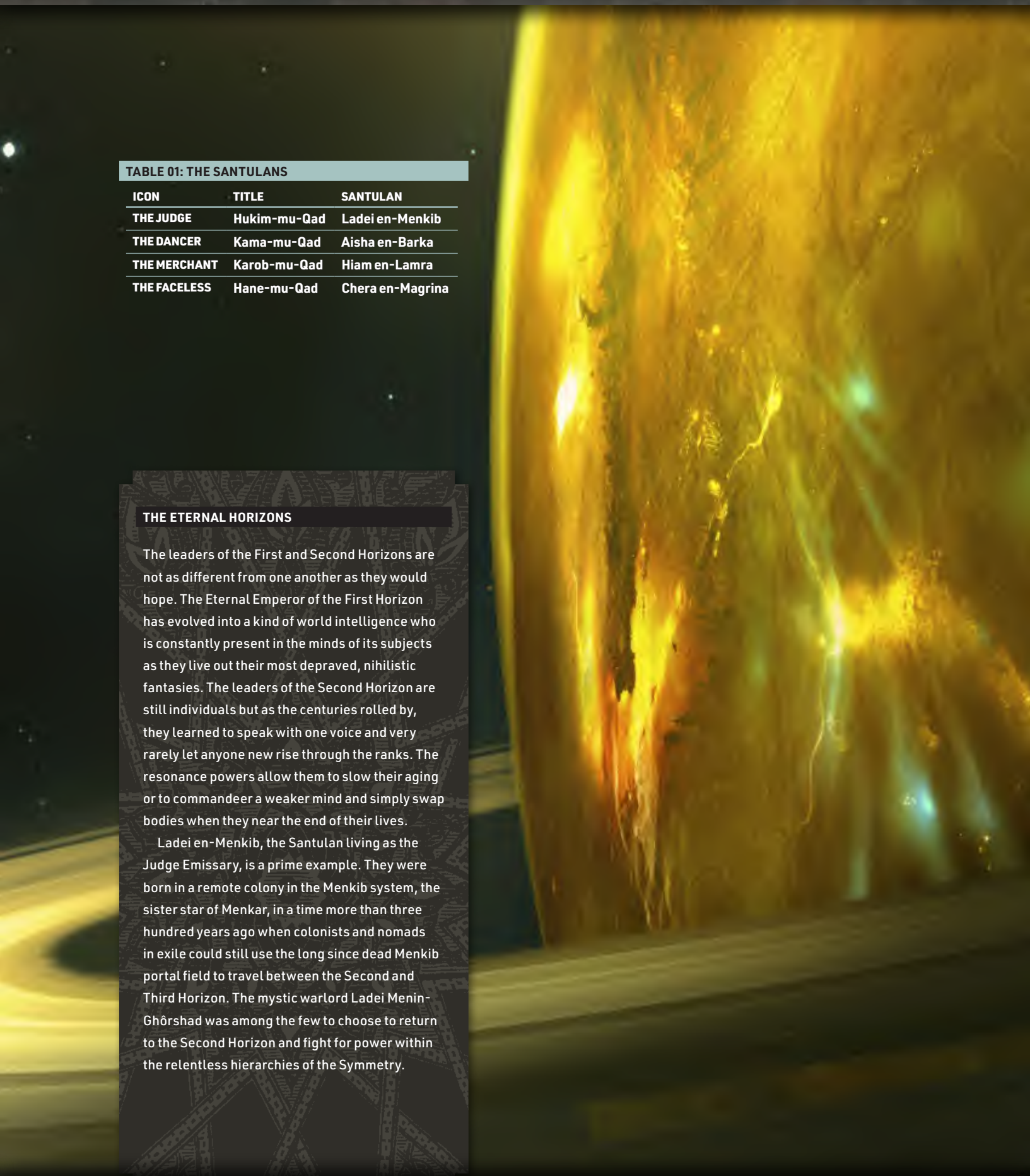


TABLE 01: THE SANTULANS

ICON	TITLE	SANTULAN
THE JUDGE	Hukim-mu-Qad	Ladei en-Menkib
THE DANCER	Kama-mu-Qad	Aisha en-Barka
THE MERCHANT	Karob-mu-Qad	Hiam en-Lamra
THE FACELESS	Hane-mu-Qad	Chera en-Magrina

THE ETERNAL HORIZONS

The leaders of the First and Second Horizons are not as different from one another as they would hope. The Eternal Emperor of the First Horizon has evolved into a kind of world intelligence who is constantly present in the minds of its subjects as they live out their most depraved, nihilistic fantasies. The leaders of the Second Horizon are still individuals but as the centuries rolled by, they learned to speak with one voice and very rarely let anyone new rise through the ranks. The resonance powers allow them to slow their aging or to commandeer a weaker mind and simply swap bodies when they near the end of their lives.

Ladei en-Menkib, the Santulan living as the Judge Emissary, is a prime example. They were born in a remote colony in the Menkib system, the sister star of Menkar, in a time more than three hundred years ago when colonists and nomads in exile could still use the long since dead Menkib portal field to travel between the Second and Third Horizon. The mystic warlord Ladei Menin-Ghôrshad was among the few to choose to return to the Second Horizon and fight for power within the relentless hierarchies of the Symmetry.

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on their captains or steal a ship and make for Kua. A growing fleet of loyal worshipers gathers in Xene's Quiet Zone under the Emissaries' protection and is becoming a worry for both the independent corsairs of Djachroum and the agents of the factions. The Symmetry are gathering a fleet strong enough to resist the First Horizon – no matter the cost for the Third.

Throughout this book, the mystic threat will continue to grow and chip away at the stability of the factionary fleets.

⚙ THE EXILED EMISSARIES

The Symmetry's uniform leadership is far from as united as they would have the rest of the Horizons believe. Two Santulans in exile have chosen to go against their former siblings: the Machine Icon and the Order of Rima.

The Machine Icon: Urni en-Argonnas is one of the exiles and arrived in the Third Horizon as the Messenger Emissary. The agents of the First Horizon managed to destroy Urni's body during the end of the first part of the campaign, *Emissary Lost*, which led to them attaching their mind to the Coriolis station instead, becoming the ethereal Machine Icon, Khari Qa'naan. Together with the rest of the Emissaries, Urni took control of the gathered mystics and used them to activate the Monolith. The destruction of Coriolis should have meant the death of the Machine Icon, but the remains of the downed Spire still rest under the green canopies of the Verkâna Ridge and within it linger fragments of Urni's mind. The Machine Icon feels guilt for the attack and has come to a painful realization: the war between the Old Horizons threatens to crush the peoples of the Third Horizon – peoples Urni has come to love. The former Santulan has decided to turn on their Emissary siblings in order to save the Third Horizon.

The Order of Rima: Forty years before the arrival of the Zenith in Dabaran, one of the Symmetry's oldest mystics found a way to anchor their mind in another body over enormous distances. The mystic, Rima en-Aldaan, split her mind several times and embedded the shards in meditating monks in a Firstcome colony in the Third Horizon. Eventually, the last pieces of Rima's mind traveled over and her original body died. The four old ascetics now sharing Rima's consciousness formed the secretive Order of Rima deep in the forgotten Shinda system, hidden behind the willful Sivas portal fields in the Quadrant of the Pillar. The colony now consists of nomad exiles and former Seekers and is still led by "the Four who are One," the very first of the Emissaries. Rima's embalmed body is revered by the leaders of the Second Horizon as they are unaware that the first Emissary didn't leave them to spread their teachings or to gather wisdom, but because she had come to despise the power structures of the Second Horizon altogether. The Rima monastery on Shiva usually only allows visits from a select few Nomad elders and only when they need insight or guidance before a big decision. But this is now where the Janhagir fleet has headed to gather strength and blessings before the coming war.

THE FIRST HORIZON

The Vestals have forced enslaved colonists from the Tsurabi mines in Taoan and refinery workers from Uharu to construct naval bases and factories in the isolated systems, and in doing so established a strong foothold for the First Horizon. The Emperor's fleets are ready and waiting in orbit around Ainios, the star on the other side of the portal from Taoan. Butterfly ships hide in the space between the portals. A swarm

TABLE 02: THE EXILED SANTULANS

ICON	TITLE	SANTULAN
THE MESSENGER/MACHINE ICON	Nabi-mu-Qad/Khari Qa'naan	Urni en-Argonnas
THE FOUR/ORDER OF RIMA	Chaar-mu-Qad	Rima en-Aldaan
THE MERCHANT	Karob-mu-Qad	Hiam en-Lamra
THE FACELESS	Hane-mu-Qad	Chera en-Magrina

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THE FOUR ICONS

"The Four who are One" and the mind of Rima represent the following Icons to their followers:

- **THE GAMBLER – seeing the world for what it truly is**
- **THE DECKHAND – a welcoming home**
- **THE TRAVELER – wandering the stars**
- **THE LADY OF TEARS – the freedom of the soul and the mind**



The Machine Icon

of termite destroyers armed with fractal torpedoes and batteries of solar drones prepares to guard the passage of the dreaded behemoths of the First Horizon's fleet – the Emperor's carabid cruisers (page 195).

THE DISAPPEARED STAR SEERS

Over the last cycle, several portal stations throughout the cluster have suffered attacks from unknown agents. Marfik, Melik, Yastapol and Ghodar have all lost their star seers – Mogul astronics who have taken over the jump calculations from the Foundation. The kidnappings have been orchestrated by a small group of surviving Nazareem cultists, and they have brought their captives first to Dabaran and then via butterfly ships to Taoan. Enthralled by the Vestals' charismatic powers, the star seers have attempted to analyze the wild fluctuations of the Taoan portals to predict when they would allow the Imperial fleets to jump through safely. A small squadron of termite destroyers and butterfly ships has already made it through and further strengthened the First Horizon's hold of the system.

THE EMPEROR'S HUMANITES

Humanites were always the backbone of the Imperial fleet, its crews and shock troops made up entirely of bionically sculpted soldiers. The Vestals are primarily captains and strategists. During the Portal Wars, the First Horizon relied heavily on the telepathic Vestï humanites until a large group deserted before the final battles around Odacon. This event and almost two centuries of further research has led to the invention of a new generation of sculpted soldiers, the Hadid (page 97), with a natural metallic skin armor, sonar-like sensory organs and minds designed for blind loyalty. Their biocode is brought on a butterfly ship through the portal between Ainios and Taoan, and Uharu factories converted into breeding farms immediately begin mass production. The Hadid are then put in stasis and shipped to various destinations around the Horizon to lie in wait for a surprise attack. The Waha-Najima bulk hauler (meaning "Celestial Oasis") – missing in Dabaran since about five segments before the beginning of the first scenario in this book – reappears, now carrying a deadly load of frozen warriors secretly destined for the Nadir Flotilla in Bahram.

THE SUGAR GLOBES

Another secret weapon in the Emperor's arsenal is the sugar globes, spread wide across the Third Horizon since the Portal

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Wars. These objects of mystery and status can be found on a myriad of planets and are often harvested with a prestigious upper-class market in mind. The sugar-induced glow of the globes is the result of the chemical reaction needed to keep the biocode of the core alive but dormant beneath the thick shell. On the Vestals' command, the globes may be activated (page 155), the sticky liquid inside transforming into swarms of bio sculpted insects feeding off the dark between the stars. The swarms, "hashara" (page 156), target mystics to weaken the Symmetry's power and can corrupt non-mystics both mentally and physically. The hashara's victims become slaves to the will of the Vestals, dark memes twisting their bodies and giving them strange, terrible powers.

THE FALL OF DABARAN

Just before the PCs are called to Kua by the Machine Icon, the lost bulk hauler Waha-Najima reappears near Dabaran. Some of its cargo is unloaded on shuttles and smaller vessels and brought to the nearby portal station before the giant continues toward Sadaal. As it arrives in Rigel, the portal suddenly collapses behind it. A few courier ships are reportedly destroyed by the portal's energy discharges, but these are actually agents of the Warriors of the Holy Light hunted down while trying to escape Dabaran with evidence of the First Horizon's plans. There is no official knowledge of what actually happened.

⚙ THE WEAPONS TESTS

The Vestals saw Dabaran as the perfect location for a series of weapons tests in preparation for the coming war. Three termite destroyers and a handful of butterfly ships accompany the bulk hauler as it reappears in the system and thanks to advanced stealth technology, they initially evade detection. Troops of Hadid humanites led by Vestals storm and conquer Dar Bahri, Lotus and several of the larger darlands and they shut down the portal station. Armed and white clad Hadid soldiers prevent people from leaving the station and a Vestal boards to activate their next hidden weapon – the sugar globes – to begin corrupting and enslaving the residents.

⚙ THE SPIES

An agent from The Warriors of the Holy Light (*Emissary Lost*, page 10) manages to sneak onboard one of the freighters unloading cargo from the Waha-Najima and witnesses the thawing of the Hadid. She relays the information to her comrades but is then discovered and killed. As the sugar globes hatch and swarms of hashara descend on the portal station's population, another agent uses the ensuing panic to hack and copy the surveillance feeds, recording the horrific attack and transmitting the data to three waiting courier vessels.

The transmission is intercepted by an Imperial destroyer which immediately launches fractal torpedoes against all nearby vessels. Two of the couriers escape destruction by jumping blindly through the portal just as it is forced shut. The fleeing pair is then pursued through multiple systems by a group of butterfly ships and although one of the courier captains sacrifices herself to buy some time, the second ship is eventually also destroyed just after it enters Kua. Unbeknownst to the Vestals, however, the last courier managed to launch a probe containing the data toward a waiting freighter that then left the system undetected. The dearly bought evidence from Dabaran will end up in the hands of the PCs during The Tenth Icon, beginning on page 49.

OVERVIEW

The scenarios and conflicts that make up *Wake of the Icons* are summarized below. The starting point is the unexplained closing of the portal between Dabaran and Rigel and the increasing number of mystics hijacking factionary ships to join the Emissaries at Xene. Unrest and mounting tensions threaten the Third Horizon's fragile peace.

A SONG FOR KUA – PAGE 17

The first scenario brings the PCs back to Kua and out into the jungles of the Verkâna Ridge. Rumors of treasure in the ruins of the fallen station spur them on, but they mainly arrive to investigate the song of the Machine Icon they hear in their dreams, whispering of mysterious knowledge and riches. The scenario leads them through jungles and deep underground ruins

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TIMELINE

This concluding suite of scenarios orbits a couple of major events but leaves ample time for your own adventuring ideas in between. After *The Last Cyclade* and the fall of Coriolis, the Coriolis Cycle calendar was replaced by the older Kuan way of measuring time from the burning of Odacon at the end of the Portal Wars. The timeline below chronicles the entirety of the *Mercy of the Icons* campaign including the old Coriolis Cycle calendar:

- **A SONG FOR JAROUMA**, the standalone scenario describing the arrival of the Emissaries, takes place in the segment of the Traveler in C159 (CC60).
- **THE LAST VOYAGE OF THE GHAZALI** details the Taoan Incident and works well as an introduction to the campaign. It takes place during the segment of the Gambler in C160 (CC61).
- **THE MERCY OF THE ICONS PART 1: EMISSARY LOST** takes place in the segment of the Faceless just before the Cyclade in C160 (CC61).
- **THE MERCY OF THE ICONS PART 2: THE LAST CYCLADE** begins in the segment of the Lady of Tears in C161 (CC62) with the discovery of the wreck of the Legion destroyer Zafirah and ends during the Pilgrimaria of C162 (CC63) at the end of the segment of the Judge.
- **THE MERCY OF THE ICONS PART 3: WAKE OF THE ICONS** begins in the segment of the Messenger in C164 (CC65), almost a year and a half after the fall of Coriolis and the founding of the Horizon Council at Djachroum.

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all the way to the vast cave that once was the Abhrra floor of the Spire, the home of the Emissary. The PCs are warned about the coming war and offered an alliance with the former Emissary.

THE TENTH ICON – PAGE 49

The factions are at each other's throats over control of the abandoned Nadir Flotilla. The mythical Aremerat and the high priests of the Amesha Spenta have absolute power in Sadaal. Only through Syndicate connections is a small delegation, escorted by the PCs, allowed entry to negotiate for the future of the fleet.

In this scenario, the PCs once again encounter the Warriors of the Holy Light and receive their secret information about what really happened in Dabaran. They also find out that Aremerat has already assumed control of the Nadir Flotilla and staffed it with First Horizon humanites. The masks of the Sadaal hide many secrets.

THE HORIZON WARS – PAGE 105

The Horizon Wars break out on two fronts as the First Horizon's fleets start conquering systems along the Dabaran circle and the Nadir Flotilla attacks along the Sadaal route. A series of mini adventures and battles allows the PCs' resolve and wit to influence the course of the war. They must work to unite old enemies to bring the fleets and factions of the Third Horizon together, break the Symmetry's control over the mystics, find new allies in the darkness between the stars and repel the Imperial fleets.

In the suite's dramatic finale, the PCs decide the fate of the Third Horizon's future by cutting off the enemy's access to the cluster.

AFTERMATH – PAGE 186

War has swept across the Third Horizon and the survivors now look for a new guiding star to give them hope for the future. Debris from Coriolis is salvaged and combined with the remains of the ships that were destroyed fighting for a free Horizon. With the stars as witnesses, construction of New Coriolis begins – a station for a new time of cooperation and peace in a new Third Horizon.

TIPS FOR THE GM

The scenarios making up *Wake of the Icons* progressively turn more and more intense. The starting adventure may begin in medias res as the PCs are making planetfall on Kua, or begin by interweaving strange dreams and visions in earlier sessions and scenarios. The second scenario has a classic three act structure where the last act ends with a closing event and a dramatic escape. The third and final scenario is different in that it is made up of a series of mini adventures whose outcome weighs heavily on the strategic developments of the Horizon Wars.

⚙ PERSONAL PREFERENCES

This book is designed to take the PCs to many different places in the Horizon and their access to a ship of their own – or lack thereof – should be considered as you prepare. Your players' group concept and play style might also require some alterations to the story. Feel free to substitute important NPCs for characters of your own creation.

⚙ THE CHOSEN ONES

The previous parts of the campaign have situated the PCs at the heart of the action on several occasions. People now consider them to have been chosen by the Icons and many believe that simply being near them works as a kind of blessing against evil. In the first two scenarios in this book, the PCs are also identified as the heroes spoken of in ancient prophecies. They are bound to a higher power through the Machine Icon and are regarded as the champions chosen to lead the peoples of the Third Horizon in the coming war against the darkness. The prophecy reduces the narrative shoehorning otherwise needed to fit their group concept within the different stages of the war.

SCENARIOS

Each scenario starts with a bit of introductory flavor text and a short summary of the plot. These are primarily written for the GM but can be shared with the players if your group can handle a lot of meta information while playing.

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BACKGROUND

The scenarios begin with a walkthrough of the acts and scenes they contain, how these are meant to be played and what background events have led to what the PCs are about the experience.

ACTS

The scenarios are made up of one or more acts divided into separate scenes.

OVERVIEW

Each act begins with a short introduction that can be read aloud to the players and contains a short summary of the immediate plot.

IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

The acts contain lists of all the important characters. The characters are described in more detail in the scene in which they first appear.

DARKNESS POINTS

Coriolis scenarios generally begin with giving the GM as many DP as there are players, down to a minimum of 4 DP. In this suite of scenarios, additional DP will come in the form of special scenes or events to give you as the GM better narrative control over the progression of the war.

SCENES

Coriolis is played in scenes. This allows you to skip tedious periods of time where "nothing happens," to easily tailor the scene order to your plot preferences and to add your own ideas more seamlessly. The starting scenes are, however, recommended as just that – the first scenes of an act or scenario.

SITUATION AND LOCATION

The introductory text at the beginning of each scene will be told from the perspective of a character within the game world. The texts are meant to be flavorful points of departure for your own imagination and can be read aloud to the players. Next is a summary of the scene's major plot hooks and a short description of the location and the situation. All-important plot information will be found in direct connection to the relevant scene.

NON-PLAYER CHARACTERS (NPCS)

Each scene contains a number of important NPCs or ships whose stats and descriptions can be found in the event where they are introduced. Several NPCs have talents or abilities that cost DP to activate. Only spend DP when using such abilities against the PCs, however – if they are instead used for the benefit of, or in cooperation with, the PCs, you can limit the use of the abilities to one free use per scene.

EVENTS

The heart of each scene is the list of events it contains, some of which are unavoidable (labeled mandatory) and some which you may use as you see fit. Events are triggered by spending DP, usually between 0 DP (for a small or mandatory event) and 3+ DP if the event is considered to be a major obstacle in the PCs' way. As the GM, your job is to enable the PCs to find the right clues or plot triggers. This may sometimes require you to design your own events or improvise changes to the ones found in the text. Be kind to your players and remind them of things their PCs should know but that they themselves have forgotten between sessions.

ENDING

Each scenario ends with a summary of what the PCs have experienced and learned, and of what societal consequences this might have led to. There is room for free adventuring, exploration or just some well-earned R&R in between each of the book's three parts.

MYSTIC PCS

In previous scenarios, only mystic PCs could experience premonitions and portentous dreams. As this book begins, however, all PCs are now susceptible to this, albeit to various degrees. Those who choose to merge with the Machine Icon (page 41) will receive special powers throughout the rest of the war.

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A SONG FOR KUA

Beyond the smoke and the ruins,
veiled in blood and grief.
You breathe faith and future.
Underwater, beneath the trees,
in the heavens and in the ground.
A glittering gem, by the people, for the people.

AN HOMAGE TO KUA, THE CONGLOMERATE, C163

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INTRODUCTION

In the first scenario of the third and final part of the **Mercy of the Icons** campaign, the PCs return to ground zero – the Kuan jungles and the remains of the Coriolis station. In dreams and visions, she calls out to them – the young woman with the burning heart and the star-covered dress. The Machine Icon is calling and their meeting with her holds answers for the future – about the prophecy, the Chosen and the Horizon Wars.

IN A SONG FOR KUA, the PCs return to Kua and the dense forests of Verkâna Ridge after being summoned by the former Emissary – abducted, destroyed and then resurrected. They aren't the only ones hearing the Song of the Machine Icon, however: the Children of the Song have been sent by the Santulans to find and return their missing sibling to Xene. The PCs dive into the dangerous woods and then go underground to seek out the remains of the Coriolis Spire. In the darkness of the Abhrra floor, they experience something that will change the Third Horizon – forever.

BACKGROUND

The Emissaries' devastating attack on Kua shocked and paralyzed the cluster, leaving the peoples full of doubt, grief and rage. Hidden power struggles culminated in much upheaval behind the scenes; only a select few know how close the First Horizon came to seizing power in the Council of Factions and having their puppets roll out their masters' invasion. The Third Horizon sunk into hopelessness for a long while after the attack, but now, life is returning to the Conglomerate – the fields are once again cultivated by colonists and farmhands and the jungle ruins are attracting the attention of artifact hunters and explorers. On the bustling station of Djachroum far from the Kuan core, the factions once again make their voices heard through the Horizon Council. But on a darker note, in the closed systems on the farthest end of the Dabaran Circle, enslaved colonists restaff the factories and the fleets of the First Horizon lie in wait just beyond the Taoan portal fields. War is brewing – all it takes is a stray spark to set the whole cluster on fire.

TO BE CALLED BY DREAMS

As the portal between Rigel and Dabaran collapses and the news of this spreads through the Horizon, the PCs experience something odd. Over a few of the first events, the Song of the Machine Icon breaks through to them in dreams and visions, calling them to Kua and the jungles of Verkâna Ridge. The visions also warn them about others on the same quest, mystics looking for the former Emissary. As the GM, use the dreams as you see fit – either as something that only recently began or as something to interweave into your own scenarios in the buildup to this adventure.

A WORLD IN RUINS

The destruction of Coriolis and Sky City has changed Kua dramatically. Much of Covenant City has been buried under debris from the collapsed city above and from the cracked outer shell of the Monolith. The event also destroyed several of the ancient dams, the cataracts, that usually keep the Conglomerate districts from flooding. The Sultra marshes have now laid the districts of Anandra, Tugul, Dan-Tugul, Ara-Ara, Mibea and Little Algol underwater. The Marzu-Khala spaceport survived on its elevated platforms and has become a new hub of life and commerce thanks to its growing river barge souks. Covenant City is believed cursed

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by the Icons and those who dare scavenge among the ruins risk both dark memes and deadly radiation sickness. This doesn't appear to keep the more daring artifact hunters at bay, however.

The Conglomerate's plantations and mining towns burned in the worker uprisings that immediately followed the fall of the Monolith. The jungles are now quickly covering the remains of the old Zenithian and Algolan power structures, except where the ruins have been taken over by Sogoi tribes and worker communities. Kuan society is slowly on the mend and both the Vasma Valley and Verkâna Ridge become free settler frontiers now that the weight of the old yoke has been shed.

On the northern shores of the Gyrides Sea, a new scavenger society of salvage divers and artifact hunters is forming. They call their town Sal-Mulukhad after the section of the station that crashed here and formed a protective atoll of debris. Fortune-seekers en masse gather here to test their courage or their madness against the dark dangers lurking in the twisting durasteel caves of the collapsed Core. Administrators from the Colonial Agency protected by a small squadron of ex-Legionnaires pay handsomely for salvaged materials, Zenithian art or family heirlooms. New contracts appear daily on the holo screens of Al-Qadr, the new city's cantina.

⚙ THE TREASURES OF THE SPIRE

Rumors run wild throughout the Conglomerate about the downed Spire in the jungles and about the riches it allegedly contains. The hoard is said to be guarded by the Machine Icon and a secret cult of former stevedores that keep nosy scavengers away.

⚙ A RETURN TO KUA

Kua has been reshaped and reborn after the Monolith's discharge. The most obvious change is the one in power dynamics, having led to increased freedom and a strong settler mindset at work in the building of new societies among the ruins of the old. Feel free to have your players spend as much or as little time as you like exploring this new Kua before they reach Verkâna Ridge. Another option is to start the scenario in medias res as the PCs have landed their ship near to or on top of the Ridge to look for a way into the ruins.

THE LANDING

VERKÂNA RIDGE: The jungles aren't easy to land in, but a **PILOT** check allows the crew to find a safe spot. A less than critically successful landing means taking up to 3 points of hull damage (with one point of damage subtracted for each six rolled). The sensor operator may test **DATA DJINN** before the landing to award the pilot one bonus die for each six rolled.

Below are some examples of alternate landing spots if the PCs instead wish to approach the Ridge on foot:

- **THE MONOLITH:** The PCs can land in the Marzu-Khala spaceport near the ruins of Covenant City, and then make it up the overflowing Ramishah on a river barge, to Baybasin or the rocky sides of the Ridge.
- **BAYBASIN:** The spaceport at the mining town is still in operation despite the uprisings, but the sinkhole has widened even further as a result of earthquakes following the Monolith's discharge. From Baybasin, the PCs can head upward and inward, trekking up the slopes and entering the jungles above.
- **THE GYRIDES SEA:** If your group wishes to see something new, you can lead them to the floating city of Sal-Mulukhad on the north shores of the Gyrides Sea. They can hire someone there to ferry them across the water to the steep southeastern coast of the Ridge.

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THE WILDERNESS GUIDE

Regardless of where the PCs land, you can have the wilderness guide (page 30) spot the landing and offer his services, for example after they have asked around town for directions or if they appear lost in the jungles. Alternatively, they meet him in the burned village of Alamuhr.

IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

- **NAYSIN TARAK – Wilderness guide and spy for a secret organization (page 30)**
- **XIU XICHAMA – Leader of the Alamuhr village (page 29)**
- **THE DAKIN PUPPETS – Possessed members of the Children of the Song (page 42)**

THE CULT OF THE REBORN

A small group of stevedores, ship workers and hands close to the Machine Icon were guided by the Song to a chamber in the Spire just before the Fall and thus miraculously spared as the station plunged burning to the ground. The survivors and some new Sogoi additions now live in the village of Alamuhr in the center of Verkâna Ridge and protect the tunnels of the enormous Ama'turab Azaëlean said to lead right to the grave of the Spire. They have formed a cult, "The Reborn," and sworn to keep the location of the Spire and the final resting place of the Machine Icon from the rest of the Horizon.

THE SANTULAN AGENTS

The mystics in the Children of the Song were spellbound by the Emissaries in order to allow activation of the Monolith. The surviving Children are now under the direct control of the Judge Emissary and receive their orders from Xene. The mystics are the perfect hosts for the Santulan assassins, the Dakin, who can use resonance powers to temporarily take direct control of a chosen mystic. A group of Dakin puppets are searching the jungles of Kua to find the tomb of the Machine Icon, hoping to trap the lingering Santulan essence in a Second Horizon artifact. The PCs will come across the tracks of the Dakin as they travel, and eventually meet them face to face.

OVERVIEW

The PCs are called to Kua to seek out the Machine Icon in the ruins of the Coriolis station. The scenario consists of four scenes, starting with the PCs' strange dreams and ending when they find the Machine Icon in the Spire.

SCENE 1 – THE CALL OF KUA (PAGE 22)

The segment of the Messenger, C164: Dreams and visions haunt the PCs. The news of the portal collapse in Dabaran are foretold even before they break across the Horizon.

SCENE 2 – THE HEART OF THE JUNGLE (PAGE 25)

The PCs travel to Kua and make it to the village Alamuhr deep in the jungles – a village built by Coriolis survivors sworn to guarding the secrets of the tomb of the Machine Icon.

SCENE 3 – THE RUINS (PAGE 33)

After seeing death and destruction in Alamuhr, the PCs

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climb down into abandoned Azaëlean tunnels (page 290 of the Coriolis core rulebook) beneath the jungles. Rock and earth turn into durasteel and the ruins of the Coriolis station.

SCENE 4 – URNI EN-ARGONNAS (PAGE 40)
The PCs reach the remains of the Abhrra floor and the former home of the Messenger Emissary (*Emissary Lost* page 45). They are offered the choice of merging with the former Emissary to become the Chosen spoken of in the prophecy of the coming war.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A Song for Kua allows for revisits to locations from *Emissary Lost*. This will remind the PCs of past adventures and hopefully help them regain their trust in the Machine Icon. The last part of the scenario contains the discovery and exploration of the Spire ruins in the form of a classic dungeon crawl. Each "room" in the treasure hunt corresponds to a numbered event. As the GM, use the map of the ruins as you like to tailor the hunt to your needs and your game pace.

PC INCENTIVES
Regardless of group concept or individual specialization, all of the PCs are called to Kua. The group is expected to have their own ship but if this isn't the case, they can always reach Verkâna Ridge by tagging along on a merchant vessel, or with a party of explorers or settlers or peddlers heading for Baybasin. Use the events to achieve the right amount of combat and other forms of conflict. If you're worried that engineer or pilot PCs won't get enough focus, have your group travel to the Ridge in a shaky ground vehicle or make their landing attempt more of a challenge.

IMPORTANT FACTS
You should be well acquainted with the Coriolis ruins and the Santulan agents when you GM the scenario. Each scene ends with a closing event that carries the story into the next scene. Use these events earlier than described below for a faster pace but make sure you don't miss any of the following key insights:

- The PCs need to make it to Kua to seek out the source of their strange dreams.
- The PCs should learn that Dabaran has been shut-off from the rest of the Horizon.
- The PCs must encounter the mystic Urni en-Argonnas.

NEW RULES: DAKIN PUPPET

A mystic subjected to a dominance attempt by a Dakin must roll a critically successful **MYSTIC POWERS** to resist. Succeeding means only suffering D6 points of stress (with 1 point negated for each six rolled).

The victim and those around her can hear a shrill, piercing sound and chorus of whispering voices just prior to the attack. A PC may try to understand what's about to happen and warn others by passing an **OBSERVATION** test at –2 or a normal **MYSTIC POWERS** test. An overtaken puppet moves jerkingly but with precision and her eyes flicker around the room as if to take in as much information as possible.

Each turn of possession, the puppet may try to resist her master by testing **MYSTIC POWERS** and voluntarily suffer as many points of stress as she rolls sixes. A puppet broken by stress is automatically free of the Dakin's control. The hold can also be broken using the mystical power Exorcist (see page 77 of the Coriolis core rulebook). You may introduce Dakin puppeteering attempts at any point during the scenario suite and are free to target PCs as well as NPCs.

- Wits and Empathy are raised to 5. Strength and Agility remain the same.
- The puppet gets 5 additional MP (a minimum of 15 MP) but is completely under GM control.
- The puppet gets a skill level of 5 in **MELEE COMBAT**, **DEXTERITY**, **RANGED COMBAT**, **INFILTRATION**, **DATA DJINN** and **MYSTIC POWERS**.
- The puppet gets one of the following mystical powers (see *Emissary Lost* page 193–194): Sculpt, Telekinetic Blast, Prevent or Soul Reader.
- The puppet regains 2 points of damage and stress per turn (see the Mercy of the Symmetry talent on page 42).

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PROPHECIES

A lone courier vessel arrives in Kua. On the bridge, the sensor operator draws a wheezing breath of the thin, scrubbed air and looks at the flickering screen:

"By the Martyr's crown – she's here. Our brothers and sisters didn't let us down."

The captain mouths a silent prayer and gives the order to send the encrypted data package. The receiving ship confirms the hand-over and disappears into the portal field.

"We did it. In the name of the Prophets and the Holy Light, let this be our atonement for all the harm we've caused."

The crew sigh with relief but only a moment later, a shimmer appears in the darkness of space nearby. Butterfly wings against the bright starlight, fractal torpedoes burrowing through the hull. The bridge depressurizes and for a brief moment, a quiet flash of fire illuminates the void. Then, night, all-encompassing, returns.

THE SCENARIO BEGINS with an opening scene introducing the foreboding dreams and progresses to guide the players through a series of further scenes and events eventually carrying over into the next part of the campaign.

OVERVIEW

Dreams and visions bring the PCs to Kua once again. Urni en-Argonnas, the Santulan they have encountered through dreams on several occasions during earlier parts of the *Mercy of the Icons* campaign, calls on them. The journey they must make to and through the jungles isn't without dangers, however. The cult of the Reborn have agents everywhere on Kua, keeping their eyes on the PCs. As the Santulans launch an attack on the village of Alamuhr, however, the cult reaches out to the PCs for help, leading them to begin hunting the marauders down into the underground Azaëlean tunnels beneath the Ridge that eventually take them all the way to the ruins of Coriolis and the tomb of the Machine Icon.

DARKNESS POINTS

Darkness Points in this scenario can be spent to make the journey more difficult by adding conflicts or obstacles for the PCs to overcome on the way. As the scenario isn't separated into acts, instead specific scenes and events will generate new DP. You get as many DP as there are PCs to begin with, down to a minimum of 4 DP.

STARTING SCENE:

THE CALL OF KUA

You wake in a cold sweat, panic tightening your chest. You've bitten your lip and taste iron. Dim lights. A cot. The familiar scent of myrrh, the hot sweetness from yesterday's dinner, the dura beams of your ship, its systems' low, pulsating hum. A dream? What has happened?

"It began with rolling fields and an invitation. An outstretched hand – whose hand? Then a starry sky and the emptiness of space. You couldn't breathe. Your heart racing as you stared into the light from a distant star. Crying. Singing. Heat. The star began to change. A planet – the emerald – Kua, waiting for you. Glittering wings in the darkness surrounding you. Hundreds of butterflies followed by enormous shell-covered titans. A locust swarm come to devour the Third Horizon."

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THE SITUATION

The scenario may find the PCs anywhere in the Third Horizon. Either gradually introduce visions and pleading, dreamed whispers from Urni en-Argonnas – the Machine Icon – or go directly to the final and most coherent dream. This can be used as an introduction to the scenario if you wish to begin in medias res as the PCs are arriving in Kua.

MAJOR EVENTS

The key event of the scene is the dream that calls for the PCs to travel to Kua. It is possible that the PCs initially won't understand the meaning of the dream. If so, the GM can use the dreams described in Minor Events to underline how important it is for them to get there, and soon. The dreams affect all PCs, mystic and non-mystic alike.

START: FEVER DREAMS

On a night like any other aboard their ship, or as they're staying at a space staton waiting for repairs, the PCs suddenly experience a strange fever dream. Either read aloud the text above, hand out notes to the players for them to read or make up your own version.

TABLE 03: FEVER DREAMS

D6	DREAM FRAGMENT	LINGERING EMOTION
1	Rolling fields and step pyramids	Longing
2	Golden tattoos on dark skin, flowing white silk and a long red shawl	Community
3	A beautiful song echoing under a crisp blue sky with two suns	Love
4	Mountains under heavy clouds, promising rain	Stress
5	A dark operating room in the Foundation hospital in the Sultra marshes and a lifeless, mummified corpse on a slab	Sorrow
6	A dark shape breaking through the light and growing larger	Panic

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As they awake and meet up, they realize they've all had the same dream but much of it has faded from their memory already. Roll a die on Table 03 to see which lingering emotion and image each PC retains. The fragments below are just small pieces of the dream in its entirety.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

CHOSEN

The first night after making the decision to return to Kua, the PCs again share a dream:

"You see a debris belt full of shipwrecks and twisted bodies – a quiet testament to the wave of death that emanated from the heart of the Monolith. The guiding hand of the Third Horizon severed. Kua singed by fire as the dream died and fell in flames. Still, beyond the belt, the emerald green below welcomes you. Scavengers, toiling families, growing river towns. The jungle returning, scabbing over the wounds, healing. The naked, black column shadowing the remains of Sky City. You feel the Messenger calling you back to the center of Verkâna Ridge and hear the Song echo through the empty Abhrra floor in the ruins of the Spire, deep under the lush, green canopy. You don't know where your journey will take you, but have a feeling that this is only the beginning…"
Cost: 0 DP

THE LOST SYSTEM

En route to Kua, the PCs are reached by troubling news either as they make a short stop at a portal station or via a radio message picked up as they arrive in Kua (see "News about Dabaran"). As the news breaks, the GM gets 4 new DP.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory, generates DP)

MINOR EVENTS

To flavor or intensify the mandatory events, use the tables below.

GROWING PORTENTS

As the PCs are traveling toward the Machine Icon, more visions appear (see Table 04). If the visions appear in their dreams as they sleep, the event is free, but at the cost of 1 or 2 DP, they manifest while awake and in the middle of something important – combat, during a tricky negotiation with a customs officer, as they're trying to land their ship in a storm etc. Pay 2 DP if the visions interrupt something important that involves more than one crew member and 1 DP if the effects are less severe. After the vision subsides, the affected PCs feel intensely drawn toward Kua and a location in the middle of Verkâna Ridge. The urge gradually becomes an obsession (the severity of which is up to you as the GM to decide).
Cost: 0–2 DP (per activation)

NEWS ABOUT DABARAN

"We have received unconfirmed reports about Dabaran saying that no one has been able to enter or leave the system in the last couple of weeks. A small group of merchant vessels, including the Waha-Najima bulk hauler, appear to be the last registered craft to pass Kua coming from the Dabaran Circle. Whether the shutdown is intentional or the result of an attack is currently unknown but our correspondents have heard rumors stating that the Dabaran authorities have indeed exiled themselves intentionally to stop the spread of a dangerous pandemic. We are currently investigating the veracity of such rumors."

TAINA ABU-HARIM, THE RED SPIDER, KUA

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TABLE 04: PORTENTS

D6	DREAM
1	Enslaved by the white Vestal, the missing nomad star seers sit in deep meditation. Their minds wander the impossible portal spaces to find a way through. The field suddenly shimmers and glows, letting through a handful of butterfly ships as tiny dots against the glowing Taoan star.
2	Butterfly ships passing through the Hamura portal are met by mystic pilgrims under the influence of the Song of the Emissaries. Explosions flash quietly in the night. Whole crews give their lives to keep the First Horizon out.
3	You approach a body made entirely of stars. The young woman embraces you and her glowing heart merges with yours – complete serenity and purpose overwhelms you. The Machine Icons enters you, revealing a new destiny as you hear people from all across the Horizon chant your name in reverence.
4	A cool cave of twisted metal welcomes you after your long hike through the dense Kuan jungle heat. You hear the Song of the Machine Icon echo through the dura beams in the walls. The crashed station's skeleton leads you down toward that which once represented the heights of civilization, the Coriolis Spire. Toward a welcoming voice. Toward the lost Emissary.
5	The round temple is covered in vines. Sunlight falls on four monks in deep prayer surrounded by nomad elders. Mogul features mark the faces of the clan leaders of the Janhagir fleet. "The Four who are One welcomes you, Urni en-Argonnas. You, like I, have wandered far but we always knew that the day would come when we would meet in this very place, united against the plans of our siblings."
6	A monastery cruiser in lone majesty against the whiteness of the star. Memories of what once was and of everything you have done to keep her alive. Final thoughts as the holy flames of the Martyr purge the system. Skies and forests burning. Fire creeping up the black surface of the Monolith. Cracks and then a great rumbling. The tower crumbles and the Horizons are cut off. Hope on a razor's edge, hope for the future of the Third Horizon.

THE HEART OF THE JUNGLE

Beyond the muddy waters of the Ramishah delta and the Conglomerate's whirlpool or laboring hands lies the almost pristine Verkâna Ridge. You remember the arduous journey and the suffocating heat of the jungle from your last visit. Revisiting the jungles brings back memories – dreams and hopes you didn't think were yours. The Song is now constantly present in your minds, bringing you back to your meeting with the rediscovered Emissary in a wide field far from the worlds you call home.

"Find me in the heart of the jungle, resting beneath Kua's forest floor – but hurry. They who were once my brothers and sisters no longer see me as an ally. Enslaved vessels seek my tomb and in their hands gleam knives meant for my back."

THE SITUATION

In this scene, the PCs make it through the jungles of Verkâna Ridge to the devastation in the hidden village of Alamuhr. Led by their dreams, they look for the entrance to the underground.

THROUGH THE JUNGLES

The journey to the center of the Ridge can happen in a number of ways. The PCs can either land their ship in the vicinity of the village, a couple of hours away or all the way below the rise of the plateau.

If the group undertakes a longer trek on foot, see The Kuan Connection in *Emissary Lost* for more inspiration.

THE FATE OF ALAMUHR

The Dakin puppets sent by the Emissaries at Xene have already found Alamuhr and attacked it. Charred bodies and burnt-out ruins bear witness to the power of the attackers' inferno grenades. A dark pillar of smoke above the treetops can guide the PCs to the few survivors still hiding in the village's alleys and tunnels. Here or just before they reach the village, you can have them encounter the half Sogoi Naysin or the village leader – former stevedore aqbar Xiu Xichama.

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A NEW BAYBASIN

It's up to you as the GM to determine if your players get to revisit the old mining town of Baybasin. More information can be found on page 111 of *Emissary Lost*.

The reign of Raquin Birbasil ended with the worker uprisings that followed after the Fall of Coriolis. The Monolith's discharge caused an earthquake that collapsed the coltan mines and the formerly fenced-in poppy fields are now used to grow sugar, wheat, palm trees and tabak. The clearcuts and swiddens on the outskirts are growing and the sinkhole has swallowed up the entire southern shantytown.

The new Baybasin grows northward where the old Birbasil complex has been fused with the surrounding shacks and container homes. The Baybasin militia disappeared with the Birbasils but ex-Legionnaire Hashema Behari's hunter-scavenger patrol remains and has been turned into a formidable police force thanks to some help from the Shaukar guerillas. Former mineral prospector Mori Dakka has joined forces with the humanite sisters Ana and Mandri Meesan to form a town council. The Sogoi clan leaders Tasheeb and Sha-Muhib also have seats at the council.

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MAJOR EVENTS

The journey takes the PCs to Alamuhr and then finally to the entrance to the ruins of the Spire. Feel free to make the trip as long or as short as you like by introducing the various events below before the PCs reach the underground.

IN THE MIDDLE OF THE JUNGLE

The small village of Alamuhr lies in the very middle of Verkâna Ridge. A first glance reveals nothing but a thick veil of ferns, pineapple plants and low cocoa trees intertwined with tangled vines and orchids on their climb toward the sunlit jungle ceiling high above. A more thorough examination allows the PCs to spot ventilation outlets protruding from the ground and cleverly hidden solar panels and wind turbines in the crowns of the trees. The undergrowth seems to grow in the direction of the center of the area where it disappears into three narrow, water-filled holes. Artificial lights and steel girders can be seen deep under the water.

Alamuhr village is actually hidden underground in a series of caves constructed near the mouth of an Azaëlean tunnel. The stevedore families who miraculously survived the Fall of Coriolis were rescued from the buried ruins by a Sogoi tribe and have since then scavenged what they can to build a new home – dura beams, furniture, machinery and whatever other technology was salvageable. The small but sturdy village now contains a couple of underground streets lined with concrete buildings illuminated by skylights or artificial sunlights and the many fresh water tanks and fish farms give Alamuhr a slight resemblance with the stevedore blocks of the Neoptra or the alleys around one of the Promenade Plazas.

- **Devastation:** Already from far away, the PCs spot a pillar of smoke and upon arrival, they see that the village surroundings are burned by inferno grenades. Mangled attack drones and cracked dura beams appear to have been destroyed by a very powerful explosion or shockwave (the attackers' mystical powers). As they climb down into the village proper, they soon come upon the dead bodies of the village hunting party, Sogoi and former stevedores caught defenseless by the surprise attack. Most of the villagers are dead but some may still remain in hiding, able to give delirious accounts of how a rain of grenades suddenly fell upon them and of a small group of attackers charging the village.

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- **The Wilderness Guide:** If the PCs have already met the wilderness guide Naysin or if they encounter him here, he tells them of the attack and leads them to the village entrance to find the wounded stevedore aqbar Xiu Xichama (see below).

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

THE STEVEDORE QUEEN

With or without the help of Naysin, the PCs eventually find Alamuhr's assembly hall located in a deep crevice. Natural light falls in from above through an atrium. The attack has reduced the once ordered rows of benches and vats of sugar globes from the Spire's Council chambers to piles of charred rubble. Choking, black fumes from the inferno grenades still hang in the air. In the back wall, a large opening partly blocked by a palisade of steel panels and curtains leads further into the remains of Coriolis. The surviving Alamuhr villagers tend to their wounded and dead in the assembly hall. The former stevedore aqbar from Coriolis stands in the middle of the chaos and attempts to organize triage efforts.

- **The Leader:** Xiu Xichama (see box and Table 05) is a muscular, former stevedore known from the Bulletin's coverage of the station's final days of rioting and unrest. She wears tight clothing under a flowing, sleeveless gown of turquoise hemp. Two nekatra follow her through the debris and growl viciously at anyone who gets too close. She notices the PCs and asks them to holster their weapons, closes her eyes and calms the suspicious animals using her mystical power.
- **Intentions:** Xiu questions the PCs about their motives for coming and about how they managed to find the village. She and her followers are the guardians of the last resting place of the Machine Icon and unless the PCs are honest about how they were called to the Ridge, Xiu and any of her followers who can still stand become increasingly hostile and reach for their weapons. If there is a fight, you decide how many of the villagers take part. Honesty on the PCs' part about their mysterious calling, either by them or through Naysin, earns them a warm welcome, however.
- **The Survivors:** Xiu tells the PCs that the villagers survived the Fall of Coriolis at the Machine Icon's mercy and that they are now sworn to protect the former Emissary from intruders. Followers can be found throughout the surrounding jungle towns and around the Gyrides coastline but in spite of this, the sudden attack on the village took them by surprise. Xiu clutches a simple prayer book in her hand, nervously thumbing its worn covers.
- **The Prayer Book:** If the PCs ask about the book, she tells them that it's a Miran prayer book of songs and prophecies from before the Portal Wars. PCs who have been around since *Emissary Lost* may test **CULTURE** to identify the book as one of the ones found in the Messenger Emissary's residence (*Emissary Lost*, page 45). Xiu claims to have been given the book directly by the Machine Icon.
- **Heeding the Call:** Over the course of the conversation, the tides may turn in favor of the PCs, especially if they are honest about the visions and the "call" they've felt from the Machine Icon. The villagers are willing to let the PCs through and into the Azaëlean tunnel that leads to the ruins of Coriolis if they think the group has a chance of catching up to and defeating the intruders before they reach the tomb of the Machine Icon. Xiu can give them some form of directions to the ruins of the Abhrra.
- **By Force:** Ruthless PCs can try to fight their way through Xiu and her followers and explore the tunnels after having won, or try to charge the palisade and then flee down into the Spire.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

THE WILDERNESS GUIDE

You decide when it's appropriate for your group to encounter Naysin the wilderness guide. He too is a member of the Reborn cult and could therefore try to shadow them or, if they make no secret of their being called by the Machine Icon, simply come up and offer his services. He could also have been sent from Alamuhr after the attack to get help. You can use him to support your group if they aren't that combat or survival savvy, even down in the ruins.

As they travel together, Naysin tells vivid stories about all the different dangers of the jungles – wild nekatra and kabrin, deadly diseases and torrential rains, Azaëlean tunnels that collapse and bury the unlucky or the ignorant. If introduced early, he will carefully try to find out the PCs' real reason for being on Kua.

Cost: 0 DP

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THE LEADER

Xiu used to be a well-liked stevedore aqbar in the Neoptra spaceport. She grew up on Lubau but moved to Kua in her teens to start working for the Cellar smugglers. After eventually migrating to more legal jobs, she began gathering contacts and resources until she could take over a couple of the Stevedore Central crews and continued managing them for about fifteen cycles. As a loyal Free League member, she was suspended after leading a series of strikes during the Zenithian takeover (see *The Last Cyclade*). She broke out after being arrested and hid in the Cellar together with other dissidents on the run. Shortly before the destruction of the station, the Machine Icon guided her group of runaways to a hidden chamber in the hull of the Spire where they miraculously managed to survive the Fall.

The PCs might have encountered or been assisted by Xiu in previous scenarios. She will still be wary of their current loyalties, however. If Xiu has already died during your campaign, substitute her for stevedore aqbar Ana Chamoud from the Mulukhad who also participated in the protests shortly before the Fall of the station.



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TABLE 05: ALAMUHR NPCS

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Half Sogoi	4	4	3	2	8	5	2	Infiltration 5, Survival 5, Dexterity 4, Observation 4, Force 3, Melee Combat 3, Ranged Combat 3	Grape rifle, knife, herbal remedy, camouflage clothing (+1)
Alamuhr villagers	4	3	3	3	7	6	3	Melee Combat 3, Technology 3, Culture 2, Data Djinn 2, Force 2, Mystic Powers 2	Power glove or dura axe, Vulcan pistol or medkit, proximity sensor or environment scanner, tabula, 100 birr
Xiu Xichama (leader)	0	0	2	0	8	–	–	Dexterity 6, Observation 6, Infiltration 3, Ranged Combat 3	Stun gun, 3 stun grenades, armor Talents: Dominate animal (see box)

NEW MYSTICAL TALENT: DOMINATE ANIMAL

You have an empathic and telepathic connection with animals and semi-intelligences in your vicinity and instinctively feel what their needs and moods are and may affect how they view you or others nearby. You may test **MYSTIC POWERS** at +2 (opposed roll vs semi-intelligences, simple roll against other animals) to befriend or dominate an animal and make it obey you. A critical success bonds the animal to you permanently after which it attempts to interpret and carry out your commands without dice rolls.

NEW TALENT: ONE WITH THE WILDS

Choose an environment (Jungle, Steppe, Tundra, Mountains or Desert). Having grown up around the local flora and fauna, you know your way around, where to find food and water, how to hunt and how to stay safe, even in the harshest conditions. You get a +2 to **INFILTRATION**, **OBSERVATION** and **SURVIVAL** while in your native environment. Once per session, you may treat a limited success as a critical one while rolling one of the above modified tests.

NAYSIN TARAK, WILDERNESS GUIDE

Naysin is a short, half-Sogoi older man with a bald head and a strong, sinewy build. With his hand-poked facial tattoos, he blends in remarkably well with the hands in the Conglomerate. The tabak he chews smells sweet, smokey and sour, and it appears to keep the jungle predators away. Growing up both in the jungle and on the outskirts of Baybasin, he feels at home both in the city and in the wilds. On the night of the Fall of Coriolis, he awoke from a deep narcotic slumber and heard the Song calling him and a few others to a crater full of burning debris amidst some collapsed Azaëlean tunnels in the jungle.

CHARACTERISTICS: Keeps stuffing more tabak under his lip and spits absent-mindedly on the ground when threatened or feeling lost.

ATTRIBUTES:
STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 3, WITS 5, EMPATHY 2

HIT POINTS: 6

MIND POINTS: 7

REPUTATION: 3

SKILLS: Infiltration 5, Ranged Combat 5, Survival 5, Dexterity 4, Melee Combat 4, Observation 4, Manipulation 3, Culture 2, Medicurgy 2

TALENTS: Rapid Reload, Third Eye, One with the Wilds: Jungle (see box)

GEAR: Long rifle with optical scope, compass, hyper rope, emergency flare, tabak

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MINOR EVENTS

Below are a couple of events you can use as the PCs are traveling through the jungles or to make the situation more threatening as they reach Alamuhr.

BAD WATER

Without clean water in the wilds, you die. The PCs' water has become spoiled and smells bad. The contamination can be revealed by a successful SURVIVAL test. Those who drink the dirty water suffer a strength 4 poison attack (see the Coriolis core rulebook page 113).

Cost: 1 DP

PEOPLE OF THE SHELL

A small band of Sogoi move through the woods carrying rolls of gear strapped to large shields on their backs. They have scales tattooed on their arms, neck and head revealed by a CULTURE test to be the identifying marks of the worshipers of the Shield Bearer, a local aspect of the Lady of Tears.

- They have an old Zalosian prayer book from the time of the colonization of the system that they'd be willing to trade for something useful. They found the book in the Coriolis ruins before the big aftershock hit Verkâna Ridge and caused the wreckage of the Spire to fall into the old Azaëlean tunnels underground. This happened a segment or so after the fall of the station.
- They can trade D6 herbal remedies to the group if any of the PCs are wounded.
- The group is headed for Baybasin to sell salvaged artifacts and rolls of dura wire. A TECHNOLOGY or MANIPULATION test can reveal the salvage to be from the ruins of Coriolis (paneling, djinn tech, spare parts, but perhaps also a desirable piece of Zenithian art).
- If persuaded (with a +2 if they're given drugs or alcohol), they can reveal that the Ridge is completely undermined by cave and tunnel systems dug by the great Ama'turab – "The Mother of Kua" – the very first Azaëlean who created the jungles by bringing water and nutrients to the surface from deep, underground reservoirs.

Cost: 0 DP

THE KABRIN NEST

As they're walking through a gully, the PCs suddenly realize they're surrounded. The loose earth starts shifting around them and the ground starts to tremble. A flock of kabrin suddenly spring from their hiding places. Their wide cheeks and necks extend and flatten as the vicious predators prepare to attack. At the cost of 3 DP, the attack is a complete surprise and catches all of the PCs off guard (see kabrin description).

Cost: 1, 3 DP

KABRIN, PREDATOR [–1]

The kabrin hunt in packs of five to ten individuals. They are hermaphrodite omnivores that like to burrow in gullies and crevices. The pack behaves like a bee or termite hive with an alpha as both primary intelligence and only fertile member. The rest of the pack

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acts as a kind of telepathic extension of the alpha. The pack stay close to their nest unless they need to find a new one. Parts of the pack also hunt during the night and venture slightly farther from the nest. Some gang leaders or slavers take kabrin alphas as pets and in doing so, gain the entire pack as an added layer of their bodyguard. Domesticating a pack can be done by successfully locating the alpha (**OBSERVATION** -2) and then winning an opposed **MANIPULATION** test but only if the PCs first have the necessary knowledge of the process (**CULTURE** or **SURVIVAL**).

CHARACTERISTICS: The head flattens to form a shield covered in small, vibrating feelers as the animal is on the hunt or when it feels threatened.

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 2/4/8, AGILITY 6, WITS 3, EMPATHY 2**
HIT POINTS: 5 (individually)
MIND POINTS: 8/14/20 (as a pack)
SKILLS: Infiltration 8/6/4, Observation 6, Melee Combat 5, Force 4, Manipulation 2/5/10
ARMOR: Thick skin 5
WEAPONS: Bite (Bonus +2, INIT -1, weapon damage 1, CRIT 2), Claws (INIT +2, weapon damage 2, CRIT 2)

- **PACK:** The pack acts with one mind and the size of the group determines how effective they are. The stats above are divided into three columns describing either a small pack (1–3 individuals), a medium pack (4–6) or a large one (7–10). The kabrin are fought using their individual HP scores but may be broken by stress as a group (the MP stat is for the group as a whole at the beginning of the combat). The members of the pack try to stay within fifty meters of each other. For each pack member that is broken or suffers a critical injury, the pack suffers 2 points of stress.
- **COORDINATED ATTACKS:** The pack fights as one but may act multiple times per turn (on different initiative scores). A small pack may act twice, a medium pack three times and a large pack gets four initiatives per turn. Each initiative is rolled separately, is worth 3 AP and may be used by one or more pack members.
- **POISONOUS BITE:** Victims who suffer damage from a successful bite attack also become poisoned (strength 6 poison attack vs Strength). Victims who fail the resistance roll suffer muscle spasms and blurred vision for D6 turns (–1 to **DEXTERITY**, **FORCE** and **MELEE COMBAT**, -3 to **RANGED COMBAT** and **OBSERVATION**).
- **LOCK JAWS (1 DP):** The kabrin can lock its jaws after performing a successful bite attack. The bite victim suffers a -2 penalty to all actions and loses 1 AP per turn. She may attempt to wrestle free by winning an opposed **FORCE**/**MELEE COMBAT** vs **FORCE** roll.
- **COMBAT BURROWING (1 DP):** The kabrin can disappear into their tunnels or quickly burrow underground during combat to reappear somewhere else. This costs one initiative (3 AP) for up to three individuals. On the next initiative score, the burrowed kabrin may perform a surprise bite or claw attack with a +2 and a CRIT of 1. Keep careful track of which kabrin burrow during combat.



REGROWTH

The dense mass of trees suddenly opens and the PCs see enormous rifts and cracks in the ground. Charred husks of ancient trees bear witness to the flaming death that came raining down with the remains of the Spire just nearby. The Ridge – already unstable due to the underground maze of Azaëlean tunnels – cracked at the site of impact and the ruins sank deep underground and were covered over by a landslide of loose earth and crushed plant matter. Since the Fall, the jungles have started to heal and the craters are now covered in low shrubs and thick fields of ferns. The surviving trees stand quiet guard around the clearing.

- **Treacherous Ground:** The ground is unstable and may collapse into the underground tunnels at any moment. At the cost of 1 DP, it affects one PC – for 2 DP, it affects the entire group. Those affected suffer 3 points of damage, lowered by the outcome of a **DEXTERITY** or **SURVIVAL** roll (each six negates 1 point of damage). Extra sixes may be

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spent to help comrades. Critically successful PCs avoid falling into the underground.

- **Treasure:** If you like, you can have your group test OBSERVATION to scavenge for remains from Coriolis in the tunnel – a piece of art, a broken storefront, crates of food (pillaged by animals), park benches or perhaps a cherry tree that somehow survived and took root again in the debris of a crushed temple garden. The tunnel may also contain a small stream of fresh water.

Cost: 0, 1–2 DP

THE RUINS

The cold walls and dim lights of the underground are a welcome change from the clammy jungle heat above. The rich Kuan soil turns from thick mud to striped granite as the tunnel digs deeper, leaving a trail of shredded roots and crushed rock behind. Everything around you is covered in a dried film of some strange secretion from the Mother of Kua, the Azaëlean whose vast size and hunger becomes chillingly clear as you take in the size of the tunnel. You send a quiet prayer to the Icons as the ground starts to tremble, hoping it's only a natural tremor and not a sign of approaching doom behind rows and rows of mauling teeth.

THE SITUATION

This scene brings the PCs down below the surface of Kua, through the Azaëlean tunnels and into the ruins of the Spire. As the GM, you are free to decide how much time the group spends searching the underground and what they encounter on their way to the Abhrra floor and the tomb of the Machine Icon.

DARKNESS POINTS

As the PCs delve into the dark tunnels beneath Alamuhr and hear the uneasy rumbling of the pained Ridge moving around them, you get 1 new DP per player down to a minimum of 6 DP. Certain events in the scene will also generate additional DP.

MAJOR EVENTS

The events taking place in the ruins of Coriolis can either happen one after the other regardless of which way the PCs choose or according to their locations on the map of

LIGHTS IN THE DARK

The underground ruins are almost never completely dark. Different light sources help guide the PCs along their way but unless the group also brings some kind of light or compensating gear with them, they get a –1 to all sight-dependent rolls.

- Daylight filters in through thin cracks in the ceiling.
- Cracked vats of sugar globes in the ruins of the finer establishments along the Esplanade or in the palaces of the Zenithian elite emit a ghostly glow.
- Bioluminescent beetles feed on the Azaëlean secretions on the tunnel walls.
- Here and there, backup systems still power holo screens and emergency light strips.

ZENITHIAN TREASURE

As the PCs rummage through the ruins, they may happen upon both useful gear and Zenithian family heirlooms. If you want to, roll two dice on the table on page 34 to determine what they find. The value in the table refers to finding the right buyer (original owner or relatives, artifact collector etc); otherwise the value drops to half or even to a mere quarter.

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the ruins (page 35). On the map, the room numbers correspond to the events below and the PCs' choice of way determines what happens when. The length of the journey to the final scene of the scenario is for you to decide.

1. SKELETON SPIRE

Before long, the PCs come to a collapse in the tunnel. From the rubble, long, twisted ribs protrude. The once mighty dura beams and vacuum shields of the Coriolis hull now lie melted and deformed after the flaming descent and subsequent violent crash. Strips of cloth and symbols painted on the metal show that this tunnel is commonly used by the Alamuhr villagers on their scavenging trips down into the tunnels.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

2. THE QUAKE

The tunnel has become a more chaotic blend of soil, tree roots and metal debris. Water seeps down from the jungles above and glistens on the beams or collects in small pools in bent dura plates and molten glass panels. The ground suddenly starts shaking, raining down dirt and scraps of metal from the ceiling. A high-pitch wail echoes through the tunnel – a gust of wind, perhaps, or something else?

The PCs shiver in the sudden cold and Kuans among them – or anyone with CULTURE or SURVIVAL – can remember the tales of the Azaëleans, the enormous worms that once lived and burrowed under the surface of the planet in prehistoric times. The only remains of the mythical creatures are their networks of tunnels. Read more about the Azaëleans on pages 290 and 320 of the Coriolis core rulebook.

- **Darkness Points:** The quake is a dark omen. Unless a PC prays to the Icons for protection, you get 2 new DP.

Cost: 0 DP (May generate 2 DP)

3. HOWLS

The tunnel has collapsed but a narrow passage next to the collapse leads into the remains of the Spire. The fall of the station destabilized the whole area, opening up deep cracks and crevices falling into blind darkness. The PCs must carefully make their way across one such abyss by walking on cracked windows and ventilation shafts. Echoes of blood-curdling howls come rippling through the dark, bouncing off the walls and reverberating in the deep cracks, making it almost impossible to determine the direction of the sound. A successful SURVIVAL test reveals the source as a nekatra warning its pack of an incoming threat.

TABLE 06: TREASURE IN THE RUINS

D66	ITEM	VALUE
11–13	Quassar necklace with a blue pearl and a Zenith pendant	3,000
14–16	Large sugar globe in shimmering mother-of-pearl	700
21–23	Tabula containing the last message of a dying family meant for relatives on Amedo	1,500
24–26	Ornate box containing a dried flower from Ardha	2,000
31–33	Small gem-encrusted dura knife with a serrated blade (BONUS +1, INIT 0)	800
34–36	A beautiful vase with Ardhan patterns	500
41–43	A small Zenith statuette carved from green jade	1,500
44–46	Encrypted tag (DATA DJINN -3) containing the lineage and DNA-sequences of the Birbasils	5,000
51–53	A stasis container holding a bottle of red wine from Ardha	3,000
54–56	Security aqbar D'nai Astir's diary with notes about several of the larger clans and factions	4,000
61–63	A beautifully carved musical instrument (GM's choice) belonging to the Dayal family	1,500
64–66	Armored stasis unit holding an infant of influential Zenithian origin rescued by its parents during the Fall	10,000*

* The PCs can either try to sell the child back to the family or return it without payment in which case they instead gain the group talent Faction Standing with the clan in question (see *The Last Cyclade*).

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THE RUINS



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- **Darkness Points:** The howls are very frightening and generate 2 DP unless a PC passes an **OBSERVATION** test, or the group explicitly says that they move forward carefully.

Cost: 0 DP (May generate 2 DP)

4. THE CITY OF RUINS

Many of the Spire floors collapsed into each other or melted together as the section hit Verkâna Ridge. The tunnels here have collapsed and given way to a labyrinth of cracked mosaic floors and burned parks, streets, courtyards and once-luxurious residential modules. The maze is difficult to walk around in and especially difficult to cross. The PCs must climb almost vertical streets and avoid stepping on doors or windows as they walk across houses laid on their sides. Here and there, whole floors have disappeared down black ravines and finding safe footing becomes very dangerous. Thanks to the affluence of the Spire's former inhabitants, however, many of the homes and boutiques had nets or vats of sugar globes and the scattered artifacts still glow faintly like tiny stars in the night. At the cost of 1 DP per entry below, the road through the ruins can be made more dangerous:

- **Collapse:** The ground gives way and one or more PCs risk falling into an old store or residential module. A successful **SURVIVAL** test allows a character to avoid the situation and **DEXTERITY** can be rolled to minimize damage (strength 8 falling roll, see Falling rules on page 97 of the Coriolis core rulebook). PCs who fall down must then try to find a way back up.
- **Ravine:** The tunnel ends in a wide ravine with ruined buildings and wet dura beams hanging out over the edge. Climbing across might work (requires a rope and **DEXTERITY**) or there might be a way around (**SURVIVAL**). A well-aimed grenade (**RANGED COMBAT**) might bring even more rubble down to create a makeshift bridge across.
- **Wall:** A street decorated in mosaics blocks the way at almost a 90 degree angle. The PC must either climb the smooth wall (**DEXTERITY**) or try to find a way around (**OBSERVATION** or **SURVIVAL**). The climb is almost twenty meters straight up and a fall could lead to serious injury (see Falling rules on page 97 of the Coriolis core rulebook).
- **Blockage:** A huge pile of debris blocks the way and the PCs must either hold a passage open as the others crawl through (**FORCE**) or push through a narrow crack in the blockage (**DEXTERITY**). If the PC holding the passage open or leading the way through the narrow crack scores a critical success, the rest of the group can pass through safely. A limited success means the rest of the PCs must roll a die as they pass the blockage. On a six, more debris falls down on them (strength 6 attack, weapon damage 1, CRIT 2).

Cost: 0, 1–4 DP

5. AZAËLEAN?

The walls of the tunnel turn from soil and rock to a cracked surface of something that initially looks like frozen or dried clay. Each footstep breaks the surface of the porous material. The tunnel also contains large rings at even intervals, raised slightly above the floor and measuring about a meter in width. Under the porous surface, the rings look to made from a much harder material resembling limestone.

A successful **MEDICURGY** test can identify the limestone rings as made from some kind of organic cartilage. The porous

A NEW HOPE

As the PCs are exiting the Azaëlean husk, you could allow them to find a small patch of dirt covered in hard, semi-buried spheres. Most have cracked and rotted but a couple seem intact (**MEDICURGY**) and a closer look reveals movement underneath the milky shell. Is the last hope for the resurrection of the Azaëleans now resting in the hands of the PCs?

HYMN TO AMA'TURAB

Oh Mother supreme.
The lungs of Kua.
The lifeblood of all.
Fertility and rebirth.
Azaël et Ama'turab
The Traveler and the Judge.
The true Icon. Guardian of Kua.

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floor also appears carbon-based and looks like thick, dry skin, something a CULTURE test can associate with the mummified elephants commonly found in Miran burial temples or the desiccated desdemodu travelers may come across in the Dabaran desserts.

A critical success on either of the tests above may reveal to the PCs that what they're seeing are the insides of a long-since dead Azaëlean. The tunnel tissue would probably be very valuable to the right buyer within the Foundation or to a Kuan historian. If they gather a sizable amount (GM decides how much), it will fetch them between 2,000 and 5,000 birr.
Cost: 0 DP

6. KHERIA'S ARBORETUM

The journey takes the PCs into what used to be a fenced-in grove with beautiful plants and exotic birds in bright colors. Kheria's Arboretum was a popular floor 14 destination for the wealthier families of the Spire and the park somehow looks to have survived the Fall – a couple of light panels still running on emergency power have allowed cherry trees and thick rose bushes to thrive along the cracked glass dome of the module. Scavenging rodents and felines from the jungles above have made their way down to the arboretum to feast on the remains of its winged former inhabitants.

A few of the birds did survive, however, and they have found chambers and tunnels closer to the surface to nest in to have easy access to the jungles above. As the GM, you decide if, when and where the PCs meet the out-of-place-looking birds.

- **Territorial:** At the cost of 1 DP, a small pack of cats or rats makes a lightning strike against the PCs (one strength 6 attack, weapon damage 1, CRIT 3). The attackers can be avoided using DEXTERITY or shooed away using MANIPULATION. Gunfire automatically scares the pack away.

Cost: 0, 1 DP

7. THE TOXIC SHAFT

The PCs reach the bottom of an elevator shaft and can either attempt to climb up the worn service ladders (DEXTERITY –1) or force their way through a locked maintenance door into the narrow stairwell beyond (FORCE). The stairs wind upward in the dark between two Spire levels and clearly demonstrate the difference in standards between the carpet-lined and richly decorated corridors of the wealthy and the dark and cramped service tunnels. Something is still supplying power to the area and several broken panels and screens crackle dangerously and stretches of the ascent appear burned.

- **Choking gas:** A choking gas has formed in the shaft and stairwell, robbing the PCs of their oxygen (see Drowning, page 97 of the Coriolis core rulebook). For 1 DP, the gas covers a section that takes two to three turns to pass and for 2 DP, the gas cloud requires six or more turns to cross and preferably some form of protective gear.

Cost: 0, 1–2 DP

8. THE GRAVEYARD

One of the Spire's more busy and crowded sections used to be the level 12 entertainment district, the Ijadra. Wide avenues lead to the ruins of exquisite food courts, theaters and museums. Right up to the fall of the station, the streets were full of friends, lovers and families having a good time but as Coriolis started to crash, the hull tore open, the ED fields were overloaded and shorted out and the fall through the atmosphere boiled or evaporated the crowds. Decaying bodies, ash and crushed bones are all that remain but a MEDICURGY exam of the more intact bodies reveals that some of them survived the crash and died later, a grimace of terror plastered on their darkened faces. Choose if you would like the darkness bound to this horrible place to try to attack the PCs:

- **Bokor:** Suddenly, several of the mangled, decomposing bodies rise from the rubble. They have become manifestations of physical darkness, mimicking life in the form of that which some legends call bokor (page 336 of the Coriolis core rulebook). At the cost of 1 DP, one or two bodies rise. Spend 3 DP and a large group reanimates and starts moving toward the PCs.

Cost: 1, 3 DP

9. THE FALL OF THE HEGEMONY

The splendor of the Therr floor with its jungle oases might be familiar to the PCs because they've actually been there or because the Bulletin regularly used to feature it in its broadcasts. The floor appears to have gone down ceiling first and the ruins are now a dangerous hike through a desert of razor-sharp shards. Some of the previously awe-striking palaces still hang precariously in the darkness above as the PCs start to walk across the glass and metal wasteland. The sections that are still intact show a hexagonal grid of glass holo screens, some of which are still functional enough to

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display a flickering simulation of crisp Ardhan skies. Fallen statues and ruins of what were once magnificent buildings form small hills along the PCs' way. Vines climb on the rubble piles toward the highest of the hills, a large mass of white gravel – the Palace of the Hegemony.

- **Shards:** At the cost of 1 DP, the PCs must pass a DEXTERITY test to cross the glass wastes safely or suffer a strength 5 (weapon damage 2, CRIT 1) attack. One PC may scout ahead by passing an OBSERVATION test to find a safe path for the others.

Cost: 0, 1 DP

10. LAKE ABHRRA

Eventually, the PCs reach the remains of floor 96 and the Machine Icon's former home. Proceed to the next scene and either read aloud the introduction text found there or describe their arrival in your own words.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

MINOR EVENTS

If you haven't played all of the dreams from the first part of the scenario yet you can do so during the group's travels through the ruins to emphasize their getting closer to their destination – the tomb of the Machine Icon.

⚙ PREY

A pack of nekatra have found the scent of the PCs in the ruins of the Spire. The starved animals hope to be able to attack an unsuspecting PC at some convenient ambush location (see nekatra rules on page 316 of the Coriolis core rulebook). The attack can happen in the ruins described above or someplace else. The pack will consist of between two and five individuals but should be tailored to the combat proficiency of your group. As the nekatra are semi-intelligences, however, they are capable of basic communication and are susceptible to dominant threats or food bribes (MANIPULATION).

Cost: 2 DP

⚙ RESONANCE: THE TRAVELS OF THE EMISSARY

A sudden sound or a failed roll during one of the events above can act as a trigger for a new vision from the Machine Icon for a PC. The visions are connected to the history of a certain location, like lingering echoes of what happened before (see the "Resonance" boxes).

Cost: 1 DP

RESONANCE: THE ALTAR OF THE EMISSARY

You kneel by the four containers – couscous, water, myrrh and a lit candle. The elements of life and of the Song: grown from seeds in the ground sown by countless foremothers; water to nourish and grow us until we step out of the stream of our parents; memories that never really fade, a smell of something dear to bring them back; wax collected and sculpted with labor to burn with the flames of passion – till only death remains.

RESONANCE: THE KIDNAPPING

They're coming. Your lost children. The exiled who renounced your love for the shadow under the Martyr's crown. A door opens and you command them, your voice hard, cutting the air, shaking the walls and tearing at their flesh in waves of pain...

RESONANCE: A POISONED ICON

Your body is bound by the poison. Cold and darkness. Cut off from the Song, your brothers and sisters – and the universe. You remember only being clear for a moment at a time, steadying your voice for long enough to form short sentences aimed at potential saviors.

RESONANCE: THE BIRTH OF THE MACHINE ICON

Something grabs and pulls on your mind – with purpose, tirelessly. Darkness seeps into your veins. The temple walls groan, crack and then... The masters and destroyers of Terra, the parents you once left behind, stand before you as you drown in a bottomless, starry night. The body is torn in a million pieces and your mind desperately tries to find shelter. First panic, then tranquility. Your lost children become a beacon – a light guiding you to a new body made of metal – your salvation, the Coriolis space station.

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RESONANCE: ZENITH'S BETRAYAL

Your body shines brightly above the green Kuan continent below. Soon, the new Horizon will be ready to become part of the world you and your siblings left your homes for. The Nazareem have fallen, their snake pits purged. But then, it happens. The children of Zenith reach out their hands for the ruling crown and behind them, something moves in the shadows. Butterflies in the darkness.

RESONANCE: THE FALL OF THE MONOLITH

My brother, the self-proclaimed Judge, raises his voice:

"Brothers and sisters. You know that only a decisive blow will sever the serpent's head from its body. The children of Terra have been deceived and our only hope to restore balance is to destroy their corrupt rule. The Portal Builders' leveler can buy us the time we need. The sky must fall to give our new order a chance to bloom."

I feel grief and despair. My new body, the link to the children I've learned to love, must perish – and I with it.

"I see what we have to do, but they'll never forgive us for it. We're standing at a cross-roads. If we do this, we'll become the Icons they fear in their dark and lonely hours. We'll become Night itself!"

URNI EN-ARGONNAS

The Abhrra used to be home to some of the station's most important leaders and aristocrats before it fell along with the rest of the Spire. The holo dome has fallen and only a few scattered panels still flicker with defiant, blue Ardhan daylight, casting long shadows around the jagged wasteland. Massive steel joists and maintenance tunnels forced upward through the floor now jut from the ground like broken swords rusting on a forgotten battlefield. Cracks in the ceiling lead the monsoons from high above down as mighty waterfalls that turn the once-magnificent gardens into swamps. You remember your last visit here. The Emissary had gone missing, there were riots in the streets. But instead of the words of judge Kurahan, you instead hear the familiar voice of the wanderer you once met in a field of grain on a distant world. The wrinkled, sun-kissed face smiles at you:

"Dear friends. We shall reunite shortly. My home is your home. But I feel the agents of my siblings drawing nearer. They will soon be here and they mean to imprison me once more!"

THE SITUATION

The final scene of the scenario takes the PCs through the destruction of the Abhrra to the former residence of the Messenger Emissary.

MAJOR EVENTS

These two events describe the final scene of the scenario.

THE BLADE FROM XENE

The surviving Children of the Song are led by the Emissaries at Xene and are being used as unwilling host bodies for the elite agents of the Santulans, the Dakin. A group of five Dakin puppets has made it to the Abhrra floor to try to capture the soul of the Machine Icon in a mind trap (see box). If a puppet is broken by stress, the Dakin is expelled from the body and the original person awakens. The returned have only a blurry sense of what has happened and only remember the more powerful events since being overtaken. The five puppets in this scene were all dominated about a week ago except for Jana who has been under Dakin control for more than a cycle – her last memory from before is traveling down the Ramishah toward the Monolith when the artifact's discharge suddenly destroyed Sky City.

Alter the size and strength of the puppet group depending on how much resistance you want to throw at your players. Make your choice well in advance to allow the group to find abandoned members of the group as the PCs are traveling through the ruins. The mystics they find

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could either be dead or have sustained enough damage for the Dakin to have been forced out (critically injured). One of the remaining Dakin puppets is carrying the mind orb (see box). Pick one mystical power per puppet from the Coriolis core rulebook or from the text below (see also page 193–194 of *Emissary Lost*). Each puppet also has one general talent (page 69 of the Coriolis core rulebook) plus the "Mercy of the Symmetry" talent (see bow).

- **0 DP:** If you can't or won't spend more DP, several of the puppets are already dead or no longer dominated, having fallen victim to tunnel collapses or nekatra attacks on the way down. Only one puppet remains (choose either Jana or Mustafa).
- **1 DP:** Three puppets remain alive.
- **2 DP:** All five puppets remain and have staged an ambush (page 85 of the Coriolis core rulebook).
- **3 DP:** All five puppets remain, have staged an ambush and have boobytrapped the site with sensor smoke and frag grenades.

Cost: 0–3 DP

THE MACHINE ICON'S EMBRACE

The broken landscape isn't easy to maneuver through but as the GM, you're of course free to decide how hard the PCs will have to work to reach the residence of the Emissary.

- **The Swamp (1–2 DP):** The wide, snake-infested swamp is difficult to cross safely (SURVIVAL) and without being bitten. At the cost of 1 DP, small, poisonous snakes lurk in the

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TABLE 07: NPCS: THE EMISSARIES' AGENTS

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Dakin puppet (modifies stats below)	–	–	5	5	–	15	–	Data Djinn 5, Dexterity 5, Infiltration 5, Melee Combat 5, Mystic Powers 5, Ranged Combat 5	(See below. All puppets get the "Mercy of the Symmetry" talent)
Jana Khamiri – Kuan river barge merchant	2	3	5	(3)	5	(8)	4	Command 3, Manipulation 3, Culture 2	Flightsuit, Vulcan carbine. Talents: Kinetic Blast, Nine Lives
Mustafa Amshi – Legionnaire working in the Rimward Reach	4	4	(2)	(2)	8	(4)	3	Observation 3, Command 2, Medicurgy 2, (Ranged Combat 4, Melee Combat 3)	Mercurium sword, thermal cricket, battle exo. Talents: Kinetic Blast, The Hassassin's Thrust
Wahid Faraan – Miran preacher	2	2	(4)	(4)	4	(8)	5	Manipulation 3, Culture 2, Survival 1	Long rifle, inferno grenade. Talents: Prevent, Third Eye
Noor Dayal – Scientist from the Foundation's base in Uharu	2	3	5	(3)	5	(8)	6	Science 4, Technology 3, Observation 2	Acc pistol, frag grenade, com link, drone. Talents: Soul Reader, Wealthy Family
Sian Ab-Hadid – Zalosian soldier from Zalos-B	3	5	(2)	(3)	8	(5)	3	Survival 3, Culture 2, Command 1, (Infiltration 4, Ranged Combat 3, Melee Combat 2)	Dura knife, thermal carbine, gravity belt. Talents: Sculpt, Executioner

MYSTICAL POWER: MERCY OF THE SYMMETRY

The mystic can harness energy from the resonance between the stars. She recovers 2 points of stress and damage at the end of every turn and recovers completely after one minute outside of combat. The recovery costs no AP but stops if the mystic loses consciousness from a critical injury (the Coriolis core rulebook, page 94) or is reduced to 0 MP.

water (See "Miran jungle viper on page 129 of *The Last Cyclade*) For 2 DP, it's a whole nest of giant cobras on the edges of the swamp instead ("Bionic large cobra", page 129 of *The Last Cyclade*).

The residence of the Emissary sits right at the edge of the swamp, half-submerged beneath the dirty water. The walkways that used to be flanked by beautiful sandstone walls and shadowed by klefsi vines are now cracked and overgrown. The terrace garden and the arcades of the residential complex are completely covered under a thick carpet of twisting jungle plants. The apartment used by the Messenger Emissary is

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ARTIFACT: MIND TRAP [–2]

The mind trap consists of two fist-sized, ornate spheres. The pair is joined but can be turned around one another thanks to a pattern of slits in the ornamentation. The origin of the artifact is unknown – it might have been created by the First Horizon to counteract the resonance powers of the Santulans and trap the minds of their leaders for interrogation.

- **EFFECT: When the spheres are aligned properly, an energy field can be created that captures mind travelers and ethereal beings such as djinni. The targets may try to resist by beating the user in an opposed MYSTIC POWERS roll. The user of the mind trap may either use the artifacts skill level of 6 or their score. If the user is successful, the target's mind is trapped and cannot break free until the spheres are turned and aligned in the correct release sequence. By using different combinations of sphere positions, the trap can hold up to nine minds at a time.**
- **DARKNESS POINTS: 3**
- **KNOWLEDGE REQUIREMENTS: MYSTIC POWERS**

OUT FROM THE RUINS

As the GM, you decide how the group leaves the ruins of the Spire. You can have the Machine Icon guide them to the surface or to their ship along a shortcut, simply cut to them having left already or challenge them to a dangerous ascent with the Abhrra collapsing behind them – the Machine Icon can no longer support the integrity of the ruins and the whole Spire risks coming down over their heads.

also in poor shape, trees and bushes sprouting in through the windows and climbing along the ceiling out into the mosaic tiled hallway outside. The living room – although with a new greenish tint to it and containing more dirt and decomposing leaves than furniture – feels surprisingly tidy, however. The PCs have reached their goal. Read aloud the text in the box below or use your own words to describe their meeting with the Machine Icon based on these bullet points:

- Urni en-Argonnas has drawn them here to offer help for the coming war.
- The PCs are mentioned in ancient prophecies from the times before the last wars.
- The Symmetry left the First Horizon and chose exile to establish their own society, far from the reach of the Eternal Emperor. They are originally the children of the First Horizon and the Third Horizon was in turn populated by groups that had grown tired of the Symmetry's rule and ventured out to look for their own freedom.
- The Machine Icon regrets using the Monolith to disrupt the Zenithian takeover (*The Last Cyclade*) and has now turned against its former siblings.
- The Machine Icon offers to merge with the minds of the PCs but leaves the choice entirely up to them. If none of the PCs is willing to let Urni in, they can instead bond the Santulan with a talisman, a significant personal item or the mind trap (if they recovered it after defeating the Dakin puppets, page 40).
- If Urni merges with a physical object, the PCs will still be able to consult the mystic through this item but are otherwise not given any special powers or benefits.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

ENDING

The PCs' hunt for answers about who was calling to them has reached its end. They have found the Machine Icon and seen visions of both the past and the future. This will give them further visions throughout the campaign, protection from the manipulations of the other Emissaries and gradually manifest powerful mystical abilities within them (see the introduction to the next scenario, The Tenth Icon, page 49).

War is coming and the heroes are getting ready.

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MEETING AN ICON

You have returned to where it all began.

On the floor before you, someone has carefully swept the dirt aside. A platter of fresh fruit and a pitcher sits in the middle of the room, surrounded by small cushions.

The floor vibrates and your fingertips tingle with static electricity. From nowhere and everywhere at once, a single note gradually grows into a chorus of reverent harmonies and then, finally, a voice:

"You are here. Thank you for coming. I have waited so long to see you again. Have a seat. Eat, drink, listen."

A sweet scent of hot chai steams from the clay pitcher and a few of the rocks just outside the cleared circle float off the ground and begin weaving a spiraling pattern in the air around you. You can almost make out a faint shadow in the middle of the room – a young girl with a dress full of stars: the Machine Icon.

"You are the Chosen. The glyphs of the Martyr and the songs of Mira all speak of the coming storm. The return of the Portal Wars, when the peoples of the Horizon will unite against Terra. We, brothers and sisters, are like you. We left the butterflies' lords behind and wandered the stars. Our exile forced us into war but we stood our ground. We knew our way was the right way."

Images shoot through your mind. A terrible storm somewhere in the yellow atmosphere of Xene. Voices calling, a weapon firing. Echoes of Bulletin reports about the Emissary's arrival to Coriolis. A cruiser, the Ghazali, ripped apart by a wave of fire. Butterfly ships flickering past. Suspicion and fear over the mystic's disease. Lonely, scared outcasts finding each other in back alleys. Humanites captured and forced to work at gunpoint. Riots in the streets of Coriolis against the new Council. The interior of the Monolith, many thousands of voices screaming in pain and terror as Sky City crumbles and Coriolis is torn apart high in the Kuan skies. Wild emotions cut through your chest like knives.

"We came here to guide our children out of exile and isolation, back into the light. Knowing what we did about Terra's plans, we thought no action too drastic. However, experiencing Coriolis falling out of the skies and my new body torn to shreds made me realize the depth of my betrayal."

More visions. Crews turning on their captains. Mutinies. Muzzle flashes. Ships gathering at Xene. Four chanting Emissaries. Butterfly ships appearing out of the portal field in Kua. Nomad ships orbiting an unknown planet. Pagodas. Four aging monks speaking with one voice. Glyph cruisers launching barrages of torpedoes. Explosions lighting the night sky. Nazareem cultists wandering through corridors, leaving them dark. A star flashing and exploding in a wave of light.

"You will be tested and have to walk through fire to reach the other side, dead or alive. Terra's fleets stand in your way. My brothers and sisters stand in your way. I sacrificed my body for something I didn't believe in and now I want to give the rest of me to help you fulfill your destiny. Through you, I can find meaning and a new Horizon."

You hear the winds play across the fields behind the high temples. A short person walks up beside you, beautifully dressed and with a wide smile warming their wrinkled, dark face covered in scrolling gold tattoos. They reach out to embrace you:

"Let me merge with your minds and give you the protection and knowledge you need to defeat the coming darkness, or let me become a guide to you by bonding to something you carry with you."

You make your choice and wake up in darkness. The floating stones have fallen to the floor and the air is still again.

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THE CHOSEN

If the PCs chose to merge with Urni en-Argonnas, they are forever changed and will gradually develop new mystical powers (see Table 08).

NEW RULES: PC RESONANCE POWERS

The PCs now use a version of the resonance rules from page 191 of *Emissary Lost*. Once they unlock their first new power (Table 08), the following applies:

- **Pooling Resonance:** All extra sixes rolled on skill tests may be turned into communal Resonance Points (RSP). The RSP pool may never exceed the group's Empathy total but can be used by anyone in the group. The pool loses 2 RSP per day but if all the PCs who chose to merge with the Machine Icon spend an hour in prayer and meditation close together (once per day only), they can cancel out the waning of the pool and generate 1 new RSP per participating PC (instead of any other bonuses from the meditation).
- **Using Resonance:** Resonance powers won't automatically generate DP. Instead, the PC attempting to use a resonance power must spend as many RSP as the talent level she wishes to activate (1–4) and test MYSTIC POWERS. If the roll fails, 1 DP is generated and the spent RSP are lost. If the roll is critically successful, the spent RSP are returned to the pool. Unlike the Symmetry mystics, PCs may only use the talent level they currently have, not lower or higher tiers.
- **Activation:** Resonance powers are generally considered slow actions (3 AP) but some powers are reactive and may be used during an opponent's initiative activation (with the same AP cost).
- **Concentration:** Powers requiring concentration need only one merged PC to be awake and able to spend a normal action per turn. If the character in question becomes broken or loses consciousness, another PC may step in and retain the concentration as long as she has at least 2 AP left to spend in the same turn.
- **Power Bonus:** When using a resonance power, the PCs always get a bonus to their MYSTIC POWERS roll thanks to the help of the Machine Icon. If the PCs are within 100 meters of each other, each merged PC generates a +1 (up to a maximum of +3). As their first ability manifests itself, each merged PC gets a permanent +1 to their MYSTIC POWERS score.

THE POWERS

PCs who merged with the Machine Icon will develop resonance powers. Roll a die or choose from the table below to determine the PCs' abilities. Each PC gains 2–3 powers (all powers on a row). These will gradually manifest during the campaign. The GM chooses if they manifest in the order of the row or if the player can choose the order.

Some of the powers are modified when used by the PCs rather than by the Emissaries (see below).

The table below also contains a suggested first activation with a short description of a vision or dream. If you want to even out the activation of new abilities, you can limit the manifesting to one power per PC per scene or act.

TABLE 08: PC RESONANCE POWERS

D6	POWER 1 (LEVEL)	POWER 2 (LEVEL)	POWER 3 (LEVEL)
1	RECREATE (1): Regeneration	TRANSLOCATION (2): Spirit Shift	RECREATE (2): Soothing Touch
2	RECREATE (2): Soothing Touch	RECREATE (3): Sculpt	–
3	MIND SHIFT (2): Mind Reader	RECREATE (1): Regeneration	TELEKINESIS (2): Kinetic Blast
4	CONTROL (3): Forbid	RECREATE (2): Soothing Touch	–
5	DESTROY (1): Sense Possession	TELEKINESIS (3): Barrier	RECREATE (1): Regeneration
6	DESTROY (3): Bind	RECREATE (2): Soothing Touch	–

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TABLE 09: RESONANCE POWERS

POWER (LEVEL)	RULES	FIRST ACTIVATION
RECREATE (1): Regeneration	Roll MYSTIC POWERS instead of MEDICURGY when treating your own wounds (even when broken but with a -2).	(You receive a critical injury or have been broken by damage) *"The pain and anxiety awaken a distant sorrow within you. Then, warm love and hope flows through your chest and you see the Kuan night sky before you. Life, untethered, surges through you."*
RECREATE (2): Soothing Touch	Use MYSTIC POWERS with a +2 instead of MEDICURGY when treating the wounds of others (in addition to the Machine Icon bonus).	(A friend suffers a critical injury or becomes broken) *"The Kuan sun warms your face and your fingers tingle with life and love. The chaos and sadness around and within you subsides and you feel safe and calm as you reach out to touch your friend."*
RECREATE (3): Sculpt	Immediately regain 4 HP or MP for each six rolled (player chooses after rolling). May be used on another merged PC as long as you are physically touching.	(You become broken) *"Darkness envelops you but at its core, a lone star pulsates. Suddenly, it explodes in a symphony of voices and turns into a vast, star-lit sky filled with hope. You get back up without a scratch on your body and feel life rushing through your veins."*
TRANSLOCATION (2): Spirit Shift	When in trance, your mind can leave your body and travel up to five meters per slow action and rolled six. You can pass through thin walls, see, hear and experience light touching but are not otherwise affected by the physical realm. If your body is harmed, your mind immediately returns to it.	(You come before an obstacle or a locked door or feel trapped) *"The walls are closing in around you. You feel shut in, bound and weak. But suddenly, there she is – the girl with the dress full of stars. She puts her hand in yours and together, you walk out of the world unhindered."*
TELEKINESIS (2): Kinetic Blast	Attack using MYSTIC POWERS (damage 2, CRIT 2, Short Range). You can divide your rolled sixes between multiple targets as long as they're within a meter of each other.	(You're threatened or in combat) *"You stare at your enemy and feel your hairs stand on end. The air crackles with static electricity as particles and small objects whirl around a wooden top floating between you. The raw power halts for a brief moment before lunging forward in a massive wave of pain."*
TELEKINESIS (3): Barrier	(Reaction) You form a shield from loose objects and light materials around you (armor 4). Concentration is required to maintain the shield. Each extra six on you roll adds +2 to the armor rating or allows you to maintain your concentration for D6 turns without spending any more AP. Forcing through the barrier to attack you in close combat requires an opposed FORCE vs armor test.	(You are attacked and take a hit) *"You brace yourself for the impact and the pain but instead feel a gentle caress. A young girl wraps you in a star-covered dress. The fabric becomes a cloud of particles, of objects pulled from the ground or walls around you, forming a shield of love."*

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POWER (LEVEL)	RULES	FIRST ACTIVATION
CONTROL (3): Forbid	(Reaction, slow action) Prevent targets within sight from performing actions. Roll MYSTIC POWERS and divide your sixes among the targets you want to affect. A critical success doubles the number of successes. Each target must beat her allocated number of sixes in a MYSTIC POWERS or Strength roll to be allowed to act.	(You encounter a numerically superior enemy and they all act before you do) *"You feel overwhelmed by the threat in front of you and your heart races in your chest. The sound of blood rushing in your head is deafening, and then... calm stalks of grain bending in the breeze, touching you lightly. You lift your arms, see a branching arc of ethereal energy spring from your hands and envelop your enemies, binding them."*
MIND SHIFT (2): Mind Reader	You can read the superficial thoughts of a target as long as you concentrate. If you win an opposed MYSTIC POWERS roll, you can also read your target's deeper memories and traumas but only as fragments of images and sensations. If you score a critical win, the fragments are clearer.	(You speak to someone who tries to hide something from you) *"The truth you seek remains unspoken and you feel your frustration growing, centering around your heart. Visualizing the core of the emotion, you suddenly see a spinning wooden top weaving the truth together and as you open your eyes, you gaze right into the soul of your opponent."*
DESTROY (1): Sense Possession	You can tell if a person or object is possessed or invaded by a foreign spirit. You understand the invader's intentions but not what or who it is.	(You are confronted with someone being puppeted, GM decides details) "As you study the aura in front of you, you sense a shadow hiding beneath the bright exterior. Strings tug at the puppet's limbs. Something foreign with the will to dominate..."
DESTROY (3): Bind	You can expel an invading force from a person, object or yourself. Roll an opposed MYSTIC POWERS roll. If you win, the invader is expelled and imprisoned in another person or object of your choosing. The invader is under your control as long as you don't fall asleep or lose consciousness. If you lose, you suffer the negative difference of your loss in stress. The power may be used to bind a Vestal or Santulan controlling a puppet.	(You stand in front of a Vestal or Emissary who threatens you) *"The servant of the Old Horizons stands before you in a glow of darkness and chaos. You feel the hate radiating toward you and the body it was just dominating becomes unimportant. The strength in you comes from the Machine Icon's faith in the Third Horizon, its faith in you and the choice before you. As you make the choice, you feel strong and determined to act, to rip your opponent from the mind of its victim and subjugate them to your will."*

MANIFESTING A NEW POWER

On the first activation of a new power, you could allow for an automatic critical success to really show the full potential of this new ability.

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THE TENTH ICON

From the darkness of war, You summoned light.
Through the eight, we hear Your voice.
Behind the mask, we feel Your love.
Once and future You, always.
You are wisdom. You are life.
You are Aremerat.

THE HYMN OF THE SAVIOR, SADAALIAN PRAYER BOOK

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INTRODUCTION

In part two of this book, the fleets of the Third Horizon are in peril as more and more mystics leave their posts and steal warships to join the devout in the Quiet Zone around Xene. The abandoned Nadir Flotilla naturally becomes the new center of attention. Blessed by the Icons, the factions approach the Sadaalian high clergy, the Amesha Spenta, and the system's mythical leader Aremerat to negotiate – unaware of the traitors waiting in the shadows.

IN THE TENTH ICON, the PCs are hired to bless a delegation on its way to negotiate with the Sadaalian leadership. The PCs' adventurous past has drawn many curious and wealthy patrons to them, and their reputation makes them the key to earning Aremerat's favor. But the Sadaalian masks hide more than idolatry and strict governance – they also hide the First Horizon Vestals who once again try to sunder the Third Horizon and bring its peoples to war.

BACKGROUND

The fate of the Nadir Flotilla has become a hot topic in the halls of power. The fleet was built at the distant shipyards of Bahram, through secret treaties with the leaders of Sadaal. The new flotilla was named after the lost sister-ship of Zenith and built by conscripted humanites. The plan was to use the flotilla to secure the power to The Consortium and The Zenithian Hegemony as they seized control over the Horizon Council. But everything changed when the monolith was activated. The exiled Zenithians found new homes on Amedo after the Fall of Coriolis and in the newly formed Zenithian Coalition, fusing the Hegemony's worship of history and bloodlines with the Consortium's expansionism and dreams of dominance. The Coalition was first to try negotiating with the Eight Wisdoms of Sadaal, the Amesha Spenta, but a decree from Aremerat soon shut the system off to almost all outsiders, putting a halt to the talks. Only the Syndicate has managed to maintain a working relationship with the Sadaalian rulers and the faction's freighters have basically become the only way in for outsiders, unless they manage to get onboard one of the few bulk haulers that are still allowed entry.

CALLED TO SADAAL

Since the beginning of the campaign, the First Horizon has gradually started to notice the PCs. The Vestal on Sadaal now demands their direct participation in the negotiations for the Nadir Flotilla through its puppet Aremerat. As the Icons' Chosen, the PCs' presence will bless the talks, but the Vestal's true motives are to either convert them to the Imperial cause or destroy them, just like it plans to do with the rest of the delegates to create further distance between Sadaal and the other factions of the Third Horizon.

AREMERAT THE ETERNAL

The twin systems Sadaal and Bahram grew strong together under a philosophy of hard work, cooperation and equality before the Icons. By the people, for the people. The Firstcome saw a golden future take shape until the final weeks of the Portal Wars when the bombs came, crushing the fertile farmlands of the Shimush Mountains and drowning the cities of Bahram under huge tsunamis. Then, out of the chaos, stepped a savior – the prophet Aremerat, who rallied the people again and rebuilt the systems. What very few know, however, is that Aremerat is actually Aresh Najendaar, an admiral from the Sadaalian fleets who was captured by the First Horizon after being defeated during the Dziban offensive. Under gruesome torture, admiral Najendaar was given

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a choice: join U'Haya and the Vestals in exchange for "eternal life" through bionic and mental augmentation. The admiral accepted, and just as the final battles raged in Odacon, a new leader emerged in Sadaal – Aremerat the Eternal. After many failed assassination attempts, Aremerat's opponents realized he was basically beyond the reach of death and chose instead to join the growing cult praising their very own Tenth Icon.

THE BEAST BEHIND THE MASK

Aremerat began seeing himself through the eyes of his devotees and therefore as something greater than the beings who had given him eternal life. He abandoned the ways of U'Haya, but after the fall of Taoan, his former masters weren't far away – the Vestals arrived in the butterfly ships and Aremerat was punished for his betrayal. In a dark crypt underneath the Ziggurat of the Icons, his desiccated body now feeds a Nazareem cadaver clock. The power of the dark between the stars flows into the Vestal Ashaan-Unt Et-U'Haya who has manipulated the leaders and people of Sadaal into completing the Nadir Flotilla and making it the first of the Eternal Emperor's fleets inside the Third Horizon.

THE HUMANITES

The Waha-Najima bulk hauler, "the Celestial Oasis," was one of the last ships to leave Dabaran before the portals closed. Onboard, more than two thousand stasis units carry Hadid humanites – the Emperor's latest weapon – fresh from the production tanks to bolster the strength of the Angra Mainyu secret police, "The Phantoms," and give the Vestals an even stronger hold of the system. A battalion of four hundred Hadid has already been deployed to preempt any attempts by the people to fight back. The remaining battalions of around two thousand humanites have been loaded aboard Aremerat's Giants, the bulk haulers on the Sadaal-Bahram line, and taken to the Daharab shipyards to begin staffing the Nadir Flotilla.

THE MUTINIES

The factions of the Third Horizon have scrambled their fleets since the Fall of Coriolis and tried to rebuild their former networks of forts and bases. The union between the Order of the Pariah and Mira appears to have cemented the Firstcome's new hold over the cluster, but the stability of this is already starting to erode. The new mystics still feel the call of the Emissaries, but something has changed. They act in unison and start taking over warships. The mutinies soon spread to all

PLAYING THE CHANGE

Although Sadaal used to be a system with many restrictions, the new state of almost complete isolation is something you need to make sure your players are made aware of. The closing can happen as a complication to an earlier scenario, if you play in the interim between the first two parts of the *Mercy of the Icons* campaign, or you can introduce it via newscasts or portal station rumors (see quotes).

RUMORS ABOUT SADAAL

After the exiled Zenithians' continued demands for further exploitation, Aremerat has issued a decree. Sadaal remains independent and neutral. Visitors without clearance must turn around or perish by the sword of the Judge.

COMMUNIQUE FROM THE SECURITY INSTITUTE

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IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

During the scenario, you might also need to add some of the minor NPCs from Table 10.

- **HEMISHA BIRBASIL – Captain of the Syndicate freighter Birbasil's Dream (page 64)**
- **JANDRI RAMANDA – Captain of The Phantoms, Aremerat's secret police (page 74)**
- **HADID – The Vestal's new humanite soldiers (page 97)**
- **ASHAAN-UNT ET-U'HAYA – The Vestal ruling Sadaal (page 98)**

the factionary fleets and threaten to destabilize the foundations of the Firstcome military alliances. Corsairs, torpedo ships, freighters, cruisers – they all gather in Kua and around Xene. Pursuers of the mutineers are forced to give up as the fleeing mystics are welcomed into the Quiet Zone and slip inside the protective range of its mighty weapon systems. As the GM, you can have this play out in parallel to the adventures of the PCs leading up to The Tenth Icon, for example by having the factions ask the group for help to track or hunt down rogue ships.

THE WARRIORS OF THE HOLY LIGHT

The secret behind the isolation of Dabaran is still unknown to the public even if many of the intelligence agencies are investigating and analyzing what might have happened behind the closed portal. Followers of the publicly shamed Warriors of the Holy Light try to redeem their organization by finding out the truth about Dabaran. They try to find and befriend the mysterious Chosen depicted on the prophetic glyph armor of the monastery cruisers and sung of in pre-War hymns, the heralds of the Machine Icon: the PCs.

OVERVIEW

The fleets of the Third Horizon are slowly bleeding out from mutinies and inexplicable guerrilla attacks from out of the dark between the stars (by butterfly ships). Negotiations with the leadership of Sadaal have broken down, time and again. An agreement to divide the Nadir Flotilla between the factions warrants a final attempt to approach Aremerat and the PCs are called in to escort the delegation's VIPs. They soon find themselves walking into a deadly trap.

SCENE 1 – BIRBASIL'S DREAM (PAGE 62)

The segment of the Dancer, C164: The PCs have recuperated after the events on Kua but are soon contacted by one of their patrons. The supreme leader of Sadaal, Aremerat the Eternal, has requested their presence at negotiations with the rest of the factions. They are expected to meet the syndicate vessel Birbasil's Dream on the independent station Djachroum and then travel to Aiwaz. The trip takes the PCs through the wounded system of Kua and prepares them for what's to come…

SCENE 2 – COMING TOGETHER (PAGE 68)

The PCs reach Aiwaz and meet the delegates. Several factions have contributed small fleets or squadrons as escorts. A

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cryptic message is delivered, promising "the truth" as soon as they arrive in Sadaal. As the delegation is preparing to depart, another mutiny takes place as a group of mystics tries to commandeer the flagship of the Order's fleets and jump toward Kua. The conflict with the mystics intensifies.

SCENE 3 – THE BETRAYAL (PAGE 73)

As the PCs arrive in Sadaal, they are awakened to an abrupt change of plans – the rest of the delegates have already been arrested and they now have to fight their way out and escape down to the planet to hide in Alburz with Aremerat's fearsome secret police on their tail.

SCENE 4 – FRIENDS AND ENEMIES (PAGE 87)

Hunted through the streets of Alburz, the PCs find new allies in Deeptown. They meet agents from the Warriors of the Holy Light and learn what's about to happen to the delegation.

SCENE 5 – THE CRYING ZIGGURAT (PAGE 91)

What was meant to be an audience with Aremerat instead turns into a public execution. The delegation is accused of treason and dealings with the enemy: the Emissaries. Only the living Icon Aremerat can save the Third Horizon. The PCs must rescue the delegates and attempt to flee the system, but Sadaal's new humanite soldiers and the Vestal controlling it all from the shadows stand in their way.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

In The Tenth Icon, the Horizon Wars begin and should remind the PCs that without strong alliances, the Third Horizon will perish before the might of the Old Horizons. The road the PCs have to choose should be obvious to them, unless they actively want to become agents of darkness (which will be more demanding for you as the GM).

The beginning of the scenario will see them reconnect with several of their former opponents and allies – potentially both rejected patrons and mortal enemies. This is meant to show them that the delegates are willing to put everything else aside to maximize their chances of resisting the coming darkness. The scenario ends with them learning the truth in Sadaal and seeing the treason there being revealed.

If the PCs chose to merge with Urni at the end of the previous scenario, it's important that you give them time and space to explore their newfound powers and link to the Machine Icon. The mystic mutinies and the threat they pose as puppets to the Emissaries should feel urgent and deeply worrying. Finally, the corruption eating its way through the Sadaalian clergy turns the Nadir Flotilla on the Third Horizon.

PC INCENTIVES

Thanks to previous heroics, their connection to the old prophecies and the guiding voice of the Machine Icon, the PCs' group concept matters less and less. By now, it determines how they belong in the corridors of power, not if they do. Some groups will want payment for their services as escorts to the delegation. As they must travel aboard Birbasil's Dream, the payment they're offered could be a new module fitted for their ship, or lengthy and expensive repairs at the docks in Djachroum or some other trustworthy base. You decide if the PCs are allowed to take their own ship to Aiwaz or if they board the Dream immediately. The scenario doesn't have to begin in Djachroum as described below, but this is a good way to introduce the gathering fleet at Xene if you haven't already done so.

IMPORTANT FACTS

Each scene ends with an event that ties in with the next scene. You can use these events earlier than described below to quicken the pace of the scenario, as long as the PCs have found the key clues below:

- The PCs have been personally chosen by Aremerat to lead the delegation to Sadaal.
- They should meet up with the rest of the delegation on the way.
- They need to understand how serious of a threat the mystic mutinies are becoming.
- They need to make it to Sadaal and meet up with the Warriors of the Holy Light.
- They should figure out that Sadaal chooses to take control of the Nadir Flotilla and turn on the rest of the Third Horizon.

ANTIHEROES

The PCs are ultimately free to choose not to rescue the delegates and don't have to encounter the Vestal. Them doing it is preferable, but what's most important is that the Warriors of the Holy Light manage to tell them the truth – it's up to the PCs if they want to act on the information or if they just want to save their own skins. You could use the Machine Icon to reveal the secret Vestal to them later, if you like.

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THE ETERNAL

"The Eternal Leader has spoken."

Some of the members of the ancient council of Sadaal are about to protest but quickly sit back in their seats again. Amesha Habathu, the Judge incarnate, stands beside Aremerat's empty throne. He looks around and speaks:

"The delegation has been granted entry on two conditions. Firstly, they may only enter our system aboard a ship chosen by us – Amesha Vanzur, it's your responsibility to contact our Syndicate allies and find a loyal captain. And secondly, the delegation must be accompanied by the Chosen. Thus He spoke and thus it shall be. For our Eternal Leader! For Aremerat!"

The other seven council members stand up and bow in silence.

Outside the Ziggurat of the Icons, the Cherry Plaza bustles with life like any other day. The hard-working residents of the Sadaalian capital continue to walk in the light of their Eternal Leader, not knowing what other shadows stalk the corridors of power.

THE SCENARIO BEGINS with an invitation and a meeting with some new Syndicate contacts. After that, the PCs accompany Birbasil's Dream and her crew to Aiwaz to begin their mission.

OVERVIEW

The invitation from a former patron reaches the PCs a couple of days before the Dream arrives at Djachroum. Negotiations on Sadaal have broken down yet again. The factions have desperately tried to write a cooperation treaty for a joint defense against outside attacks but the leadership of Sadaal refuses to listen – until now. Aremerat has allowed for a meeting on the premise that a delegation of Council members and high-ranking dignitaries arrive in person to Sadaal, escorted by the Icon's Chosen – the PCs. After a pleasant and hospitable meeting with captain Hemisha Birbasil and her crew, the journey takes them through Kua and onward to Aiwaz. During the journey, the PCs slowly discover how to use their new powers and speak to the Machine Icon in their dreams.

DARKNESS POINTS

As usual, you begin with at least as many DP as there are players, down to a minimum of 4 DP. More DP are generated during three specific events and the details can be found in the event descriptions:

- Scene 2 – during the mutiny in Aiwaz
- Scene 3 – upon arrival to Alburz
- Scene 5 – at the public execution

SCENARIO LOCATION: DJACHROUM

Even if the scenario begins with the PCs leaving Djachroum, a thorough description of the station has been included to give a better feel for the introduction of the scenario and to provide you with the option to let them spend some time exploring it and the Rimward Reach. Also, The PCs will return to Djachroum during the final part of this adventure.

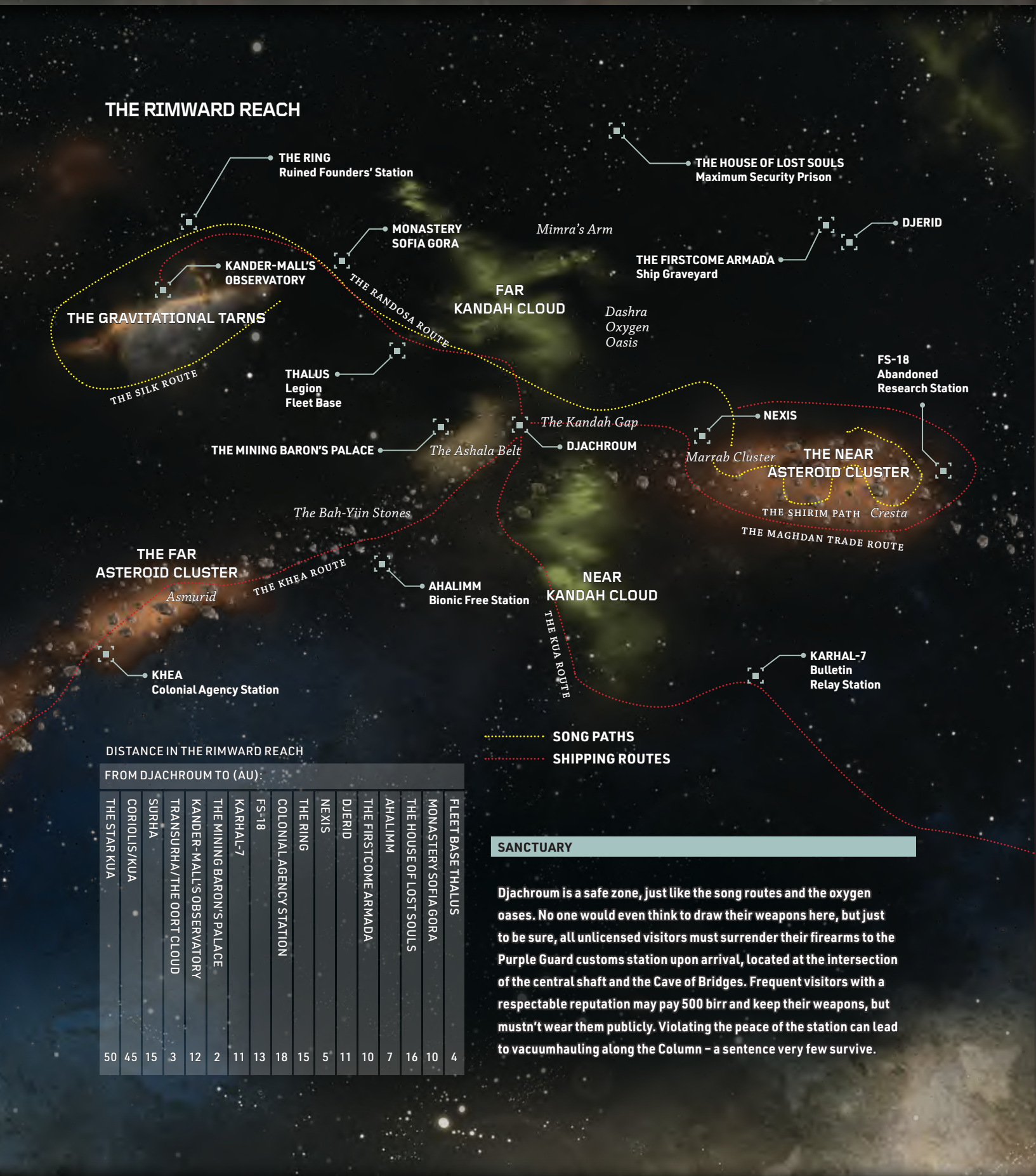
THE KANDAH CLOUD

The Kandah Cloud is an enormous gas cloud in Kua's outer asteroid field reaching 30 AU from Djachroum which places it at a great distance from the core of the system – Djachroum station is already 47 AU from the star. The Cloud is full of mysteries to unravel. Travelers stick to the outer rim or stay inside the Mouth of Kandah, a maze-like pattern of clear corridors that appears to divide the Cloud in two. The reason for the recolonization of this remote part of the system is the discovery of the precious mineral maghdan, a far stronger sibling of selidium which is the primary material used in the construction of graviton projectors.

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DISTANCE IN THE RIMWARD REACH

FROM DJACHROUM TO (AU):	
THE STAR KUA	50
CORIOLIS/KUA	45
SURHA	15
TRANSURHA/THE OORT CLOUD	3
KANDER-MALL'S OBSERVATORY	12
THE MINING BARON'S PALACE	2
KARHAL-7	11
FS-18	13
COLONIAL AGENCY STATION	18
THE RING	15
NEXIS	5
DJERID	11
THE FIRSTCOME ARMADA	10
AHALIMM	7
THE HOUSE OF LOST SOULS	16
MONASTERY SOFIA GORA	10
FLEET BASE THALUS	4

SANCTUARY

Djachroum is a safe zone, just like the song routes and the oxygen oases. No one would even think to draw their weapons here, but just to be sure, all unlicensed visitors must surrender their firearms to the Purple Guard customs station upon arrival, located at the intersection of the central shaft and the Cave of Bridges. Frequent visitors with a respectable reputation may pay 500 birr and keep their weapons, but mustn't wear them publicly. Violating the peace of the station can lead to vacuumhauling along the Column – a sentence very few survive.

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THE FOUNDERS

The Founders were a deeply religious group of Firstcome colonists who settled the Reach about 400 cycles ago and worked in the wide emptiness beyond Kandah. They worshiped mainly the Judge and are said to be the creators of the so-called song routes, a vast network of routes that keep the darkness from overwhelming travelers in the Mouth of Kandah. The Founders disappeared suddenly and inexplicably some 300 cycles ago leaving many strange things behind; the most important of what's been found so far are the Forbidden Sector of Djachroum, the Armada of the Firstcome and Mining Station 13.

THE SONG ROUTES

The song routes cover the entire Rimward Reach, running between asteroid stations, oxygen oases, khayaal gardens and colonies. Folklore attributes them to the shirim, the Founders' high priests, storytellers and gurus. The shirim "sang the songs of life" to repel the dark and shared much of their religious devotions with the Santulans. The songs are kept alive to this day by the nomad swarms through the use of song towers, small temples built on asteroids from which the voices of old still echo in their ancient Miran dialect. Traveling along a song route is considered safe and the song code dictates that no one may fight on the routes, a code respected even by smugglers and corsairs. Those who break the code are believed to fall under the Curse of the Faceless: to be hunted through the night eternal by the star serpent of the Kandah cloud, bah-jin, "the Darkness Eater" (Coriolis core rulebook, page 331).

THE NOMAD SWARMS

The sector around the Mouth of Kandah hasn't been completely deserted since the disappearance of the Founders. Four wandering nomad clans, or swarms, inhabit the Reach: the relatively aggressive and territorial Mehtar; the reclusive and deeply religious Badjao; the trader clan Yahin-Kabu (who take main responsibility for the oxygen oases); and up until recently, the now disappeared Ahilar. The swarms stay mainly near the Marrab cluster, about 5 AU from Djachroum, consisting of the asteroids Marrab, Nija, Hraub, Dakka and Rayyan.

In more recent years, the Reach has seen a steady influx of new residents. The explorer Antoli Djachroum arrived with the two ships Volos and Holy Amesia after the Foundation had reported findings of shipwrecks from earlier colonization waves. Djachroum's arrival led to the bloody Marrab conflict

NEW RULES: HADRA CLOUDS AND ION STORMS

Throughout the Reach, travelers will encounter the mysterious gas clouds know as Hadra, or Hadra clouds. They are almost impossible to spot but can disrupt both sensor operations and other electronic communications equipment (**DATA DJINN** –3).

The Kandah Cloud is intermittently plagued by violent ion storms. Ships caught in such a storm suffer damage per the list below, but the pilot may try to reduce the severity by testing **PILOT**. Each 6 rolled negates 1 point of HP or EP loss. A critically successful roll cancels out all damage. An assisting **TECHNOLOGY** roll performed by another crew member gives the pilot 1 extra die per 6 rolled. Depending on the intensity of the storm, the frequency of attack rolls varies:

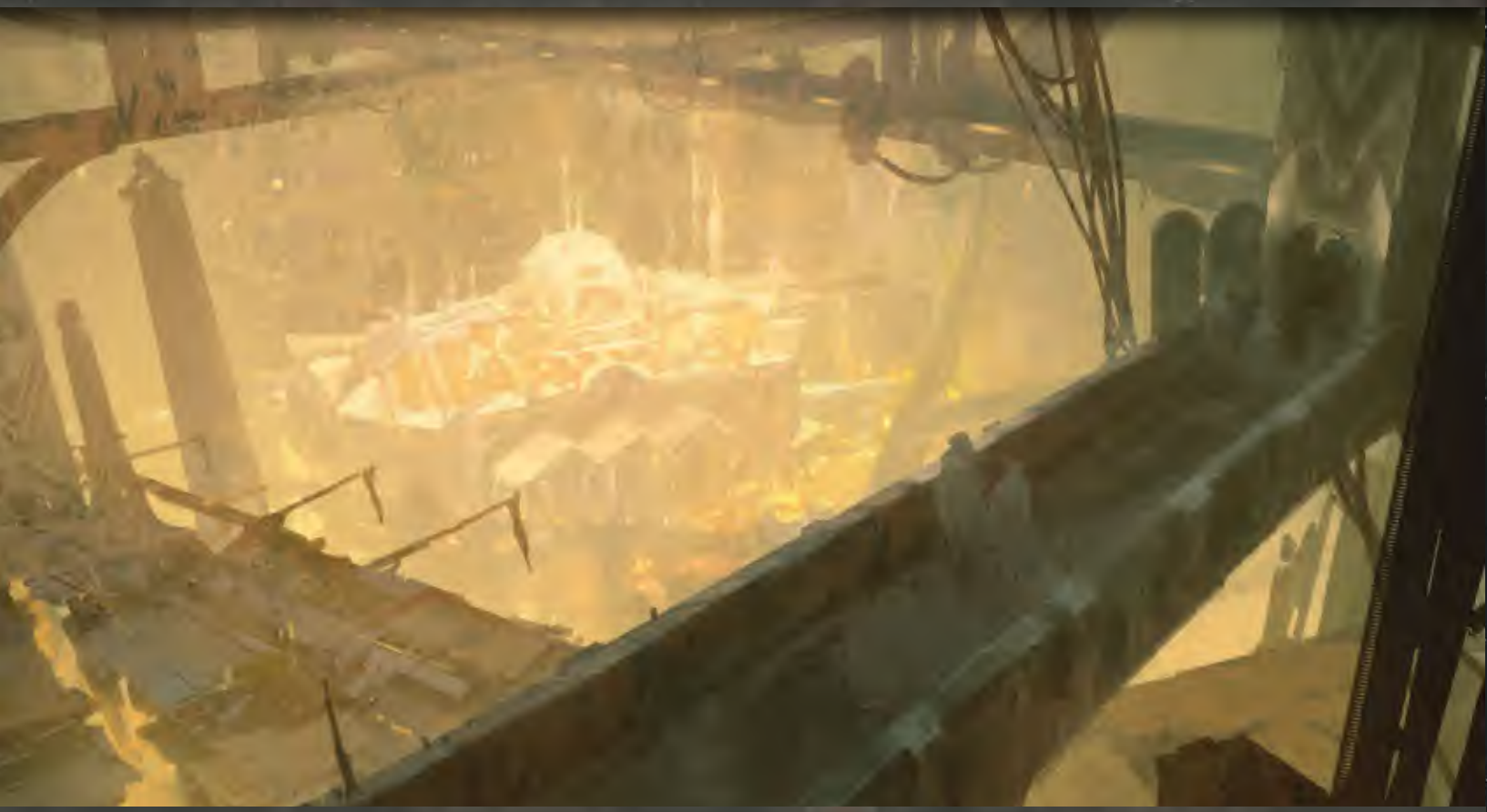
- **1 DP – SINGLE DISCHARGE:** One attack (1 HP, 2 EP)
- **2 DP – PROLONGED DISCHARGES:** One attack per watch (2 HP, 2 EP)
- **3 DP – INTENSE STORM:** One attack per hour (3 HP, 4 EP)

The ionic discharges can be almost avoided if the reactor is completely shut down together with the ship's life support. The ship will then drift through the cloud taking as little damage as possible (one strength 4 attack per watch, only HP damage). Many desperate skippers have tried this trick to survive the harshness of the Reach.

OXYGEN OASES

The nomad swarms who originally had the Reach to themselves established oxygen oases along the song routes. The oases are small bunkers or emergency pods with automatic com systems for mayday calls and contain oxygen reservoirs. Sometimes, the oases are organically replenished by vacuum-living organisms who break down the minerals of the asteroid crust and produce oxygen as waste, or by a photosynthetic reaction to the light of the distant Kua star.

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ASTEROID WALLAHS

The wallahs are the lonely asteroid herders who look for mineral deposits in asteroids and bring them to the smelteries, using only small single-person shuttles or custom mining exos. The repopulation of the Reach can be attributed to one main event: the discovery of maghdan. The Rimward Reach mineral rush created the asteroid wallahs, both as a profession and as a term. They travel between the oases alone and almost never step onboard stations or other ships. The wallahs are often cybernetically enhanced humans or humanites adapted to extreme loneliness and a zero-G life, such as the Anoa (*The Last Cyclade*, page 103).

and some of the Reach's worst fighting to date. The conflict began when the Yimon prospector clan operating out of their Nexis mining base on Rayyan found high levels of precious minerals on Marrab, an asteroid considered holy by the nomads. The prospectors' attempts at mining were met with force and their ships and drones destroyed. This led to the prospector clans forming an alliance with the Consortium and the Legion to raid several nomad settlements on nearby asteroids, provoking a retaliatory strike on the Nexis station by the nomads. Unfortunately, this attack hit a residential dome and cost many innocent lives.

During the prospectors' counter-offensive, the Ahilar's home on Dakka-3 was destroyed and the swarm hasn't been seen in known space since. A curse seems to have fallen over Nexis after the attack on Dakka-3, dropping the birth rate to zero and reportedly making all the station's inhabitants sterile. It's believed that the curse won't be lifted until the Ahilar return and reclaim a home among the Kandah asteroids. Aqbar Rakiv Fatiman has banned new settlements in the cluster to try to wind down the conflict.

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THE ARMADA OF THE FIRSTCOME & MINING STATION 13

In the part of the Mouth of Kandah called Hazin Ai-hayil, "The Great Sorrow", lie hundreds of warships in perfect rows. The automated defense systems still work and appear to be powered by the cloud's ion storms. Right next to the ship cemetery, one finds the Djerid asteroid cluster consisting of the Djerid-1, Djerid-2, Haisan and Ibram asteroids. Djerid-1 contains a song route monastery marking the far end of one of the routes and an oxygen oasis whose microbes have slowly eaten their way through the asteroid. Djerid-2 houses Foundation station FS-11, an archaeological outpost staffed by twelve researchers studying nearby phenomena. Before the Fall of Coriolis, the Legion kept the sector closed but the Foundation and Aqbar Fatiman have now drawn up a treaty permitting other factions to visit the area as well.

The Haisan asteroid houses one of the more significant Founder artifacts, Mining Station 13, which hides a valuable secret beneath an inconspicuous exterior: the only remaining Founder databases, albeit no complete ones. The data cores are currently being deciphered to gain more knowledge about the mysterious history of the Founders.

THE HORIZON COUNCIL AND THE POST-FALL ERA

Even if Djachroum always remained independent, the Foundation and the Legion had gradually expanded their presence into the Rimward Reach up until the Fall. The destruction of Coriolis brought an end to this. The Legion fleets were divided and most of the squadrons formerly tasked with keeping other factions out have now joined the Aqbar's Purple Guard. The Purple Guard's mandate has widened beyond the station itself to include peacekeeping in both the entire Mouth of Kandah and the starward sectors.

Several stations formerly owned by the Consortium – such as the Khea mining station and Foundation station FS-11 – are today cooperating with other factions. By decree of the new Horizon Council, all prospecting and scientific endeavors must be Council-approved and open to all factions, processes, gains and all. The Aqbar has also assumed control of Legion base Thalus and the Bulletin's Karhal-7 sensor array, located 4 and 11 AU from Djachroum, respectively. The latter is now used for all communications with the corsairs and Purple Guards responsible for keeping the peace, and Thalus has been turned into a shipyard called the Kandah Yards. The Yards are used both for building and servicing ships and for refining locally mined minerals.

The Rimward Reach has become one of the top destinations for former Free League members. Stevedores and deckhands, traders and salvagers – all are welcomed by the Aqbar to strengthen and supply the Reach's network of oases and colonies in the vast asteroid belt. The League has even been permitted to run an official trading post on Djachroum, near the stevedore central.

THE INDEPENDENT SPACE STATION DJACHROUM

The station has been constructed on top of old Founder ruins. A split runs down the middle of the asteroid, known as Eskalom's Rift, dividing the ruins in two. The Twin Station opposite Djachroum is forbidden to visit and is said to be haunted by the lost souls of the Founders. A small section of the Forbidden Sector is occupied by Djachroum's life support systems, however, to which a reclusive group of engineers known as "the operators" are allowed.

The inhabited parts of the station are known to the locals as "the Tear" and comprise one half of the asteroid plus a quadratic network of exterior modules holding docking corridors, loading bays, elevators and various transportation rails. Here, the gravity drops to only 0.2 standard gravity. The spaceport is known as "the Greeting Hand."

Across the surface of the asteroid, a railway connects the hydroponics domes, commercial districts and the Tear residential areas, conveniently numbered 1 through 8. Two sensor towers named Amesia and Volos after the ships of Antoli Djachroum rise high above the rest of the station but look tiny next to "the Column," a towering giant holding the weapon systems and a docking station large enough even for bulk haulers (even if they rarely venture this far from the core). At the top of the Column lies the Souk Ramallan and the luxury restaurant Shom-Ramallan where many valuable trade agreements have been struck in the shadow of ever-blooming cherry trees. The center of the Tear is home to the spectacular Cave of Bridges (Coriolis core rulebook, page 296), an enormous hall measuring hundreds of meters in both width and height. This, the true heart of the station, is filled with Firstcome art, culture and life and a tangle of bridges, ramps and stairs connects the various palaces, plazas, souks, shacks and cantinas with each other. Aqbar Rakiv Fatiman and the Horizon Council hold court in the magnificent Governor's Palace in the middle of the Cave.

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THE INDEPENDENT SPACE STATION DJACHROUM

- **POPULATION:** 12,000 residents and 2,000 visitors
- **FACTION:** Independent, seat of the Horizon Council
- **DAY LENGTH:** 30 hours divided into three watches (artificial day cycle)
- **GRAVITY:** 1 standard gravity
- **LAW AND ORDER:** The Purple Guard (loyal ex-Legionnaires and corsairs)
- **IMPORTS:** Medical equipment, cattle, luxuries
- **EXPORTS:** Maghdan ore, fruits and vegetables to the colonies, graviton projectors, ship modules



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TABLE 10: ENCOUNTERS IN THE RIMWARD REACH

NAME	BACKGROUND	AGENDA
Asoud Yimon	Greedy prospector (Yimon clan)	Looking for maghdan. Commands a group of prospectors and colonists preparing an attack against the nomad swarms.
Yawin Neved	Searching prospector (Neved clan)	Son of clan leader Gavro. Searching for Ahilar survivors to make peace with the nomads.
Amon	Determined preacher on Nexis	Preaches about the Curse of Ahilar and about returning the swarm's homes to them to try to revert the infertility of the Nexis colony.
Ein Sargád	Bodyguard to a visiting Horizon Council member	Bodyguard and member of the Purple Guard. Secretly a Sohâi (Draconite warrior monk). Leaves Djachroum in between missions to visit one of the Draconites' flagships, the Soh'albuuka, beyond the far reaches of the Kandah Cloud where rumors say a gateway to other worlds might be hiding...
Adina Nayal	Curious FS-11 scientist	Believes to have found a way to approach the Armada of the Firstcome after having deciphered an ancient Founder text. Looking for someone daring enough to try...
Toran Nôrghu	Ex-Legionnaire now with the Purple Guard	Formerly posted to FS-11 and the blockade around the Armada of the Firstcome. Took part in several expedition parties attempting to explore the ships but was forced to retreat every time. Bitter and lost after the breaking of the Legion.
Mirjam Sasani	Determined Free League administrator at the Djachroum office	Of Dabaran descent and with a long League career to look back upon. Regarded as a local leader. Chose Djachroum after the allegations against the League risked leading to legal repercussions. Secretly smuggled much of the League's contacts databases, contracts and trading manifests from Coriolis before the Fall, hoping to be able to rebuild the faction.
Sur'ga Ghôrhun	Tired corsair captain	Corsair captain nearing retirement. Has spent the last twenty years patrolling the outer space of Kua. Currently in command of a squadron of corsair ships and ex-Legion vessels traveling between the portals and Djachroum. Has personal experience of the resonance weapon near Xene.
Khemiri Assoud	Unlucky explorer	Captain of the salvage vessel The Lady's Eye that has a long history of running into the dangers of Kandah while traveling. Has lost three crews so far and is now known as Captain Curse.
Mahmoud Irb	Saboteur at the Kandah Shipyards	Poses as a worker at the Yards but is in reality a surviving Nazareem cultist trying to sabotage the new fleet by building faults and weaknesses into the ships.
Tandra Abid	Doomsday prophet and asteroid wallah	Preaching that the gravity wells of the Hadra clouds are actually the eyes of the Icons. Wanders the song routes and has been accused of vandalizing the song temples, something many fear will let darkness back into the Mouth of Kandah.
Hana Ab-Shamon	Free trader secretly belonging to the Red Spider	Investigative journalist keeping an eye on the conflicts and secret factionary dealings throughout the Reach.
Sayeed Alim	Driven corsair, formerly in the Legion	Originally posted to a secret Legion base at the Yrind asteroid hidden in a pocket inside Kandah. This is where the Judge Emissary was evacuated during *Emissary Lost*. After the Fall of Coriolis, the civilian staff of the secret base sacrificed themselves to break out the Emissary who was then rescued by three unknown ships. Sayeed is now hunting those three ships.
Tain	Kawah trader on Djachroum	Anoa humanite who, uncommonly enough, can't take the loneliness of the wallah lifestyle. Tain traded the exo for a kawah stand, the "Tain-ashan," near the entrance to the Cave of Bridges. If you know the right questions to ask, Tain can supply you with rare drugs and poisons.
Josséf Hamsaad	Retired mercenary tending a hanging garden on Djachroum	Responsible for the order to fire on Dakka-3 and the destruction of the last known base of the Ahilar. Lives a quiet, nightmare-ridden life tending to hydroponic gardens and algae farms in one of Djachroum's agridomes.

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STARTING SCENE:

BIRBASIL'S DREAM

The message on the screen from your old patron casts a gloomy light around the bridge. It's a call for help.

"The Emissaries at Xene are able to turn even our most loyal crews against us. The Council has asked Aremerat himself for an audience to discuss dividing the Nadir Flotilla between us to strengthen the Third Horizon's fleets…"

You remember the secretly constructed fleet, meant to consolidate Zenithian power, now abandoned after the Fall of Coriolis.

"When Sadaal closed to outsiders, all negotiations ceased, but now, Aremerat has granted permission for a delegation to visit – as long as they're escorted by the Icons' Chosen. By you! The leader of Sadaal has asked for you, personally, and it appears a non-negotiable condition. You are the last hope for stability in the Third Horizon…"

THE SITUATION

No matter where the PCs are, the scenario begins with them receiving a call for help. If you're using the text above, insert their patron's name. Aremerat the Eternal has requested their presence to escort a delegation representing the factions of the Third Horizon. The delegation is invited to Sadaal for negotiations with Aremerat and the Amesha Spenta, but there are of course some complications: only the Syndicate is trusted enough by the Sadaalian regime to be allowed entry into the system. A crew meeting the requirements has been chosen – captain Hemisha Birbasil of Birbasil's Dream. The Dream will meet the PCs on the independent station Djachroum in the Rimward Reach and then travel to Aiwaz and rendezvous with the rest of the delegation. A meeting has been set up between the PCs and the Syndicate crew in the commercial district of Djachroum, a busy place of stevedores, prospectors and merchants. After the meeting, they immediately head for Aiwaz.

MAJOR EVENTS

Meeting captain Birbasil and passing thru the Kua system are the scene's major events.

⚙ START: THE SYNDICATE AGREEMENT

The PCs have arrived on Djachroum. The spaceport's labyrinth of docked loaders, salvage rigs, asteroid exos and mining drones seems as chaotic as the corridors and elevator shafts inside, lined with frozen goats, crates of vacuum-dried vegetables, oxygen tanks and more or less credible "ancient" salvage. The central shaft's rail brings visitors into the wide tunnel leading straight to the heart of the station: the Cave of Bridges. Thousands of various light sources illuminate the dark cave and its stone houses, ramshackle huts, kawah stands, rope bridges, ramps and stairs. In the middle of the hall lies the Governor's Palace, stretching its countless towers and spires toward the ceiling and into the overhanging network of walkways. On the cave floor lies one of the larger bazaars, the souk known as Fatiman Square. A large population of wild Kuan bantam monkeys have made the cave their home and the pranks they play on new arrivals while constantly spitting a fast-paced chatter at each other add a certain type of flair to the scene. The cosmopolis of Djachroum with its mixture of clashing ideologies, classes and cultures could just as easily have been a part of the Kuan Conglomerate, the commercial district in the City of Foreigners or the Pilgrim Plazas of Mira.

- **The Meeting Place:** The meeting is to take place at Shima's Chai House in the souk. Even without the photo you've been given of captain Hemisha Birbasil, you would have spotted her instantly. The Birbasils' striking features with round cheeks, olive skin and chestnut hair don't appear to skip generations. A trained eye can spot a few of Hemisha's crew members strategically posted throughout the crowd, most likely carrying concealed, licensed weapons under their flight suits. A COMMAND test can reveal that two of the bodyguards (Harista and Makid) have backgrounds in the Hegemony's fleet. Their stern faces and postures contrast the crew's only Firstcome member, a dark-skinned, tattooed man with a shaved head and a colorful shawl identifying him as a nomad (Moshi). Next to the captain sits a beautiful but mysterious crew member (Arin) who doesn't bother hiding a finely ornamented Vulcan cricket.
- **The Meeting:** Captain Hemisha spots the PCs as soon as they arrive. She waves across the room and appears happy to see them, getting up to greet them properly when they arrive at her table. The PCs are offered sweet wine, stuffed vegetables, deep fried grasshoppers, steaming hot chai and small baklava squares covered in powdered sugar. After the appropriate amount of cheek kissing and small talk, she moves on to the matter at hand.

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- **The Mission:** Hemisha's ship, Birbasil's Dream, has been chosen directly by the Amesha Spenta to take a delegation of negotiators, including the PCs, to the Sadaalian capital of Alburz. The Dream has been authorized to travel in the otherwise closed system which means the PCs must leave their ship behind. The mission is time sensitive, but you decide if you want the PCs to board the Dream here on Djachroum or if they're allowed to take their own ship to the rendezvous point in Aiwaz. If they leave their ship behind, the PCs might consider docking it for service and upgrades at the Kandah Yards (see PC incentives, page 53). If they take their own ship to Aiwaz, they will have less time to get to know the Birbasil crew. The rest of the delegation's members will be picked up along the way. The Miran and Order of the Pariah fleets already have ships in Aiwaz and the Salam Flotilla is en route to Errai, where the Zenithian fleet and some ex-legionnaires contracted by the Zenithian Coalition are waiting.
- **Departure:** When the PCs are ready, they should make their way to dock 16 to board the sleek freighter Birbasil's Dream. A PILOT or TECHNOLOGY test can identify the ship as a Miran torpedo ship model.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)



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HEMISHA BIRBASIL, SMUGGLER CAPTAIN

Hemisha Birbasil has had a long career of transporting valuable artifacts, kidnapped dignitaries and sensitive trade agreements. Her contracts are usually related to the family business in some way – remote and unscrupulous Sadaalian factories or her aunt Raquin's plantations on Kua for example, at least up until the Fall. The occupational hazards that come with the territory have made her invest in discreet cybernetics as backup in case a situation turns hostile, and she has widened her network of contacts by taking a lover within the Bureau of Medicine on Sadaal. She pumps her paramour for information and has become excellently situated to leverage good contracts with high priest Amesha Vanzur.

Hemisha dresses austerely and wears a discreetly patterned thick shawl around her neck that covers her mouth. If she takes a liking to a business proposal, her cautious interest can flare into a passionate, almost overwhelming decisiveness. In such a situation, she takes over the conversation completely and her gaze becomes very intense.

CHARACTERISTICS: Rubs the contact electrodes in her palms when studying or listening to someone in a conversation.

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 3, WITS 4, EMPATHY 4**
HIT POINTS: 5
MIND POINTS: 8
REPUTATION: 6
SKILLS: Command 5, Manipulation 5, Culture 4, Melee Combat 4, Observation 4, Dexterity 3 (+2), Ranged Combat 3, Data Djinn 2
TALENTS: Wealthy Family: Birbasil, Accelerated Reflexes, Skin Electrodes
ARMOR: Flight suit (armor 1) with ablative elements (-3 to first hit)
GEAR: Vulcan cricket, encrypted tabula (containing orders to deliver the delegation to Sadaal for immediate arrest), tag (5,000 birr)



THE CREW: The crew all have attributes scores of 3, 6 Hit and Mind Points and a skill level of 5 in the skill relevant for their crew position. Additionally, they all have a skill level of 3 in **CULTURE** (except for Arin, the gunner), **MELEE COMBAT** and **RANGED COMBAT**. They each have access to a Vulcan carbine, an acc pistol, a flight suit and a tag of 300 birr.

- **HARISTA:** dry personality, dedicated and meticulous. Pilot from the Hegemony's Aviation Academy.
- **MAKID:** irritable and observant sensor operator from the same class as Harista. Avid domino player and card house builder.
- **MOSHI:** Firstcome engineer and physician. Retires to a cot in the reactor room when the rest of crew starts discussing Zenithian supremacy.
- **ARIN:** the crew's enigmatic gunner. Former Legionnaire who left the faction after the Fall to work private security for Zenithian aristocrats on the run. Has a sweet tooth.

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TO THE PORTAL

The journey from the sector of the Lady of Tears isn't exactly a small affair. The 47 AU between Djachroum and the core takes most freighters just under a segment to travel. The trip is long and tiring and most crews will make stops along the way on one of the smaller mining bases in the inner asteroid field, for repairs and some well-earned rest. Birbasil's Dream is a ship designed specifically for long distances, however, and will make it all the way to the portal station in about twelve days.

The crew is likable and welcoming but unwilling to talk about what kind of jobs they usually take on and why they have so many stasis units onboard. They make the trip to Sadaal fairly regularly and can share their firsthand experiences of the tightening of control around portal access. Outsiders are escorted straight to Alburz or to one of the giant bulk haulers that transport cargo to the shipyards in the sister system of Bahram. The Amesha Spenta and Aremerat's advisors pay handsomely for special deliveries, however – often of a much more glamorous nature than what's imported for the general population.

- **Aboard:** Life onboard the Dream is simple. The crew work their shifts and after a few days, the PCs may be entrusted with some shifts of their own if they want. None of the crew members are particularly skilled in the kitchen and the meals onboard are often nutrition cubes and algae paste. PCs who can actually cook will be very much appreciated. One of the stasis units contains Hemisha's private wine collection – an impressive selection of vintage bottles from practically the entire Horizon.
- **The Mission:** During the trip, let the PCs get to know the crew, have dinner together and explore the ship a bit. None of the crew members wish to end up on the wrong foot with "the Chosen" and will try hard to be friendly with the PCs. The crew expect a substantial reward for delivering the delegation to Sadaal and are aware of what fate awaits their passengers. They will probably have a difficult time traveling after the mission ends and captain Hemisha has planned for an extended holiday on Sadaal when they're done. If the PCs somehow pick up on the crew's doubts about the mission, directly confronting them with the right questions can lead to the captain admitting that Aremerat and Amesha Spenta aren't the most trustworthy of employers but that this truly appears to be the only way of securing negotiations.

Cost: 0 DP

AN OFFICIAL WORD

As the PCs are nearing the Kuan portal station, news from Dabaran reaches the system via a probe. The sender is emir Rahmalan the Elder and his three daughters dari-Jahra, dari-Mefti and dari-Masedleh and the broadcast comes straight from the emir's palace in Dar Bahri (see "The Emir's Speech").

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

BIRBASIL'S DREAM, REPURPOSED TORPEDO SHIP

Birbasil's Dream is an impressive feat of imaginative reconfiguration. An old Miran torpedo ship has been turned into a fast courier ship with a creatively designed cargo hold. Despite the sleek design and the shortness of the craft – it measures only twenty-eight meters from bow to stern – the modules inside have been divided between three levels. The lower level contains the reactor, the engine room and the acc gun turret connected by low corridors. The living modules can be found in the center of the ship, lined with two long rows of cryo chambers and the top level holds the service module, cargo space and torpedo room. Hemisha Birbasil both owns and captains the ship after having bought it cheap in poor condition off a retired corsair from Ordana. The former owner had salvaged the ship from the cemeteries in Yastapol and rumors about it say that it had taken part in an expedition to one of the system's many abandoned weapons platforms – a trip from which few return unscathed.

THE EMIR'S SPEECH

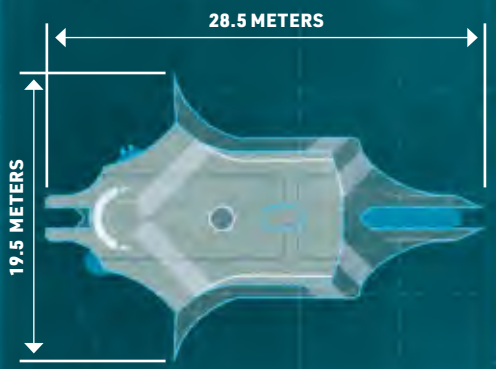
"People of the Third Horizon. I, my daughters and the leading dars of our world stand before you today under the lotus, ready to tell you the truth about our drastic isolation. A group of thugs afflicted with the mystic's disease have carried out a series of terrorist attacks in our system. Dabaran and our portal station were severely affected by these dark acts springing from the infected's unholy alliance with the false Icons. To protect the rest of the Horizon from a fate worse than death, we have chosen to place ourselves under complete quarantine. No vessels are allowed in or out of the system. The terrorists have been apprehended and we will send you more news when we have them."

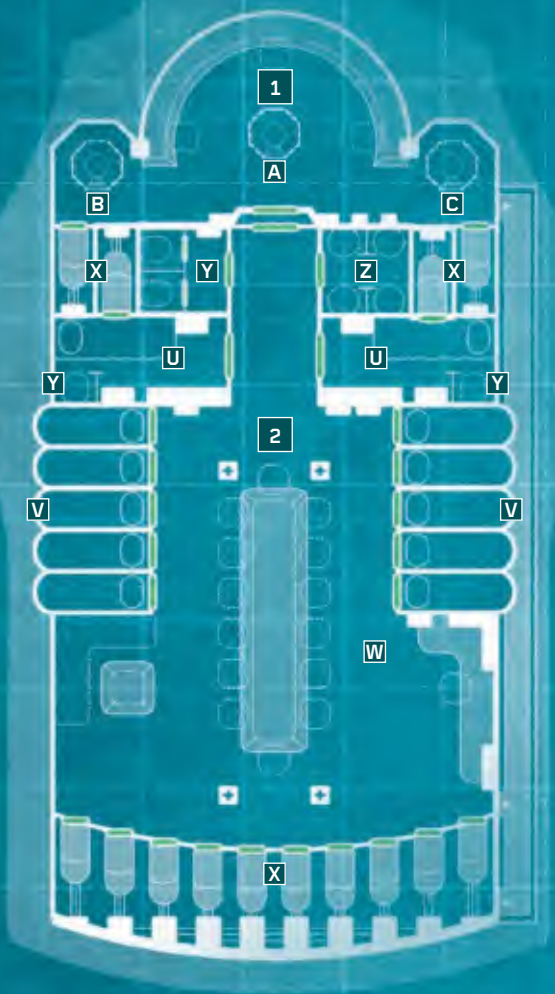
EMIR RAHMALAN THE ELDER, DAR BAHRI, DABARAN

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BIRBASIL'S DREAM, (REPURPOSED TORPEDO SHIP, CLASS II)

- **SHIPYARD:** (Chelebs, Mira) Harima, Kua
- **CREW:** 4
- **EP:** 5
- **HP:** 3
- **MANEUVERABILITY:** +4
- **SIGNATURE:** 0
- **ARMOR:** 4
- **SPEED:** 4
- **MODULES:** 2 Cabins (1 person standard), 2 Cabins (5 people coffins), Cargo Hold (5 tons), Docking station, Heavy Acc Cannon, Service Module, Smuggler's Stash (1 ton), 4 Stasis Holds (times 5 beds), Torpedo System (2 plasma, 2 nuclear)
- **FEATURES:** Antimatter Rockets, Atmospheric Entry, Bonus Modules (5), Ejector
- **PROBLEM:**
  Unstable transponder: The ship's transponder sometimes overcharges when the sensors are activated, allowing for a misidentification of the ship's identity based on it's far from spotless past: either as the corsair vessel Black Onyx (wanted by both the Colonial Agency and the Order) or the deserter torpedo boat Hamsha Alil, allegedly involved in an attack on one of Mira's former matriarchs.
- **COST:** 620,000 birr

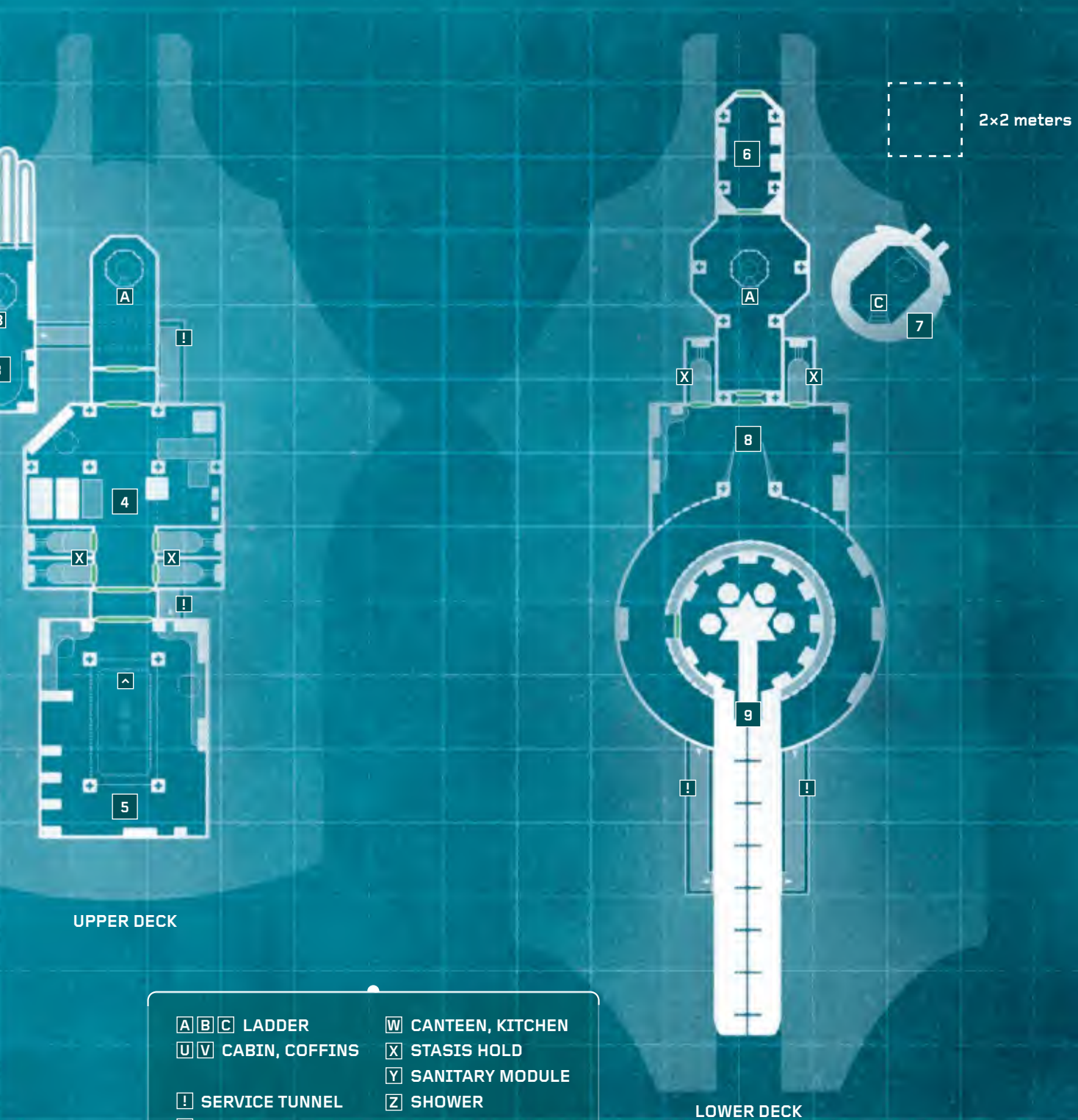




MIDDLE DECK

1: BRIDGE
2: LIVING QUARTERS
3: TORPEDO SYSTEM
4: CARGO HOLD
5: SERVICE STATION
6: DOCKING STATION
7: HEAVY ACCELERATOR CANNON
8: REACTOR CONTROL
9: ANTIMATTER ROCKET

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MINOR EVENTS

If you feel like it, take the opportunity to let your players experience some more of the unique features of the Rimward Reach. The sector has its own societal norms, a rich, unexplored history and many strange natural and cosmic phenomena.

⚙ RENEGADE DESERTERS

As the ship passes through the outskirts of the asteroid belt, the sensors suddenly report of incoming vessels. A **DATA DJINN** test can reveal the class and affiliation of the ships as three Order fighters (type Nasia, class I, *The Last Cyclade* page 32) chasing one of their own supply ships, commandeered by mystics who have answered the call of Xene (use the "Salvage model" stats on page 159 of the Coriolis core rulebook). For 1 extra DP, another two signatures are on their way – corsairs in the service of the Aqbar of Djachroum (page 160 of the Coriolis core rulebook).

The corsairs will try to stop all military vessels in the sector and threaten to fire upon the Order ships unless they turn back toward the portals. The fighters concentrate on trying to destroy the fleeing supply ship.

- The corsairs fire warning shots around the fighters and proclaim all Kuan space to be under Djachroum protection.
- The fighters request permission to pursue and defeat fleeing deserters but are denied.
- The crew of the supply ships tries to beg for help. They claim to be pilgrims seeking asylum in Kua.

It's up to the PCs how they wish to act – leave the supply ship to its fate, or choose sides in the conflict? Will they step in between the corsairs and the Order fighters, or between the fighters and supply ship?

For 1 additional DP, the supply ship positions itself with the PCs between it and the pursuing fighters.

As the GM, you're free to decide if the fleeing ship escapes into the asteroid belt or is destroyed and whether or not the corsairs allow the Order's request for firing permission. If the PCs travel aboard the Dream during this event, it could lead to some intense debating. Captain Hemisha might for example offer aid for payment, or ignore all pleas for help completely.

Cost: 1, 2–3 DP

COMING TOGETHER

The whispering, dreamless mists of hypersleep feel like a welcome reprieve after your long journey through Kua. You wake up to proximity alerts from your sensors as you arrive in Aiwaz. An enormous vessel appears before you: The Hammer of the Martyr, the flagship of the Order of the Pariah. High prayer towers and glittering glyph armor make her a spectacular, terrifying relic from the Portal Wars. The space around her and the Aiwazian portals is filled with fighter patrols, torpedo ships and small destroyers.

"This is the Shakush-M'hatoun. In the name of the Martyr, we welcome you to Aiwaz. Your arrival has been highly anticipated. Welcome aboard – we don't have much time…"

THE SITUATION

During *The Last Cyclade*, Aiwaz was under Order blockade but an alliance has formed between Zalos and Mira after the Fall of Coriolis. Starting with pilgrims, Zalosian space was eventually opened also for commercial traffic along the reopened Miran Chain. The Djachroum declaration of peace in Kua means that no factionary warships may stay in Kuan space, making all fleet logistics between the Dabaran Circle and the rest of the Third Horizon difficult. All passage of military vessels must be announced well in advance via probe or courier and larger cruisers must pass alone, without escort. The Alabaster Council in Khorsabad has also imposed strict new regulations on fleet movements in the Quadrant of the Pillar and the sector is becoming known as less safe than it used to be. Rumors say that the devastating weapon systems in the Black Sector in Altai have become able to spot and fire on ships as far away as by the portals. The combined effect of the changes above is that most of the Third Horizon fleets currently reside in Aiwaz or the nearby systems of Errai, Zalos and Mira.

⚙ THE DELEGATES

The four delegates represent the Horizon's major factions that desperately want to negotiate with the Sadaalian regime.

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All but the Zenithian Coalition's representative are already onboard The Hammer of the Martyr when the PCs arrive. Upon arrival, Birbasil's Dream is escorted to and given docking clearance with the mighty battleship to meet up with the delegation and its entourage of bodyguards and assistants. As this is going on, a mystic mutiny aboard The Hammer begins.

If the PCs rescued an appropriate patron or Council member during the finale of *The Last Cyclade*, you can substitute this character for one of the below to represent their faction. Personal connections between the PCs and the delegates are favorable – no matter if they are good or bad.

- **Khaleem Hydarnes:** Member of the Martyr Council, (uncle of Chabaun Kheml who led The Warriors of the Holy Light in *Emissary Lost*), the Order of the Pariah
- **Mata Amri:** Religious leader and advisor to the matriarch and patriarch of Mira, the Church of the Icons
- **Sandar Artabazus:** Successful corsair lord (and secret Draconite agent) and son of the matriarch Genya who rules the most influential clan on the Alabaster Council, the Nomad Federation
- **Ana Din Eusidia:** Former neo-Zenithian lobbyist responsible for the deal with Sadaal to build the Nadir Flotilla (*The Last Cyclade*, page 183), the Zenithian Coalition

MAJOR EVENTS

The PCs meet the delegation and travel to Sadaal. The urgency of the situation is emphasized as the Emissaries' interference and the war between the Old Horizons become increasingly noticeable. The events below can be played through in a high tempo but should build toward the third and final part of the book.

START: THE MARTYR'S HAMMER

The Order's monastery cruiser orbits close to the portal station, surrounded by a swarm of torpedo ships and fighters. Despite the words of welcome as the PCs came out of the portal, they are taken to The Hammer by a heavily armed escort. Two torpedo ships lock onto Birbasil's Dream (and the PCs' own ship if they brought it) and six fighters in combat formation make sure they stick to their approach vector. Regular Order monastery cruisers are already enormous – measuring 1,100 meters from bow to stern – but look like toys compared to the ancient, 1,800 meter long flagship, one of the largest vessels ever constructed in the Third Horizon. Position lights glitter on the fractal armor hull and the glyphs placed there by the prophets of old light up, sentence by sentence, as the PCs begin docking.

After docking, the PCs and captain Hemisha enter a large chamber with arcades and stone walls reminding them more of the aristocratic quarters in the City of Foreigners than the labyrinthine architecture usually associated with the Order of the Pariah. Surprisingly enough, the chamber even has trees planted along its walls and mechanical birds flutter between the treetops in the pale, artificial sunlight form the ceiling. Halls like this were constructed in the exodus era, designed for crews to live out their entire lives in as the Order exiled themselves from the Second Horizon to cross the darkness in search of a new home. This is truly hallowed ground.

The PCs meet up with the other delegates and their accompanying assistants and bodyguards. Eight martyr warriors

AIWAZ

Aiwaz was explored relatively late in the Firstcome colonization of the Third Horizon. The first colonists came from Kua and later also from Zalos as defectors and began taming a couple of the planets in the system, mainly in the form of biodomes on the two planets closest to the star, Aiwaz and its exo-moon Sahrt.

The planets share an orbit at about 15 AU from the star and the Foundation's astronics believe the significantly smaller Sahrt must have been a moon to Aiwaz that was struck out of its original orbit by an asteroid. The system also contains a remote gas giant, Haish, believed to hold remnants of First Horizon weapons from the Portal Wars in its orbit.

Aiwaz-B, the distant sister star, is said to be a system far richer in natural resources but the 300 AU journey to get there makes large-scale colonization difficult. The system has instead become a refuge for deserters and retired corsairs looking for new lives away from the prying eyes of the rest of society. Rumors about Aiwaz-B also speak of ruins from a dead civilization, perhaps a sister tribe to the mysterious Founders in the Rimward Reach?

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TABLE 11: DELEGATION NPCS

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	DP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Typical delegate	2	3	4	5	5	9	9	Culture 5, Command 4, Manipulation 4, all other skills 1	Encrypted tabula, talisman, tag (5,000 birr), fine clothing, subdermal emergency transponder chip (position) Talents: Faction Standing
Typical bodyguard	3	4	4	2	7	6	5	Observation 6, Dexterity 5, Ranged Combat 5, Melee Combat 4, Infiltration 3, Medicurgy 3	Stun gun, acc carbine, 3 stun grenades, body armor (6), personal communicator, advanced scope Talents: Executioner
Typical assistant	3	3	4	4	6	8	4	Culture 5, Science 4, Data Djinn 3, Manipulation 2, Ranged Combat 2	Tabula with itinerary, personal communicator
Martyr warrior	4	4	3	3	8	6	3	Melee Combat 4, Ranged Combat 4, Infiltration 3, Observation 3, Manipulation 2	Vulcan carbine (homing rounds +2), light Order armor or Holy Glyph Armor (*The Last Cyclade*, page 89) Talents: Combat Veteran, Machinegunner
Mystic mutineers	2	3	4	3	5	7	4	Pilot/Data Djinn/ Technology 4 (depending on crew position), Melee Combat 2, Mystic Powers 2, Ranged Combat 2	Stun or Vulcan pistol, Order flight suit (armor 4), dura knife or acc pistol Talents: one mystical power
Akouba/ Diona	3	4	4	3	9	9	6	Ranged Combat 5, Manipulation 4, Melee Combat 4, Observation 4, Command 3, Dexterity 3, Infiltration 3	High-density armaweave uniform (armor 4), Judicator model acc pistol (INIT +1), dura claws, communicator Talents: Tough, Hardened (*Emissary Lost*, page 43)

THE LEGACY OF THE GRAND MASTER

On approach, the sensors pick up another signature of epic size, the Shakush M'hatoun's sister ship Naar-Amshaar. This means that grand master Samesh Alim, leader of The Cold Flame and the monastery fortress Amshaar, is most likely present (unless he was assassinated by the PCs during *The Last Cyclade*).

If the grand master is dead or if he was turned down in the previous scenarios, the PCs are met by a hostile atmosphere when they dock and may not even be let onboard. If they instead helped Samesh, they receive a warm welcome with lots of deep bows, well-wishes and "May the Crown of the Martyr guide you." They may also encounter the grand master in person as he has remained onboard The Hammer, waiting to personally shake their hands and kiss their cheeks once more before taking a shuttle back to his cruiser.

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in their mythical animate suits of armor are their escort, the leader of which welcomes the Chosen and introduces them to the rest of the delegation before leading the way back toward the Dream. The minor event contains a premonition of the mutiny after which you can progress to the next scene.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

THE WARNING

At some point after the PCs arrive at the flagship – but preferably before the mutiny begins – a secret message is delivered to one of them. The message (see box) is delivered on a tag pressed in their palm during a handshake, for example by grand master Alim, or slipped inside their pocket by a passing guard "accidentally" bumping into them. Alternatively, an encrypted message is sent straight to one of their tabulas or coms for them to read as they leave the ship.

THE MARTYRS' WARNING

"You walk in the shadow of the Martyr, far from the holy light. Darkness seeks to destroy you. You are heading into conflict and danger. Sadaal wishes you harm but you are the prophets, the Third Horizon's Chosen. Find us in Deeptown in Alburz, near Pheri's Hammam. Ask for the light and we will come to you. Beyond The Phantoms' bloodhounds and the delusions of the tenth Icon, you will find friends and learn the truth. We have to meet. Sleep with your weapons near. Remember where the escape pods are and be ready to fight to stay free."



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The message is from the agents of The Warriors of the Holy Light that managed to escape the invasion of Dabaran. They are hiding out near Pheri's Hammam, the baths in Deeptown underneath Alburz. At the cost of 1 DP, the PC receiving the message feels sick, hears her heart racing and is stricken by a throbbing headache (resulting in 2 points of stress). The sensation is quickly followed by a wave of warmth and a sense of safety if she has merged with the Machine Icon, and she hears the echo of a beautiful song. She feels drawn toward Sadaal and the promise of "the truth" – whatever it may be.
Cost: 0, 1 DP (Mandatory)

⚙ THE MUTINY

On their way back to the docks, the PCs hear worry in the voices of the martyr warriors. A scuffle breaks out up ahead and then shouting. A shot rings out and an alarm starts ringing. Groups of crew members are fighting each other or screaming with their weapons drawn. This event generates 8 DP as complete chaos erupts around the PCs. The martyr warriors and the delegation bodyguards form a protective half circle around their marks and the PCs, and try to bring them back to the Dream as quickly as possible. The Emissaries have assumed control over all mystics onboard The Hammer and the mutiny spreads like wildfire. At the cost of 1 DP, an assistant or staff member of the delegation becomes a Dakin puppet (see page 42). For 2 DP, it affects one or more martyr warriors or bodyguards.

If the mutineers are fired upon or if they are denied control of the ship, fighting breaks out, but they will primarily try to get their way using threats and will avoid violence for as long as possible. Make sure the PCs' main goal is escaping with the delegation rather than joining the fight. The martyr warriors will prioritize getting the delegation to Birbasil's Dream safely before turning around to deal with the mutineers.

As the Dream leaves the monastery cruiser, its projectors light up and the enormous battleship starts to move toward the portals. The escorting squadrons desperately try to avoid a barrage of fire from The Hammer's countless weapon stations. Smaller monastery cruisers converge on the flagship to try to stop it, but soon the portal field shimmers and the commandeered colossus disappears toward Kua. Left in its wake is the wreckage of the ships that got in its way and the despairing remains of the Order's fleet.
Cost: 0, 1–2 DP (Mandatory, generates 8 DP)

⚙ WORRIED VOICES

The delegation is gathered aboard Birbasil's Dream, but the PCs can choose to travel to Errai in their own ship and only join the rest of the delegates before the final jump. Play this event either immediately after the mutiny or after the PCs have left their own ship in Errai.

It's becoming all too clear that the spreading unrest in the Horizon is wearing down the factions' abilities to organize and mobilize. Several of the delegates say that the mutiny on The Hammer shows that no one is safe anymore, not even the most loyal. The Order and Mira representatives say that this event makes it clear that those infected with the mystic's disease have become a threat to the future of the entire Third Horizon. The Nomad Federation disagrees with this, saying instead that the new mystics' lack of true faith has made them susceptible to the influence of the false Emissaries. The darkness is growing around Xene and the delegation's task of bolstering their respective fleets with the Nadir Flotilla becomes even more urgent.

Captain Hemisha and the crew interrupt the discussion and tell everyone to get ready for stasis. End the scene when the Dream jumps to Errai or Sadaal, depending on when the scene is set.
Cost: 0 DP

⚙ THE JUDICATOR RETURNS

This is the final event before the PCs reach Sadaal. It makes sure that all the required characters finally end up together aboard Birbasil's Dream.

Remnants of the fleet of the Legion and a couple of Hegemony destroyers form a scattered blockade at the portal station in Errai. During the night watch, a lone shuttle approaches the Dream from one of the ships in the blockade, in the last hours before the delegation and the PCs go into stasis for the jump to Sadaal.

Onboard the shuttle is the delegate for the Zenithian Coalition and her bodyguard who turns out to be a familiar face: judicator Akouba Kosha, or Diona Hashim (if either of them are still alive at this point in the campaign). Having lost much of her influence and reputation after the finale of *The Last Cyclade*, the judicator now provides personal security to the Zenithian Coalition delegate. She is strict but sociable and may exchange a few words with the PCs before they go on ice. Fresh scars show that she only barely escaped the Fall of

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Coriolis (her Strength has been lowered) but she looks more experienced and dedicated than ever (see table on page 70 plus page 228 of *The Last Cyclade*).
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

MINOR EVENTS

The event below can be used as a premonition to the coming scene.

⚙ RESONANCE: THE AFFLICTED

As the PCs board The Hammer and meet her crew, one or more of them may experience a resonance event. They feel drawn to some of the cruiser's crew members and feel a shared sense of belonging. The crew members in question may feel the PCs' gaze and shy away as if in shame or fear, or as if they're afraid of being found out.

A **MANIPULATION** test can indeed identify the crew members' reactions as stemming from a fear of being exposed. A mystic PC may try to read the mind of the crew members by testing **MYSTIC POWERS** and if she passes, she can tell that several of the crew are secretly mystics. A critical success also reveals that something else – someone else – is hiding on the outskirts of the mystics' minds, whispering. Singing.
Cost: 1 DP

THE BETRAYAL

The mutiny onboard The Hammer of the Martyr was like a dagger in the back. The mighty Order stood defenseless against the false Emissaries. Haunting dreams plague your sleep. Whispering voices. Ghosts in the night. A strange cold…

As the stasis unit opens and the mists clear, you hear captain Hemisha's voice:

"Welcome to Sadaal. I'm sorry it had to end like this…"

She steps out of the light from the stasis bed and disappears into the shadows.

"Rayid, our mission has been accomplished. I expect immediate payment."

Armed silhouettes step into the light. Your pale faces are reflected in the visors of their helmets.

"In the name of Aremerat the Eternal, I place you under arrest for treason. Resistance will be met with deadly force. Your sentence and punishment awaits…"

THE SITUATION

Aremerat has once again had his way. Birbasil's Dream – a ship usually bringing alcohol and opiates for the Bureau of Medicine – had been tasked with bringing the factionary delegates and, most importantly, the Icons' Chosen to Sadaal. Two torpedo ships from the Habathus Flotilla were primed and ready above Sadaal, carrying Angra Mainyu patrols, the regime's secret police. When the Dream arrived, only the crew were woken up at once, the other stasis units thawing one by one to make the arrest of the delegates as easy and controlled as possible.

The PCs find themselves in a very delicate situation. They must escape the ship and make it down to Sadaal in whatever way they can think of.

⚙ KIDNAPPED DELEGATION

The delegates are already being brought aboard one of the torpedo ships when the PCs wake up. Some of the bodyguards fought hard to protect their employers but were defeated. In the ship's mess, rows of bodies with sheets carelessly thrown over them bloody the floor.

The delegates and their surviving staff are in handcuffs and on their way to Sadaal and the Ziggurat of the Icons where Aremerat will determine their fate. In less than twenty-four hours, at dawn, a mock trial will be held resulting in a live broadcast execution staged to rally the people against the insidious factions of the Horizon trying to infiltrate Sadaal.

MAJOR EVENTS

The PCs evade arrest aboard Birbasil's Dream and manage to make it down to the Sadaalian capital of Alburz. The minor events can be used to add some extra flavor to the different stages of the escape. Reward your players for inventive ways of somehow making it to their contact at the Pheri's Hammam baths.

⚙ START: A SADAAL AWAKENING

Four members of the secret police (see "The Phantoms", Table 12, page 74) surround the PCs as they come out of stasis.

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SCENARIO LOCATION: SADAAL AND ALBURZ

See page 78 for more details about Alburz. After escaping the ambush on Birbasil's Dream, this is where the PCs end up.

TABLE 12: SADAALIAN NPCS

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Typical Sadaalian	2	3	3	3	5	6	3–6	Force/Data Djinn/Medicurgy/ Technology 4 (depending on profession), Dexterity 3, Manipulation 2, Melee Combat 2	Tools, clothing, 20–300 birr, basic or expensive mask
Angra Mainyu (The Phantoms)	3	4	3	2	9	5	8	Infiltration 5, Observation 4, Ranged Combat 4, Data Djinn 3, Manipulation 3, Melee Combat 3	Vulcan carbine, communicator, stun grenade, ablative armasuit (armor 3, -3 to first hit), sensor helmet (OBSERVATION +1) Talents: Body Armor (+3), Targeting Scope, Nine Lives
Guard or police officer	3	2	2	3	5	5	5	Melee Combat 3, Observation 3, Ranged Combat 3	Acc carbine, smoke grenade, dura knife, shock stick Talents: Third Eye, Machinegunner
Attack drone	4	2	4	2	6	–	–	Ranged Combat 6, Melee Combat 3, Observation 3, Dexterity 2, Infiltration 2, Manipulation 2	Grav unit, thermal cricket, grape rifle, stun glove, communicator
Recon drone	1	3	5	3	4	–	–	Observation 5, Infiltration 4, Dexterity 3, Manipulation 3, Ranged Combat 2	Grav unit, stun gun, communicator
Martyr warrior (The Warriors of the Holy Light)	3	4	4	3	9	7	3	Culture 4, Manipulation 4, Melee Combat 4, Observation 4, Ranged Combat 4, Command 3, Data Djinn 3, Dexterity 3, Infiltration 3, Pilot 2	Vulcan carbine, dura knife, discreet clothing (INFILTRATION +1) Talents: Tough, Combat Veteran, Fanatics (2 AP: regain 2 HP and consciousness if broken, see *Emissary Lost* page 22)

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There might be combat immediately, or later as they are being taken away. If they allow themselves to be arrested, they are handcuffed and brought to the torpedo ship. Along the way, they see signs of combat and dead bodies in the ship's corridors. It's up to you as the GM to decide the number of enemies the PCs have to defeat to escape – it could be only the original four plus the pilot waiting by the airlock, or another two to four soldiers as backup. Below are some suggested ways down to the planet:

- **Shootout in the Stasis Chamber:** At least one PC is armed and manages to spring a surprise attack on the soldiers (INFILTRATION to draw the weapon unseen) or uses the handcuffing to get close enough to wrestle with one of the enemies for their weapon (opposed MELEE COMBAT).
- **Unexpected Assistance:** A crew member meets up with the patrol as the PCs are being herded toward the airlock. The person suddenly attacks the patrol or throws a smoke grenade to distract The Phantoms long enough for the PCs to escape. The crew member might even get off the ship together with the PCs and become a valuable ally.
- **The Airlock:** A last conversation between the captain and the patrol right outside the airlock presents a quick-minded PC with an opportunity to access the airlock controls (DATA DJINN or TECHNOLOGY). The doors suddenly close with the PCs and one very surprised soldier on one side and the rest of The Phantoms on the other...
- **Help from the Icon:** One PC's more dangerous new powers manifests during the stress of being arrested and can trigger combat. Remember that the first activation of a new power may be an automatic critical success.

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DELAYED ESCAPE

If the PCs accept arrest, they will be taken to the spaceport of Alburz aboard the waiting torpedo ship and then escorted through the city under armed guard. At a point of your choosing after this, martyr commandos will strike to liberate the PCs. The warriors engage the PCs' captors in a firefight to give them a chance to escape with the instruction to meet up with their liberators in Deeptown later.

***TORBA*, SADAALIAN TORPEDO SHIP**
CLASS: II
SHIPYARD: Daharab, Bahram (Coriolis core rulebook page 143)
CREW: 8 (Captain, Pilot, Sensor operator, Engineer, 4 Gunners), skill level 7 in all relevant skills
EP: 4
HP: 4
MANEUVERABILITY: +1
SIGNATURE: −1
ARMOR: 4
SPEED: 4
MODULES: 2 Advanced Torpedoes (4 ion, 4 nuclear), Countermeasure Dispenser, 2 Stasis Holds (5+5 beds), Autocannon, Chapel
FEATURES: Ablative Armor II (−3 damage to first two hits), Atmospheric Entry, Ejector

Making planetfall requires either getting to the escape pods or stealing the docked torpedo ship (or perhaps Birbasil's Dream). On the way down, Habathus Flotilla fighters will chase after them but as they aren't built for atmospheric entry, they break off pursuit when the PCs reach the upper clouds. If the PCs used the escape pods, they can avoid being pursued by shutting off their emergency transponders. Make the PCs sweat to escape below the clouds and down to the mountain range.

On their way, the PCs spot both the Waha-Najima bulk hauler from Dabaran and two of Aremerat's giants, the bulk haulers that shuttle between Sadaal and the Daharab shipyards on Bahram.

The escapees' destination is Alburz, the megacity where both the captured delegates and the PCs' mysterious contact can be found. As they immediately become wanted in the system, heading for the spaceport will be difficult. Regardless of where they land, they will have to enter the city from the lowlands below the mountains. Pheri's Hammam in Deeptown underneath the city should be their first priority but the city is now swarming with police and Phantom patrols, informants and recon drones all looking for the PCs. Time to blend in…
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

⚙ THE SLAUGHTERHOUSES

The PCs land their escape pod or stolen ship below the high peaks of the mountains and far from its sensors and guns. The landscape is a bleak, windy one – treeless steppes as far as the eye can see. The wind whips sand in their eyes and the cold air is hard to breathe. The day's first light pierces the mist and colors the sky a glowing red, like lava. Small herds of urvan buffalo graze nearby below some low, rocky hills. The silhouette of Alburz appears against the rising ridge in the distance. Much closer to their landing site, however, they spot a massive slaughterhouse complex with huge, fenced-in stockyards and freezing works brightly illuminated by floodlights on high stands. Huge herds of urvan packed tightly together wait in narrow pens to meet the butchers' knives. Train tracks emerge from the main building through an opening in the rather decrepit fence. The trains transport both the workers and their products to Alburz.

- **The Train Station:** The platform is located inside the slaughterhouse but security is pretty lax. The difficult part might be sneaking past the outside guards patrolling the fence (use the "Soldier" stats, Coriolis core rulebook, page 343). If they

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make it inside, the PCs can disguise themselves and bluff their way past any inquisitive administrators ("Agent", Coriolis core rulebook, page 343) in an opposed **MANIPULATION** test. Alternatively, sneaking past and onto the trains could be an opposed **INFILTRATION** vs **OBSERVATION** test. Another option is to try to sneak inside one of the refrigerator cars as the train is being loaded at the warehouses behind the platform. If they fail a die roll and the guards begin chasing them, they might have to give up on taking the train altogether.

- **The Tracks:** Hiking on foot along the train tracks will take most of the day. They will arrive at the outskirts of the city by late afternoon and have very little time left.
- **Sadaalian Winds (1 DP):** Without a mask and something to drink, traveling across the steppes becomes difficult. For 1 DP, have a PC test **SURVIVAL** to find drinkable water and shelter from the winds. If the roll fails, all PCs suffer 2 points of damage but may test **FORCE** to withstand it (each 6 negates 1 point of damage).

Cost: 0, 1 DP

⚙ THE FACE OF ALBURZ

As the PCs draw nearer to the city, the train tracks lead up the high cliff sides of the Shimush Mountains. If the group travels on foot, the mountain face requires some challenging climbing (**FORCE** to avoid 2 points of damage). If they have the proper equipment or if the one leading the way passes a **SURVIVAL** or **DEXTERITY** test, they get a +2 to the roll.

- **Service Tunnels:** On the lower ridges of the mountains, the PCs see huge industries – sewage plants and compressor stations for the gas pipelines leading up to the city. A **CULTURE** (–2 unless a PC is from Sadaal) or **SCIENCE** test supplies the PCs with knowledge of how water and natural gasses are transported up into Alburz which they may use to access the plants' service tunnels. Through the tunnels, they can travel unseen into the city, or maybe even straight to Deeptown (GM decides).

Cost: 0 DP

⚙ RESONANCE: THE VOICE OF THE VESTAL

As the PCs approach the gardens and fountains of the Cherry Plaza and the Ziggurat of the Icons, PCs who merged with the Machine Icon are struck by a dark vision. The Vestal of Sadaal is trying to manipulate them but the Machine Icon steps in and disrupts the attempt. Read or hand out the text in the box.

Cost: 0 DP

***AFRAAT*, SADAALIAN FIGHTER**
CLASS: I
SHIPYARD: Daharab, Bahram
CREW: 2 (Pilot and Gunner), skill level 8 in all relevant skills.
EP: 3
HP: 2
MANEUVERABILITY: +2
SIGNATURE: –2
ARMOR: 3
SPEED: 4
MODULES: Ordinary Torpedoes (4 ion), Autocannon, Nestera Mangler
FEATURES: Ejector, Ship Intelligence (Attributes 1, Skills 3), Precise Thrusters (PILOT +2 to docking, landing and evasive maneuvers)

THE VOICE OF THE VESTAL

"The sky darkens above you and the sound of waves drowns out the city. Lights twinkle at you through the cloudy air... or is it water? Something bears down on your body and lungs with great force. You see a clearer light appear, the silhouette of a person. The most radiant beauty you've ever seen. A perfect melody, a whisper, of belonging... until it's interrupted by a young girl's voice, the Machine Icon: – Not here! Not now! They aren't yours to command!

You're suddenly returned to the plaza and enveloped in the sounds of the city. Prominent in the soundscape are the tortured screams of the prisoners of The Phantoms amplified through speaker posts. The pained cries from the Ziggurat of the Icons remind you with perfect clarity of just how the Sadaalian leaders keep their subjects in line."

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SCENARIO LOCATION:

SADAAL AND ALBURZ

The people of Sadaal were hit hard by the Portal Wars – orbital bombardments crushed the Shimush Mountains and caused tsunamis that drowned entire cities on Bahram. From out of the chaos after the ceasefire, Aremerat the Eternal arose to subjugate the people and to rebuild the systems.

SADAAL – THE CHILDREN OF AREMERAT

The citizens live humble, predictable lives in service of their great society where the words of the leaders are never questioned. The news is information and information is truth. The high priests of the Amesha Spenta take good care of their citizens and although there is much hard work to be done, the citizens are graciously also bestowed leisure time to spend as they like – in the steams at one of the many bath houses, with friends in a quiet cafe or a gambling hall or walking in one of the beautiful parks. The societal structure is quite diverse and complex and the system has a multitude of languages that identify both class and neighborhood background. As a rule, the aristocracy can't speak Zeni, choosing instead to do business with foreigners via strictly controlled interpreters. Ziggurats and residential complexes rise above parks and squares. Punctual train and grav services keep it all moving. Moderation is a coveted virtue except for two nights per year when the cities are richly decorated and the people forget their duties for the revels of the Dance of the Masks carnival.

SADAAL'S ICON BELIEF AND AMESHA SPENTA

The eight religious leaders advising Aremerat embody the unique local Icon worship practiced in Sadaal since the end of the Wars. The members of the council have taken the names of the Icons they represent and oversee the various bureaus and institutes that make up the political, spiritual and military organization of Aremerat's rule.

- **ERIOSANG (THE MESSENGER):** Upholds tradition. Heads the Bureau of History and the education departments together with Amesha Ramaiti. Amesha Eriosang is firmly against outsiders gaining a foothold in the systems and preaches isolation and dogmatic purity.
- **VANZUR (THE DANCER):** Represents inspiration and eternity. Through the Institute of Culture, carefully curated and edited art is presented to the people. Amesha Vanzur brings happiness and rest to the hard-working population. The yourba dancers' swirling skirts, the songs of the taribs and the Bureau of Medicine's approved intoxicants give people a much-needed break and a sense of community. Amesha Vanzur has growing dealings with the Syndicate's smugglers.
- **MATAY (THE SEER, THE GAMBLER):** Uncertainty and the possibility to change. The Department of Insights is the closest thing to research one finds in Sadaal. Amesha Matay maintains the ED fields that protect the coastal cities from tidal waves and organizes the expeditions that explore the system's secrets. These so-called astromantics investigate

THE MASKS OF SADAAL

Since the Portal Wars, the Sadaalian lowlands and mountain slopes have been plagued by intense sandstorms. The air outside is still thick with dust, forcing the people to wear masks to protect themselves. The wealthy also air condition their homes and gardens and use ED fields to keep the dust out. The masks have become a way to display your standing in society – the finer and more fanciful the craft and decorations of your mask are, the more important you are. The works of the best craftsmen sell for tens of thousands of birr. Many homes have statuettes in the entrance hall for visitors to hang their masks on when they arrive. Pilgrims and workers often use single-use paper or rubber masks while the merchants and administrators prefer to splurge on fabrics or wood.

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THE ASHEGRID STAR

According to the legends, the Sadaal star was originally known as Ashegird, "the Black Sun." Its corruption pulled people down into darkness and let snakes loose in the promised lands. After the final days of the Portal Wars, the people of the systems prayed to the Icons and were heard. Aremerat descended from the heavens and snuffed out the black sun, instead lighting the blessed new star Sadaal to rejuvenate the worlds. To this day, the shadow of Ashegird is said to sweep through the system like the ghosts of the plains on Sadaal, raising dancing djinn and efrites in its fiery wake.

everything from the bloodthirsty rampage of the tarwich ghosts on the steppes to the rumors about Ashegird, the black sun, saying that the fragments of the dead star still orbit the system's sun.

- **RAMAITI (THE SERVANT, THE DECKHAND):** Duty and obedience. Through the Populist Bureau, every citizen is guaranteed work and a wage. Amesha Ramaiti makes sure the right person ends up in the right place and keeps the workers content and accepting of their lot in life.
- **URVATAT (THE BRINGER OF GIFTS, THE MERCHANT):** Gives the people what they need – no more, no less. The Bureau of Logistics organizes the supply chains between the slaughterhouses, mines and factory cities and oversees the scheduling of the bulk hauler traffic between Sadaal and Bahram. Ten enormous bulk haulers called Aremerat's Giants regularly make the long trip back and forth.
- **HABATHU (THE JUDGE):** Justice, law and order. The Defense Institute monitors the people and safeguards Aremerat's rule. They are also responsible for planetary defense and control the fleets and the army. Rumors say that Amesha Habathu has been sidelined and that Aremerat himself now controls the institute.
- **MANAVOH (THE ADVISOR, THE TRAVELER):** Good advice to the faithful. The Ministry of Worship preaches the wisdom of Aremerat to the people. The preachers in their crimson robes are always ready to guide the lost back into the fold. The temple of the Eternal offers redemption and forgiveness to the repentant, but some say that The Phantoms of the Whisperer take care of those who admit to too much. Amesha Manavoh has faced much resistance from the other council members for wanting an open system and her priests are rumored to sow doubt in the minds of the younger generations.
- **VOUKASHA (THE LADY OF TEARS):** Protector of the dead and the dying. The Ministry of Life runs the hospitals, bionics institutes and medicurgical centers that keep the population alive and healthy. The Eternity Bureau is an inescapable part of everyone's lives as they organize the funeral pyres that reunite the souls of the dead with Aremerat.

In addition to the eight members of the council, the ninth Icon is represented by HAKAD (The Whisperer, The Faceless) in the form of the secret police Angra Mainyu, or "The Phantoms" as they are known on the streets. They are said to answer only to Aremerat himself and not even the Ameshas are safe from their judging eyes and deadly methods. The Phantoms are believed to be the ones choosing a new Amesha after her predecessor has returned her soul to Aremerat.

⚙ FACTS ABOUT SADAAL

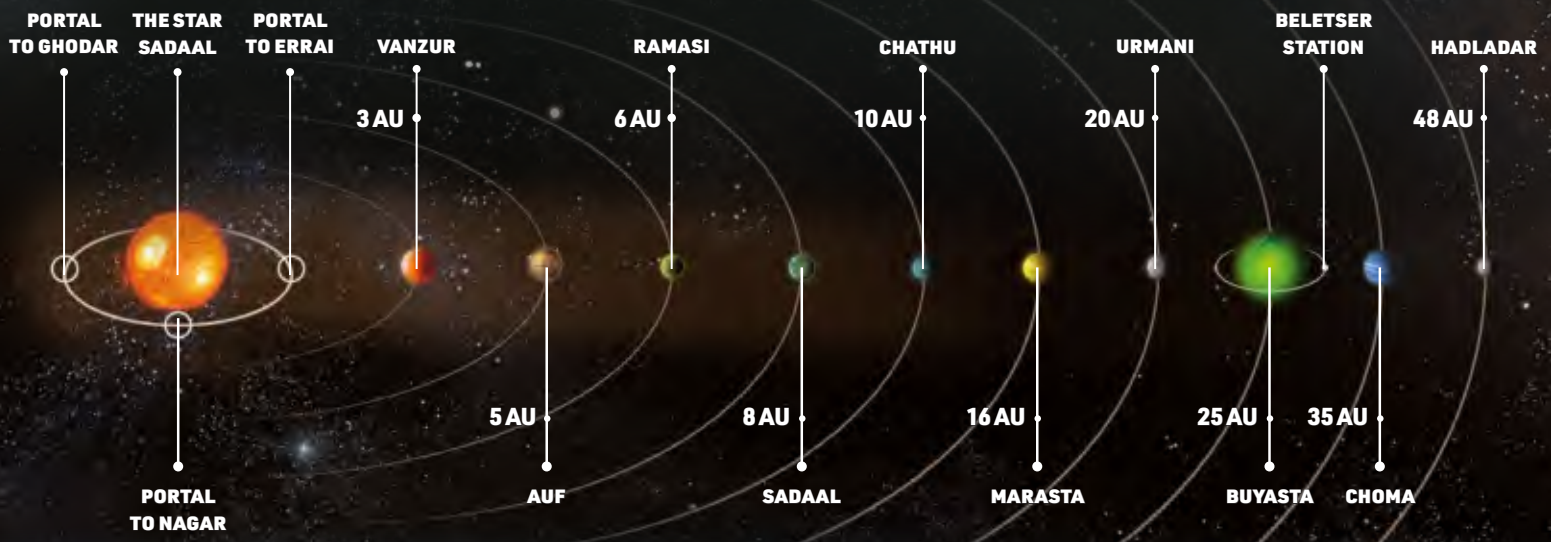
Despite the system having quite a few planets, mainly Sadaal and parts of Chathu have been colonized in a more substantial way.

- **VANZUR (3 AU):** The planet of the Dancer. Home to mysterious places where time is said to stand still.
- **AUF (5 AU):** Steppes and high mountains, inhospitable because of the toxic atmosphere.
- **RAMASI (6 AU):** Pristine beaches and deep woods. Aremerat vacations here and the planet is therefore off-limits to both visits and business.
- **SADAAL (8 AU):** A scarred world rebuilt from the ashes of the Wars. Deep beneath the Shimush Mountains, dissidents hide in mysterious caves. The steppes are home to djinn and soulless geustasa driving cattle to the slaughterhouses. In the worktowns, hands and aristocrats alike wear masks for protection against the harsh winds.
- **CHATHU (10 AU):** Hot spring resorts and ice cold mountain lakes.

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- **MARASTA (16 AU):** Sulfuric world where the Bureau of Logistics runs mining operations.
- **URMANI (20 AU):** Habathu fleet bases and, according to the rumors, a secret shipyard.
- **BUYASTA (25 AU):** Gas giant with twenty-three moons. Left alone and forbidden, rumored to contain ruins and defenses left behind by the Portal Builders.
- **FS-19 "BELETSER" (25 AU):** On one of Byasta's moons. Formerly owned by the Tilides family, abandoned since the collapse of the Monolith. Squatted by a dissident group called "Tempus" looking to join the Draconites.
- **CHOMA (35 AU):** Gas planet with ice storms and cold phenomena known as The Dancing Frost Efrites.
- **HADLADAR (48 AU):** A barren, lonely moon.

THE SADAAL SYSTEM (A)



PLANETARY DATA

- **DIAMETER:** 10,621 km (about 85% of Kua)
- **GRAVITY:** 0.9 standard gravity
- **DAY LENGTH:** 28 hours
- **SIDEREAL YEAR:** 487 days
- **AXIAL TILT:** 27 degrees

MORE ABOUT SADAAL

Read more about Sadaal in the Atlas Compendium (p 15).

THE LIGHTHOUSE

In the darkness between the systems lies Aremerat's Gift, a sensor station guiding traffic through the darkness along carefully calculated vectors. The sector is a tumultuous no man's land where the two systems wrestle for control of asteroids and debris from the Wars. The lighthouse is protected by a mighty artifact, however – a microsun stabilizing the asteroids. The Foundation believes it could be a remnant from an earlier civilization but all of Aremerat's citizens know that it's a gift from the Eternal Leader himself.

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MINOR EVENTS

The following events can show the PCs a bit more of Sadaal or throw surprise complications at them during their journey there.

⚙ GHOSTS OF THE PLAINS

The PCs pass a newly deserted campsite. The ashes from a fire are still warm and the surrounding ground has been grazed and trampled by hooves. A family of geustasas, the native nomad people, spent their night here. Despite their origins as the descendants of the system's earliest Firstcome settlers, the geustasa have been treated like pariahs and barbaric heathens ever since the Portal Wars.

As the PCs continue, more and more urvan buffalo appear until they are almost surrounded by a huge herd. Trying to scare the animals away would be very unwise but the herd keeps coming closer. There's suddenly a sharp whistling and the herd changes direction under a unison choir of hums and grunts. A young boy walks up through the herd, gesturing to the PCs to stand very still. He then points out small sand whirls blowing across the steppes all around the PCs. When observed closely, it looks like shadowy shapes stir up the sand with their footsteps. A biting cold emanates from the dust devils and they make the group feel uneasy.

- **The Djinn Dance:** A PC with the Exorcist talent can sense that some kind of ethereal beings – djinn or ghosts – are wandering across the plains, looking for weak minds and warm bodies. They won't find any today, however: the boy takes a couple of steps forward, closes his eyes and begins to dance while slicing the air around him with his riding crop. Spinning faster and faster in his dusty robe, he seems to attract the sand whirls. They flow around and with him until he suddenly raises his tattooed hands and they shoot up into the air and disappear.

  After the dance, the boy approaches the PCs and signs at them to give him something. In return, he can offer them water from a skin slung across his shoulder. If they give something valuable, he also takes out a small box and from it, an ink bowl. He spits into the bowl, crushes and mixes the pigment into a dark liquid and offers to draw protective symbols on the PCs' hands and arms. If they are uninterested or hostile, he disappears back into the herd.
- **A Helping Hand:** If any of the PCs are injured since their escape from the ship and if they can pay enough, the boy leads them back to his family. The aged but strong matriarch there can offer first aid (MEDICURGY 8) and suture any cuts they might have. The poultices and herbal remedies applied count as one m-dose.

Cost: 0 DP

⚙ DRONES

At the cost of 1 DP, a recon drone (Table 12, page 74) is suddenly within range of the PCs, scanning the area. One PC may test MANIPULATION or INFILTRATION at –2 to hide the group. If they are detected, the drone starts to follow them and three attack drones (Table 12, page 74) show up after about a minute.

At the cost of another DP, the recon and attack drones arrive at the same time.

Cost: 1–2 DP

ALBURZ

Alburz is built on the highest plateau of the Shimush Mountains. Untouched by the fire of the Wars, it's one of the few remaining places where the history and culture of the original settlers still lives. The heavily populated metropolis is rightly considered one the wonders of the Horizon as it's carved directly out of the rock and richly decorated with volcanic glass and obsidian to reflect and refract the lights from a city that never sleeps.

Ziggurats, wide avenues and squares, pillars of steam and elegant bridges make up the central districts but the bulk of the massive population lives in the surrounding cave systems or lower down under the slopes beneath the plateau. Both public places, such as the sloping terraces on the mountain sides, and private gardens and rooftops are covered in plants and apiaries thanks to the protection offered by the Shimush from the sandstorms and oppressive heat waves of the lowlands. Below the mountains lie factories, sewage treatment plants and huge compressor stations that supply the city above with clean water and natural gasses.

The dedicated craftsmanship of the city's artisans has earned Sadaalian crafts high renown all around the Horizon. Finely carved masks, exclusive chronographs, jewelry, crystal glass and talismans fetch high prices at auctions and over the counter in all systems claiming at least a modicum of civilization.

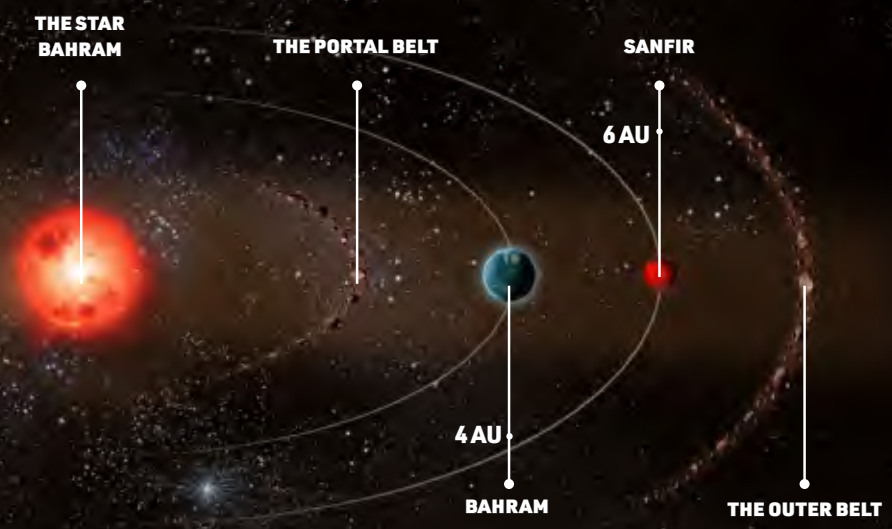
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THE SECTOR OF THE WHISPERER:

BAHRAM

The main planet in the sister system of Bahram suffered terrible tidal waves and floods at the end of the Portal Wars. Today, the rebuilt cities are protected by enormous ditches and ED based wave fields. The Newlands used to be an area open to foreign factions and companies but since the Fall, many of the islands have been deserted after the severing of Zenithian trade agreements. Aremerat doesn't want outsiders spying on the construction of the Nadir Flotilla, now growing ship by ship in the asteroid belt by the portals.

THE BAHRAM SYSTEM (B)



FACTS ABOUT BAHRAM

- **THE PORTAL BELT (0–2 AU):** An inner asteroid field hiding the Nadir Flotilla under the supervision of parts of the Habathus Flotilla.
- **BAHRAM (4 AU):** Fertile oceanic planet now closed to outsiders. Home of the controversial Daharab Shipyards.
- **SANFIR (6 AU):** Desert planet whose rich mineral deposits are mined extensively to supply Daharab with ore. Loading point for bulk haulers.
- **THE OUTER BELT (10 AU):** Dense asteroid belt separating Bahram from Sadaal. Home to several large mines and smelteries.

THE SLAUGHTERHOUSES

In the shadow of the mountains sit the slaughterhouse districts and before them, the wide steppes where the urvan buffalo graze. The cattle are herded by the native nomads, the geustasa, who are considered bloodthirsty and soulless but nonetheless a vital part of the local economy. Only the slaughterhouse foremen deal with the nomads and there is therefore many rumors and superstitions among the common workers accusing the geustasa of having a secret pact with the djinn and ghosts of the plains. When the workers head back home to the city after a completed two-week rotation, many claim to see white shapes dancing around the nomads' campfires from the train windows.

THE ZIGGURAT OF THE ICONS

The Ziggurat of the Icons in the Alburz's city center is a reminder of ancient glory. The city around it appears to climb its terraced sides and from each level rises high aqueducts overflowing with plants. The hanging gardens climb down and between the supporting stone pillars to form a soft

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ceiling of vines, flowers and fruit above the Cherry Plaza below, where the biannual harvest festival Urvatat Khari takes place to honor Aremerat and his creation.

In contrast to the tranquil beauty of the Cherry Plaza's orchards and fountains, the temple is also known for something else and under a different name: the Crying Ziggurat. Criminals and dissidents are arrested by the secret police and brought to the ziggurat for relentless torture, flogging on the Plaza or public executions on the top of the pyramid. The screams of the torture victims are sometimes broadcast over a city-wide PA system to remind any would-be insurgents of the price for resisting the Eternal Leader.

A square tower in obsidian with a single balcony high above the ground rises at the edge of the Plaza. It's called the Eternity Spire and is said to have been carved from a lava pillar that burst forth from the ground on the day the Icon Aremerat took physical form. Some people say that the Eternal Leader sometimes watches the city from the protected balcony and that he is present for all major executions to guide his opponents back into the light after their deaths.

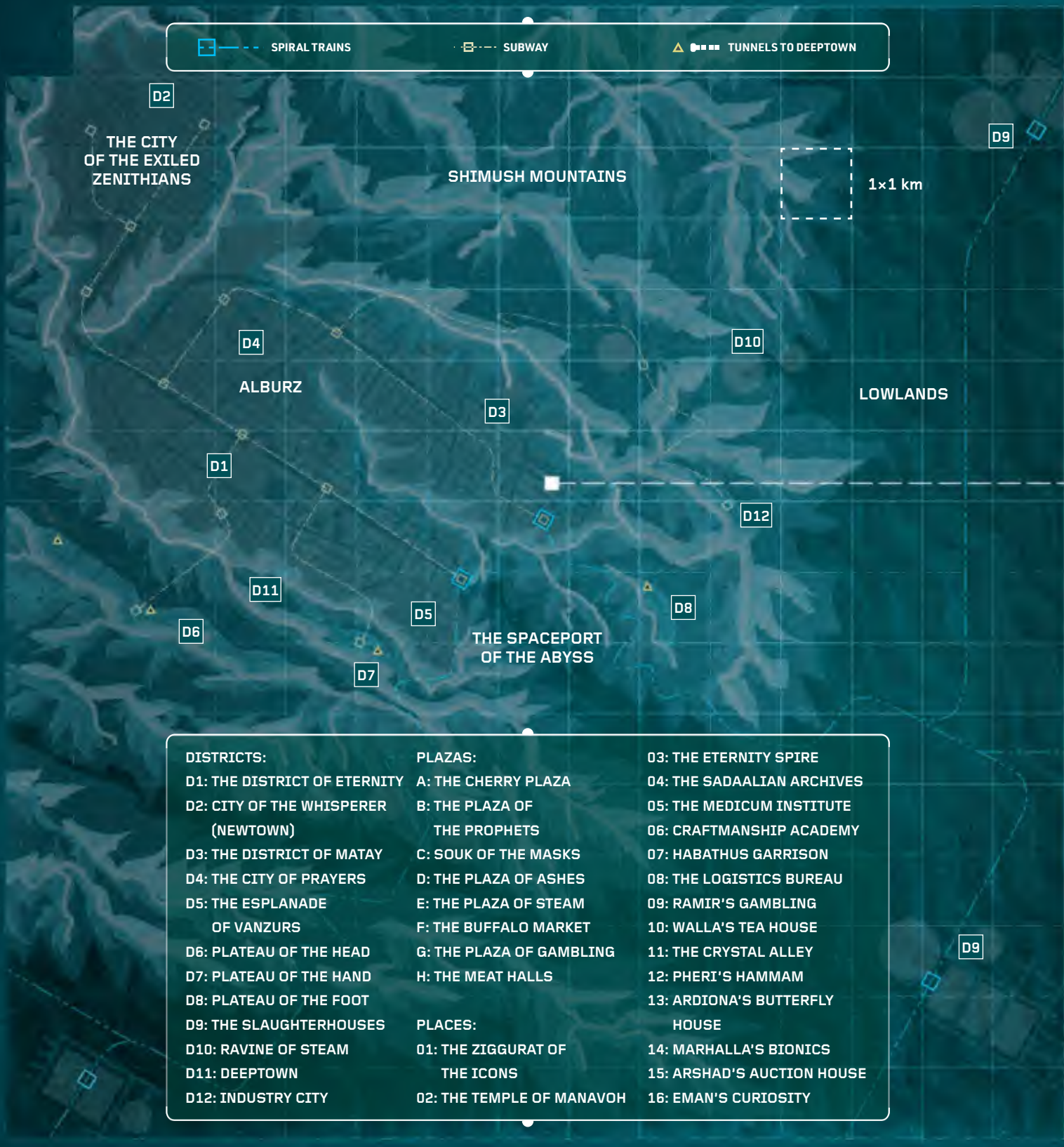
DEEPTOWN

Deeptown is a constant whirlpool of people coming and going. The layered and covered fashion of the upper levels gives way to looser and more plain coats or caftans here, and it's the destination of choice for most people looking to spend their days off with friends in a gambling hall or in the steaming baths that keep Deeptown in a perpetual misty haze. It's a mask-optional zone and this appears to bring out a more open and relaxed atmosphere, regardless



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ALBURZ



DISTRICTS:
D1: THE DISTRICT OF ETERNITY
D2: CITY OF THE WHISPERER (NEWTOWN)
D3: THE DISTRICT OF MATAY
D4: THE CITY OF PRAYERS
D5: THE ESPLANADE OF VANZURS
D6: PLATEAU OF THE HEAD
D7: PLATEAU OF THE HAND
D8: PLATEAU OF THE FOOT
D9: THE SLAUGHTERHOUSES
D10: RAVINE OF STEAM
D11: DEEPTOWN
D12: INDUSTRY CITY

PLAZAS:
A: THE CHERRY PLAZA
B: THE PLAZA OF THE PROPHETS
C: SOUK OF THE MASKS
D: THE PLAZA OF ASHES
E: THE PLAZA OF STEAM
F: THE BUFFALO MARKET
G: THE PLAZA OF GAMBLING
H: THE MEAT HALLS

PLACES:
01: THE ZIGGURAT OF THE ICONS
02: THE TEMPLE OF MANAVOH
03: THE ETERNITY SPIRE
04: THE SADAALIAN ARCHIVES
05: THE MEDICUM INSTITUTE
06: CRAFTMANSHIP ACADEMY
07: HABATHUS GARRISON
08: THE LOGISTICS BUREAU
09: RAMIR'S GAMBLING
10: WALLA'S TEA HOUSE
11: THE CRYSTAL ALLEY
12: PHERI'S HAMMAM
13: ARDIONA'S BUTTERFLY HOUSE
14: MARHALLA'S BIONICS
15: ARSHAD'S AUCTION HOUSE
16: EMAN'S CURIOSITY

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TABLE 13: ENCOUNTERS IN ALBURZ

NAME	BACKGROUND	DESCRIPTION
Badri Surhan	False seer (propagandist)	The servants of the Seer, the Kavi, can be found near the Plaza of the Prophets where the words of Aremerat and the Ameshas are carved directly into the stone. For a couple of birr, passersby can have their fortunes told, often relating to one of Aremerat's decrees.
Kalyan	True seer (mystic Kavi)	A kavi with the mystic's disease walks down the street chanting: ***"If you hear the Song, you know liberty. Leave Sadaal and give yourself to the Icons."*** Shortly thereafter, two masked individuals in dark robes show up to arrest the seer.
Palani Nizagana	Clockmaker	An unassuming older lady sits by a small market stall. On the cloth before her lies water clocks, pocket watches and chronographs. The Icon Vanzur is etched into several of the cases. The clocks sell for 25 birr but are probably worth around 200. She's very grateful for any business she can get since The Phantoms destroyed her shop...
Vessek Sarabrua & Nalah	Merchant with submissive interpreter	A wealthy man with a richly decorated fabric mask haggles aggressively with a shopkeep. He prods his defeated interpreter with a walking stick. The shopkeep is Zenithian and is complaining about the rise in buffalo meat prices.
Vaishali Bihar	Gardener	An older man with a maimed right hand and plenty of scars from an adventurous past is carefully pruning a flower bed as he mutters to himself: ***"Making it pretty. Green leaves and flowers to appease the Eternal. Maybe the screams won't be as loud if there are more dancers at the next U-Khari..."*** He is referring to the Urvatat Khari harvest festival that takes place on the Cherry Plaza just below The Crying Ziggurat.
Rewa Koraam & Ghodava Barathi	Worker and foreman from the slaughterhouses	A man and a woman are drinking. The woman says that she has seen the barbarians of the plains drink buffalo blood and draw strange symbols on the ground. The foreman shakes his head and mutters in agreement. He thinks the geustasa are summoning djinni and evil spirits with the their foolish rituals and that they possess the cattle...
Tirup Sans Arid	News smuggler	Along a dimly lit street sits a row of outcasts. Some passed out, some with their lips sewn together, many with missing limbs. One of them pulls herself from her stupor to beg for a drink or a couple of birr and then whispers in a raspy voice: ***"Strangers. This is what they do to those who speak of the world outside."***
Sawa Rikesh	Gambler	A gambler notices the PCs. She wonders if any of them would be interested in a low-stakes game of kardhkel. Minimum bet is 50 birr. Roll an opposed MANIPULATION (Sawa has 8) test. The winner doubles her bet. If Sawa loses more than 150 birr, she might send a couple of dock workers along later to reclaim her loss... (2 DP)
Kala Ferin Alketer	Zenithian former scientist (the Foundation, Beletser station)	The PCs are recognized by the former scientist and she needs their help. Many Zenithians have ended up in jail and had their assets confiscated. The station she was working on had found Portal Builder ruins on one of Buyasta's moons but they never had time to analyze the results before The Phantoms showed up... For 1 DP, the scientist attracts the attention of a police patrol.
Bogdhâ Nim & Farouk Harab	Pilgrim and dissident	A pilgrim from the mining town of Kedar plays the card game nardshir on a park bench. He talks about how the righteous can win Aremerat's favor by working in the Ramaiti temple towns. He has sent in his application and is praying for good news. His opponent, a part time drunk, full-time cynic who works as a detective says that there are no such temples, only labor camps and a slow death. Rumors say that the residents of the now empty Whispering City were taken to such a "temple town"...

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of the intermittent drone patrols that keep an eye on things for Amesha Habathu.

These levels of the city are part of old Alburz and were constructed long before the Wars. Streets and chambers bustle with workshops, gambling halls, cafes, restaurants and squares with vertical gardens and hot springs. The light coming in from above through deep atriums is supported by huge chandeliers full of growth lamps, large vats of sugar globes and prayer alcoves filled with oil lamps to chase away the dark. Deeptown is a calm oasis of relative freedom in the otherwise regimented and windswept capital. The central blocks are home to the Steam Plaza and the white marble palace shared by the prestigious Pheri's Hammam baths and Ardiona's Butterfly House. There are rumors going around about a secret network of tunnels and chambers that connect Deeptown with both the forgotten wartime bunker systems and with several of Aremerat's ziggurats and the Amesha Spenta's topside institutes.

THE SPACEPORT OF THE ABYSS

The city's spaceport can be found in one of the mountain valleys outside the capital's limits. Large hangar gates in the mountainsides connect to wide chambers where docking plateaus and loading bays in many levels await incoming freighters. Defense Institute guards in dark armor and mirrored visors patrol the spaceport; attack drones high in the steamy air scan for dissidents and smugglers and meticulous; well-dressed customs officers check and double check all import licenses. Larger ships are usually diverted to the lowlands to dock with the slaughterhouses and unload their cargo for distribution via shuttles or trains.

FRIENDS AND ENEMIES

"In the name of the Martyr – welcome. My name is Kamala Hydarnes, follower of the teachings of the prophet Iria Urahuk, daughter of arch priot Khaleem, cousin of your former enemy Chabaun Kheml."

The woman before you is covered in scars and tattoos after a long life in the service of the Holy Light. You can see that she wore glyph armor until very recently, probably until she and her crew had to hide here on Sadaal.

"My cousin was… misinformed. We believed we were keeping the darkness out. But the glyphs from the Wars never spoke of us – you are the true champions of the Martyr! Our agents gave their lives to bring this knowledge to you. The leaders you brought here will be executed at dawn. Aremerat is in league with the dark. He wants the Nadir Flotilla for himself and is ready to go to war with the rest of the Horizon. Inside the Ziggurat of the Icons, your allies await their deaths. Help us rescue them. Our ships and weapons are at your disposal. May the Prophet be ever by your side."

THE SITUATION

The PCs have avoided the Sadaalian patrols and made it to Pheri's Hammam in Deeptown. In a network of tunnels, the martyr warriors who managed to flee with the data about the true fate of Dabaran are hiding. Time is running out as the arrested delegates have been taken to the Crying Ziggurat at the Cherry Plaza to be executed as soon as the sun rises.

MAJOR EVENTS

In Deeptown, the PCs search for the contact from the message they got aboard The Hammer of the Martyr in Aiwaz. They find out what's in store for the delegation.

THE ENVOY

If the PCs get lost or take too long, The Warriors of the Holy Light dispatch someone to come and find them. A drunk older lady staggers out into the street from a gambling hall. She wears a plain, ill-fitting paper mask to protect against the night winds. After spotting the PCs, she feigns collapsing into their arms and whispers or gives them a piece of paper with the message on it.

- The PCs must make it to Pheri's Hammam in Deeptown before dawn.

She then asks for some food and drink and at the cost of 1 DP, she also steals a couple of birr or a non-essential item from the pockets of one of them (especially if they didn't give her anything to eat or drink).

Cost: 0, 1 DP

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A NIGHT AT THE BATHS

The Steam Plaza by the central chamber of Deeptown is the largest in the lower city and this is where you find the marble palace that houses Pheri's steam baths. The square outside is lined with open pools where tired workers soak their legs in the warm water, breathe in the steam or enjoy a mug of chai.

Before the PCs enter the palace, they are led through a gallery full of plants and butterflies, with mosaic walls of painted glass. This is Ardiona's Butterfly House, a calm and peaceful garden cafe run by the younger cousin of hammam matriarch Seliah Pheri, the half-Zenithian Lea. As they step inside the bath palace, they are greeted by staff who give them towels and bathrobes. The arches and benches in the reception feel soft and soothing despite being made of marble and everything has been wiped clean of condensation from the baths further in. A visit costs 50 birr (non-negotiable).

- **The Passphrase:** By discreetly asking for "the light" and then waiting while the confused receptionist speaks to Seliah herself, the PCs will be taken to a private steam chamber with ensuite changing rooms. The PCs are left alone to rest for a while and may help themselves to fruit and beverages while they wait.
- **The Ambush (3 DP):** At the cost of 3 DP, the secret police ambush the PCs at the baths. Phantoms (page 74) armed for close combat spring from two hidden doors on opposite sides of the chamber and attack, but The Warriors of the Holy Light arrive after a while to aid the PCs.
- **The Agents:** A woman and two men enter the chamber. They are wrapped in anonymous cloaks but the tattooed

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Martyr glyphs are still clearly visible, despite the clothes and a thick layer of makeup. The woman has what looks like burns all the way up to her jaw, identifying her as being bionically linked to a suit of holy Zalosian glyph armor and holding the rank of priot (group leader). You don't recognize these specific individuals but you have met their kind before: martyr warriors. They raise their empty hands to show peaceful intentions and gesture for you to follow them down into one of the Shimush Mountains' forgotten bunker systems.

- **The Complex:** The warriors have found a series of abandoned tunnels and a half-collapsed bunker underneath the mountains. After a kilometer or so to the northwest, one of the tunnels leads to a cave where three injector ships are hidden (*Emissary Lost*, page 87). These stealth-equipped space scooters are the only way for the martyr warriors to get in and out of the city undetected. This model has been constructed to carry up to three passengers, or two tons of cargo, but has an armor rating of only 1. The martyrs' courier ship, Ruhm-alyash ("The Jade Spear"), is hidden in orbit around one of Sadaal's moons. In the warriors' makeshift base – a chamber near the cave with the injectors – one of the walls is covered in glyphs describing both ancient prophecies and recent events. The agents have clearly been trying to interpret the sacred texts in a new way.
- **Gear:** Crates of weapons and armor can be found just outside the chamber and the PCs are welcome to take what they need of the following: 1 chameleon suit (Coriolis core rulebook, page 119), 2 modulation masks, 3 Vulcan crickets, 2 Vulcan scorpions, 1 accelerator pistol, 1 medium breach charge and ablative pads. The ablative pads are fastened to a person's armor and subtract 3 from the damage of the first hit. After that, the tech must be restored using an advanced spare part and TECHNOLOGY. Full body protection requires six pads; if you wear less, roll a die when hit to see if the pads activate. For example, if you wear three pads, a roll of 1–3 means the attack hits one of your pads (player chooses which one).
- **The Mission:** The delegates have been sentenced to execution at dawn. The PCs are given access to the martyr warriors' space scooters and gear to try to liberate them and escape Sadaal. The Nadir Flotilla is lost but the alliances between the Third Horizon factions might survive if their leaders do. You can use the scene's intro text as priot Kamala's welcome speech if you like. Additionally, she tells them the following:
  - She is a follower of the prophet Iria Urahuk and the cousin of Chabaun Kheml, the priot encountered by the PCs at the Foundation hospital during *Emissary Lost*.
  - The Warriors of the Holy Light have analyzed and re-evaluated the holy verses and identified the PCs as the prophet's chosen ones.
  - The Urahuk Verses prayer book was quoted in *Emissary Lost*. The "The Song of Urahuk" box contains a longer version and may be read to the PCs.
  - The Warriors were misled by the Vestals and turned on the Messenger Emissary and the mystics when they would have been the way to salvation. The Emissary is the key to finding the Hermit, an ancient ally hiding in the Quadrant of the Pillar.
  - The PCs are given a Machine Icon talisman that wears a Martyr crown of thorns (blessed, +1 to any one roll).
  - Kamala plays a clip on her tabula showing what really happened on the Dabaran portal station (see box "The Fate of Dabaran").
  - The Waha-Najima bulk hauler brought Hadid humanites from Uharu to Sadaal to strengthen the army and crew the Nadir Flotilla with capable soldiers loyal to the Vestals and the First Horizon.
  - The Vestals appear to have some form of darkmorph under their command, swarms of something insect-like that the martyr warriors call hashara.
  - The members of the delegation are under arrest and scheduled for execution atop the Crying Ziggurat by the Cherry Plaza at dawn.

Regardless of whether the PCs feel comfortable around their former enemies or not, the agents will be cooperative. You can end Kamala's speech with "Kamala's confession" (see box). After meeting the martyr warriors, progress to the last scene.
Cost: 0, 3 DP (Mandatory)

MINOR EVENTS

The following events can be used to spice up their stay in Alburz and add some extra pressure.

PHANTOMS IN THE STREET

An Angra Mainyu patrol (The Phantoms, page 74) has tracked down the PCs and attempts to arrest them in a narrow alley or tunnel. The situation quickly escalates with

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grenade blasts and gunfire echoing between the stone walls. For 1 extra DP, The Phantoms have set up an ambush with frag grenades and for 2 extra DP, they have rigged inferno grenade traps they try to herd the PCs into. The ambush may be spotted with OBSERVATION at –1.
Cost: 2–4 DP

THE CITY OF THE EXILED ZENITHIANS

The relatively recent addition of Newtown can be found on the outskirts of Alburz. The neighborhood is also known as Whisper Town after the inhabitants who lived here before Newtown was built all vanished overnight about ten cycles ago. Zenithian businesses and organizations moved in instead, remodeling the block after their own stringent tastes in office buildings, boutiques and wide avenues. All visitors and

THE SONG OF URAHUK

We shall face the children of Terra beyond dawn and sorrow and old chains shed.

Eyes that close open the way for false prophets. There will come a time when mankind turns to darkness once more. When the unworthy speak without tongues. When sister betrays sister. When the light of peace nourishes the servants of darkness. When brother kills brother. Only they who live in the darkness will see the light, and find truth within the false song.

They are the prophets and the pathfinders. When light turns to darkness, the hermits come down from the mountains and cross the blood-red fields to greet the new dawn…"

THE "PROPHET'S PATH" VERSE, THE URAHUK VERSES PRAYER BOOK

KAMALA'S CONFESSION

"The Serafs of Terra poisoned our minds and deceived us. As we fought and closed our portals, you continued along the path of the prophet. When we tried to silence the unworthy, you fought for their future. We believe you are the pathfinders mentioned in the holy texts – the ones meant to find the hermit and lead the Horizon through the war and into a new dawn."

FILM: THE FATE OF DABARAN

The tabula shows the flickering Dabaran portal just as butterfly ships and glimmering, shell-covered destroyers break through it, swarming around a giant bulk hauler.

A camera drone follows a tattooed woman sneaking around in the bulk hauler's cargo hold – rows and rows of stasis beds, it must be thousands. Several units are open and bright lights shine on hairless humanites with rough, silvery skin surrounding a Vestal. A shot rings out and the spy falls down dead. Cut.

The Dabaran portal station. People running for their lives. Armored soldiers follow the Vestal through dark corridors that seem to disappear behind them. A complete, swarming darkness follows the group, drowning everything and everyone in its way. Cut.

The tabula shows a feed from the exterior hull camera of a courier ship. The crew's voices over the intercom shout in Zalosi, desperate to take off. Three ships leave the portal station and start heading toward the star. One is ripped apart by a fractal torpedo. Two butterfly ships pursue the remaining courier ships as they jump blindly to escape with the data.

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residents here must wear masks at all times, regardless of weather and wind, and foreigners must even wear a special kind of red mask to identify them as off-worlders.

After the collapse of the Monolith, many Zenithians sought asylum in the system and after some negotiating with the Amesha Spenta, the Newtown complex was given to the Zenithian refugees as their new home in exile. Previously wealthy families who operated mines in the system in the past also live here but most have lost their former status and now live off small scale trading.

The Birbasil Syndicate family has taken over running the district and various Syndicate gangs patrol the streets and clubs. Newtown's small spaceport, its warehouses, nightclubs and gambling halls have given Deeptown some competition for the workers' time and money. A deal with the Bureau of Medicine and Amesha Vanzur has secured a steady flow of opiates and other permitted intoxicants but a new drone network and surveillance system called the Shalan, "the eyes of the high priest," makes sure to record what's said and done while under the influence.

- **Monitored:** A couple of Newtown's upsides are that you can converse in Zeni and that almost anything, even weapons, can be purchased here if you've got the money. The streets are heavily monitored, however, and if the PCs wish to stay out of the way of The Phantoms or informants, they need to be wary. One PC must roll an **INFILTRATION** test at –2 for the group to avoid the sensors. Another PC may assist by rolling **CULTURE** to reward bonus dice for each 6 rolled. Failure most likely leads to the PCs running into a Phantom patrol (see "Phantoms in the street" above) or recon drones (see page 74).

Cost: 0 DP

THE CRYING ZIGGURAT

Dark tunnels and caved-in bunkers lead you toward the surface. The sounds of the city waking up above you tell you time is running out. Dawn is fast approaching and the Cherry Plaza will soon be full of devout citizens waiting for the traitors to face their doom. The crowds praise the glory of Aremerat and hope to see the Living Icon on his balcony in the Eternity Spire.

The light from the tabula leads the way. You follow the bunker map and find the stairs near the Plaza and the gate that should take you inside the Crying Ziggurat, to the chambers of the Amesha Spenta and the imprisoned leaders of the Third Horizon. The fate of the delegation now rests in your hands…

THE SITUATION

On Aremerat's orders, the Amesha Spenta has sentenced the delegates to death for treason. Their lust for the Nadir Flotilla – Aremerat's way of securing peace for the Horizon – must be punished. The news reports also say that the delegates were extremists planning to assassinate members of the Sadaalian government. When the sun dial at the Cherry Plaza awakens at dawn, the condemned will be taken to the roof of the Ziggurat of the Icons and be exsanguinated. Their blood shall water the climbing gardens and fatten the vultures.

The PCs will have to make their way through the Ziggurat of the Icons and into the council chambers, or up to the roof, but regardless of when and how they reveal themselves, the Vestal Ashaan-Unt Et-U'haya will confront them.

THE CALL OF DAWN

Let the PCs prepare for the rescue mission as they travel through the bunker network toward the ziggurat and hear the crowds gather in the plaza above. The delegates are already being brought to the execution site. As the GM, you decide how large the tunnel complex under the city is and how long it takes the group to arrive. Use this to determine how much time they have when they eventually make it to the ziggurat, but if they've wasted more time than they should have, the executions might already have started when they do. Several of the delegates might already have bled out over the stones on top of the ziggurat (your choice of who).

PROTECTED

The Amesha Spenta has gathered in the council chambers together with the recently arrived armored Hadid bodyguards. The corridors of the ziggurat are full of guard patrols.

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THE ZIGGURAT



VOICE OF A VESTAL

The Vestal will witness the execution from the balcony at the top of the Eternity Spire. Dark powers allow the Vestal to wear the appearance of Aremerat rather than reveal itself as an agent of Ardha, but the illusion is powered by the energies of the cadaver clock and will be weakened if the clock is destroyed. In this case, maintaining the illusion will sap the Vestal's own energy. When the PCs finally encounter Ashaan-Unt Et-U'haya, they will be subjected to their manipulative powers but the protection of the Machine Icon might let them see the truth.

MAJOR EVENTS

The PCs must make their way through the ziggurat to reach the delegates. The council chambers are cleared to take the convicted up to the roof. You can reveal the imprisoned body of Aremerat before or after the rescue.

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HELP FROM THE MARTYRS

If the PCs have a hard time making it to the top of the ziggurat or escaping from the final combat, you can let the martyr warriors arrive as reinforcements or to create a distraction to buy the PCs some time. The warriors are ready to sacrifice themselves to allow the PCs to complete their mission.

⚙ THE ZIGGURAT

The Ziggurat of the Icons contains ancient halls and chambers dedicated to the Icons brought to the systems by the original settlers. The concepts of the Amesha Spenta mirror these Icons to this day, albeit in a modified form. Worn glyphs, faded paintings and cracked mosaics portray Icons still revered by other original Firstcome clans throughout the Third Horizon. After the Portal Wars, the wisdom of Aremerat has been added to the decorations and each chamber has a gold-lined quartz and obsidian plaque in the ceiling telling the story of how the Eternal Leader lit Sadaal's new sun. The ziggurat is practically a labyrinth of dark and secret tunnels, some of which are known only to the secret police and the clergy.

1. **The Bunker Complex:** Tunnels and low halls upheld by robust pillars and arches containing forgotten equipment from the days of the Portal Wars. The complex is divided into sectors: a residential module containing beds and lockers; kitchens with dead plant beds and dry fish farms; and the Habathus sector where abandoned monitors, coms and gunner's seats once controlled sensor stations and weapons platforms all along the Shimush Mountains. The different sectors are separated by thick metal doors but most of them are open. At the cost of 1 DP, the PCs come to a locked door (FORCE to open manually, or TECHNOLOGY) or a collapse in the tunnel (FORCE) that slows them down.

2–3. **The Cherry Plaza:** The plaza is a large public space just below the aqueduct gardens. As the day begins, more and more citizens arrive after having heard the propaganda about the treason of the rest of the Horizon. The gathered hope to be blessed with Aremerat's presence as maybe the great leader will come to watch the execution in person from his perch in **The Eternity Spire [3]**. The Spire's black majesty contrasts the lush green that covers the Ziggurat of the Icons.

4. **The Acolyte Sector:** Wide corridors and rooms with stained glass skylights filtering light from high above. This section is always busy with clerical assistants, analysts and administrators from the different institutes who work hard to keep the city running smoothly. The offices, archives and meeting rooms breathe centuries of piety. Most of the governmental operations take place in the actual institutes and bureaus but this is where the work is compiled and presented to the Amesha Spenta. In the early hours only a few eager assistants are in, plus a handful of security guards doing their morning rounds through the pyramid.

5. **The Complex of the Clergy:** Eight suites surround an arboretum with a tearoom in the middle. This is where the members of the Amesha Spenta meet to plan and scheme, each of them having a suite of their own as well as offices and relaxation areas built from exquisite Sadaalian obsidian, limestone, marble and Bahramian teak. The complex is kept separate from the rest of the ziggurat and protected by rigorous security systems (DATA DJINN or INFILTRATION –2) but there are secret tunnels that lead here from the sector of the The Phantoms. In Sadaal's history, it's been alleged more than once that Ameshas with plans to go against Aremerat have vanished or been found dead in the tearoom.

6–8. **The Sector of The Phantoms:** No one knows where the entrances to the headquarters of the secret police are, only that somewhere within the Ziggurat of the Icons, dissidents and rebels are tortured and murdered. **The Phantoms' Sector [6]** is a series of floors around the central column inside the pyramid all the way from the crypt to the council chambers. One reaches the labyrinthine tunnels and **Cell Blocks [7]** through hidden doors and elevators from the other parts of the ziggurat, but there are also tunnels that reach deep into the underground bunker network. Far below, hidden hangars contain gravcraft and atmospheric shuttles. At the heart of the sector of The Phantoms, a false

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atrium lit by bright floodlights contains a central staircase carved into the polished marble walls. The stairs and the hidden elevators take The Phantoms to whichever **Torture Room [8]** or prison cell they like. The whole sector reeks of death and terror and muffled cries and wails can be heard coming from behind sturdy, locked doors.

9–10. The Crypt: Underneath the labyrinth of The Phantoms and the complex of the clergy lies the crypt. Low tunnels lined with sarcophagi preserve the remains of former members of the Amesha Spenta. Skeptics falsely believe that this is where earlier generations of the Aremerat figure might be hidden away, but this is wrong – Aremerat's families and lovers are interred here (some of whom met with premature ends) but the Eternal Leader himself is just that, eternal. The crypt is decorated with obsidian and cut vulcanite and lit by sugar globes in small niches in the walls. The globes are fed sugar water dripping down from canals in the walls and the sound of the slow drip gives the crypt a wet and stuffy atmosphere. An illusion, guided by the presence of the Vestal, keeps curious visitors from the central chamber and **The Cadaver Clock [10]** (see below). The central chamber is round and dimly lit. Vines with red leaves climb the walls toward the eight slowly rotating gears in the ceiling that churn away above a mosaic rendering of the Great Beast U'haya. The pained screams of dying victims from executions in the past live on as echoes here and feed the dark energies that strengthen the agents of the First Horizon. A broken, tortured body hangs in the middle of the chamber – Aremerat himself (see "The Cadaver Clock" below).

11. The Council Chambers: Sharp rock walls cut from the bedrock of the Shimush rise above a marble floor. Nine thrones sit on sculpted cliffs, like little islands, with stairs leading up to them. Eight of the thrones form a semicircle facing the ninth – the golden throne of the Eternal One. The teachings of Aremerat cover the walls as glyphs or paintings. Empty galleries for assistants or visitors still remain from the time before the Wars when Sadaal was a blossoming socialist democracy. It's been many years since anyone used the benches now.

12. The Altar of the Icons: On the roof of the Ziggurat of the Icons, surrounded by the splendor of the hanging aqueduct gardens, rises an octagonal terrace on thirteen pillars. In the center of the platform, an altar has been cut in the shape of a flaming sun on top of which sacrifices can be made to the skies. Four ledges protrude above the plaza from the platform. These are sometimes used by victims awarded the option to step over the edge of their own volition and fall to their deaths against the jagged stone ornaments covering the sides of the ziggurat. All public executions are broadcast by camera drones swarming around the altar to large holo screens on the pillars below the aqueducts.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

⚙ THE CADAVER CLOCK

The chamber with the cadaver clock is obscured by the Vestal's illusions and not even the secret police who patrol the surrounding corridors or the acolytes who work in the crypt know the way inside. The PCs' bond with the Machine Icon heightens their senses and gives them a chance to see through the lies, but the ornate stone doorway leading inside the chamber (the crypt of Marabed the Wise, Sadaal's first leader) still just glides through the PCs' field of vision, like a mirage – one second it's there, in the corner of their eye, and then gone again. A sense of dread and the smell of decay are constantly present, however, telling them that something dark is close by. PCs who didn't merge with the Machine Icon see or feel none of the above.

- **The Doorway:** The door is opened with an electronic key that is part of a talisman the ancient leaders of Sadaal used to wear. The talisman contains one key for each chamber and former leader but is currently worn by the Vestal. Without the key, forcing the door requires a **DATA DJINN** at –1 or a critically successful **FORCE**.
- **The Chamber:** Marabed's sarcophagus in the center of the room is covered in mother-of-pearl, gilded glyphs in what looks like ancient Miran, polished neodym from the Sadaalian asteroid belt – and partially dried blood. Hung in the ceiling, rotating slowly, are eight dark gears forming a death wheel. The turning of the gears flickers in and out of vision. The air is thick and nauseatingly sweet. Anxiety grips the hearts of the PCs and you can have them roll for terror (*The Last Cyclade*, page 31) if you like.
- **Aremerat:** Suspended from thin, silky wires below the rotating wheel hangs Aremerat the Eternal. A thin man with long, lank hair and moist, cracked leathery skin appears to slowly melt onto the sarcophagus. The face is twisted in pain and from behind the grinding teeth comes a low whimper. **MEDICURGY**

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can reveal to the PCs that the body is in remarkably good condition, given the circumstances, which is probably the work of the nanites and bionics meant to give the leader an unnaturally long life. The Eternal Leader can still be saved by passing a SCIENCE test at –2 to get him down off the cadaver clock, and a MEDICURGY test at -1 to treat his wounds (requires medical supplies). He has been infected by dark memes, however, and is all but apathetic, unable to walk on his own. It will take a lot of time and treatment before the leader of Sadaal is in his right mind again.

- **Darkness:** The cadaver clock feeds the darkness and the Vestal for as long as it's active. Even if the PCs rescue Aremerat, the life force of imprisoned dissidents will continue to supply it with some power. To shut off the clock without creating a hole in reality, the PCs need to pass a MYSTIC POWERS roll at -2. Even if they pass the test, you can let a darkmorph make it through. At the cost of 1 DP, it's a darkbound and for 2 DP, it's either the Hounds of Tirides or a dark djinn. You decide if the PCs realize something is breaking through before it happens.

Cost: 0, 1–3 DP

THE EXECUTION

The Altar of the Icons at the top of the ziggurat is surrounded by rows of Hadid humanites in white armor and Angra Mainyu Phantoms. The delegates and their bodyguards are lined up nearby with their hands cuffed and with golden hoods over their heads. The Amesha Spenta is represented at the execution by Vanzur (the Dancer), Habathu (the Judge) and Voukasha (the Lady of Tears). Acting on what they believe to be Aremerat's orders, they have organized the execution of the delegation.

Habathu stands on one of the protruding platforms overlooking the Cherry Plaza, ready to address the masses. See the box below or make up your own speech containing the following:

- The Sadaalian people have built a peace fleet and the other factions now desire it to make war.
- Sadaal with its workers and craftsmen are the Third Horizon's heart and destined to lead the other systems to peace and unity.
- The delegates stand accused of having sent assassins and spies to undermine the rule of Aremerat but they were apprehended in time and will now be sacrificed for the glorious future of the system.

NEW TALENT: SHIELD OF THE ICONS

The person feels protected by the Icons or some other higher power. It can be actual divine protection or simply rigorous training. The person may pray to the Icons for a reroll to an armor roll once per hit. Costs 1 DP if the user is an NPC, generates 1 DP when used by a PC.

PUBLIC ADDRESS

"As the sun rises, we come together before Aremerat the Eternal. We have defended the interests of the Third Horizon and created community through ingenuity and trade. Ours is the toil in the mines, ours is the sweat in the smelteries and shipyards. Despite our sacrifices for peace, our neighbors mean to bring us war. Their so-called negotiators have set their assassins and agents on us to try and destroy our glorious realm, but we shall never bow to their demands. Today, the guilty stand before you, the people of Sadaal, to repent their misdeeds through the ultimate sacrifice..."

HIGH PRIEST HABATHU, THE ZIGGURAT OF THE ICONS

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NEW HUMANITE/CYBERNETIC TALENT: ADAPTIVE SKIN

A mesh of ablative micro pads has been grown into the person's skin. The thickness and composition of the metallic mesh can be regulated by a network of neurally linked receptors. The skin has a natural Armor Rating of 2 but will also adapt as it learns to handle new threats. All hits from the same damage source after the first have their damage reduced by 2 (after normal armor rolls) but the skin can remember only three types of damage at once (for example: Vulcan, thermal, acc, stun, regular melee combat). Bio sculptors in Menkar have managed to create a cybernetic equivalent of the graft, but this can only remember one type of damage at a time.
COST: 15,000 birr (CYB).

NEW HUMANITE/CYBERNETIC TALENT: ECHOLOCATION

Transmitters and receivers in the frontal bone and trachea allow for an advanced form of echolocation. People nearby can hear it as clicking or crackling sounds. The sonar has a reach of 100 meters and ignores light and dark completely, giving the user a +2 to **OBSERVATION**. A cybernetic version has been created by the Legion for tunnel warfare during the Tarash conflict on Algol.
COST: 8,000 birr (CYB)

NEW BIONIC SCULPT: INDOCTRINATED

The person has been genetically manipulated for blind loyalty to the members or leaders of a certain organization. Rank and chain of command can't be altered without extensive surgery. The person is unable to commit disloyal actions or disobey commands. If subjected to manipulation attempts to go against her leader, the indoctrinated person gets a +3 to **MANIPULATION** to resist. When physically near the leader or when acting on the direct orders from that leader, the indoctrinated is immune to stress.

- **The Sacrifices:** After the speech, the delegates and their surviving entourage are led, one by one, to the edge of the platform. Their hoods are removed and their faces wiped with a wet rag. After Habathu grants them the Icons' forgiveness, cables tied to their wrists pull their arms above their heads. Ritual symbols are carved into their back and belly and their blood starts to pool in canals on the floor. When they can't stand upright anymore, or pass out from blood loss, the frame they're hanging from is swung out over the edge and the body is let go. A triangular pattern of sharpened stone teeth sticking out from the side of the pyramid mangles them as they fall to their deaths on the lower terraces. Stress the PCs' lack of time to intervene, the execution will start before they can plan their attack. When the execution begins, you get 4 new DP.
- **Combat:** Let the PCs gauge the strength of their opponents before they are discovered. You should tailor the number of guards to the size of your group – a small group should meet four Hadid and two Phantoms (page 97), a medium-size group should meet six Hadid and three Phantoms and a full-size group should be faced with eight Hadid and four Phantoms. You can let the enemies act in groups of between two and four individuals in terms of movement and initiative. Unless the odds are clearly in favor of the executioners, the Ameshas will quickly retreat through one of the four exits from the ziggurat roof.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory, generates 4 DP)

THE ARRIVAL OF THE VESTAL

When the fighting escalates to the point where the PCs get a chance to start rescuing the delegates, the worried murmurs from the crowd below abruptly change to ecstatic cheers. A light from the Eternity Spire hits the top of the Ziggurat of the Icons and even the combatants take a second to look out across the plaza in startled anticipation. Use the text below or make up your own description of the Vestal's arrival.

- The Vestal has been looking for the PCs and wants to turn them into its lieutenants in the new Horizon.
- The Machine Icon will try to speak to the PCs to break the Vestal's spell, regardless of whether they merged with her or not.
- The Vestal will eventually realize that they aren't willing to join the First Horizon and then attack, but feigned submission might buy them some time.

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TABLE 14: NPCS AT THE EXECUTION

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
High priest	2	2	4	5	4	9	9	Manipulation 6, Culture 5, Observation 4, Dexterity 3, Science 3, Infiltration 2, Medicurgy 2, Ranged Combat 2	Thermal cricket, ornate mask (worth 5,000 birr), exquisite clothing, armasuit (armor 3). Talents: Shield of the Icons (see box), Wealthy Family, Beautiful, Regenerate
Angra Mainyu (The Phantoms)	3	4	3	2	9	5	8	Infiltration 5, Observation 4, Ranged Combat 4, Data Djinn 3, Manipulation 3, Melee Combat 3	Vulcan carbine, communicator, stun grenade, ablative armasuit (armor 3, -3 to first hit), sensor helmet (OBSERVATION +1) Talents: Body Armor (+3), Targeting Scope, Nine Lives
Hadid humanite	4	4	3	2	8	(5)	5	Infiltration 5, Melee Combat 5, Ranged Combat 4, Manipulation 3, Observation 3	Thermal carbine, accelerated combat suit (armor 6, DEXTERITY +2), advanced scope Talents: Adaptive Skin, Echolocation, Indoctrinated (see boxes)



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After speaking to them, the Vestal will float toward the PCs high above the plaza and then join its minions in attacking them on the ziggurat's roof. This generates 4 DP. The crowds below are also under the Vestal's control and will act as a poorly armed mob (see "Mob combat" on page 220 of *The Last Cyclade*). Use the text below or describe the revelation of the Vestal in your own words.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory, generates 4 DP)

VESTAL ASHAAN-UNT ET-U'HAYA

Ashaan-Unt was one of the first Vestals to reach the Third Horizon after almost fifty years of waiting in the darkness between the portals. They are the captain of the butterfly ship that attacked and enslaved the Tsurabi colony in Taoan (see The Last Voyage of the Ghazali) and began the process of awakening the slumbering Nazareem cells. Ashaan-Unt is loyal to the Eternal Emperor until death and beyond and is now general over the armies in Sadaal, tasked with preparing for the arrival of the First Horizon and its rightful conquest. Ashaan-Unt demands absolute loyalty from their manipulated citizens and is using a mass illusion to trick everyone, even the Amesha Spenta, into seeing the Vestal as Aremerat rather than as themselves.

CHARACTERISTICS: The Vestal floats through the air and never touches ground. The stillness around it is deafening and its hands and mouth appear to be the only parts of it that move.

The stats below are for the Vestal in its normal form. For its weakened shape, see the "Without the Cadaver Clock" box.

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5, WITS 5, EMPATHY 8**
HIT POINTS: 20
MIND POINTS: – (immune to stress)
REPUTATION: 10 (automatically superior)
SKILLS: Culture 10, Mystic Powers 8, Command 5, Data Djinn 5, Manipulation 5, Melee Combat 5, Observation 5, Pilot 5, Science 5, Technology 5, Dexterity 2
ACTIONS: Three separate initiatives per turn, each with 3 AP to spend.
TALENTS: See powers table. Costs 1 DP per activation except **CHANNEL THE VOID** and **ENTHRALL**.
ARMOR: Ablative absorption negates 2 points of damage from first physical hit each turn and negates one CRIT.

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THE VESTAL ATTACKS

A light and a note beyond human hearing attracts your attention. Aremerat's body and golden robe morph into a floating Seraf of ethereal white light coming toward you. Its eyes are covered by a red silk ribbon but you still feel seen like never before. Love and anxiety duels in you chests. Your hearts pump hard. A choir of voices caresses your minds:

"My friends, we have looked for you between the stars and here you are, in our home. We are the light and the future. Stand with us against our lost children. Renounce the dark agenda of the Symmetry and make way for a new Horizon. We are the parents you never had. You have been through so much but we are here to release you from the chains and shames of society. Give yourselves to a true life, without moderation, modesty or hierarchies."

You feel how love and a liberating anarchy grows within you, but then a cry for help cuts through the mists. The Machine Icon wraps her cloak around you and calls out through a sea of burning stars:

"Heed not the nihilistic promises of Terra. You have grown beyond the Horizons. You are your own now, you don't need your parents anymore."

The image of the Seraf flickers. The light fades and turns to ash and whirling darkness carrying a deformed body toward you. Blood runs from a mouth full of glittering, razor-sharp teeth. The sounds from the crowds unify in a single, hateful voice:

"If you can't love us then love nothing. You are doomed to perish. Your lifeless bodies will nourish us and make way for the true rulers of the Horizons. You are the heralds of a new era but will never see the fruits of your labor. We will break your bones like bread and spill your blood on the ground like spoiled wine. Today is your last day."

PROTECTED

PCs who have merged with the Machine Icon are immune to the Vestal's mind-tricks and manipulations. All NPCs (except the Dakin) are automatically affected, however. The PCs get the Machine Icon bonus (page 45) to all defensive MYSTIC POWERS rolls.

WITHOUT THE CADAVER CLOCK

If the PCs destroyed the cadaver clock in the crypt, the Vestal is weakened:

- –1 to all skill rolls.
- Only two activations per turn instead of three.
- The ablative armor becomes useless after absorbing one CRIT.

BETWEEN LIFE AND DEATH

If the Vestal drops to 0 HP and isn't able to regain at least 1 point (see "Channel the Void"), the body hangs limply in the air in a sort of regenerative coma. The PCs may then test MYSTIC POWERS if they have a power that somehow banishes spirits. The comatose Vestal gets a –3 to its defense roll. If the banishing succeeds, the Vestal is torn apart by the escaping forces of the dark but risks opening a tear into portal space as it dies (see the "Dark Birth" event, page 102).

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TABLE 15: THE VESTAL'S POWERS

D6	DESCRIPTION
*	**CHANNEL THE VOID:** This power is automatically activated when the Vestal reaches 0 HP or when the GM runs out of DP. The Vestal harnesses energy from the darkness. Cracks appear in the air around it, leaking dark, heavy smoke and glittering, black dust. Everyone within Short range of the Vestal must pass an EMPATHY or MYSTIC POWERS test or suffer 2 points of stress. ◆ Each failed test generates 2 DP and heals the Vestal for 3 HP. If the stress leaves a character broken, roll a die: On a 6, the person also suffers a Mania (see page 337 of the Rulebook). ◆ If no one fails their roll, the Vestal enters its regenerative coma (see "Between Life and Death").
1	**ENTHRALL:** The Vestal can puppet its devotees within Short range. The affected act out the Vestal's wishes until they drop to 0 HP. The attack is a MYSTIC POWERS roll and affects everyone within Long range. For a victim to disobey or break free, she must pass a MYSTIC POWERS test with a –1 for each 6 on the Vestal's roll (up to -5). Breaking free leads to 2 points of stress. **MERGED:** PCs who merged with the Machine Icon are immune.
2–3	**LEVITATE:** The Vestal can levitate itself or others by testing MYSTIC POWERS + DEXTERITY (effectively 10 Skill dice). Alternatively, anyone within Short range may be targeted for either of the following: ◆ The victim is knocked one distance further away from the Vestal (opposed MYSTIC POWERS vs FORCE). ◆ The victim suffers physical damage. Roll a MYSTIC POWERS attack (weapon damage 2, CRIT 2) against the victim. The victim must test DEXTERITY instead of Armor to reduce the damage.
4	**WARP:** The Vestal can remind its victims of their Problem by winning an opposed MYSTIC POWERS roll (any number of targets within Long range, one roll per target). Each roll inflicts 2 points of damage on the Vestal. ◆ A won roll activates the target's Problem for D6 turns in combat or ten minutes out of combat. ◆ Each extra winning 6 inflicts 1 point of stress on the target and heals the Vestal for 2 HP.
5	**DESTROY:** The Vestal challenges a target to an opposed roll for MYSTIC POWERS vs MYSTIC POWERS, alternatively FORCE. If the Vestal wins the roll, the target experiences a vacuum-like state for one turn per winning 6. ◆ Tissues necrotize and blood begins to boil. The victim must test FORCE at the beginning of each turn until the effect wears off, with a cumulative –1 modifier for each turn after the first. ◆ Failing the roll leads to losing all HP, becoming broken and dying after D6 minutes unless treated with a successful MEDICURGY test. ◆ If the Vestal reaches 0 HP, the effect ends immediately.
6	**ALLIANCE:** The Vestal tests MYSTIC POWERS and draws in a darkmorph form the Void to fight alongside it for one turn per 6 rolled. See "New darkmorphs" below).

NEW DARKMORPHS

The power of the Vestal feeds off the dark between the stars but this comes with side effects. Some darkmorphs breaking through take physical form (see "Darkmorphs" in the Coriolis core rulebook, page 325) while others are only ethereal spirits or twisted echoes from a distant past ("Spirits and Sarcofagoi", Coriolis core rulebook page 333). Choose from the rulebook or use the new beings below when determining what comes howling through the tear...

HINN, SPIRIT [–1]

A relative of the ethereal djinn but sprung from toxic fumes, acids and environmental destruction. They're sometimes also known as samum. As ethereal beings, they can only be harmed by **MYSTIC POWERS**, rituals using **CULTURE** and rose water, but they can take physical form and focus their smoke-like appearance as crystals, often appearing in shades of green or purple. Dark mystics have tried to enslave hinn, locking them to their physical manifestation by fastening a copper plate inscribed with the rules of the spell on the creature's chest (like the golems of Ardha). When the greenish cloud that is the hinn moves around, plants wither and die and dark maggots burst from the ground.

ATTRIBUTES:
STRENGTH 6, AGILITY 3, WITS 3, EMPATHY 4

HIT POINTS: 9

MIND POINTS: 7

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SKILLS: Force 5, Melee Combat 5, Mystic Powers 4, Dexterity 3

ARMOR: (Crystal body 10)

WEAPONS: (Crystal stab, damage 3, CRIT 2, poison strength 4)

- **CRYSTALLINE:** For 1 DP, the hinn takes physical shape as razor-sharp crystals. It can use its body as a weapon to slice and cut opponents and poison them.
- **ACID WIND:** While in ethereal form, the hinn can summon toxic mists and acid rains targeting everyone within Short range. The rains are a strength 5 attack (damage 2, CRIT 2) every turn and they erode 1 point of armor per attack (can be repaired using **TECHNOLOGY**). If a target would suffer a critical injury, roll a strength 3 fire attack instead (Coriolis core rulebook, page 97).
- **SUFFOCATE:** For 1 DP, the hinn can encapsulate a victim in its crystalline form (opposed **DEXTERITY**). The effects of the crystal prison are equivalent to the vacuum of space (Coriolis core rulebook, page 99) but the victim or someone on the outside may try to break the cell. After suffering 6 or more points of damage, the hinn reverts back to its ethereal form.

KUTRUB, DARKMORPH [–2]

A creature haunts the dark folktales of the Third Horizon, a creature with fur like ripped shreds of anti-light. The kutrub can lie dormant, curled into a fetal ball in the nothingness of space or deep underground in putrid crypts only to spring to life when it catches the scent of living flesh and blood. Their shape is sometimes described as enormous wolves walking upright and sometimes as something in between a human and a bird spider. The number of long, spindly limbs ending in sharp talons varies but their mouths always burn with the light of a newborn sun.

ATTRIBUTES:
STRENGTH 8, AGILITY 6

HIT POINTS: 14

SKILLS: Melee Combat 4, Force 4, Dexterity 2

ARMOR: 5

WEAPONS: Bite (damage 4, CRIT 3), Stab (damage 2, CRIT 2)

- **SUNRAY:** At the cost of 1 DP, the mouth opens and lets out the raging starfire, burning the eyes and faces of everyone within Short range. All affected get a –3 to actions requiring clear vision and suffer a strength 3 fire attack (Coriolis core rulebook, page 97). The light is active for two turns.
- **BLADESTORM:** The creature shakes and the shreds of two-dimensional fur turn into knives that stab in all directions, hitting any number of targets within Short range. Strength 8 attack, damage 3, CRIT 1.
- **PHASESHIFT:** The creature folds in on itself and disappears. In the following turn, it may reappear anywhere within Long range and may perform an ambush attack with a +3 to initiative. The targeted opponent may try to spot the kutrub when it reappears to negate the ambush (**OBSERVATION** –3).

MINOR EVENTS

Use these events to make the ziggurat even more difficult.

TRAPPED

Ambush! A group of Hadid humanites (Table 14, page 97) in white armor and mirrored visors surrounds the PCs. The attack takes place inside the ziggurat as the PCs are heading toward the execution site. For 2 DP, the attackers number as many as the PCs and for 4 DP, they outnumber the PCs two to one. The Hadids' metallic skins and sonar-like sensory capabilities make them terrifying opponents and it might be a good idea for the PCs to withdraw.
Cost: 2–4 DP

JAILBREAK

In the sector of The Phantoms, the PCs come upon torture chambers and prison cells holding a handful of badly injured prisoners. The captives might hear the PCs approach and plead for help through the door in broken Zeni or one of the local dialects. The door locks are controlled from a central chamber which might be guarded by two Angra Mainyu guards (for 1 DP). Hacking the system without triggering the silent alarm requires a **DATA DJINN** test. If they trip the alarm, a handful of guards either storms the control chamber or stages an ambush nearby. The cell doors can also be blown open with explosives (GM decides the blast power needed). The escapees have the "Fugitive" stats according to Table 15.1 on page 343 of the Coriolis core rulebook but only 3 HP and 2 MP. Some example escapees are:

- **Awyan Khau:** Slaughterhouse worker who tried to organize a strike for better working conditions. **FORCE** 4.
- **Merrai Tarash:** Teenage ex-deckhand of a merchant vessel who was begging for food on the Cherry Plaza. Was taken

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after witnessing the secret police arrest a (now dead) dissident. TECHNOLOGY 2.

- **Tama Eb-Walah:** Mystic captain (with one power of your choice) from the Habathus Flotilla. Knows about the crewing of the Nadir Flotilla with humanites arriving from Dabaran. COMMAND 4, PILOT 4.

Cost: 0, 1 DP

RESONANCE: THE DAKIN'S ALLIANCE

If the PCs liberate Tama Eb-Walah above, or if there are other mystics in their group, you can trigger this event. Second Horizon Dakin dominate and puppet the mystic's body and offer the PCs an alliance:

- The Emissaries are worried about the PCs' interference and either demand their loyalty or threaten to attack them.
- The immediate enemy of them both is the Vestal ruling Sadaal, however. The PCs are therefore safe from retribution for the time being and the Dakin suggests a temporary alliance until the agents of the First Horizon have been defeated.
- If the PCs decline the offer, the Dakin could still choose to attack them at the cost of 1 DP.

Cost: 0, 1 DP

RESONANCE: DARK ENERGY

As the PCs leave the bunker complex and enter the ziggurat, they feel a rising sense of dread. Tormented screams echo in their heads and they feel as if something is blotted out of their minds, creating a blind spot. A seductive song is trying to break through, carrying the scent of rose petals, but then their minds reject the illusions of the Vestal, instead bringing out sensations of darkness, lust and anxiety. Voices and sharp fingers claw at their skin. Something is hidden here, like the illusion they experienced in the hangar bay of the Zafirah in *The Last Cyclade*. Grinding wheels and screams of pain ring in their heads.

At the cost of 1 DP, the affected PCs suffer 3 points of stress reduced by 1 for each 6 rolled on a MYSTIC POWERS test. If the roll is successful, they also get a sense of direction to what is creating the blind spot in their heads – the chamber of the cadaver clock calling them in its attempts to stay hidden.

For another 2 DP, the energies of the cadaver clock attract a bokor or sarcofagoi (Coriolis core rulebook, page 335–336) that manifests in the shadows nearby or in the body of a deceased dissident.

Cost: 1–3 DP

ENDING

After having been called to Sadaal, the PCs have survived the betrayal of Aremerat and the Syndicate. War is drawing near but there's still a moment of uncertainty about what will happen next. The Vestals have proved themselves servants of the dark between the stars and the people of Sadaal have fallen to the First Horizon. What remains to be done is to bring the delegates back to their fleets in Aiwaz and then try to rally the people in defense of the Third Horizon. More and more crews defect to the Emissaries at Xene, however, and the Syndicate's betrayal makes the other factions even less inclined to trust each other. The future looks bleak indeed.

DARK BIRTH

The end of the scenario might create a permanent tear in the fabric of space on Sadaal and the actions of the PCs could come to affect the next scenario a great deal:

- **Tear (9 DP):** If the PCs fail to disable the cadaver clock or if they actually manage to defeat the Vestal, a tear leading to the darkness between the portals may form at the cost of 9 DP. Like when they found the body of the Messenger Emissary in *Emissary Lost*, true darkness seeps in and takes shape. The being manifests slowly and is at first confined to the crypt or the top of the ziggurat, but will eventually grow and consume all of Alburz...
- **Rage of the Vestals:** The death of Ashaan-Unt on Sadaal may anger the rest of the First Horizon's agents so much that they step out from the shadows. As the GM, you might therefore choose to play the "Legacy of the Founders" mission (page 154) earlier than described in the text and awaken the sugar globes at the beginning of the war.

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THE MACHINE ICON'S SPEECH

Urni en-Argonnas, the Machine Icon who has become one with the PCs, now becomes their guide as they try to unite the peoples of the Horizon. When the PCs leave the system, they have a hypersleep dream where they once again encounter Urni standing on the fields of Argonnas.

"You are betrayed and broken but there is still light behind the storm clouds. My brothers and sisters see the children of the Horizon as their tools and minions. My parents see you as children who must never grow up. We must destroy them, pull up the roots to bring down the crown. In doing so, we will need all the help we can get. It's time for you to meet my first family, the temple under the pillars of the Horizon where only the lost wander. There, under the lotus, sits the Santulan who left it all behind to become one with the Horizon. We must visit Rima, the first Emissary, the Four who are One..."

ESCAPING SADAAL

The PCs can flee Sadaal at any time. They don't have to bring all of the delegates with them but how well they do will affect the coming scenario. As they retreat through alleys and tunnels, angry mobs of citizens may attack at any point (Mob combat, *The Last Cyclade*, page 220) or they could run into guard or Hadid patrols. The PCs' escape should remain an escape and not become a lengthy battle, however. Encourage them to find clever ways to avoid pursuing enemies. Leaving the planet can be accomplished using the martyr warriors' injector ships, aboard Birbasil's Dream (if they managed to steal it at the beginning of the chapter) or by stealing a ship in the spaceport. As they ascend through the atmosphere or on their way to the portal, Habathus Flotilla fighters may take up the chase.

THE NADIR FLOTILLA

"Your sensor screens are flooded with activity as you approach the portal station. The alarms going off inform you of hundreds of ships waiting around the star. White hulls gleam with gold ornaments and glyphs praising Zenith, Nadir and the glory of Ardha. Huge battleships are joined by flotillas of torpedo ships and destroyers from Bahram. The newly-constructed fleet now under First Horizon control is being crewed by humanites unloaded from the Waha-Najima bulk hauler orbiting Sadaal. The Nadir Flotilla is ready and now begins the war for the Third Horizon..."



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THE HORIZON WARS

Ardha's children, chained to history.
A dance with darkness and light.
In the broken Horizon,
where fire reigns and burns.
Despair, the final challenge,
and beyond it – the future.

THE DECREE OF RIMA, QUADRANT OF THE PILLAR, C54

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INTRODUCTION

In the final part of the **Mercy of the Icons** campaign, war breaks out and the PCs must lead the people of the Third Horizon to victory. They must disrupt the Symmetry's control and repel the fleets of the First Horizon, form alliances and use the mysteries of the Void as weapons in the war of all wars. Will they survive the test, or add their names to the martyr songs of coming generations?

IN THE HORIZON WARS, the PCs participate in battles and events that reshape the Third Horizon forever. Their sacrifices steer the course of the war and determine what remains when it's all over. From out of despair comes hope and the promise of a new era.

BACKGROUND

War is here. The PCs have fought the power hungry Zenithians, broken the Nazareem's Sacrifice, seen the true faces of the Emissaries and found both betrayal and unlikely new allies. They have become that which keeps the story and the Third Horizon together. The cluster's alliances must be strengthened to make the fleets ready for war with the Eternal Emperor. The Santulans' control over the new mystics must be broken, the exile of the Janhagir fleet must end and ancient weapon systems must once again be powered up. Time has come to determine the fate of the Third Horizon.

OVERVIEW

The Horizon Wars consists of a series of missions and space battles (War Turns) that lead to drastic changes to the Horizon. Depending on the PCs' level of success – if they succeed at all – their actions and choices control the outcome of the naval battles raging across the star map. The battles are fought with a new metagame ruleset described below, which can lead to the loss of entire fleets or even systems. As the GM, you determine when and if it is the right time to interject mini missions and adventures of your own between the War Turns, to alter the length of the Horizon Wars. From start to cataclysmic end, it may be anywhere from a few short segments to an entire cyclade.

THE TIDES OF WAR – PAGE 109

The factions' goals and motives determine their involvement and movements in the war. Below is a short summary of the outcomes of the different missions the PCs will undertake. The Horizon Wars will mainly take part along the Sadaal Route and the Dabaran Circle, with a strategic focus around Zalos, Mira and Kua. The Quadrant of the Pillar and the Algol Route are more or less out of harm's way.

The missions will lead to positional changes in the war, as the different factions win or lose territories. The outcome of the missions might also affect the scenario locations and starting situations of later scenarios, but practically all of the missions will fit in the game regardless, albeit with more or less modifications.

MINI MISSIONS – PAGE 119

There are multiple mini missions in the book for you to use as you like. Elaborate on these adventure seeds or events to turn them into proper missions to involve the PCs in the war directly – as tacticians, couriers, rescue parties or secret agents. The mini missions contain example bonuses for the players to use in the metagame, as well as proposed changes to how the war progresses.

SCENARIOS – PAGE 124

The War Turns are the backdrop for all the scenarios the PCs get involved in. They are contacted by old patrons or contacts within the different fleets, or find guidance in the dreams and wisdom of the Machine Icon – you determine what information they get and how it's shared

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with them. If appropriate to your story, they might take active in-game part in the strategizing of the fleets before the War Turns, but either way you should make the ebb and flow of the war present in the game and give the players a direct sense of how their actions affect the war. The end of the chapter describes the final mission that determines how the PCs end the war.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

For the ending of the *Mercy of the Icons* campaign, you need to prepare well and read up on the different stages of the Horizon Wars. Make sure you know the beginnings and outcomes of the scenarios and in which order they can be played. All NPC descriptions can be found in the events in which they are introduced. It should also be noted that even though many of the scenario locations are described in previously published products, sometimes in more detail, this book includes all you need in order to play the adventure.

PC INCENTIVES

Regardless of the backgrounds of the PCs they have become key assets for the factions and leaders of the Third Horizon, acting as advisors and agents capable of handling special operations – sometimes behind enemy lines.

IMPORTANT FACTS

Anchor the consequences of the PCs' action in the world as you play to give them a clear sense of how they affect the story. As the war is developing, some other events to include are:

- The Santulans' control over the new mystics tears the alliances of the Third Horizon asunder.
- The PCs need to travel to Xene to strike against the Santulans, but the weapon in the Quiet Zone is a potent threat.
- The PCs must aid the Zenithian fleet and the Order's blockade to avoid losing Dabaran.
- The sugar globes are the Vestals' secret weapon and will be used to plunge the Third Horizon into chaos and despair.
- The Armada of the Firstcome risks falling into enemy hands and must either be conquered or defended.
- The enormous fleets of the First Horizon are about to stabilize the Taoan portal fields and jump through in full force. They must be stopped in the final battle.
- The PCs need to decide if they will travel to the First Horizon and destroy the portals there, or sacrifice Kua and maim the Third Horizon forever.

THE METAGAME

The following pages describe a way for you and your group to play out the war in a metagame of fleet movements and clashes. This allows you to actively shape the war and the future of the Third Horizon, but feel free to engineer your own version of the war.

- Before the first scenario and in between all missions after that, play one metagame War Turn. Together with your players, resolve a battle on each of the fronts of the war.
- The players control the fleets of the Third Horizon – where they move, how they attack or defend, and which bonuses to use.
- You control the First Horizon and roll all dice for the invaders (see below). Unless the players move in to attack, the First Horizon will always try to advance.
- The metagame is for the whole group and the thoroughly described conflict phases (page 114) guide you through it. Move the fleets on the star map that came with this book.

APPENDIX: SPACECRAFT

The appendix at the end of this book (page 191) describes the stats of various ships taking part in the war, as enemies or allies of the PCs. The list adds to the ship table on page 160 of the Coriolis core rulebook and can be used as needed.

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STARTING CONFLICTS AND SCENARIOS IN THE HORIZON WARS



- S STARTING CONFLICTS
- 1:1 THE FIFTH SYSTEM (THE OXYGEN OASIS)
- 1:2 THE FIFTH SYSTEM (WELCOME TO SHINDA)
- 2 THE GHOSTS OF XENE (STATION FS-7)
- 3 THE LEGACY OF THE FOUNDERS (THE RIMWARD REACH)
- 4:1 THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (THE FALL AND REBIRTH OF AMSHAAR)
- 4:2 THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (THE BATTLE FOR KUA)
- 4:3 THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (THROUGH HAMURA)
- 4:4 THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (DARKNESS IN TAOAN)
- 4:5 THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (THE BATTLE OF AINION)

NPCS

The NPCs important to the various missions are described in the events in which they are introduced. An NPC index can be found at the end of the book.

DARKNESS POINTS

Each mission begins with the generation of new DP equal to the number of players, down to a minimum of 4 DP. If a Third Horizon fleet is forced to retreat, 2 new DP are generated and if it's defeated, you get 4 new DP.

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THE TIDES OF WAR

The balance of the war is determined by the movements and actions of the various fleets. The fleets move and act either while the PCs are off adventuring or as a direct result of their actions. The PCs' missions can be grand battles or mini scenarios comprising only one or a couple of events. The War Turns, during which the battles are resolved, lead to drastic changes in the cluster depending on the tides of the war.

THE WARS BEGIN

When the Horizon Wars begin, the factions of the Third Horizon are divided. Suspicious rumors and strife have come in the way of a joint strategy in case of a First Horizon invasion. Just before the first battle, the situation is as follows:

- **Sadaal:** The Nadir Flotilla is activated in Sadaal (see previous scenario).
- **Aiwaz:** Mira and Zalos strengthen their positions in Aiwaz.
- **Algebar:** The exiled Zenithian fleet in Amedo is forming a blockade toward Algebar to prepare for an attack on Rigel and Dabaran.
- **The Quadrant of the Pillar:** The Alabaster Council have isolated themselves from the rest of the Horizon but will be struggling to rally the nomad fleets as long as the Janhagir fleet is missing.
- **Kua and the Rimward Reach:** The peace in Kua is still upheld by Aqbar Rakiv Fatiman's Purple Guard and mercenary corsairs. After dramatic negotiations in the Horizon Council, however, parts of the Rimward Reach fleets are diverted to Algebar to assist the Zenithians.

SCENARIO SUMMARIES

The different missions are summarized briefly below. The "Requirements" column contains the narrative prerequisites for involving the PCs in the mission. The different possible outcomes and the consequences of the actions of the PCs are also described for each mission.

SCENARIO: THE FIFTH SYSTEM (PAGE 124)

REQUIREMENTS	EARLIER OUTCOME
The Tenth Icon (page 49)	The PCs have visited Sadaal and realized that the Vestals are involved and that the Nadir Flotilla is under First Horizon control.

FLEET POSITIONS

The fleets are present on various fronts when the war begins and have reinforcements waiting in their home systems. Use the star map as the game board for your metagame. The fleets begin in the locations described below and each have goals they want to accomplish:

THE FIRST HORIZON: The agents of the Eternal Emperor invade the Third Horizon from Dabaran, Taoan and Sadaal. They try to take control of the home systems of their enemies to wipe out all opposition. Dabaran and Taoan are replenished with ships that make it through the unstable Taoan portal, but the Nadir Flotilla in Sadaal has a fixed strength and may be routed and destroyed. Sporadic cells belonging to the Nazareem organize themselves in Odacon during the later part of the war (See Table 18).

THE SECOND HORIZON: The false Icons are assembling a disparate fleet of deserters and force their crews to perform suicide strikes to protect Hamura from the fleets in Taoan. The Emissaries' control over the mystics continues to sap the strength of the Third Horizon fleets through more mutinies.

THE THIRD HORIZON: The alliance between the larger fleets of the Third Horizon makes up the foundation of the cluster's defense. Whether or not the PCs manage to bring back the Janhagir fleet and assume control of the armada in the Mouth of Kandah will have a huge impact.

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WAR TURNS AND TIMELINE

A War Turn is made up of one PC mission (over one or more sessions) and a metagame phase where you resolve one battle on each front of the war. You can either use the metagame ruleset (page 112) or make up something of your own. We recommend that you let this closing chapter of the Mercy campaign contain at least the four main scenarios in this book plus three to four mini missions. Play the very first War Turn before your first scenario.

INTELLIGENCE NETWORKS

Reliable information is paramount to the war effort. The PCs can use their patron or their contacts to find out how things are going. The Draconites are hard at work in the shadows to steer the strategic decisions of the fleet commanders, and you can use agents from Aishan's Emporium or Ahlam's Temple as informants as well. Use NPCs the PCs know from earlier scenarios. More information about Aishan's Emporium can be found in *The Last Cyclade*.

The PCs travel to the Quadrant of the Pillar to visit Rima, the exiled Santulan hiding in Shinda, the secret fifth system of the quadrant. This is also where the Janhagir fleet and the Mogul elders have gone to seek guidance.

OUTCOME: The PCs' past and negotiation skills determine if the Janhagir fleet joins the war or not.

⚙ SCENARIO: THE GHOSTS OF XENE (PAGE 140)

REQUIREMENTS	EARLIER OUTCOME
Mystics capable of weakening the Emissaries' defenses	The PCs have recruited Rima the Santulan (The Fifth System) or Fahti the mystic (Harmony) and are able to weaken the weapon system.
A fleet under player control in the metagame joins in the attack	The PCs are unable to attack Xene on their own. An allied fleet of the players' choice can join in, trying to break through the defenses so the PCs can board FS-7.

As the Emissaries' influence grows from their base above Xene, more and more deserters join them. The PCs must use an allied fleet to break through the defenses of the Quiet Zone and then confront the Emissaries aboard station FS-7. The Machine Icon and their other allies help and protect them during the attack.

OUTCOME: The PCs' handling of the Emissaries determines how the blockade against Taoan fares and how the liberation of the puppeted mystics will go.

As long as the power of the Emissaries isn't broken, the fleets of the Third Horizon are considered "Overrun" and get a –2 to Strength in all battles (see page 114).

⚙ SCENARIO: THE LEGACY OF THE FOUNDERS (PAGE 154)

REQUIREMENTS	EARLIER OUTCOME
The Ghosts of Xene (page 140) or another mission outcome that has angered the Vestals	The PCs have either struck a deal with or defeated the Emissaries and thereby strengthened the fleets of the Third Horizon. They might also have interfered in a conflict somewhere and made the First Horizon worried about the success of their invasion plans.

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The Vestals activate the sugar globes and hashara swarms hatch in system after system to corrupt and enslave the people of the Third Horizon. Meanwhile, a coup is staged on Djachroum where hashara and mercenaries from the Yimen prospector clan try to conquer the station and form an alliance with the armies of the Eternal Emperor. In the ensuing chaos, Nazareem cultists enter the station's Forbidden Sector to find the keys to the Armada of the Firstcome. Who will the dormant warships in the Kandah cloud belong to – the First or the Third Horizon?

OUTCOME: The PCs' actions will determine the continued involvement of the Rimward Reach in the war, and whether or not the Armada of the Firstcome becomes a friend, an enemy or remains asleep. The aftermath of this scenario will affect how well Kua can withstand the invasion of the First Horizon.

⚙ SCENARIO: THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON (PAGE 168)

REQURIEMENTS	EARLIER OUTCOME
Earliest War Turn 6 or at some point after The Legacy of the Founders	The war is going poorly for the Third Horizon and at least one front has been pushed back all the way to Kua. The Imperial fleets seem endless and the Third Horizon won't be able to hold on for much longer.

The PCs have reached the end of the Horizon Wars. The scenario is divided into two parts and two War Turns. Part one contains luring parts of the First Horizon fleets to Zalos and activating the Order's ancient weapon systems. The second part sees the PCs attacking into Kua aboard an Order monastery cruiser together with the fleets of their surviving allies. They steer their ship toward their goal and fight to stay alive.

The enemy is constantly reinforced through Taoan and the PCs must destroy a monolith to stop the Emperor once and for all: either the one on Kua or one behind enemy lines in the distant First Horizon.

OUTCOME: The end of the war shapes the future of the Horizon. As the GM, you choose how your surviving Horizon evolves and what stories will be told on the ruined worlds. See the epilogue on page 185 for more information.



METAGAME LOG BOOK

Use the metagame sheet to keep track of the Strength and Reinforcements values of the various fleets as well as their current positions. See Tables 18 and 19 for information about the fronts and fleets.

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PLAYING THE METAGAME

In between PC missions, resolve a battle on each front every War Turn. The turn phases are described in Table 16. As the GM, make sure to keep notes of how the war is developing. The players will know how the war is going in detail, but you should make sure to introduce information to their PCs as well, to give them a chance to react to and act on the changes in the metagame.

During a War Turn, play through one battle at a time phase by phase (Table 16). The fleets' Conflict Goals (page 116) give you an idea of how they prioritize. When playing the First Horizon, stick to these goals, but give the players more room as they play the Third Horizon fleets – as long as they aren't wasteful with their precious few resources.

DISTRIBUTING DAMAGE TO STRENGTH

The person controlling the fleets that suffer damage distributes the damage as she likes. Damage suffered may be split between allied fleets, for example:

If the Order of the Pariah and Mira are blockading Aiwaz and suffer 2 points of damage, either one of them may lower their Strength by 2, or they may each lower their Strength by 1. Distributing damage wisely is key to keeping individual fleets from retreating or being destroyed.

FRONTLINE ALLIANCES

Tables 18 and 19 list what factions have formed wartime alliances and merged fleets. This is GM only information, to give you an idea of who is fighting who. The merged fleets cannot be split into smaller units.

TOTAL WAR

Each mission followed by a chance to act in the war is what makes up a War Turn. The length of the turn varies – form a few days for a mini mission up to whole segments. The fleets clash on the fronts, often in the form of a defender trying to maintain their blockade while the attacker attempts to somehow sabotage or weaken it and make it through the portal field.

You will play the metagame together with your players – deciding which fleets move where, how reinforcements are used and who goes on the offensive.

- The locations and stats for each fleet (Strength and Reinforcements) should be revealed to the players.
- During the first War Turn, the First Horizon always attacks the starting blockades of the Third Horizon.
- After that, the players assume control over the Third Horizon fleets and decide how and where they move, if they should merge, where to attack and where to blockade.

If your players wish to avoid taking big strategic decisions or if they aren't that into the metagame, you can play out the war on your own and simply summarize the important changes to them. Make sure they get to make some of the decisions, however.

⚙ THE SHIFTING METAGAME

- **War Turns:** The fronts change as the war rages and most large fleet movements happen while the PCs are away on a mission. In terms of battles, a War Turn consists of one battle on each front (or a nervous standoff in case both fleets are weak and awaiting reinforcements).
- **Movements:** The players decide where the fleets of the Third Horizon are needed the most to slow down the Imperial invasion.
- **Outcomes:** The actions of the PCs can give the fleets of their allies bonuses (or penalties) in coming War Turns.
- **Reinforcements:** Some fleets may be reinforced from their home systems, but if a fleet is routed and defeated completely, the remaining, unused reinforcements turn into refugee or mercenary fleets and no longer affect the war (if the Strength of a fleet drops to 0, so does its Reinforcements value).

⚙ THE PCS AS STRATEGISTS

If the PCs are faced with a difficult choice or a mission with an uncertain outcome, one of them may test COMMAND to gain a hint form the GM. For each of the other PCs with a skill

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level of at least 1 in COMMAND, the roll gains a +1. For each 6 rolled, a clue about the situation or possible outcome should be provided. As the GM, you decide how detailed your answers should be but an example can be: "If you manage to recruit Rima, it will be easier for you to get at the Emissaries at Xene."

STRENGTH AND REINFORCEMENTS

Each front must contain at least one active fleet. Each fleet has two stats, Strength and Reinforcements. The tables below list how much lost Strength may be recovered through Reinforcements. The fleets may be reinforced no matter where they are but always from their home systems. When Reinforcements is lowered, the Strength of the fleet is raised correspondingly. When you play out a fleet battle during a War Turn, use the total Strength of all allied fleets within the same system.

RETREAT AND REGROUPING

When an individual fleet is reduced to Strength 1, it retreats to avoid total destruction. The exception is when it is defending its home system, in which case it fights to the bitter end. At the end of the War Turn, all fleets with Strength 1 will regroup. This means that merchant captains, previous deserters, pensioned war veterans or warmongering corsairs join with the fleet to bolster its strength (Strength 1+1=2).

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TABLE 16: CONFLICT PHASES

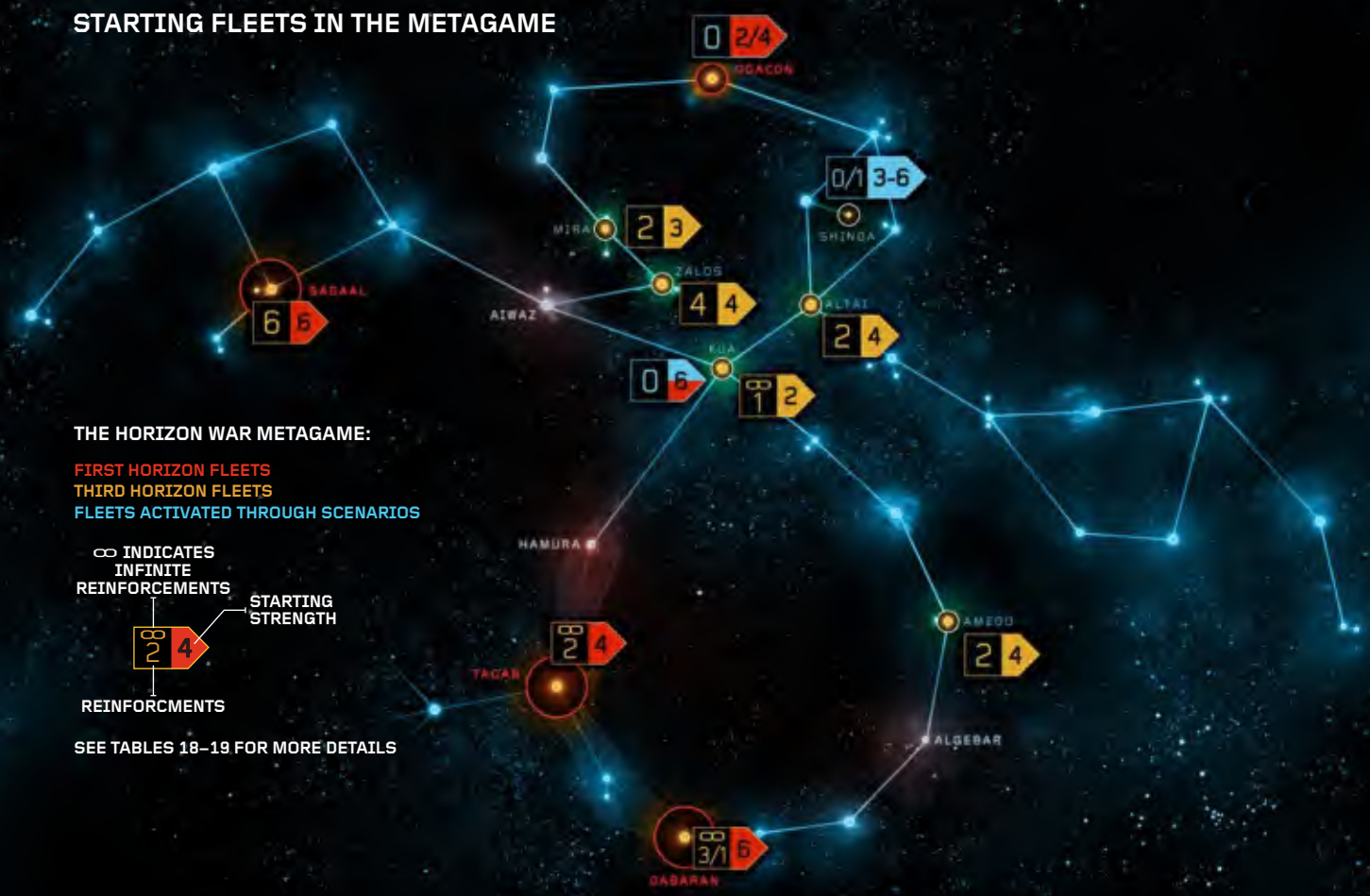
PHASE:	STEP:	DESCRIPTION:
1.1	REINFORCEMENTS ARRIVE (+/- Strength)	If any of the active fleets called for reinforcements, raise their Strength and lower their home system Reinforcements.
1.2	MANEUVERS (Attacker's movement)	The players decide if the fleets of the Third Horizon will attack or defend. Attacking fleets may move any number of jumps as long as they don't encounter resistance. The First Horizon will almost always try to attack unless the players do so first. The above applies unless: ◆ A lone fleet has a Strength of 1 or 2: It may await reinforcements or form a blockade regardless of which side it's on. ◆ A fleet has been reduced to Strength 1, Reinforcements 0: The fleet retreats back to its home system (unless cut off by blockading enemies).
1.3	ACTIONS (Both attackers and defenders)	Allied fleets fight together and total their Strength scores if in the same system. Remember their individual Strength scores when distributing damage, however (see below). The battle begins: ◆ System entry: Phase 2.1 through 2.4, once per battle. Engagement: Phase 3.1 through 3.4, repeated until battle is over.
2.1	EVENTS (Table 17)	Roll once on Table 17, COMBAT EVENTS. The attackers are already jumping through the portal and the outcome of the event cannot be avoided (unless the PCs have gained such an option through a mission).
2.2	BLOCKADE (Attacker's Strength –1)	If a system is defended by a fleet, the blockade lowers the Strength of the attackers by 1 as they enter. Closed systems with unstable portal fields (Dabaran and Taoan) may only be attacked as part of PC missions.
2.3	STRATEGY (D6 vs D6+2, Strength –1)	Each side rolls a die. The First Horizon always gets a +2 to their roll except when fighting a Third Horizon fleet in its home system, in which case the bonus instead goes to the Third Horizon. The side with the lowest roll suffers a -1 to Strength. In case of a tie, neither side suffers any damage.
2.4	OVERRUN (2 less Strength than opponent, –2 to Strength)	If one side's total Strength is at least 2 lower than its opponent, it suffers 2 points of damage (to be distributed among the active fleets). ◆ Until the Emissaries are defeated (see The Ghosts of Xene, page 140), all Third Horizon fleets are considered Overrun except for the mystic fleet at Hamura.
3.1	CONTACT (Strength –1)	Each side suffers 1 point of damage simultaneously. If multiple fleets are battling together, the controlling player chooses who suffers the damage. If the damage is more than 1 (see "Vicious fighting" in Table 17), it may be distributed between multiple fleets.
3.2	RETREAT (Strength 1)	If a fleet drops to Strength 1, it retreats to a system one jump away (though not into or through enemy units). If the fleet can't retreat or is already in its home system, it will fight until defeated or the enemy retreats. If both sides would retreat at the same time, the attackers leave the system and the defenders remain. After the retreat, all fleets that took part in the battle and that have Strength 1 regroup, meaning they get +1 in Strength before the next War Turn starts.
3.3	DEFEATED (Strength 0)	A fleet is considered defeated if it drops to Strength 0 before it has a chance to retreat (phase 3.2) or if it happens in its home system. The fleet is routed and any remaining Reinforcements are scattered or destroyed (Reinforcements also drop to 0). The First Horizon fleets invading from Dabaran and Taoan are exempt, however, as their resources appear endless. If such a fleet is defeated, replace them with a new attacking fleet at Strength 4 in their home system at the beginning of the following War Turn.
3.4	CONTINUED ASSAULT (Return to phase 3.1)	Repeat phases 3.1 through 3.4 until one side wins (by defeating or forcing their opponent to retreat).
4.1	EMERGENCY HAILS (If less than Strength 6)	When a battle is over, or if a fleet avoids combat during a turn altogether, the final phase of the turn allows all survivors to call in reinforcements from their home systems. ◆ A single fleet may never exceed Strength 6 at the beginning of a turn, except through events in Table 17: Combat Events. ◆ The First Horizon fleets always call for as many reinforcements as possible (see Table 18). ◆ The Third Horizon fleets may call for reinforcements up to a maximum of 2 points (players decide, 0–2 points if available) per turn. ◆ The reinforcements must have a clear route to their destination free from enemy fleets.

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TABLE 17: COMBAT EVENTS

3D6	EVENT	FRONT EFFECT
3	THE SERAFS	The Vestals rally followers in subjugated systems. In the next War Turn, all First Horizon fleets get 1 additional point of Strength in addition to any reinforcements called.
4	THE NAZAREEM	Nazareem cultists intercept the courier ship carrying the reinforcement orders. One random Third Horizon fleet may not call for reinforcements during phase 4.1 cannot be a fleet with Reinforcements 0).
5	DEVOTION	The Vestals attract new followers. The Third Horizon fleet suffers a -1 to Strength and the First Horizon get a +1.
6–7	PORTAL MISHAP	Ships are lost during a jump. The attackers loose 1 point of Strength (if more than one fleet, determine loss randomly).
8–9	PRECISION STRIKE	A flagship is targeted by a guerrilla strike. The side with the highest Strength total loses 1 point of Strength (determine loss randomly if equally strong).
10–11	DECOYS	A decoy attack using sensor probes confuses the defenders. Skip the BLOCKADE phase (2.2).
12–13	VICIOUS FIGHTING	Both sides lose 2 instead of 1 Strength during the first CONTACT of the turn (phase 3.1).
14–15	UNSTABLE PORTAL	The portals become unstable during the fighting. No side may RETREAT (3.2) until after at least two CONTACTS (3.1).
16	SECRET DATA	Informants manage to steal enemy data. Skip OVERRUN (2.4).
17	DESERTERS	Humanites break free from the Vestals' control. The First Horizon fleet suffers a –1 to Strength, the Third Horizon fleet gets a +1.
18	NEW RECRUITS	Mercenaries and refugees join the alliance. Distribute 3 points of extra Reinforcements between your choice of Third Horizon home systems. May re-raise a system's Reinforcements stat above 0 as long as its fleet remains.

STARTING FLEETS IN THE METAGAME



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TABLE 18: FIRST HORIZON FLEETS

HOME	FACTIONS	GOALS	STRENGTH	REINFORCEMENTS
Sadaal	**THE NADIR FLOTILLA:** ◆ The Nadir Flotilla ◆ The Habathus Flotilla	**AIWAZ, then ZALOS and MIRA.** ***Will move toward Kua through Odacon and the Quadrant of the Pillar if Zalos and Mira have been wiped out.***	6	6
Dabaran	**THE FIRST IMPERIAL INVASION FLEET:** ◆ The Dabaran Dar flotillas ◆ First Horizon ships ****) Endless reinforcements. Up until Kua, they get 3 points per turn – farther away than that, only 1 point.***	**KUA and then ZHAU.** ***Will only continue toward Mira and Zalos after all fleets of the Quadrant of the Pillar have been defeated. Will take the Odacon route to Mira if undefended.***	6	3/1*
Taoan	**THE VESTALS' SLAVE FLEETS:** ◆ Butterfly ships from the First Horizon ◆ Taoan and Uharu's colonist fleets (with surviving Order ships) ****) This fleet's conflict with the Emissaries doesn't use the regular War Turn rules. The fleets are considered equal and will fight for Hamura until the PCs have played "The Ghosts of Xene" (See "Outcome", page 152).***	**HAMURA and then KUA** *****) Infinite reinforcements at 2 points/turn***	4*	**
Kua	**THE ARMADA OF THE FIRSTCOME:** ◆ The Armada of the Firstcome (from the Mouth of Kandah) ***"The Legacy of the Founders" may result in this fleet belonging to the Third Horizon instead.***	***If the fleet falls under First Horizon control, the GM chooses a goal from one of the other Imperial fleets.***	6	0
Odacon	**THE NAZAREEM'S SACRIFICE:** ◆ Local Nazareem cells ◆ Mercenaries and corsairs ***The Nazareem show up behind enemy lines and may strike against unprotected home systems. If either of the Order or Miran fleets are alive, the Nazareem will focus on attacking their home worlds. If the Nazareem reach the systems without combat, they use the next War Turn to reduce the Reinforcements value of the system they're attacking to 0. If both Mira and the Order have been defeated, the Nazareem head for Kua instead.***	**ZALOS or MIRA / KUA** ****) The fleet of the Nazareem shows up if the Third Horizon manages to fight off an attack on Kua or Altai. If the PCs completed all of the Nazareem scenarios in The Last Cyclade and defeated the cells featured in them, the Nazareem fleet has its Strength reduced to 2. If any of the cells survived, the fleet has Strength 4 (GM decides).***	2/4*	0

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TABLE 19: THIRD HORIZON FLEETS

HOME	STARTS IN	DESCRIPTION	STRENGTH	REINFORCEMENTS
Zalos	Aiwaz	**THE FLEETS OF THE ORDER OF THE PARIAH:** ◆ The Martyr Flotilla ◆ The Salam Flotilla	4	4
Mira	Aiwaz	**THE MIRAN FLEET:** ◆ The Miran defense fleet ◆ The Honorary Legion of Zhau	3	2
Amedo	Algebar	**THE ZENITHIAN EXILE FLEET:** ◆ Surviving Hegemony fleet squadrons ◆ Ex-Legion flotillas	4	2
Kua	Algebar	**THE PURPLE GUARD:** ◆ The Djachroum Purple Guard ◆ Rimward Reach corsairs ◆ Rimward Reach nomad swarms ◆ Ex-Legion flotillas ***) The Purple Guard get a +1 to Strength every turn as more corsairs and mercenaries join the war. If defeated, the fleet regroups in Kua at Strength 1 in the following turn. The fleet is disbanded if Djachroum falls to the allies of the Vestals during "The Legacy of the Founders" (page 154).***	2	*
The Quadrant of the Pillar	Altai	**THE NOMAD FLEET:** ◆ The corsairs of Khorsabad ◆ The swarms of the Quadrant of the Pillar Ex-Legion flotillas ***) The fleet has the entire Quadrant as its home system in terms of strategic advantages and reinforcements. May retreat into any Quadrant system if reduced to Strength 1.***	4	2*
The Quadrant of the Pillar	Sivas	**THE JANHAGIR FLEET:** ◆ The Mogul swarms ◆ The swarms of the Quadrant of the Pillar ***) The fleet becomes player controllable if the PCs manage to convince the Mogul elders during "The Fifth System" (page 124). Otherwise, it remains in exile. You can either set its Strength to 5 or have the result of the PCs' persuasion attempts determine its value (page 134).*** ****) The fleet has the entire Quadrant as its home system in terms of strategic advantages and reinforcements. May retreat into any nearby system if reduced to Strength 1.***	3–6*	0–1**
Kua	Kua	**THE ARMADA OF THE FIRSTCOME:** ◆ The Armada of the Firstcome (from the Mouth of Kandah) ***Player controllable if the fleet falls under Third Horizon control. If so, it begins in Kua.***	6	0

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METAGAME PHASE EXAMPLES

Each War Turn contains one battle per front against the First Horizon. The example below involves the Order and Miran fleets, after the players decide to pool their resources (Strength 4 and 3) in Aiwaz to defend against the attack of the Nadir Flotilla (Strength 6).

⚙ WAR TURN 1

- (1.1) No reinforcements arrive during the first War Turn.
- (1.2) Aiwaz is already under blockade. The Nadir Flotilla moves from Sadaal to Errai and attacks into Aiwaz (1.3).
- (2.1) The GM rolls a 12 on Table 17 and reads the "Vicious Fighting" entry. Both sides will suffer worse losses during the first Contact of this turn.
- (2.2) The Nadir Flotilla jumps through the portal and engages the defenders' blockade. The attackers lose 1 point of Strength (Strength 6–1=5)
- (2.3) The strategies of the fleet commanders determine how well they anticipated the enemy's actions. Each side rolls one die. As no one is in their home system, the Nadir Flotilla gets a +2. Both Horizons roll and total a 4 – a tie. No one loses any additional Strength.
- (2.4) The defenders' Strength total is 7 and the attackers have 5. This would normally mean the attackers lose 2 points of Strength, but as the Emissaries still cause massive mystic mutinies from Third Horizon ranks, their fleets are considered Overrun. The Third Horizon fleets lose 2 points of Strength and the players decide to split it between the two fleets (the Order Strength 4–1=3, Mira Strength 3–1=2).
- (3.1) The first Contact phase of the turn starts with both sides at Strength 5. The roll on Table 17 above means the intense fighting leads to 2 points of Strength loss for both attackers and defenders. The Nadir Flotilla lowers its Strength from 5 to 3. The players don't want to lose any of their fleets and divide the losses between them (the order Strength 3–1=2, Mira Strength 2–1=1).
- (3.2) The Miran fleet is down to Strength 1 and retreats into Zalos to regroup and avoid being defeated. They recover 1 point of Strength and are back at Strength 2. The Order fleet is left alone to defend Aiwaz.
- (3.4, 3.1) A new Contact is played out, and both sides lose 1 point of Strength (Nadir Strength 3–1=2, the Order Strength 2–1=1).
- (3.2) The Order can no longer defend Aiwaz and retreat to their home system of Zalos. They regroup there and recover 1 point of Strength for a total of 2. The Nadir Flotilla now controls Aiwaz.
- (4.1) All fleets now call for reinforcements. The Nadir Flotilla requests 3 points and will be down to Reinforcements 3 in the coming turn (6–3=3). The Order requests 2 points, lowering their Reinforcement value from 4 to 2. Mira also requests 2 points and depletes their home system Reinforcements (2–2=0).

"The Nadir Flotilla has attacked Aiwaz. The vicious fighting first broke the Miran fleet, forcing it to flee, and continued to decimate the Order fleet, dissolving the blockade and winning the system for the First Horizon. If it hadn't been for the mystic mutinies, maybe the admirals of the Third Horizon could have defended better against the invasion."

⚙ WAR TURN 2 (AFTER THE FIRST SCENARIO)

- *"The PCs can either use the Janhagir fleet to attack Xene and stop the Emissaries from puppeteering any more mystics or choose to reinforce Zalos. They leave Zalos and Mira to their fates and focus on the Emissaries."*
- (1.1) Reinforcements arrive from Zalos and Mira. Both fleets are reinforced by 2 points and reach Strength values of 4. The Nadir Flotilla is also reinforced by 3 points and reaches Strength 5.
- (1.2) The Third Horizon fle ets choose to stay in Zalos. The Nadir Flotilla attacks.
- (2.1) The GM rolls an 8 on Table 17. A surprise attack catches the stronger side off guard! The defenders have a joint Strength of 8 and the attackers a total of 5. The GM decides that a group of Nazareem cultists take out a Miran flagship just as the turn begins, taking away 1 point of Strength from the fleet (Mira Strength 4–1=3).
- (2.2) The Nadir Flotilla jumps through the portal into Zalos and engages the blockade. The attackers lose 1 Strength (Strength 5–1=4).
- (2.3) Once again, the strategists attempt to predict the enemy's tactics. Each side rolls a die. Because the Order of the Pariah are in their home system, they get a +2 to their

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roll. Both sides roll a 4 but because of the bonus, the Third Horizon wins with a total of 6. The Nadir Flotilla loses 1 more point of Strength and is now down to Strength 3.

- (2.4) The defenders total Strength 7 (Order 4 + Mira 3) and the attackers only 3. The attackers are due for more damage, but as the Emissaries are still active, the Third Horizon is considered Overrun and loses 2 points of Strength. Since the Order fleets are already in their home system and cannot escape anyway, the players choose them to suffer the whole loss (Strength 4–2=2).
- (3.1) Contact. Both the attackers (Strength 3) and the defenders (Strength 5) lose 1 point of Strength, leaving the Nadir Flotilla at Strength 2 while the players opt to reduce the Order fleet to Strength 1.
- (3.2) No fleet is retreating, since the Nadir Flotilla and the Miran fleet have more than Strength 1, while the Order fleet (which is at Strength 1) can't retreat from its home system.
- (3.4, 3.1) Second Contact. Both sides lose 1 point of Strength; the Nadir Flotilla is reduced to Strength 1 (Strength 2–1=1), and the players choose to lower the Strength of the Miran fleet to 2 (Strength 3–1=2).
- (3.2) The Nadir Flotilla is unable to continue its assault and retreats into Aiwaz where it regroups and restores 1 point of Strength (for a total of Strength 2). The defending fleets remain – the Order has Strength 1 and regroups (1+1=2), while the Miran fleet is at 2 and does not regroup. The Zalosian defense didn't break.
- (4.1) The fleets call for reinforcements. The Nadir Flotilla calls for their remaining 3 points, dropping their Reinforcements value to 0. The Order request 2 points, also depleting their Reinforcements. The Miran fleet is already at Reinforcements 0.

"The Nadir Flotilla has attacked Zalos. A strike against a Miran flagship gave the defenders a tough start, but the martyr warriors came resolutely to their aid and turned the tides toward victory. The Nadir Flotilla was forced to retreat back through the portal after suffering devastating losses. It's time for the Third Horizon to launch a counter attack and perhaps defeat one of the invading First Horizon fleets altogether..."

FURTHER WAR TURNS

The examples above describe a potential way of playing the first two War Turns as the PCs are heading to the Quadrant of the Pillar to find the oracle Rima. The outcomes of their adventures have already started to affect the war. The above describes only one front, however, and it soon becomes clear that the hijacked Dabaran fleet has been used to drive away the exiled Zenithians and threatens to crush Amedo. Are the Zenithians in greater need of the newly returned Janhagir fleet than the Order? What will happen when the Emissaries can't fight off the invasion in Hamura any longer? Some people claim to have seen First Horizon agents traveling the song routes of the Rimward Reach to meet with the leaders of the prospector clans...

As the GM, present your players with a multitude of paths to follows and hard, potentially world-ending, choices.

MINI MISSIONS

To establish the Horizon Wars as truly great and apocalyptic – and also to make sure that the preferences and expertise of your players and their PCs get enough room – there are mini missions to play in-between the main scenarios. They shouldn't contain more than one or a couple of events, such as a new location, a fight and some negotiating. Below is a short list of missions that can have a smaller, but still valuable, impact on the war as a whole.

TO TASTE

The mini missions are all optional and should only be played for added depth. They allow for more varied play between the main scenarios to give the PCs more insights into both the consequences of the metagame and the situations for the various fleets.

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SHORE LEAVE

The War Turns take weeks or sometimes a whole segment. Let the PCs use the time between missions to rest up on allied portal stations or bases. Let them receive medical care, get their ship repaired and be met by rumors from the front.

THE MISSIONS

A mini mission – including travel and rest – always takes one War Turn. The mini missions described in this book are listed below, but feel free to create your own:

- The Blood of the Zenithians – below
- Harmony – below
- The Admiral – page 122
- Blitz – page 122
- The Gauntlet – page 122
- A Ravenous Dark – page 123

THE BLOOD OF THE ZENITHIANS

The domes shake under the enemy bombardment. The forest on the slopes of the Alantide Mountains is burning as more and more ships leave the spaceport and the evac zones. Fortunes change hands as wealthy families buy their way to first in line for passage off-world. Artifacts and family heirlooms recently returned to their former owners from the ruins of Coriolis are left behind to be buried under the collapsing palaces. Survival is the only thing that matters for the Zenithians now.

THE SITUATION

The Zenithians' exile fleet is about to be destroyed by the enslaved Dabaran dar flotillas. First Horizon ships fresh from the Void strengthen the attack. The enemy has reached Amedo and the Zenithian bloodlines are threatened. Expatriate and Zenithian refugees are evacuated from the dome city of Xhi.

THE MISSION

The PCs could either lead a fleet into the system to try to hold off the attackers or assist with the evacuation. They might have come to rescue their own family or the relatives of someone close to them.

OUTCOME

- If they rescue any prominent Zenithian leaders, they get a +1 to Reputation.
- If the evacuation goes well, the players get 2 extra points of Reinforcements to distribute among the Third Horizon fleets as the exiled Zenithian captains begin cooperating with the other fleets more.
- If the PCs hear about the evacuation but choose not to visit Amedo until later, a large portion of the Zenithian fleet is already destroyed and the PCs may only attempt to rescue the leaders (see the first bullet above).

HARMONY

As you enter, you hear the chanting of praying acolytes fill the room. The glow of the sugar globes in the wall niches falls on red carpets laid out over the stone basement floor.

"Can you feel the call of the Emissaries fading? You are safe here and may remain safe if you share your wealth with us. Before the truth, we are all equal."

The old man stands before you wrapped in silk, gold patterns snaking up his arms. He signs at you to sit down before a curtain hanging from the ceiling in the middle of the room. This is the veil that separates you from the holy guru – from Fahti the Farseer...

THE SITUATION

All through the Quadrant of the Pillar and the Miran clergy, a rumor is spreading – a rumor about a new cult

THE LENGTH OF THE WARS

As the GM, you decide if you play a metagame War Turn for every mission (including mini missions) or if you do it only for the main scenarios. We recommend that you begin the final scenario in War Turn 7. You can wait longer of course, but after War Turn 10, the Third Horizon fleets will likely have been decimated beyond any hope of winning the war. The desperate atmosphere of almost certain death might be an interesting backdrop for the final scenario, however.

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called the Voice of the Truth. In the Ash Belt of Odacon, a mystic by the name of Fahti the Farseer has attracted a growing number of followers. Through his powers, his flock is said to be protected from the call of the false Emissaries. Could he be the key to defeating the Santulans at Xene?

THE MISSION

The PCs are looking for Fahti to understand his powers and possibly to ask for his help against the Emissaries. The guru they seek turns out to be a ten year old boy with mighty powers being held captive by the cult forming around him. His uncle heads the growing cult which attracts mystics with both real and imagined powers. The followers pay Fahti's uncle for the boy's powers and the cultists are terrified of once again falling prey to the Song of the Emissaries.

OUTCOME

- If Fahti accompanies the PCs (voluntarily or otherwise), he can help them weaken the Emissaries' defenses at Xene (see "The Ghosts of Xene", page 140).
- If the PC bring Fahti along on their journeys instead of using him to defeat the Emissaries, they get one reroll on Table 17: Combat events, after having played "The Ghosts of Xene").
- If the PCs leave Fahti in the hands of the cult, they may allow one fleet in the metagame to retreat and regroup in Odacon before the first Contact phase of the turn, regardless of its Strength value. The route to Odacon must be clear of enemies.

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THE ADMIRAL

"If it's me they want, I'll take them all with me in death. Their efforts will mean nothing and we will come out stronger."

The admiral turns back toward the bridge monitors to look at the enemy sensor echoes that draw nearer like a swarm of locusts with no other purpose but to destroy.

THE SITUATION

A successful fleet admiral has managed to hold the line against the Imperial invasion and is growing her ranks. She is on her way to meet up with additional flotillas to prepare for the next battle but is attacked en route. Enemy agents try to sabotage her ship. The admiral is prepared to fight until death if necessary.

THE MISSION

Agents either from Aishan's Emporium or the Astûrban have figured out the enemy's plans to attack the admiral's ship to demoralize her followers. The PCs are nearby and might get there in time to stop the attack, mislead the enemy or perhaps evacuate the admiral from the doomed ship. It might be difficult to rescue someone intent on dying at her post, however.

OUTCOME

- The admiral survives, perhaps even together with her ship. The victory bolsters morale and the recruitment offices overflow. Instead of a War Turn event roll on Table 17, the players may choose the "Deserters" entry.
- If the admiral dies, the next Third Horizon fleet to drop to Strength 2 in the metagame must retreat after the first Contact.

BLITZ

The dimly lit cargo hold flickers as the freighter passes through the portal field. The pale light falls on row upon row of stasis beds and lines of combat exos whirring softly in alcoves in the walls. In the darkness outside the dura glass of the airlock, termite destroyers glisten ominously. The fighter escort swarms like Miran sawflies around their nest, ready to defend the precious cargo against any and all threats.

THE SITUATION

Agents from Dabaran have managed to smuggle out data about reinforcement orders. The First Horizon is about to bolster its boarding parties of assault troopers with a new batch of Hadid humanites in combat exos from Uharu. Several freighters are heading for the front, escorted by torpedo ships and a small fighter squadron.

THE MISSION

The PCs lead an attack behind enemy lines with the goal of taking out the new assault troopers. They need a small, quick team to jump in undetected and strike without the battleships in the nearby system being alerted. No probes must be allowed to leave the system…

OUTCOME

- If the ships are destroyed, the nearest enemy fleet gets only 1 point of their requested Reinforcements during this War Turn.
- If the ships are hijacked, the above applies in addition to the players getting to raise the home system Reinforcements value of one of their fleets by 1 point.
- If the attack fails, the nearest enemy fleet gets full reinforcements.

THE GAUNTLET

The torn remains of a courier ship drift through the night in the shadow of the portal station. Dead bodies silhouetted against the bright star after the impact of the fractal torpedo. A patient, shell-covered shape floats nearby – a chrysalis waiting for shining wings to unfold and doom the next victim foolish enough to use the portal.

THE SITUATION

Communications between the Third Horizon fleets are in shambles due to constant enemy attacks. Courier ships and probes are being taken out and it's becoming harder and harder to coordinate attacks or request fresh reinforcements. The Vestal butterfly ships prowl the darkness around the portals like lions on the savannah.

THE MISSION

The PCs must deliver a message to an allied fleet fighting at the front. On their way there, a butterfly ship ambushes them. The ensuing chase takes them through both portal fields and asteroid belts.

OUTCOME

- The PCs bring the vital message to the front. One fleet of the players' choice gets to retreat from a system before

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any combat and get a +2 to Strength in addition to any reinforcements requested.

A RAVENOUS DARK

The helmet lights illuminate empty corridors and slowly drifting soot in the air. What looked like the result of an evacuation soon turns out to be something else entirely. Scraping echoes, burn marks and holes from tiny legs on the walls, twisted bodies and gutted exos await you in the darkness…

THE SITUATION

An important portal station, naval base or flagship goes silent as swarms of hashara hatch and spread across the Horizon. Sensor logs or an emerald disc with information about what has happened must be recovered from the site. The mission can be used as a dark premonition to "The Legacy of the Founders" (page 154) or as a later mission to emphasize the dangers of the hashara swarms (page 156).

THE MISSION

The PCs locate the site – possibly together with a strike team for backup – and find it completely dark and dead, slowly falling toward a nearby planet or into an asteroid belt. Inside, they find mangled corpses, darkbound and perhaps something even worse…

OUTCOME

- The sensor logs contain vital information about the hatching of the sugar globes. What initially looks like just white noise turns out to be an encrypted data sequence, transmitted from probes secretly spread around the Third Horizon by the Vestals. The command activates a chemical reaction inside the sugar globes but it takes time to spread. The signal can be jammed to protect the allied fleets from the influence of the darkness. An allied fleet automatically Overruns (phase 2.4) their First Horizon enemies in one battle. Players choose which fleet and when.

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SCENARIOS

Aysha Dari-Akheem looks out across the temple city of Lotus toward the spaceport below. The humble dwellings of the pilgrims and the city's temples lie empty.

"Tarek, look. Even the grazing desdemodu have abandoned us. Dabaran is now a planet enslaved by the Serafs. Our ships will depart for the stars to rain death and destruction over our Zenithian and Firstcome brothers and sisters. You and I remain unmoved by their commanding words – our mystic's disease dooms us to watch our people's demise."

Beyond the ancient spires of the temple city, grav projectors blacken the granite of the spaceport and the sky is filled with the collected fleets of Dabaran leaving the desert to win the Third Horizon for Ardha and the Emperor.

WAR HAS BEGUN and the PCs look for allies beyond the known systems to turn the tide and win back their Horizon. The legends have long spoken of friends in exile and the mysterious whereabouts of the Janhagir fleet. Time has come to make war for the future of the Third Horizon.

SCENARIO:

THE FIFTH SYSTEM

The aging clan leader draws a crooked finger along the lines on the star map, eyes red from the opor mists and lips wet from cheap wine. Black rings cover the skin in the tradition of the Moguls – one for every family who chose exile in the Third Horizon.

"Altai, Ordana, Zhau and Sivas. The pillars supporting the temple of our new civilization. The way in and the way out. Riches beyond our wildest dreams. This is where our new world was truly born, removed from the oppressive regimes of the old horizons. We are the moguls, destined to lead the way into the future and to protect our paradise at the center of the temple – the Quadrant's beating heart: Shinda."

OVERVIEW

The Machine Icon and the martyr warriors the PCs met on Sadaal spoke about the need for new alliances. The oracle of the nomads, the exiled Santulan who renounced the Second Horizon, has joined forces with the Third Horizon. The Janhagir fleet is missing, but despite intense Zenithian propaganda during *The Last Cyclade*, rumors persist about their exile being voluntary. The time has come for the PCs to find the Moguls and form a new alliance for the future.

PC INCENTIVES

The PCs might either get involved in the search for Rima, the mystic guru, through dreams from the Machine Icon or through a patron or ally within one of the other factions. The Draconites, Ahlam's Temple and the Astûrban have all heard rumors through their agents about the closed fifth system and the nomads' star keys believed to activate a dead portal somewhere in the Quadrant of the Pillar. Depending on which factions the PCs have had dealings with in the past, the representatives reaching out to them can vary.

When you decide who this character will be, consider NPCs the heroes rescued at the end of *The Last Cyclade* as well as older contacts. The person should also be able to provide the PCs with information about the Nadir Flotilla's imminent attack and the blockades in Aiwaz and Algebar. Stress the growing concern for the

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spreading mystic mutinies that lead to deserters heading for the new fleet gathering at Xene.

ALTAI AND KHORSABAD

Altai is the gateway to the Quadrant of the Pillar and home to several mighty lords, merchant houses and corsair clans with their roots among the first nomad swarms to arrive from the Second Horizon. The Quadrant of the Pillar has seen large civilizations rise and fall many times since the systems were colonized and old grudges die hard here. If it wasn't for the Alabaster Council, the governing body of the corsair fortress Khorsabad on the dwarf planet of Marakanda, the different clans in the Quadrant would be openly at war with each other. The emerald green domes, bunkers and spires of Khorsabad tower above the ruins from the civil war that reduced the city state of Marakanda to ashes. Bright light from the star filters in through the thick domes and bathes the city below in a green glow that only trained eyes can handle properly. Newcomers are therefore easy to spot as they often cover their eyes with glasses or visors.

Khorsabad is a wild city where corsairs, free traders and birr-laden merchants trade in everything from ore and natural gas to slaves and fine art. The city has one of the Quadrant's finest shipyards and is brimming with workshops and machine halls ready to service or butcher a salvaged wreck. Skippers with enough money can find both illegal weapon systems and other shady ship modules here.

The city has about 85,000 residents and around 10,000 visitors at any one time. The Alabaster Guard keeps the peace, but visitors without acknowledged social standing, a respectable lineage or a personal invitation from one of the clans of the Alabaster Council should make their own security arrangements. Bodyguards can be hired in the spaceport, but who knows if their loyalty has already been bought by someone else?

SIVAS

Sivas is a neglected corner system in the Quadrant of the Pillar. Traders and colonists rarely visit and the few, barren worlds found there are hardly worth the efforts to colonize by the expansionists in what used to be the Colonial Agency. The only frequent visitors to the system are corsair patrols from the larger clans or the Moguls' Janhagir fleet. The Kala gas giant is about to fall into the star which threatens to collapse the portal fields and isolate the system completely

DREAMS OF THE QUADRANT

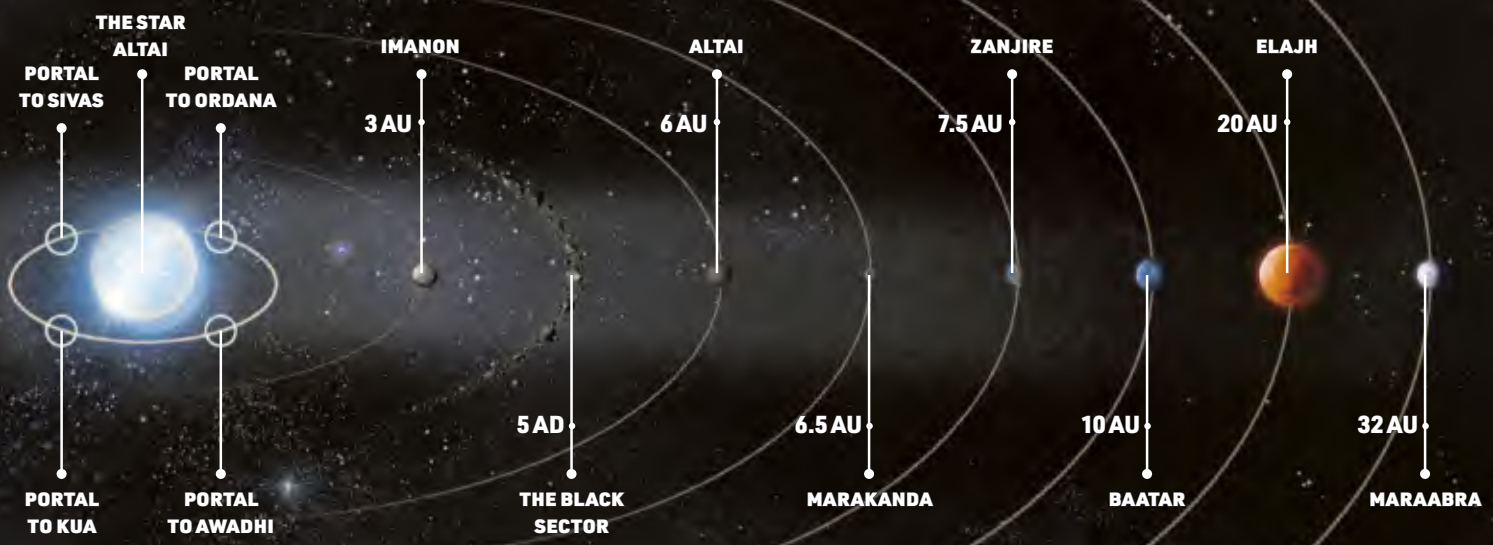
When our children left our home,
they found new ones under the roof of the Quadrant.
Built empires.
Our children grew up and grew old.
Together, they shelter the heart of the Quadrant.
Seek the elders to find the key.
The Moguls are the way in, the way to Rima.

THE MACHINE ICON

THE BLACK SECTOR

Khorsabad orbits at 6 AU from the star but before reaching it, all new arrivals must first pass through the asteroid cloud that separates the portals from much of the rest of the system. The cloud contains an ancient defense system left behind by the first colonists. Torpedo rooms, stasis chambers full of waiting personnel, fighter ships and devastating warheads lie hidden in countless crevices throughout the cloud. The way through the asteroids is usually the Yamuna or Tang Gol route and passage will cost you dearly unless you have been personally invited by one of the council families.

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within the near future. The fall of Kala has affected the orbit of the other planets in such a way that they today are even more hostile than they used to be.

The lonely, rocky planet of Sivas is rumored to contain a wealthy vein of mineable bauxite but the weapons of the Moguls protect it from exploitation. Sivas' moon, Karast, is home to the system's largest population. The ten families rumored to have been the system's original settlers still remain, governing the moon through a patriarchal brotherhood known as the Sowers. They worship only three Icons: the Judge, the Lady of Tears and the Faceless and find them represented in Sivas by its three ice planets Nurija, Gamhija and Comija, a trinity on the far reaches of the system. The Sowers and the recently arrived Lotus Brothers rule the planet with an iron fist and have banned all forms of calendars. The Lotus Brothers determine the date and time of year by intermittent decrees but most farmers secretly measure the sun's height above the horizon to know when to reap and sow anew.

SHINDA

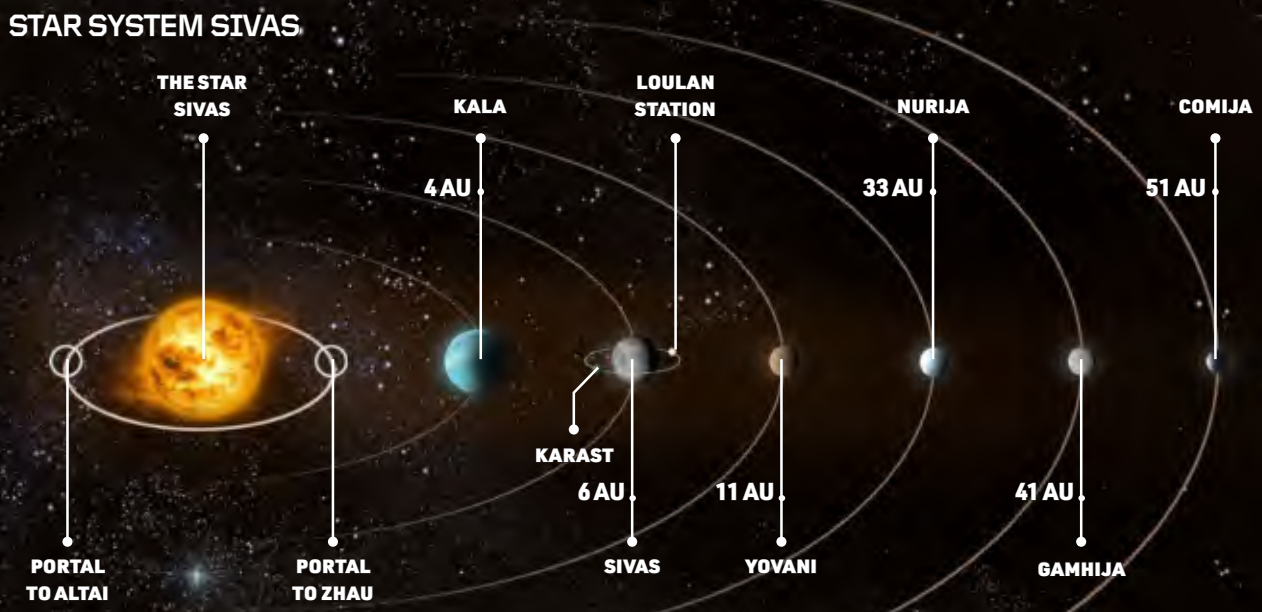
Behind one of Sivas' seemingly dead portals, the fifth system of the Quadrant of the Pillar can be found. It's never spoken of and both the Alabaster Council and the larger nomad clans in other systems have put people to death merely for mentioning its name. Adventurous captains looking for the mythical system out in the darkness go missing under strange circumstances. Aging drunks can recount the stories of Mogul crews sworn to keeping the heart of the Quadrant a secret from the rest of the Horizon.

THE ORDER OF RIMA

The rumors are indeed true. Shinda contains a remnant of the original settlers' holy temple city, Ghûl-Sian, located on the system's single planet, a moon wandering the dying star. It's believed that many of the great nomad leaders and rulers of past civilizations were taken to Shinda aboard the Moguls' burial ships. Their final resting place is rumored to be a mausoleum referred to by nomad elders as the Valley of the Lotus.

Around the fertile lowlands and their ceremonial stone formations, lotus fields and ever-blooming cherry trees are several smaller pagodas and round huts. These belong to the ascetics and acolytes formerly known as the Keepers but who changed their name to the Order of Rima about forty cycles before the arrival of the Zenith.

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THE FOUR WHO ARE ONE

The Order of Rima is a secret society that protects the legacy and history of the nomads. They found their long-awaited prophet in Rima en-Aldaan, the Santulan who left her body in the Second Horizon to give herself to the families of the long-since exiled nomads. Her fragmented mind now inhabits four mystic gurus and bestows eternal wisdom on the sworn-in nomad elders who seek her advice. The four ascetics carrying Rima are regarded as one entity and their collected knowledge passes into a new acolyte when one of them dies. Only the most prestigious nomad clans are allowed to send their family members as acolytes to the order. Serving as a vessel for Rima is considered the highest honor possible for a member of the order.

THE MISSION

The PCs are tasked with finding the enlightened mystic rumored to be somewhere in the Quadrant of the Pillar. This person's powers are apparently strong enough to resist the Emissaries and liberate the mystics from slavery. The rumors about the guru contain many warnings and those who go looking for the fifth system of the Quadrant of the Pillar might become targets for more than just threats. The PCs must begin by making their voices heard among the nomads to attract the attention of someone who understands the importance of allowing them to visit Rima.

MAJOR EVENTS

The events in this scenario begin with the search for a way into the fifth system and end with the PCs finding the Janhagir fleet and Rima in the lost temple city in Shinda. Most of the complications happen either early or when the PCs return to known space again (see Minor events, page 138).

THE MOGUL DESCENDANT

To begin with, the PCs need to find someone who knows the way into Shinda. They might already have a suitable contact who can put in a good word for them (requires a talent connected to a nomad faction), or they can ask around by testing CULTURE. A Firstcome PC gets a –1 to the roll, a Zenithian –2 and a nomad PC gets a +1. A successful roll gives them a name and location:

- **Arban Ghôl-Bataar:** The ninety-three year old captain of the Ravan Bataar family ship and former clan elder of the Bataari swarm until he was replaced by his daughter Dureena (who is herself already seventy). Arban is in good

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health but has always had a soft spot for opor and the potent Altaian chewing tobacco known as Khar.

- **Param's Cantina:** You can place the cantina anywhere in the Quadrant of the Pillar – on a busy portal station, among the Khorsabad chai houses and gambling halls or in a colony run by one of the wealthier clans. One level below the commotion of the street, a velvet drapery separates the outside world from Param Nadiv's infamous cantina. Scarred veterans and new arrivals crowd around the gambling tables and spend long nights hunched over the engraved game boards. Pillows and rugs cover the floor and birr or precious metals change hands in the dim lights from hand blown glass spheres filled with sugar globes and syrupy water.

A failed roll might give the PCs the location but not the name and gives you as the GM a good opportunity to use the "A Warning" event (page 138). Asking around about an aging Mogul descendant in the cantina is difficult and requires a MANIPULATION test. The outcome of the roll determines how much money the answers will cost them, from 50 birr (critical success) to 500 (failed roll).

When the PCs eventually find the former clan leader in a dark corner, they can engage him in a slurred conversation:

- **Exploitation:** He talks at length about the Zenithian exploitation of the Quadrant and about how the Mogul fleet used to be the Horizon's only hope during the Long Night after the Portal Wars. The fleet's star seers were the only ones who could master the volatile portals and maintain at least some semblance of trade and communication.
- **Silence:** Because he is sworn to never reveal the secrets of the Janhagir fleet, he needs to become heavily drugged in order to speak about it. Moreover, as he starts to divulge information to the PCs, it obviously gets harder for him to breath; he looks sick or even suffering from an intensifying psychosis (see the Talent Swarm Oath, page 131).

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TABLE 20: NPCS IN THE MOGUL DESCENDANT

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Arban Ghôl-Bataar (retired skipper)	3	2	2	5	5	7	6	**Command 4, Culture 4, Manipulation 3, Melee Combat 3**	**Reliquary (bones from the founders of the Bataari swarm), pocket watch, 3 doses khar, staff (expandable) Talents: Zero-G Training, Bless, Swarm Oath (page 131)**
Param Nadivs (cantina owner)	4	3	2	3	7	5	4	**Manipulation 4, Melee Combat 4, Ranged Combat 3, Culture 2**	**Shock stick, grape rifle, tag (500 birr) Talents: Defensive**

- **The Heart:** If properly motivated – for example if the PCs agree to gamble with him or if they buy him expensive drinks or drugs – he becomes loose-lipped and mentions the heart of the Quadrant: the system no one may name.
- **Oathbound:** He will try to intimidate the PCs with stories about how only death awaits those who seek the fifth system and its treasures. Only they who have sworn their lives and names to the Janhagir fleet may pass through the portals without being consumed by the dark between the stars.
- **The Keymasters:** If they ask him for the star keys or if he knows the way into Shinda, he shakes his head. He is no longer entrusted with a key, but the PCs have now been noticed asking around. The keymasters have eyes and ears everywhere.

After that, he has become so intoxicated that it's hard to follow what he's saying anymore. The PCs leave him to his wine and his memories.

PILLARS OF THE ELEMENTS

The PCs' quest for Rima and the fifth system has made someone take notice of them, either because of their talk with the drunk swarm elder or thanks to them using other contacts. When they return to their ship, they find four empty bowls there, beautifully carved with old Miran patterns.

A CULTURE test reveals the bowls as the "pillars" of the nomads' belief system. The four vessels represent the four spiritual transformations or elements that can be found both in the faith of the Santulans and in many Firstcome cultures (see *Emissary Lost*, page 46). The patterns and glyphs on the sides of the bowls hint at their meanings:

- **Earth:** Sustenance, stability and beginnings.
- **Water:** Life's origin, the catalyst, pliability and change.
- **Air:** Rebirth, traveling, starting a family and new perspectives.
- **Light:** Intellectual enlightenment, taking a stand, spiritual purpose and initiative.

The PCs' ship computer or a tag left near the bowls contains a set of coordinates and a message with distinct dialectal features from the nomads' trade language (see box):

- The PCs have no right to visit the heart of the Quadrant.
- They must become part of the blood and community of the nomads.
- They should fill the bowls with their proper contents and then go to the enclosed coordinates.

In Firstcome faith, the contents of the prayer bowls determine what foundation they represent. See next Event for more information.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

THE OXYGEN OASIS

The coordinates designate a small cluster of asteroids in Sivas slowly falling into the star. They are currently almost in the corona, on the edges of the portal fields.

- **The echo:** The PCs' sensors read a faint echo coming off one of the asteroids. It used to be an oxygen oasis, like the ones scattered along the routes in the Reach.
- **The bunker:** The oasis is a Portal War bunker holding oxygen reservoirs and basic survival gear. A docking hatch connects to an airlock and the inner chamber. Everything is done manually with knobs and levers.

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- **The Chamber:** In the main chamber, someone has drawn four circles on the floor where the PCs are meant to place their ritual bowls. An old woman lies in stasis in an alcove in the far wall. Her skin is covered in black tattoos and glyphs.
- **The Bowls:** When the bowls are placed inside the circles, a bio scanner in the ceiling suddenly activates, its lasers reading the contents of the offerings.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

SWARM OATH

The objects the PCs must place inside the bowl can be identified using **CULTURE**, by asking around (**MANIPULATION**) or by testing **DATA DJINN** using a large enough data base:

- **Earth:** Actual earth or some form of grain (couscous or wheat).
- **Water:** Clear water or wine (some cultures use flavored tea)
- **Air:** Incense or nothing but a single feather or leaf.
- **Light:** A lit wax candle, or burning coals or peat.



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If the bowls are filled with the right substance or object, the bio scanner confirms this – the lights in the room go out and the stasis unit powers up, becoming the only source of light, illuminating microbes growing in complex patterns over the chamber's walls and ceiling.

- **The Guru:** The stasis unit holds a nomad guru. She has the ability to read the minds of the PCs and to make them stick to their words. When she wakes she emerges from the stasis unit, sits down by the bowls, and looks at each of the PCs before starting to write on a tabula.
- **The Proposition:** Her text and symbols are not difficult to understand. The PCs must take an oath to join the Janhagir fleet and the Moguls' honorable mission to keep and protect the peoples and the heart of the Quadrant. She mixes a little from each of the four bowls they brought into a fifth, adding some liquid and dried leaves. If they take the oath, she gestures at them to drink from the fifth bowl to start the ritual.
- **Poison (0–2 dp):** The mixture is a strength 5, non-lethal poison attack (no timed mortality on failed resistance rolls). The poison deals damage to Empathy+MP. Use the poisoning rules from the Coriolis core rulebook or the rules extensions on page 129 of *The Last Cyclade*. For Zenithian PCs, add one automatic success to the poison attack roll. The effects are powerful hallucinations – basement corridors, dark woods and derelict spacecraft; echoing breaths; damp, clammy heat followed by fever chills and stiffness. For 2 DP, the PCs also suffer hallucinations reminding them of their Problem.
- **Fight the Dark (2–3 dp):** If you want to put your players through some combat, you can spend additional DP to create a shared hallucination of an arena where they have to fight a darkmorph (for example one or more darkbound, or even stronger creatures). If any of them become broken, they're all pulled out of the vision and dropped into the next part of the dream sequence. If you spent 2 DP to trigger the combat, the PCs regain all HP they lost during the fight when they awaken but no MP. If you spent 3 DP, they recover nothing – during their thrashing around while hallucinating, they hurt themselves for real.
- **Tattoos:** The PCs suddenly see themselves squatting before the old woman and feel overcome with elation and joy. Cinnamon and citrus incense fills the room. Jolts of pain

TRAVELING BLOOD

"We see you searching for something not yours to find. The heart of the Quadrant can only be shared with one already part of its bloodstream. You are prophets – but of exaltation, or extermination? Fill the bowls and prepare to prove your worth. We will be waiting."

CALLING THE PROPHETS, UNKNOWN NOMAD

NEW TALENT: SWARM OATH

You have gone through the Aresh-Aman ritual, "the Journey of Life," and are now sworn to the Mogul swarms. The black tattoos that cover your hands show your devotion in rows of rings and glyphs.

- You get a +2 to Reputation when dealing with other nomads and will be met with respect by the corsairs of the Rimward Reach, the Quadrant of the Pillar and Odacon.
- You may now purchase advanced tech in the abovementioned systems, and the costs of service and new ship modules is reduced by 10% for each crew member with Swarm Oath (down to half price).
- Once per calendar triad, the talent can be used to save your life as Firstcome or nomads unexpectedly come to your rescue (GM has final say). Reset cooldown at each of the three major holidays.
- If you actively damage the nomad cause or reveal a faction secret, you suffer a psychotic break equivalent to a strength 5 poison attack (for 1 DP). The attack damages Empathy+MP and is lethal (weeks) unless you find a way to atone for your crimes.

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and pleasure shoot up their arms as the nomad elder slowly hand pokes black tattoos onto their fingers and hands. Black rings and mysterious glyphs now cover their hands. When she's done, the old woman takes a large swig from a flask and spits a clear spirit over her work, the alcohol burning the bleeding fingers.

- **Oathbound:** PCs who undergo the ritual are now bound to protect Rima and the secrets of Shinda. They feel strangely compelled to honor their word and may spend 2 XP to purchase the Swarm Oath talent (see box), either immediately or later. Regardless of getting the talent or not, they now have one additional Problem (see the talent description).

CHOSEN: When the ritual is over, the PCs – still in something of a dream state – are led down into the basement of the oasis, through microbe reserves and machine rooms to an escape pod. The pod contains enough stasis beds for all of them and the last thing they see before the hatch closes is the intense light of the star as the pod is shot into the nearby portal field.

REFUSAL: If any of them choose not to participate in the ritual, they are considered unworthy to visit the fifth system which might mean you'll have to split the group and have them play different scenes. PCs who stay behind on their ship will see their friends in the escape pod disappearing into the portal.
Cost: Varies (Mandatory)

⚙ WELCOME TO SHINDA

The PCs come out of stasis on the other side of the portal. The systems of the ancient escape pod provide little information as to where they have ended up. A **DATA DJINN** test reveals that the entry vector and jump coordinates appear to have been wiped from the computer right after the jump and the logs are clean except for the thaw-out command sent to the stasis pods.

Initially, the sensors pick up nothing but static, but then, the dusty screen begins filling up with echoes. A fleet of many hundreds of ships seems to be orbiting a small moon, the only planet in the system that hasn't been absorbed by the dying star. They see signatures they recognize: the Moguls' enormous flagship, the Vaharwala; the three battleships Bhartena, Ghôl-Sarbh and Magratûrk; and the council ships of the larger swarms together with armed clan vessels, retrofitted destroyers, freighters and shuttles in a wide belt about half an AU from the portal field. This is the lost Janhagir fleet in all its glory, the exiled Mogul fleet that left the Second Horizon all those years ago. Another AU farther out, the moon of Shinda still defies the hunger of the system's star.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

⚙ MEETING THE SWARM

A smaller swarm of ships approaches the PCs' pod. They're taken aboard and the hatch opens. In the small hangar, ten nomads greet the PCs with their weapons drawn. When they see the tattoos on the hands of the visitors, the captain of the ship steps forward, introducing herself as Dia Goharshûd. A **CULTURE** test reveals her as the niece of Abyeia Goharshûd, the former spokesperson for the Nomad Federation (whom the PCs might have rescued at the end of *The Last Cyclade*). Regardless of their past, the crew know who the PCs are, but if they have betrayed the nomads in the past, they are treated more like prisoners than as guests.

Dia invites the PCs to join her for a meal and a discussion about why and how they have come to Shinda:

- She says that Nasreddin of Arjjat, a prophet in the Ordana-B system, has foretold their arrival – "Moguls not by birth shall visit the Four who are One."
- Dia tells them that the Mogul elders and the Janhagir fleet generals chose to leave the Third Horizon to seek the advice of the oracle Rima.
- The Zenithians' constant attacks on the rights and freedoms of the nomads have made their leaders question whether they should remain in the Third Horizon at all. Many within the fleet instead think that they should leave the cluster and let their Kahin star seers guide them toward new Horizons.

- **Scrutinized (1–2 dp):** During dinner, a visiting captain, Ishvat Shaharzad, questions the legitimacy of the PCs' quest (at the cost of 1 DP). If they haven't previously been sympathetic toward the nomad cause, this scene can be used to fill them in on how bad the Firstcome and nomads have suffered under the Colonial Agency and the militaristic expansion of the Zenithians into the Quadrant of the Pillar. Captain Ishvat also questions why outsiders should be allowed to set foot on holy Shinda when his family hasn't yet been awarded the same honor.

  The PCs can calm him down using **MANIPULATION** or **COMMAND**, but a critical success is required to completely win his trust. **CULTURE** may be tested before the roll to award

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cultural insights and bonus dice (one per 6 rolled). At the cost of 2 DP, the argument quickly spirals out of control and guns are drawn, giving the rolls a –2. If fighting breaks out, it's broken up by the rest of the crew after one turn.

After dinner, the PCs are shown their cabins and instructed to rest up before their trip to Shinda.

Cost: 0, 1–2 DP (Mandatory)

THE MOGUL COUNCIL

If the PCs are scrutinized by captain Ishvat Shaharzad (see above) or if they haven't been supportive of the nomads during previous parts of the campaign, they might not be taken to the oracle right away. Instead, they may either have to speak to the Mogul council via holo link from captain Goharshûd's bridge or in a face to face meeting in a temple hall onboard one of the Janhagir flagships.

Whether or not the PCs have to persuade the nomads to join the war effort is for you to decide – perhaps their actions in the past mean large parts of the fleet join them automatically (Strength 5).

- **Meeting the Council (1 dp):** Convincing the council captains can either be handled as a MANIPULATION roll or as a dialogue scene. The outcome of the scene determines the strength of the fleets that join. Even failed negotiations will lead to some captains joining the PCs (see Table 22).

Cost: 1 MP

THE TEMPLE CITY OF SHINDA

Captain Goharshûd's vessel lands on Shinda. The PCs are disarmed and taken to the Ghûl-Sian temple city. Pagodas and round stone houses surround the elevated landing platforms of the small spaceport. Thick vegetation covers the ground and the area is full of monks and ascetics in patterned, deep red robes. Their heads are shaved and they wear tattoos similar to the PCs'.

- **The Lowlands:** The PCs are led down long stone stairs onto a paved footpath past the lotus fields and the rock

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TABLE 21: NPCS IN MEETING THE SWARM

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Dia Goharshûd	2	4	3	4	6	7	6	Command 4, Culture 4, Dexterity 4, Manipulation 3, Melee Combat 3, Pilot 3, Ranged Combat 3	Talisman (the Lady), Vulcan cricket, flight-suit, dura sword Talents: Exo Specialist, Swarm Oath (page 131)
Ishvat Shaharzad (typical leader)	4	3	2	3	7	5	6	Melee Combat 5, Command 4, Culture 3, Manipulation 2, Technology 2	Talisman (the Messenger), chameleon suit, mercurium sword, stun glove, battle exo Talents: Zero-G Training, Swarm Oath (page 131)

TABLE 22: THE SIZE OF THE JANHAGIR FLEET

DICE ROLL	STRENGTH OF THE FLEET	FLEET REINFORCEMENTS
(no sixes) Failure	3	0
(one six) Limited Success	4	0
(two sixes) Success	4	1
(three sixes) Critical Success	6	1

columns of the sacred burial site. The columns are made up of intricately decorated urns stacked in tall piles, illustrating the bloodlines of the nomads clans. The lowlands are also home to irrigation canals and enormous cherry trees. A thick carpet of leaves dampens the sound of their footsteps as they approach the temple.

- **The temple:** A group of round buildings on the other side of the valley has been covered in floral patterns in gleaming gold. The temple rising above the lower buildings glows in the starlight. Rima acolytes guard the temple wearing segmented shell armor and carrying long rifles and dura swords. Their tattooed necks and hands show that they have forsaken their families to serve the Four who are One. Inside an antechamber with a huge lotus mosaic on the ceiling, the PCs must leave their belongings and wash themselves in cold spring water from a basin in the wall. They are given robes with embroidered vines scrolling around them and silk wrappings to cover their hair with. They are now "under the lotus" and allowed inside the sanctum where no violence may ever take place.

THE FOUR WHO ARE ONE

The walls of the main chamber are covered in mosaics panels made from painted mother-of-pearl, each depicting a person – nomad PCs or a successful CULTURE test can identify the distinct clothes on the mosaics as the clan patterns of the most esteemed families. The people in the panels are the

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TABLE 23: NPCS IN THE TEMPLE CITY OF SHINDA

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Acolytes of Rima	4	3	3	5	7	8	7	Melee Combat 5, Dexterity 4, Ranged Combat 4, Infiltration 2, Observation 4, Mystic Powers 5	Long rifle, dura sword, shell armor (armor rating 4, light armor with ablative pads) Talent: One mystical power



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THE CHILDREN OF URNI

"You honor me with your visit, beloved sibling. Urni, you were the last to support my wish to wander the stars and meet our children, but now, despite everything, I see we may not be as different of opinion after all…"

ORACLE RIMA, SHINDA

ANCIENT STRUGGLES

"My name is Rima en-Aldaan. You have traveled far and seen much. Your world is but a battlefield where history makes war over ideological supremacy: in what way shall the people be governed?"

ORACLE RIMA, SHINDA

THE FIRES OF THE PORTAL WARS

"After we set fire to your Horizon to stop Terra from taking over, I saw no hope for our doctrine anymore. If our children – the swarms who used to be the pulse and heartbeat of the Second Horizon – had left us, who were we to force them back in line?"

ORACLE RIMA, SHINDA

original swarm leaders who chose exile from the Second Horizon. The floor in the center of the room has been lowered and covered with rugs and pillows, making the edges of the center circle a natural place to sit.

- **Rima the Oracle:** In the middle of the circle, lit from above by light coming through frosted panels in the ceiling, sit four old ascetics, all with shaved heads and tattoos covering their bodies. The sinewy muscles in their bare chests hint at rigorous physical training and their ebony skin identifies them as nomads. They wear simple dhoti pants and sit cross-legged on the floor.

  As the PCs approach, the Four who are One open their eyes and gesture in perfect synchronicity at them to sit down. When they speak, their voices merge in complete harmony, their different ages, genders and timbres making up a collective voice that almost doesn't sound human:
  - If the PCs merged with the Machine Icon, Rima speaks directly to Urni.
  - They explain that the Third Horizon has become a battleground for two ancient ideologies fighting for domination. The people here mean nothing to the Old Horizons.
  - Rima explains that they chose exile after seeing too many of the Santulans' people leave the Second Horizon.
  - The Third Horizon must be left alone in the hands of its original colonists. They deserve their own shot at greatness.
  - Rima let their mind wander across piece by piece, each part finding a willing host among the nomads. Finally, their last fragment came into the Third Horizon to stay.
  - They are opposed to the Santulans' accelerated creation of mystics to use as foot soldiers. The false Emissaries must be stopped.
- **The Conversation:** The PCs may now speak with Rima and ask for their help. The former Santulan can provide aid in a number of ways by answering their questions and recommending actions:
  - The First Horizon's intentions are to incorporate the Third Horizon into their nihilistic reign of terror. As long as the people don't threaten the Emperor's authority, they will be left alone to live lives free from rules or laws. Nothing but turning on the Empire is forbidden – the whims and lusts of the individual dictate everything else. This will be a world of conflict and terrible cruelty.

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- The Second Horizon wishes to be revered as the Icons they claim to be. Principles and rules will dictate everyone's lives. The Santulans will rule by decree and as they please. Obedience and piety will be required, motivated by false promises of potential elevation to Santulan status.
- The Emissaries' hold over the mystics is practically complete and unbreakable as long as the Santulans still inhabit physical bodies in the Third Horizon. While the possibility of convincing them to relinquish control of course exists, it's more likely that they will refuse to admit any faults or accept surrender and that the PCs will have to destroy them. The Santulans have organized a powerful defense and stopping them will require both courage and cooperation.
- Rima can join the PCs either by merging with them or by having their host bodies travel along with the group. If Rima accompanies the PCs, they can weaken the Emissaries' defenses and make it easier to reach their base above Xene.
- If the negotiations with the Mogul council (see above) didn't go too well, Rima can help convince more captains to join (counts as one extra 6 on the roll).

When the PCs feel finished with the meeting and have struck a deal for the cooperation of the oracle, it's time to travel back into known space. If they are injured or in need of rest, they may spend one night in the temple city and be healed by the powers of Rima or by their devoted ascetics. During the night, one or more PCs may dream of how the war is going (War Turn 1, see below).
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

REENTRY
The PCs leave Shinda aboard captain Goharshûd's ship. The leaders and generals they have convinced to join the war effort are already waiting by the portal field – enormous battleships and armed clan ships representing several swarms stand ready to follow them into battle. Describe the scene and the atmosphere before they go into stasis. The captain proposes a toast before the jump and hopes the leaders of generations past will bless their quest with wisdom and fortitude.

After re-entering known space, you can either add a couple more events or consider the mission completed. See below.
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

THE STAR WANDERER
"I rode the solar winds through nebulae and quasars in search of the pulse of my lost children. I was set free a fragment at a time, never to return, until eventually my cage was empty and my children welcomed me home in their new world."

ORACLE RIMA, SHINDA

FALSE EMISSARIES
"I know that my brothers and sisters have enslaved some of your Horizon's people. They wage their never-ending war against Terra at the expense of your families. They have control over their portal into this world and rule in the light of the gas giant. What do you seek? Aid? Wisdom? Action?"

ORACLE RIMA, SHINDA

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MINOR EVENTS

The minor events occur mostly as the PCs return to known space again. Use them to add flavour or danger to this part of the scenario.

A WARNING

As they look for someone with information about the fifth system, the PCs attract unwanted attention. One of the more prominent nomad clans has paid a group of down-on-their-luck stevedores and deckhands to teach the PCs a lesson. The attackers outnumber the PCs by two and you can use either the Shipworker stats (2 DP) or the Soldier stats (3 DP) from page 343 of the Coriolis core rulebook. Alternatively, you can use the Mob Combat rules from The Last Cylade (page 220), in which case the attackers are joined by more angry nomads.

The PCs are lured into the trap by an elderly, scarred man claiming to know more about what they seek. He asks to meet them in an alley, an abandoned engine room or some other remote, dark place. As the PCs arrive, they may test OBSERVATION to spot the ambush (if they roll two or more 6s). When they attack, one of the stevedores roars that the PCs should not look for what doesn't belong to them. If a PC suffers a critical injury or becomes broken, the attackers back off, repeating their warning as they retreat.

Cost: 2–3 DP

BOARDERS!

Travel in the Quadrant of the Pillar is dangerous business. A corsair vessel (page 202) demands a trade of food and medicine for spare parts. You can tailor their offer to whatever the PCs need the most. If they are let onboard, see below. If the PCs are suspicious of their intentions and choose to run away or attack instead, the corsairs will try to disable their reactor using a data pulse (EP damage) and then board the ship. They will threaten to launch an ion torpedo unless let onboard.

If the corsairs make it onboard, they demand a "customs fee" to allow the PCs to keep traveling. Negotiating with the corsair captain is an opposed MANIPULATION test which may lead to combat if the roll goes poorly. The corsairs demand payment in the form of food, gear, weapons, exos, drugs, medicine or spare parts. They appear nervous and actually look malnourished. Their gear and their ship look to be in bad shape.

The PCs might hear children crying in the background when they are first hailed by the corsairs. The ship is actually a small family ship with the starving families of the crew onboard.

Cost: 2 DP

RESONANCE: FIRST BLOOD

As the PCs sleep, they dream of a starry night lit by explosions. Screams and commands echo in the dark. It sounds like a ship crew. Before using this event, you should have played through War Turn 1 to have an outcome to present in the dream. The fate of the blockades in Algebar and Aiwaz as they were attacked by the Nadir Flotilla and the fleets of the First Horizon will be revealed as the PCs sleep:

- **Retreat:** "They've broken through! We've lost the second fleet. Retreat!"
- **Victory:** "Their waves are thinning. No more portal entries on the sensors. They are retreating!"

TABLE 24: NPCS IN BOARDERS!

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Corsair captain	3	4	3	4	7	7	4	Manipulation 4, Ranged Combat 4, Command 3, Culture 3, Melee Combat 3, Observation 3	Talisman (the Lady), Vulcan carbine, dura knife, tag (150 birr), field ration, light armor Talents: Intimidating, Combat Veteran
Corsair crew	4	3	4	2	9	6	3	(Pilot, Technology or Data Djinn 4) Melee Combat 4, Dexterity 3, Force 3, Ranged Combat 3	Prayer beads, Vulcan carbine, power glove (engineer only), protective mask, tag (50 birr), light armor Talents: Tough

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If you rolled a combat event during the War Turn, include its effects in the dream, as well as any unforeseen twists and turns – a mutiny, a portal mishap etc. Let them experience a mystic crew attacking a butterfly ship in Hamura by ramming it and sacrificing themselves.
Cost: 0 DP

FANATICS

As the PCs return to their ship, they discover they aren't alone. A small nomad crew from Altai has boarded their ship in their absence (if any of them stayed behind, they should be given a chance to defend themselves from the corsairs, of course). If they had passengers onboard, these are taken hostage and ransomed for them giving up Rima. The boarders claim to be from the Walad swarm, destined for a paradise beyond the Horizon through the Four who are One, according to an ancient prophecy. Their birthright to the secret of Shinda was taken from them after they fell from grace during Marakanda's golden age for choosing not to fight together with their siblings in the Portal Wars.

Use the stats from the "Boarders!" event above (page 138).

If you want to focus the event on space combat, the fanatics instead claim that Rima is a Second Horizon agent that cannot be allowed into the Third Horizon and attack the PCs' vessel. Their ship counts as a nomad family ship (page 201).
Cost: 2 DP

ENDING

The PCs leave Sivas and the Quadrant and receive news from the nearest portal station about how the war is progressing. The mystic mutinies are increasing and the Emissaries' control over the mystic population soon threatens even the portal stations as the nomad star seers start to feel the pull of the Quiet Zone around Xene. Courier ships at the portal station await further orders – it's up to the PCs how they want to use the Janhagir fleet and what mission to undertake next.

OUTCOME

- **Without Rima:** If Rima didn't accompany the PCs, they can either sacrifice large portions of the Janhagir fleet to assault Xene anyway (see "The Ghosts of Xene" below) or hold back for the time being. News soon reaches them about a mystic in Odacon who appears immune to the song of the Emissaries (see "Harmony", page 120).
- **Nomad Assistance:** The strength of the Janhagir fleet determines whether or not it's best used to back up other fleets or if it's strong enough to hold its own against the First and Second Horizon.
- **Recruiting Martyrs:** If the PCs wish to attack Xene straight away, without the assistance of Rima or the Odaconian mystic, and if they only managed to sway a small part of the Janhagir to join, you might need to introduce a couple of scenes of your own where the PCs travel to Aiwaz or Zalos to negotiate with the Order or Mira for aid. Alternatively, they could travel to Djachroum and meet the Aqbar to persuade him to give them the support of the Purple Guard – at the cost of weakening the defenses on the Dabaran front, however.

TABLE 25: METAGAME SHIFTS

OUTCOME	CONSEQUENCES
Rima accompanies the PCs	See the "The Deadly Resonance Weapon" box on page 141. Preparatory prayer in a chapel now affects two skills instead of one.
The Janhagir fleet joins the alliance	The Mogul fleet becomes available to the Third Horizon war effort. The PCs choose which front to send it to (see "The Mogul Council", page 133).
Regardless of outcome	"The Ghosts of Xene" is unlocked. Use a mini mission such as "The Blood of the Zenith" or "Harmony" as an alternative, stressing the importance of the PCs' choice of tactics.

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SCENARIO:

THE GHOSTS OF XENE

The azure family ship of the Gar'amshi clan. Generations of children have run and played in its corridors ever since the swarm left the Second Horizon to find a new home among the stars.

Dust now covers the residential modules. A chorus in somber prayer echoes from the dimly lit bridge. All but the pilot and the sensor operator joins in:

"Karob-mu-Qad, our home is your home. Kama-mu-Qad, through your dance we cross behind the veil. Hane-mu-Qad, in your shadow we see the true face of the dark. Hukim-mu-Qad, with your blade we vanquish our enemies."

Then, the reactor is pushed to its limits and the ship shoots into the Hamura star. Something flickers into view – a butterfly ship – followed by a collision and a bright flash of light.

OVERVIEW

The collapse of the Monolith and the wave of destruction following the end of *The Last Cyclade* marked the beginning of the Emissaries assuming full control of the mystics, their secret weapon. Since then, more and more mystics have amassed at Xene, forced to give their lives as living ammunition in the war between the Old Horizon.

PC INCENTIVES

The Emissaries' control over the mystics of the Third Horizon increases with every passing segment. The probes and courier ships that bring the news through the cluster all report the same thing – mutinies take place throughout all the large fleets and the defectors travel to Kua on their way to the Quiet Zone by Xene, stealing everything from small supply ships to large warships. The metagame rules reflect this by treating the Third Horizon fleets as Overrun (page 114). Unless the PCs already have a plan, they will be contacted by a courier from the front asking for their help. Choose a surname for the courier captain Saara depending on her origins: Haroum (Mira), Al-Faisal (Zalos), Yrides (the Zenithians) or Ergûd (the nomads).

THE QUIET ZONE

The devout puppets of the Emissaries congregate around the Quiet Zone of Xene. The largest of the commandeered warships watch the perimeter of the sector while the mutineer Legion cruisers gather further in, nearest to FS-7 and Xene itself. Smaller torpedo ships and civilian vessels are instead sent to Hamura to sacrifice themselves in suicide attacks against the First Horizon fleets by ramming them as living torpedoes. The portal to Taoan is under constant bombardment to keep it unstable, making even the passage of the butterfly ships unsafe.

THE LEGION

The Judge Emissary brought to the Legion's secret base on the Yrind asteroid in the Kandah cloud during *The Last Cyclade* has returned victorious to Xene as commander of the Legion's lost Shahrazad flagship, the Adulaaza and Shaheresh battleships and a flotilla of torpedo ships. Once the space around Xene had been secured, the other Emissaries were summoned along with their followers (see the epilogue of *Emissary Lost*).

STATION FS-7

Foundation Station 7 used to be a relatively inconsequential weather post and admin hub for the mining colonies on the moons of Xene. When the so-called Jarouma pattern was discovered on the gas giant, the faction's scientists deployed a network of arrays on grav projectors around the gas giant to reshape its energy patterns based on the hexagonal, cage-like shape of the Izar Net veil. The experiment was successful, but not in the way the Foundation had hoped. A bridge was formed to the Second Horizon, strong enough to let the Santulans transport their minds into the scientists working on the experiment. The four surviving Emissaries now live on the station, guarded by a group of twenty ex-Legionnaires formerly known as the Chau'kedaar, "the Watchers" (page 147). The squadron is under the command of Tehira Markoon, one of the nominees for a Council seat in the finale of *The Last Cyclade*.

THE MISSION

The PCs must break the Emissaries' control over the mystics. To do this, they need to make it through the Quiet Zone, past the defenses and all the way to Xene. The assault will be bloody and they will see their allies annihilated, one ship at a time. If they use one of their allied fleets as backup, don't use the

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THE MOTH AND THE FLAME

The birthplace of the Song and the Emissaries.
The prayer tower calling its pilgrims home,
denied their free will.
Brother turns on brother.
Sister turns on sister.
Slaves in complete obedience,
drawn to the light of the gas giant,
burning with devotion.

THE MACHINE ICON

THE DEADLY RESONANCE WEAPON

Ships coming within 3 AU of Xene get their sensors disabled, making navigation much more difficult (–3 to **PILOT**). Once per watch, the ship suffers 1D6 HP damage without armor rolls, plus one critical damage (Coriolis core rulebook, page 172). A quick, speed 4 ship such as a fighter or torpedo ship can make it through the Quiet Zone in three watches but a regular, speed 2 freighter would need six watches for the journey, thus suffering damage six times. If anyone still makes it through alive, a flotilla of ex-Legionnaires awaits them at Xene, ready to defend their new masters.

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THE PRICE OF THE GIFT

Mystics who steel themselves against the resonance weapon and the powers of the Emissaries become twisted and corrupted by dark memes equivalent to a critical injury. If Rima or Fahti accompanies the charge through the Zone, roll one die for each of them on the Critical Injuries table on page 96 of the Coriolis core rulebook and read the 61–66 results. Measure the loss of consciousness in days instead of hours and the healing time in weeks instead of days.

DESTROYING FS-7

There is plenty of room for the PCs to be clever within the framework of the mission. Even if the Legion ships are there to protect the station from incoming attacks and shield it from both cannon fire and torpedoes, creativity and luck might still enable the PCs to attack FS-7 from space. If they think of a way, let them do so – you can still have them encounter the Judge Emissary during "The Executioner" (page 150) after it flees the station onto the ship of either the PCs or one of their allies.

regular rules for the resonance weapon – see the "Breaking through" box instead. As they are fighting the ex-Legionnaires at Xene, they can choose between various tactics:

- Request an audience with the Emissaries and negotiate for the independence of the Third Horizon. If the negotiations fail, they may be forced to destroy the station instead.
- Destroying the station by getting onboard and sabotaging the reactor, hopefully also damaging the Emissaries enough to force the Santulans to leave their hosts.

MAJOR EVENTS

The different stages of the scenario include the journey through the Quiet Zone and the heavy losses suffered there, as well as the arrival to the station itself where the PCs either try to negotiate with the Emissaries or blow up their seat of power. The minor events contain various other situations that might arise on their way to or from the station.

THROUGH THE ZONE

The Quiet Zone stretches 3 AU in all directions around Xene. When the PCs' ship and their fleet enter the Zone, their sensors give out and the reactors begin overcharging. Communications within the fleet become broken up and full of crackling static. Use the events below to flavor the journey and turn up the pressure:

- **Sensors Collapse (1 DP):** The sensors go offline and the intercoms stop working. A DATA DJINN test is required to recalibrate them. Failing the roll leads to a –1 to all sensor rolls (such as weapon locks and navigation) until the ship has been serviced.
- **Reactor Spike (1 DP):** The reactor suddenly loses power and the ship's systems start to malfunction. A TECHNOLOGY test stabilizes the reactor again but a failed roll costs 1 EP and gives the engineer a –1 to all rolls relating to energy distribution or overloading the reactor.
- **Critical Load (2 DP):** The reactor is about to suffer a meltdown. A TECHNOLOGY or DATA DJINN test is required to stabilize it. Failing the TECHNOLOGY test leads to 3 points of HP damage to the ship. Failing the DATA DJINN test leads to 1 point of EP damage. This damage cannot be repaired until the ship has been serviced.
- **Forced Betrayal (2–3 DP):** The Emissaries try to hamper the PCs' attack by having their assassins, the Dakin, enter the minds of the crew of one of the ships in the fleet. For

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2 DP, the captain and parts of the crew of another ship are taken over and they ram their ship into one of their allies, destroying both. For 1 additional DP, debris from the crash is hurled toward the PCs' ship and they must either avoid it (PILOT) or shoot it down (RANGED COMBAT). Unless someone onboard first spots the incoming threat using DATA DJINN, both rolls are at –2.

- **Assassination Attempt (2 DP):** The Dakin attempt to puppet someone onboard the PCs' ship to be able to attack Rima or Fahti. Seepage 21 for the Dakin's puppeteering powers. The target can be a PC but in such a case, remember she gets a bonus from the Machine Icon (see page 45). Rima and Fahti are in a deep trance when the attack begins and have 6 HP each. If they become broken, they suffer a critical injury and if they lose consciousness, their dampening of the resonance weapon stops and it immediately deals more damage to the assisting fleet (see "Breaking Through" to the right).
- **Asteroid Shower (3 DP):** Asteroids and space junk rain over the attacking fleet. The PCs might be able to detect the incoming projectiles using their sensors in time to warn the rest of the fleet by testing DATA DJINN. Failing the roll leads to 1 point of damage to the assisting fleet and a disabled, non-required module on the PCs' ship. Rolling one 6 leads to 1 point of damage for the fleet but no damage to the PCs' ship. Two 6s leads to the destruction of a minor ship in the fleet but no Strength loss and three or more 6s means everyone makes it through alright.
- **Shock and Awe:** Without spending DP, you can have the resonance weapon destroy ships in the fleet just to give the PCs an indication of its enormous power. The sensors go offline after which the reactor overcharges and destroys the ship, or damages it so severely that it can no longer continue the attack and has to turn back. The PCs learn what's going on over the shaky fleet coms.
- **Omens (0–1 DP):** The Emissaries try to scare the PCs by projecting nightmares and visions into their heads – they see their loved ones dying or feel overcome with doubt and grief. At the cost of 1 DP, all affected characters suffer 3 points of stress, reduced by 1 for each 6 rolled on a MYSTIC POWERS test.

If the fleet assisting the PCs is destroyed before they reach the station, you can have the resonance weapon target the PCs' ship as well (see "The Deadly Resonance

BREAKING THROUGH

To break through the defenses around Xene, the PCs will need the help of one or more of the Third Horizon's fleets. The defenses count as a blockade (1 point of damage to Strength) in addition to the effects of the resonance weapon (4 points of damage to Strength). This means that the attacking fleet must begin at Strength 5 or higher.

If Rima (see "The Fifth System", page 124) or Fahti (see "Harmony", page 120) joins the attack, the effects of the resonance weapon are lowered from 4 to 2 points of damage. If both Rima and Fahti have joined, they cancel out the extra damage caused by the resonance weapon (but not the damage suffered by attacking the blockade).

DESTROYING THE STATION

The Emissaries' regenerative powers make them almost impossible to defeat in combat. If the PCs want to force them to surrender and leave, they can make their way to the engine room and manipulate the reactor to explode. The way there should contain guards and other obstacles, and when they get there, they will either need a suitable bomb (**TECHNOLOGY** –1) to place inside the protective dura beams and ED fields, or a way into the reactor to sabotage it (**TECHNOLOGY** –2). As the reactor and the graviton projector are exploding, the fleeing PCs might have to roll **DEXTERITY** tests in a weightless vacuum. If you then wish for a final encounter with the Emissaries, use the event "The Executioner" on page 150.

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FOUNDATION STATION 7









U: SECTOR 11 (BARRACKS)
V: SECTOR 19 (VISITOR'S DOCK)
W: SECTOR 18 (DOCK, SHUTTLE)
X: SECTOR 17 (DOCK, INTERCEPTOR)
Y: SECTOR 31 (THE EMISSARIES)
Z: SECTOR 27 (DATA CORE)

1: THE CENTRAL CORRIDOR
2: SENSOR ARRAY
3: RESEARCH SECTORS
4: ADMIN
5: SECURITY HUB
6: DOCKING PLATFORMS
7: ENGINE ROOM

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Weapon", page 141). As the GM, you decide how many watches (attack rolls) they still have to go.

Cost: Varies (see list)

THE BATTLE OF XENE

When the fleet makes it through the Quiet Zone and reaches the gas giant, they are met by the battleships formerly belonging to the Legion. The battle begins immediately, acc cannons firing and torpedoes launching on both sides. The station is protected by fighter and torpedo ships ready to sacrifice themselves to stop incoming torpedoes. The captains of the ships allied with the PCs engage the defenders to buy the heroes time to make it onto the station. Depending on how much of a warship they have, choose if the PCs are pursued by fighters, torpedo ships or both. Their maneuvering to get to the station takes two turns (or four, if you spend 2 DP) starting with the defenders meeting them head on and then taking up the chase. The stats for the defending Legion fighter and torpedo ships can be found on pages 197–198.

When the PCs reach the station, they can either try to stay hidden or send a message to the Emissaries via the station's coms, asking to negotiate.

Cost: 0, 2 DP

THROUGH THE STATION

Onboard FS-7, the PCs are free to roam around its corridors and sections. However, the base is defended by twenty ex-Legionnaires, ten indoctrinated pilgrims and a handful of Algolan rebels.

The PCs can either attempt to dock their ship at the security hub or spacewalk over to the station in exos. Docking while in active combat carries a penalty of –2 to PILOT. If the docking roll fails, they must undertake the spacewalk. This is a DEXTERITY test, but as soon as the first person has made it, they can attach a guide wire, giving the people walking behind a +2 to their rolls. Regardless of whether they dock or spacewalk, opening the airlock from the outside requires a successful TECHNOLOGY, DATA DJINN (–1) or FORCE (–2) test. Failure leads to 2 points of stress for the active character and an ambush has been prepared inside (see below).

1. **The Central Corridor:** The sectors of the station rotate around a central axis. At the heart of the central axis, a low-gravity corridor runs the length of the station. Fighting or performing quick movement in the central corridors requires DEXTERITY tests. Attaching one's exo to the elevator rig in the corridor allows for transportation to any sector along the shaft, but interrupting the elevator once it is in motion is a Slow action.
2. **Sensor Array:** One end of the central corridor leads through an airlock to a rig of antennas making up the station's sensors. The array scans both the atmosphere of Xene below as well as the surrounding space. If the array is disabled by a well-placed shot (2 HP, –1 to hit) as the PCs are approaching from space, the guards onboard can no longer see their arrival.
3. **Research Sectors:** Three independent sectors, each containing a main corridor extending from the station's central shaft through an airlock. The sectors contain a research room, a data hub, a workshop and residential modules with kitchens, a gym and coffin-style cabins. The sectors were originally used to keep different groups of researchers isolated from each other so the main security officer could control them more easily. Sector 31 is now home to the Emissaries (see "Meeting the Icons" below) and sectors 32 and 33 are used by the Algolans and a group from the Children of the Song. A Seeker mystic commands the Children (see the NPCs list above). The Algolans aren't mystics and can therefore be convinced to renounce the Emissaries by winning an opposed MANIPULATION test (in which the Algolans get a +2, however).
4. **Admin:** The administration area is all but deserted. The dark rooms contain inert djinn systems, data cores, waiting rooms and offices. A main corridor runs through the circle and small observation windows allow for a view of the sickly greenish yellow atmosphere of Xene. A patrol of ex-Legionnaires sometimes passes through, but the doors are otherwise locked and the only residents are the dead plants, the powered-down monitors and scattered pieces of forgotten Zenithian art.
5. **Security Hub:** The module contains two small interrogation rooms, a couple of cells, a small assembly hall and two residential units where the barracks and the weapons lockers are located (sectors 21 and 22). There are several access points here between the hub, the central corridor and the eight docking platforms along the curvature of the hull.
6. **Docking Platforms:** Eight small hangars and docking platforms accessed via the security hub. Ten fighters (in pairs) and two atmospheric shuttles occupy seven of the

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TABLE 26: NPCS IN THROUGH THE STATION

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	MP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Ex-Legionnaire	3	4	3	2	7	5	3	Infiltration 5, Melee Combat 5, Observation 3, Ranged Combat 3, Science 3, Manipulation 2	Thermal carbine, combat suit (armor 6), sensor smoke grenade, advanced scope Talent: Nine Lives or Executioner
Pilgrim	3	3	2	3	6	5	3	Melee Combat 3, Culture 2, Dexterity 2	Blunt instrument (equivalent of baton) or knife, rations, Judge talisman
Algolan rebel	3	3	2	3	6	5	4	Manipulation 3, Melee Combat 3, Observation 3, Ranged Combat 3, Infiltration 2	Dura axe or dura knife, Vulcan pistol, light armor
Mystic leader	3	2	4	4	5	8	4	Mystic Powers 5, Observation 3, Ranged Combat 3, Manipulation 2, Technology 2	Legion carbine Dayal-3, armavest (armor 3), incense, Second Horizon prayer book Talents: Regenerate or Stop (Table 09, page 46)
Mystic, the Children of the Song	2	3	3	4	5	7	2	Infiltration 2, Melee Combat 2, Mystic Powers 2, Ranged Combat 1	Blunt instrument (equivalent of baton) or sawed-off grape rifle, prayer bowl Talents: One mystical power

platforms, leaving the last one empty. It's large enough to fit a Class II ship inside the hangar or accommodate an externally docked Class III.

7. **Engine Room:** The station's reactor and protruding grav projectors are protected behind a thick duralite frame and a series of ED fields. The central corridor doesn't reach all the way to the engine room, requiring a spacewalk between the reinforced airlock (FORCE –2, 15 HP) at the bottom of the corridor and the engine and life support modules. This close to the projectors, gravity is unpredictable and dangerous, fluctuating between 0 and extremely high levels. All actions relating to movement and physical activity carry a –1 penalty here, including simply holding onto something. The PCs can find several dead crew members here who fled into the vacuum of the engine room when the Emissaries arrived. Despite them carrying emergency transmitters, help never came.

When the PCs move about onboard FS-7, what obstacles, locked doors and enemy patrols they encounter is up to you. Each failed attempt to shut down the station's defenses and surveillance systems reduces the DP costs below by 1 (even down to 0).

- **Ambush (1–4 DP):** Armed enemies have staged an ambush, outnumbering the PCs by two. They are pilgrims (1 DP), Algolans (2 DP) or ex-Legionnaires (3 DP). For 1 additional DP, they initiate the ambush with a stun grenade.
- **Patrol (0–1 DP):** The PCs have been spotted and a pair of ex-Legionnaires are dispatched to investigate. Depending on how noisy the PCs are, they might either hear or be heard by the approaching enemies (opposed highest OBSERVATION vs lowest DEXTERITY). You choose who rolls for what, depending on the situation.
- **Vacuum (3 DP):** Suddenly, several bulkhead doors close and a red light switches on. PCs with a TECHNOLOGY level of at least 2 understand that the section they're in is about to suffer explosive decompression. Shortly thereafter, a nearby airlock opens and the PCs must roll not to be sucked out into space. See the Explosive decompression rules in *Emissary Lost*, page 57.

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FIGHTING AN ICON

Hotheaded PCs might try to defeat the Emissaries in combat. Use the Judge Emissary's stats from page 150 ("The Executioner") for all four Santulans, or prepare individual stats for them using the rules found in *Emissary Lost*, pages 189–194. The powers of the Machine Icon makes it possible to fight the Emissaries but it definitely won't be easy – make sure the players understand this.

FRIENDS

"Friends. We have come to stay. We are the answer and the Emissaries of your new future. We are the light of peace, beyond the darkness at our doorstep…"

THE JUDGE EMISSARY, HUKIM-MU-QAD

- **Locked Section:** The way forward is blocked. The hatch barring the way has no manual controls, only an electronic DNA lock. It can be opened using explosives (8 HP), brute force (FORCE –2) or a DATA DJINN test at –1. A failed roll sets off an alarm and guards are dispatched (see above).
- **Watched:** The section is monitored by cameras and heat vision alarms. Spotting the security measures is an OBSERVATION roll after which a PC can either guide the group through the area's blind spots (DEXTERITY) or disable the system (DATA DJINN). Failure leads to guards showing up (see above).
- **Automated Defenses (1–2 DP):** The section has automated defense systems that, if triggered, will make the trip across the base much more difficult. The section is wholly or partially fitted with systems that release a cloud of toxic chemicals, extreme heat from the overcharged atmospheric systems or freezing fire suppression gas. The chemicals count as smoke grenades with a strength of 4 (Wits+HP) unless the PCs have some form of protective mask. A SURVIVAL test allows a PC to find safe passage through the cold or the heat for the whole group. A failed roll leads to either an extreme cold attack equivalent of an ice storm (The Last Cylade, page 37) or a Fire 2 attack (Coriolis core rulebook, page 97).

Cost: Varies (see list)

MEETING THE ICONS

Research sector 31 used to be home to the scientists whose bodies the Santulans commandeered as they entered through the Xenian resonance bridge. Since then, the sector has been refurbished with thick rugs, small prayer towers and clay sculptures of the Icons. Cinnamon, cedarwood and citrus incense fills the corridors with a thick haze. Two pilgrims, two former Legionnaires and one of the Algolans can be found here, praying. Clay bowls line the main corridor and the door to the research room, containing the chamber of the Emissaries, is surrounded by offerings of fruit, vegetables and nuts.

- **A Humble Welcome:** When the PCs arrive – regardless of if they fought their way here or came in peace – the devotees rise from their prayers and welcome them warmly. They ask the group to leave their weapons in the corridor and then enter the Emissaries' chamber and speak with the living Icons under the lotus. Their presence inside has been requested.
- **The Emissaries:** Research stations, desks and computer panels have been pushed up against the walls to clear out the

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middle of the room. Rugs and rows of candles lead up to a huge panoramic window overlooking the yellow glow of Xene. In the back of the room, on a low dais from which the Jarouma pattern used to be monitored, the four Emissaries wait in silence.

They wear full, ceremonial suits of armor, seemingly of Legion origin, but are also draped in shawls, capes and talismans that appear more Miran. Their bodies and faces are completely hidden behind glyph-covered plates and visors. The air seems to shimmer around them and the hairs on the PCs' arms stand on end. They feel as if a great weight bears down on them and hear a faint whooshing, or the echoes of a song, urging them to take a knee and give their minds to the Icons before them. Have them roll for terror (*The Last Cyclade*, page 31) if you want to emphasize the gravity of the situation further. The Judge Emissary, Hukim-mu-Qad, wearing copper red armor covered in spindly glyphs steps forward and raises a hand in greeting. The conversation that then follows is purely telepathic. Below is a list of important points to include in the scene.

- **The Enemy:** The Emissaries want to destroy the First Horizon and return the Third Horizon to the ways of the Symmetry.
- **New Portals:** The Santulans envision a future where the Second and Third Horizon are joined again, through the portal in Menkar-B, Menkib. The fields there are long since dead as the system was hit hard during the Portal Wars. During the Long Night, the Circle of Seekers began constructing a sensor cage around the planet of Izar in the Eanu system – today known as the Izar Net veil – based on ancient research about the Portal Builders to try and re-open a way into the Third Horizon.
- **The Resonance Fields:** Neither the Izar Net nor the experiments of the Foundation to reproduce the Xene pattern will lead to the creation of new portals, however. Only minds can travel across the stars using these methods but the Santulans wish to refine these technologies and create permanent portals for physical travel after the wars are won.
- **Governance:** The Santulans lead by religious decree but claim to listen to their subjects. Their wisdom shapes the Horizons and makes everyone's lives better: wealth and progress for all as long as people understand their place in the societal pyramid. They expect absolute obedience but only because this will allow them to give people what they really need – whether they realize it or not.

PARTING AS FOES

"The people can never lead for the benefit of all. Your ambitions are disorganized, egocentric and emotional. Go now and let us work. You are under the lotus and free to leave the station but beware if we ever lay eyes on you again!"

THE JUDGE EMISSARY, HUKIM-MU-QAD

THE JUDGE'S GLYPHS

A limited success on a **CULTURE** test can reveal to the PCs that the glyphs on the Judge Emissary's armor can be interpreted as a Zalosian hymn to the Martyr. A critical success identifies the origins of the language as much older, however. The glyphs mention martyrdom and speak of how the original Emissaries who first led humanity out among the stars sacrificed themselves to open up the Horizons. How this was done is unclear, though. Much seems to indicate that the glyphs are talking about the Portal Builders.

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- **Purpose:** For the good of the many, the few must suffer – such is the natural order. But as long as a person lives, she has a right to safety and a purpose.
- **Maturity:** Mankind as a whole will never be ready to govern themselves. Only the chosen, the elevated, dare to look upon the future with open eyes. The Third Horizon cannot be left to its own devices – it must follow the path laid out by the Santulans.
- **The Portal Builders:** The Santulans' ultimate deities are the Portal Builders and they regard themselves as Icons destined to care for the legacy of their gods. Through reaching a state of intellectual and spiritual nirvana, the Santulans, too, have become like gods – gods for the human race.
- **The Horizon Wars:** They want the PCs to convince the allied fleets of the Third Horizon to abandon their selfish doctrines of protecting their home worlds and instead travel through Taoan and sacrifice themselves in a glorious assault on the unholy and corrupted world intelligence calling itself the Eternal Emperor. This will guarantee future generations a world free from darkness.

◆ **Negotiations:** Let the PCs reason with the Emissaries and try to bargain for their futures. They might attempt to convince the Santulans to leave them alone but this should be a very difficult feat to accomplish. The Second Horizon feels a strong sense of ownership and parental responsibility over their exiled children and doesn't want to let them go a second time. Buying the cluster some more time will be easier. The PCs might for example bargain for ten or so years of self-determination before the Santulans return to stake their claim again.

How the scene ends is up to you. If the PCs fail, they might anger the Emissaries and be told to leave. If so, they are allowed to retreat from the station under threats of death if they ever interfere with the plans of the Santulans again.

Cost: 0 DP

MINOR EVENTS

After the PCs have confronted the Emissaries, you can choose to end the scenario with them leaving the station. Emphasize the massive sacrifices made to enable them to carry out the mission. Alternatively, they have angered the Judge Emissary in such a way that the scenario ends in lethal combat instead.

⚙ THE EXECUTIONER

If the PCs choose a violent approach to the mission and anger the Judge Emissary enough, it will confront them either as they are leaving the station or – if they blew up the station – back at their own ship. The Judge Emissary's mind leaves its host body and migrates into a suitable NPC near the PCs. The new host collapses into a violent fit on the floor until they suddenly and gracefully rise in a single, fluid motion. Their eyes roll back into their head and they turn straight toward the PCs. Decide if this prompts a terror roll or not (*The Last Cyclade*, page 31).

The Judge Emissary is very difficult to kill. The PCs might defeat the host body for a turn or two but it regenerates almost immediately. Their only real chance of destroying the creature is by venting it out into space, perhaps through an airlock or inside a torpedo aimed for Xene below, or the vast dark between the stars. Who knows when or if the Judge will return to exact revenge in the future…

The Machine Icon or Rima might assist the PCs in the fight by intervening in a moment when the Judge Emissary is weakened, pinning or trapping it to buy the heroes some time. For a truly dramatic finale, you could have the Machine Icon sacrifice itself to destroy the Judge Emissary. This will strip the PCs of the powers they developed after merging with Urni, however.

Cost: 3 DP

HUKIM-MU-QAD, THE JUDGE EMISSARY

The former mystic guru Ladei Menin-Ghôrshad of Menkib was elevated to Santulan status after having served as an admiral in several of the Second Horizon's major battles with the Eternal Emperor. Ladei became part of the strategic fleet command and has a very militaristic worldview. They consider the Janhagir fleet traitors and actively promote the doctrine of Santulan control over all of mankind's expansion out into the universe.

CHARACTERISTICS: Maintains a combat-ready stance when speaking, arms slightly raised in front of them, sometimes making fists. When thinking something over, their rasping exhales almost sound like growls.

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5, WITS 6, EMPATHY 5**
HIT POINTS: 12
MIND POINTS: 12

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REPUTATION: 10

SKILLS: Mystic Powers 10, Culture 8, Science 8, Manipulation 6, Observation 6, Command 5, Survival 5, Melee Combat 4, Ranged Combat 4, Dexterity 2

ACTIONS: Two activations per turn, different initiatives with a +1, 3 AP each

TALENTS: Recreate (levels I through III), Control (levels I and II), Contaminate (levels I through IV)

RESONANCE POINTS: 15 (see Resonance Points box)

MANIA: Blood lust

GEAR: Ornate armasuit (armor 6), Portal Builder talismans, 5 healing scarabs (attached to armor), shield projector belt (artifact, see below), hand fan. (Gear only if the encountered onboard FS-7)

- **POWERS:** Uses Resonance Points, see Table 27.
- **BLOOD LUST (2 DP):** Twisted and corrupted by the dark, the Emissary is sometimes overcome with hate and a desire for death. At the cost of 2 DP, the first time the Judge Emissary drops below 5 HP and the first time the Regenerate power is used, the blood lust awakens and grants the Emissary 3 extra AP for offensive actions (attacks and/or powers) to spend on its current activation.
- **SHIELD PROJECTOR BELT (3 DP):** Projects a powerful force field (armor 5) that protects against all forms of damage, including meson. The field also grants the wearer of the belt a +1 to **FORCE** and **DEXTERITY**. Lasts for two turns.
- **COMBAT MEDITATION (1–3 DP):** If the Judge Emissary drops to 0 RP, they lose their temper altogether and channel power from the dark instead. In the coming turn, each full activation (3 AP) spent on harnessing new power restores as many RP as 6s rolled on a **MYSTIC POWERS** roll. You must spend at least 1 DP to activate the power, but may spend up to 3 DP (each extra DP grants a +2 to the rolls).

BANISHED: When the Judge Emissary has depleted their RP, it will use whatever weapons are at its disposal while trying to draw new power from the dark (see Combat Meditation above). At 0 RP, it's very vulnerable – the Machine Icon or a PC trained in exorcisms may try to perform a banishing. If it drops to 0 HP or MP while being out of RP, the Santulan's mind is forced out of its current host body and the PCs win the fight.



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TABLE 27: THE JUDGE EMISSARY'S POWERS

POWER	DESCRIPTION
RECREATE I: REGENERATION	Test MYSTIC POWERS instead of MEDICURGY when treating the mystic's own injuries. May test even if broken, but at –2.
RECREATE II: SOOTHING TOUCH	Test MYSTIC POWERS at +2 instead of MEDICURGY when treating any form of injury, on anyone within Short range.
RECREATE III: SCULPT	The cells are instantaneously recreated. 10 HP and 4 SP are restored, one critical injury of your choice is healed and the Judge Emissary gains a natural armor rating of 4 for four hours (may be combined with armor, doesn't stack if the power is activated multiple times).
CONTROL I: STOP	The Judge Emissary can stop another character from performing a minor action, such as looking over their shoulder, opening a door or checking a sensor monitor. May not be used in combat.
CONTROL II: PREVENT	As a Reaction, the Judge Emissary can prevent someone within line of sight from performing an action or attack. Roll an opposed MYSTIC POWERS. Each of the Emissary's winning 6s reduces the target's remaining AP by 1. Bonus 6s may be spent on also inflicting an initiative penalty (-2 per 6 until end of combat).
CONTAMINATE I-IV	See box

ENDING

The PCs leave Xene and the Quiet Zone is no more. No matter the outcome of their meeting with the Emissaries, the actions of the PCs will carry serious consequences. Even if they successfully negotiated for the Third Horizon's independence, the Santulans will still work in secret to undermine the cluster's attempts at self-governance to legitimize and justify their claim to power. If the negotiations failed or the scenario ended violently, other major changes occur.

OUTCOME

- **An Independent Horizon:** The Santulans demand control over the Sadaal Route and promise to close the Errai portals to keep the First Horizon from penetrating deeper into the cluster. They leave Xene and move their fleet to Errai but maintain their hold over the mystic fleet in Hamura (page 192) to make sure the Imperial forces can't reach Kua through Taoan. They stop their aggressive recruitment, however, and the mystic mutinies cease.
- **A Little More Time:** The Emissaries leave Xene and their host bodies (who die or collapse into a deep coma). They then lead a small part of the mystic fleet to Hamura to keep the First Horizon at bay for a while longer (Table 28). After that, they will leave the Third Horizon to whatever fate awaits it.
- **The Emissaries are Destroyed:** The PCs destroy the station and the Emissaries. The Santulans attempt to launch a counter-attack against Taoan but are unable to maintain their control over the mystics (Table 28). The defenses in Hamura break down and the First Horizon can now attack Kua.

RESONANCE POINTS

Resonance Points (RP) are used instead of DP when activating resonance powers. Each activation of a power costs RP equivalent to the power level.

- A resonance mystic may pool up to (Empathy + **MYSTIC POWERS**) RP.
- The mystic may only activate power levels I through III.
- When critically successful, the activation of the power is raised by one level (thus making a critically successful level III activation the only way to reach level IV).
- The equivalent of a prayer reroll costs 2 RP.
- The mystic restores RP through meditation. Test **MYSTIC POWERS** once per four hours of meditation – each 6 rolled restores 1 RP.
- On all other skill tests where bonus 6s are rolled but not spent, they may be turned into RP instead (one 6 = 1 RP).

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RESONANCE POWERS: CONTAMINATE (I-IV)

The Santulans rule the Second Horizon through a rigorous doctrine and wide-reaching influence, but the journey of the Emissaries through the resonance bridge has twisted their minds and corrupted their powers. The Contaminate power is a direct result of this.

Contaminate (I): WARP – Roll MYSTIC POWERS instead of COMMAND to lead your allies (see COMMAND rules in the Coriolis core rulebook, chapters 3, 5 and 7). All 6s rolled become bonus dice for the subjects of the Santulan to use when they carry out its orders. All enemies in sight suffer 1 point of stress per 6 rolled. The victims of the MP loss may test Empathy or MYSTIC POWERS to lower or negate the stress. Each 6 rolled reduces the MP loss by 1 point.

Contaminate (II): CORRUPT – Dark memes take hold of the victim's mind and body. Roll an opposed MYSTIC POWERS. Each of the Emissary's winning 6s grants a +1 to the roll below:

D6	CORRUPTION
1–5	The victim hesitates and loses 1 AP on its coming activation.
6	The victim hesitates and loses 2 AP on its coming activation.
7–8	The victim turns her weapon on herself. She may forgo her activation and suffer 2 points of stress to stop herself from self-harming for one turn. If she chooses not to stop herself, she attacks with a +3 (may only test armor if full body). If she suffers any damage, becomes broken (damage/stress) or disarmed, the corruption is broken. The effects may also be dispelled using COMMAND.
9	The victim attacks her nearest ally until either she or her target becomes broken. A successful COMMAND test at -3 may cancel the influence of the corruption.
10+	Same as above, but the victim also suffers a Mania (Coriolis core rulebook, page 337) that may be activated by the GM as a Problem.

Contaminate (III): SHRED – All enemies within line of sight and Short range are barraged by a rain of dark tears opening in the air around them like two-dimensional shreds of darkness (strength 6 attack, CRIT 2). Those who suffer damage from the attack are enveloped by the dark tears that burn like white phosphorus. In the coming turn, they also suffer a strength 3 fire attack (D6 turns). Enemy movement within range of the power and in the same turn requires DEXTERITY tests at –2 to avoid a new attack and potential fire damage.

Contaminate (IV): CONTAMINATE – Matter and darkness fuse together. The range of the attack (see above) is now Long and no longer requires line of sight. In addition to the damage and burning, the dark tears also start to affect the bio code of their victims as the area is flooded with radiation (1 point of radiation per turn, see Coriolis core rulebook, page 99). The power remains active as long as the user concentrates.

TABLE 28: METAGAME CHANGES

OUTCOME	CONSEQUENCE
The Santulans are given the Sadaal Route, retain their host bodies and agree to defend the Third Horizon	The Third Horizon fleets no longer count as Overrun (page 114). The lines in Hamura hold against the Vestal invasion from Taoan for the remainder of the war.
The Santulans voluntarily relinquish control of their host bodies	The Third Horizon fleets no longer count as Overrun (page 114) and the players may distribute 3 points worth of extra Reinforcements between their fleets' home systems (even fleets with depleted Reinforcements). The liberated mystics gradually leave Hamura and the defenses there are weakened. The First Horizon fleet in Taoan may attack Hamura after the next War Turn.
The Santulans' host bodies are destroyed	The Third Horizon fleets no longer count as Overrun (page 114) and the players may distribute 5 points worth of extra Reinforcements between their fleets' home systems (even fleets with depleted Reinforcements). The liberated mystics leave Hamura and the defenses there are swept away. The First Horizon fleet in Taoan may attack Hamura during the next War Turn.
Regardless of outcome	Unlock a mini mission of your choice. Play one or two mini missions before starting The Legacy of the Founders.

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SCENARIO:

THE LEGACY OF THE FOUNDERS

Shamsa Yimon is waiting in the cantina of the mining colony, trying to keep his hands from shaking as he grips his mug of tabak-infused chai. An ordinary-looking man comes over and sits down, wearing a plain shawl around his head. His scarred neck and sinewy arms are covered in spindly glyph tattoos.

"Mister Yimon. My masters accept your demands. Djachroum will be yours and you are free to restore your clan's status in the Reach by toppling the unjust rule of the Akbar. In return, you will give us access to the forbidden parts of the station. And should you ever choose to go against us, the wrath of the Serafs will be terrible. The last thing you'll see before your families perish in our purging fires will be great, shimmering wings blotting out the sun."

OVERVIEW

The return of the Janhagir fleet and the attack on Xene has strengthened the Third Horizon's defenses but the Vestals have already planned ahead. They are getting ready to activate the sugar globes and release death and destruction upon the Horizon through the awakening of the hashara swarms that will kill or corrupt everything in their path.

Agents from the decimated Nazareem's Sacrifice are sent to Djachroum in the Rimward Reach to find the key that activates the mythical Armada of the Firstcome deep in the Kandah cloud. More information on Djachroum can be found on page 54. The hatching of the sugar globes may lead to no reinforcements for the Third Horizon during this War Turn (see page 166).

THE ARMADA

The greatest mystery of the Mouth of Kandah is the fleet of abandoned ships left behind by the Founders after they suddenly disappeared – the Armada of the Firstcome. The armada can be found near the Djerid asteroid cluster containing the most intact Founder ruins, Mining Station 13. Both the Foundation and Akbar Fatiman have sent research expeditions to the station and their findings seem to conclude that its data cores are locked behind a bio cipher. The cipher can't be unlocked until the biocode of the original leaders is restored to the computer systems. The missing cipher sequences have survived in the forms of a flute and a talisman from the days of the Founders, made from the bones of the first leaders.

THE FOUNDER RELICS

The society of the Founders was started some four hundred cycles ago by the two original matriarchs, Mustira-Sama and Mustira-Muhit – "The Rulers of the Sky and the Sea." Sama is buried in the Twin Station and several relics were fashioned from her bones, among them a flute, meant to be played along the song routes. It was supposed to be passed down the generations from one leader to the next but has been forgotten – today it lies locked away in the darkness of the Twin Station. Muhit was buried in the second home of the Founders, the Natifa asteroid, whose name lives on only in legend as the ion storms of the Kandah devoured it long ago. Not even the most daring of prospectors has been able to get to it since. The lost Ahilar nomad swarm had a Muhit relic in their possession, a Judge talisman carved from her spine, but this has fallen into the hands of the Nazareem's Sacrifice.

THE MISSION

The First Horizon has brokered a deal with the Yimon prospector clan to overthrow Akbar Rakiv Fatiman and bring down the independent station of Djachroum. By creating chaos on the station, the agents of the Nazareem's Sacrifice can sneak into the otherwise locked second half of it and steal the biocode needed to take control of the Armada of the Firstcome. Additionally, they want to take out the Purple Guard and end their protection of the Kua system.

PC INCENTIVES

The PCs hear disturbing reports about the hatching of the sugar globes (and might even witness it firsthand if you play the "The Hatching" event (below) or the A Ravenous Dark mini mission, page 123). Several large battleships and important hubs in the Third Horizon are swept up in a panicked frenzy as the dark swarms attack. The hashara kill or corrupt using dark memes and afflictions and command the enslaved swarmbound to hunt down any survivors.

The news of these events is followed by reports from factionary agents about the Yimon prospector clan challenging

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the Akbar for control of Djachroum from their home base on the Nexus asteroid. The agents have been informed about an imminent coup onboard the station, threatening the power balance in the whole system. The PCs and a small squadron of warships from whichever faction the PCs are most closely allied with must travel to Djachroum and try to stop the coup. Mystic PCs might experience premonitions and see visions of the coup makers and instead learn of it this way.

MAJOR EVENTS

The PCs arrive to a station in turmoil and must try to rescue the Akbar and then catch up to the Nazareem agents rushing to unlock the Armada of the Firstcome. You might need to alter the scenario a bit depending on when and where the PCs catch up with the agents. Make sure to be well-prepared and read-up on the various events.

THE HATCHING

The scenario might find the PCs in a number of locations – praying in their chapel, asleep in their bunks, relaxing in a cantina or space station oporia, in an important fleet meeting onboard an allied ship, in secretive dealings with a former patron, etcetera. Wherever they are, the soft glow of a couple of sugar globes illuminates the scene, their fragrant, syrupy water scenting the room. The artifacts have been considered collector's items and symbols of wealth for as long as anyone



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POWER IN THE DARKNESS

Far from the squabbling of the factions
lie the ruins of greatness past.
An armada among the stars,
bound to the bones of the Founders,
strong enough to tip the scales.
Under the wings of the butterfly,
in the shadows of the night,
ancient enemies walk, unseen,
seeking the forgotten key.

THE MACHINE ICON

SWARMBOUND, CORRUPTED HUMAN

A swarmbound person awakens enslaved by the hashara. She retains her original attribute scores but gets 5 additional HP and is now immune to stress and stun weapons. She gets a natural armor rating of 3 and fights with a newfound frenzy in close combat (**MELEE COMBAT** +4). Her accuracy becomes slightly reduced (**RANGED COMBAT** –1). She can no longer be manipulated but can still handle weapons and basic tools. The swarmbound are slaves to the Vestals but will hunt and kill mystics unless given other orders. They become susceptible to the dark between the stars and may use one random power from the list below per turn for 1 DP.

can remember. If you want to, the Machine Icon may try to warn the PCs that something bad is about to happen.

Suddenly, mystic PCs feel an icy pain and hear a sharp, shrill note that drowns out all other sounds. A feeling of elated love and immeasurable hate overflows them. The episode reminds them of what they felt when faced with their first Vestal during The Last Cylade or during their more recent visit to Sadaal. The light from the sugar globes intensifies, they absorb the water they're in and swell up. After a couple of seconds, they suddenly go out, the last of their dying light showing shadowy movement inside them. Darkness comes ripping through tears in thin air above the vats and is sucked into the globes. Something groans, cracks – hatches. Soft membranes harden into shells that break apart and swirl around in the water inside the vats. A second later, something black emerges – first it looks like oil, then like insects, hundreds – thousands – of insects. They rapidly fill the vats and bowls, overflow and fall onto the floor and the tables. Tiny legs and wings unfold, and they begin to move. Dark forms swarm together, seemingly bending light around them. They create strange heat shimmers in the air, distorting everything around them as they start to attack.

At the cost of 1 DP, a small swarm hatches. For 2 DP, it's a large one. The swarms get two turns of free power activations, after that the powers cost DP as per the list in the description. The hatching doesn't begin simultaneously all over the Third Horizon – it will take a couple of weeks for the chaos to spread. The Vestals relentlessly activate their secret weapon and lay waste to station after station, world after world.

Cost: 1–2 DP

HASHARA SWARM, DARKMORPHS

The hashara are a biological weapon lying dormant inside the sugar globes. Until activated, they are nothing more than cells and genomes in liquid form, ready to take shape. If given sugar water, their metabolism grows and the globe can grow somewhat in size. The excess energy produced is given off as light and a slight warmth.

APPEARANCE: When the dark from between the stars seeps into a sugar globe, the cells inside activate and merge. This leads to the hatching of insects that are each about the size of a thumbnail, resembling ancient Ardhan trilobites. The size of the globe determines the overall size of the swarm. The shells of the hashara are

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impossibly black, almost as if light bends around and past them, which makes them all but invisible when they move, appearing more like a heat shimmer in the air than as actual insects. Spotting a moving swarm requires an **OBSERVATION** test at –1 for a big swarm and at –2 for a small one. When the swarm attacks, it becomes gruesomely visible, however, covering the victim in a black, slow-moving, crawling cocoon.

CHARACTERISTICS: The creatures attempt to gather in larger and larger swarms and primarily target and kill mystics. Non-mystics caught in the way of a swarm are instead often changed and twisted by dark memes.

ATTRIBUTES: STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5
HIT POINTS: 26 (huge swarm), 16 (large swarm), 6 (small swarm)
SKILLS: Mystic Powers 6, Dexterity 5, Observation 5, Infiltration 3
ACTIVATIONS: 2 (huge swarm, 3 AP each), 1 (large or small swarm, 3 AP)
WEAPONS: Only spend DP when the swarms attack PCs, not others.

- **DARK WAVE:** As a Slow action, the swarm can try to stay hidden (**INFILTRATION** vs **OBSERVATION**) and then fall upon or lunge at its target and cover it over. The attack roll is a **DEXTERITY** test (armor may be tested) and the swarm tries to get underneath the victim's clothes. If it manages to inflict damage, see below.

  HUGE SWARM – Moves 10 meters per AP, covers up to ten victims within Short range

  LARGE SWARM – Moves 10 meters per AP, covers up to three victims within Close range

  SMALL SWARM – Moves 5 meter per AP, covers one victim within Close range
- **CAUSTIC COCOON (1 DP):** Only mystic targets. The hashara try to get in underneath the victim's armor and clothes. The attack is a Slow action.

  DAMAGE – The attack is equivalent to a strength 5 fire attack each turn (no armor rolls, Coriolis core rulebook page 97). Also inflicts 1 point of stress.

  BROKEN – If the victim becomes broken, she also suffers a critical injury. If the swarm continues attacking in the following turn, the victim suffers another critical injury from the 61–66 entries on the Critical Injuries table (roll one die). After that, the swarm leaves its victim to die and moves on.

  DEFENSE – Fire, extreme heat or cold or vacuum for two turns can force the swarm to release its victim, as can beating it in an opposed **MYSTIC POWERS** test.

TABLE 29: SWARMBOUND POWERS (1 DP)

D6	POWER	DESCRIPTION
1	From within	Targets all within Close range. Opposed MYSTIC POWERS roll. Targets who fail see and feel black worms burst from tears opening in their skin. The hallucination inflicts 1 point of stress, plus 1 additional point for each of the swarmbound's winning 6s.
2	Blink	The creature phases through portal space in the blink of an eye, disappearing and then reappearing somewhere within twenty meters. If someone else occupies the space the swarmbound reappears in, the movement counts as a strength 5 attack (INIT +1, damage 2, CRIT 2). The attack strength may be lowered by the target successfully testing OBSERVATION (-1 to attack strength per 6 rolled).
3	Blinding	The creature radiates blinding light and heat, becoming overwhelmingly beautiful to all within ten meters. Those affected must pass an OBSERVATION test (1 AP) before each action requiring eyesight during their coming turn. Visors and hi-tech filters may protect against the light.
4	Coral skin	A shell of porous coral forms on the creature's skin. It counts as ablative pads (-3 to next damage from next hit).
5	Dark embrace	Black spikes of coral and nightmarish malformations of bone grow out to cover the creature's skin. It then attempts to body slam its victim. Attack using MELEE COMBAT (damage 2, CRIT 2), target tests DEXTERITY instead of armor.
6	Swarm birth	The creature is devoured from within and births a new hashara swarm. The thick stench of decay is overwhelming. Roll a D6: 1–3 small swarm, 4–5 large swarm, 6 huge swarm.

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- **DARK CORRUPTION (1 DP):** Only non-mystic targets. The dark wave envelops and twists its target as a Slow action. Like above, the swarms tries to get in underneath armor and clothes.
  DAMAGE – 1 point of stress per attack.
  BROKEN – If broken by stress, the corruption begins.
  CORRUPTION – As a Slow action, the swarm tries to beat the victim in an opposed **MYSTIC POWERS** vs **FORCE** or **SURVIVAL** roll. If the swarm wins by two 6s, the victim suffers a mania (Coriolis core rulebook 337 or *The Last Cyclade* page 69). If the swarm wins by three or more 6s, the victim is struck by a powerful fever and loses consciousness. Unless treated with **MEDICURGY** at –2 within four hours of the attack, the victim awakens as a swarmbound slave (page 156).
  DEFENSE – As above, but the swarm's priority will always be mystics, meaning that if a mystic character is within Long range of the swarm, it will release its non-mystic victim and instead move toward the mystic (see box).

TYPICAL SWARMBOUND

ATTRIBUTES:
STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 4, WITS 3, EMPATHY 4

HIT POINTS: 12

SKILLS: Melee Combat 7, Mystic Powers 6, Dexterity 3, Observation 2, Ranged Combat 1

THE FALL OF THE FREE STATION

As the PCs arrive on Djachroum, both the station itself and the surrounding space is in complete chaos. A cry for help comes over the radio. If the PCs identify themselves to the caller and ask about the Akbar or the Horizon Council, they are informed that the Council was evacuated but that the Akbar is trapped in the Governor's Palace in the heart of the station (see map on page 161). Hashara swarms have attacked the Purple Guard and the inhabited parts of the station. People are flooding to the spaceport in a blind panic. Meanwhile, the Yimon putschists engage the remaining Purple Guard in firefights in the streets. If the PCs find a Purple Guard, she can tell them that the Akbar is trapped in the main hall of the palace together with his bodyguard, but that the Yimon are advancing, seemingly unaffected by the spawn of the sugar globes. You can either use some of the events below as the PCs make their way to the palace or make up your own:

Cost: Varies (see table)

FATIMAN DETHRONED

The PCs reach the palace and are about to enter the council hall when the ceiling suddenly caves in. Among the rubble and debris, they eventually find Akbar Fatiman (page 160), several of his dead bodyguards and perhaps also another member of the Horizon Council. The Akbar is wounded but alive (critical injuries 32 "Broken Arm", 35 "Gouged Eye" and 53 "Bleeding Gut"). At the cost of 1 DP, he is unconscious from his stomach wound and requires treatment using MEDICURGY before he can speak. The wounds aren't primarily from the cave-in, however, but look to be from a dura knife. He can tell the PCs that:

- Two people entered the palace.
- One of them was thin and gangly, with pale skin and androgynous features. Their black eyes seemed to pierce his soul.

TABLE 30: NPCS IN THE FALL OF THE FREE STATION

	STRENGTH	AGILITY	WITS	EMPATHY	HP	DP	REP	SKILLS	GEAR
Yimon putschist	3	3	3	2	7	5	4	Dexterity 4, Melee Combat 3, Observation 2, Ranged Combat 2	Vulcan pistol, dura axe, light armor (armor 4)
Djachroum Purple Guard	3	4	3	2	7	5	6	Melee Combat 4, Ranged Combat 4, Dexterity 3, Manipulation 3, Observation 3, Infiltration 2	Acc carbine, heavy armor (armor 6), personal communicator

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TABLE 31: EVENTS ON DJACHROUM

D6	EVENT	DESCRIPTION
1	SWARM!	The PCs reach a calmer alley or corridor. Empty vessels along the walls and small shell pieces on the ground tell them sugar globes probably used to illuminate the area. Now, all that's left is the soft flutter of the swarm's wings as they attack. For 0 DP, it's a small swarm, for 2 DP it's a large one and at the cost of 3 DP, the PCs are attacked by a huge swarm.
2	FIREFIGHT	Yimon putschists are fighting their way toward the Governor's Palace to capture or kill Akbar Fatiman. They are either already in the Cave of Bridges, at the palace gates or nearby. Two groups are pinned down, exchanging fire from behind makeshift barricades, street corners and sheds. The PCs can choose to intervene or take advantage of the situation to divert attention from their entering the palace from a different direction. The coup-makers are setting up a grenade launcher, however...
3	REFUGEES	A family with three children spring at the PCs. They are residents of Djachroum with nowhere to run – can the PCs help them find safe shelter or bring them onboard their ship?
4	HASHARA BURNS	A badly burned resident or Purple Guard pleads for the PCs' help. A successful MEDICURGY test at -1 is required to stabilize the injuries. If the PCs succeed, the patient tells them how to fight off the swarms.
5	SWARMBOUND	People come running out of a cantina in fear, chased by one (0 DP) or three (2 DP) swarmbound. If the PCs draw attention to themselves, the swarmbound attack them instead but if they ignore the situation, they see the darkmorphs catch up to the fleeing civilians and start tearing them apart.
6	EXECUTION	Yimon putschists (page 158) have captured a handful of Purple Guards and forced them to their knees in the street, hands behind their heads. The leader of the group, Amshar Yimon, is aggressive and feels pressured to shoot the prisoners. The fact that the Guard captain, Narid Karoum, heckles them as cowardly traitors doesn't make things better. The PCs can either ignore the situation (in which case it will very likely lead to the summary execution of the Purple Guards) or intervene and negotiate.



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- The other had a more ordinary appearance.
- They were surrounded by hashara swarms flying and crawling around them but without touching them.
- The pale one was a mystic and made Fatiman's bodyguards turn on each other. Then it was as if an invisible hand gripped him and he couldn't move or resist as the second person walked up to him and cut out a bionic chip from inside his arm and took out one of his eyes.
- The person with the knife had scar patterns in the shapes of strange glyphs on their forearms.

  A **CULTURE** test at –1 or **MYSTIC POWERS** at –3 can inform the PCs that the duo is likely a Nazareem leader and an acolyte, both under Vestal protection.
- **The Key:** The biochip taken from the Akbar's arm unlocks the forbidden Twin Station and the old Founder ruins. Deep down, below the life support systems and the tireless work of the operators, lies a chamber full of old relics and a research facility used to analyze the Founder archive retrieved from Mining Station 13. In its data cores, a partial bio cipher was discovered that somehow appears to relate to the Armada of the Firstcome. The cipher sequence looks to fit with bio code extracted from an old Founder relic but the process is incomplete.

  The PCs must now make a choice between chasing after the Nazareem agents or staying behind to protect the Akbar. He is still in mortal danger as the coup-makers are about to break through into the palace. You choose how likely he is to be killed if the PCs decide to leave (see Outcomes, page 166).

Cost: 0, 1 DP

RAKIV FATIMAN

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 2, WITS 4, EMPATHY 4**
HIT POINTS: 5
MIND POINTS: 8
REPUTATION: 8
SKILLS: Culture 5, Manipulation 5, Command 4, Dexterity 3, Melee Combat 3, Science 3, Ranged Combat 2
GEAR: Talisman (the Lady), fine clothing, healing scarab, personal communicator, mercurium sword

TIME UNITS (TU)

The Nazareem agents are heading to the Twin Station and the forbidden parts of Djachroum. If they make it inside and out before the PCs catch up, they will be able to escape unharmed. Measure the chase in Time Units, TU, rather than minutes and hours to keep things flowing. The cultists need 7 TU to complete their task (as they're already at Eskalom's rift) and the PCs start one step behind (at the Governor's Palace). The steps below detail what the Nazareem need to do:

1. Exit the Governor's Palace and the Cave of Bridges (PCs begin here)
2. Cross Eskalom's rift (cultists begin here)
3. Set the hashara swarms on the operators of the Twin Station
4. Destroy the security systems and reach the vault
5. Find the relics and secure the armada key
6. Exit through a side tunnel to the surface of the asteroid
7. Power up their courier ship
8. Leave the station (see "The Fate of the Armada", page 166)

The PCs can try to catch up to the cultists. Each sector in the "The Twin Station" event below involves one key dice roll that determines how fast the PCs are going. Let them know how well they do in the tests determines how fast they can travel. You can also let them know that they're only one sector behind the Nazareem. Naturally, you can always disregard the rules and have the PCs catch up in a sector of your choice, regardless of dice rolls.

- **FAILURE:** 2 TU
- **SUCCESS (ONE OR TWO 6S):** 1 TU
- **CRITICAL SUCCESS (THREE+ 6S):** 0 TU

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THE TWIN STATION

A lot can happen along the way as the PCs chase after the cultists. Each sector contains one important die roll or event for the PCs to overcome. Depending on how well they perform, the time it takes them to make it through the different sectors varies (see "Time Units" box). Here and there, they see evidence of hashara swarms having accompanied the Nazareem. If the PCs intercept and defeat the cultists before they reach the relics chamber (see below), the areas further in have yet to be reached by the darkmorph and the PCs might instead meet the reclusive, fine-limbed operators living in the tunnels of the Twin Station. In this case, some extra improvisation will be required but you should nonetheless acquaint yourself with the sector descriptions before you begin.

0. Fatiman's Well-being: The PCs are 1 TU behind the cultists when the chase begins but might lose additional time before making it across Eskalom's rift.

- **+1 TU:** Failing the MEDICURGY roll when waking up the Akbar (if he's knocked out) costs 1 TU. A successful roll is free.
- **+2 TU:** Making sure the Akbar and any straggling Council members are safe costs 2 TU. This could for example be done by taking them back to the PCs' ship for evacuation. The TU expenditure also includes making it to Eskalom's rift after the rescuees are safe.
- Flying to Eskalom's rift won't be quicker than walking because of the time it will take them to power up the ship and depart.

THE TWIN STATION



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1. **The Sector of the Lady of Tears:** The PCs must exit the palace and the Cave of Bridges, make it through the fleeing masses, the swarming hashara and the trigger-happy putschists. They might try to maneuver around and avoid a fight or choose to fight their way through the Yimon coupists head on.
   - **Combat:** Five turns of combat or less counts as a quick fight and won't cost the PCs any TU, but any more than that will cost them 1 TU. If any of them become broken or pass out from a critical injury, getting out of the sector costs them a total of 2 TU.
   - **Stealth:** Sneaking out undetected requires an INFILTRATION test at –2. Another character may assist by testing OBSERVATION or MANIPULATION (to scout/ask for directions) and award bonus dice to the INFILTRATION test for each 6 rolled. A failed attempt at sneaking out might still keep them out of combat but the escape will instead cost 2 TU.
2. **Eskalom's Rift:** Beyond the Tear and the other inhabited sectors, a network of dura beams keeps the dug-out asteroid together. The deep cut through the middle of the asteroid can only be crossed via an old steel bridge connecting the forbidden sector to the open areas.
   - **Space Walk:** Crossing the bridge in low G requires the PCs to get exos. Basic exo suits can be found in nearby workshops or stevedore halls. The leading PC must pass a DEXTERITY test at –1 to guide the rest of the group across the girders to the airlock on the other side (which has already been opened by the Nazareem).
3. **The Engine Halls:** The halls beyond the airlock are full of pipes, cables and ancient computers. The area looks more like an anthill than a space station. The caretakers of this ancient machinery, the operators (see box), get around by climbing on grips in the walls and by hooking their exos onto rail systems in the ceilings.
   - **Finding the Way:** Navigating through the engine halls in low G is difficult. One PC must test either TECHNOLOGY or SCIENCE to lead the way, the outcome of the roll affecting how much time they need to make it through. As the PCs aren't native to low G environments, they get a –1 to all mobility actions.
   - **Dark Harvest:** The pipes and panels look almost burned from the dark swarms and it's not long before the PCs come upon the hasharas' victims floating in the tunnel or squeezed in-between pipes in desperate attempts to flee. The operators were swarmed by the darkmorphs and killed but some defended themselves with thermal cutters or cooling units. Dead hashara swirl around the bodies like soot.
   - **Hashara (1 DP):** At the cost of 1 DP, swarmbound operators attack the PCs (see stats on page 158). The attackers are one fewer than the PCs but if combat lasts for more than five turns, it still costs them 1 TU.
   - **The Survivor:** The PCs might come upon a wounded operator in need of help. The person's strange physiognomy gives the treating PC a –1 to MEDICURGY. If they stop to help, the outcome of the roll may cost additional TU (see the Time Units box above).
4. **The Home of the Founders:** On the other side of the winding engine halls, the PCs reach the heart of the Twin Station's forbidden sector. The airlock leading inside has already been opened.
   - **The Architecture:** The Founders' residential halls are built in a brutalist, geometrical style. The lines and intersecting cubes in the walls look like they shift or pulse when observed closely, almost as if they're breathing. TECHNOLOGY or SCIENCE reveals them as machinery rather than wall panels – heating grids, oxygen processors, energy couplings, dry irrigation channels and hydroponic beds. Glyphs and other strange patterns light up faintly when a surface is touched, revealed by DATA DJINN to indicate holo screens built into the machinery for some unknown purpose.
   - **Dark Harvest:** The tidal wave of darkness has swept through here as well, leaving corroded, almost burned areas in its wake. The PCs soon find wrecked thermal machineguns and stun weapons shot to pieces or ripped from their wall mounts.
   - **Active Defenses:** If the PCs reach this area before the Nazareem, the weapon systems are still active and will attack unless the PCs are carrying Fatiman's biochip. Use the stats for thermal machinegun and stun gun from the Coriolis core rulebook. Each weapon platform has either 6 HP (thermal) or 3 HP (stun). Scale the strength of the defenses to match your group but give a wary PC the opportunity to spot the weapons using OBSERVATION or RANGED COMBAT and figure out how they work.
   - **The Airlock:** Having crossed the residential areas, the PCs reach an airlock controlled by ancient locks and biometric

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scanners. Getting through requires a successful **DATA DJINN** or **TECHNOLOGY** test, or some form of explosive (satchel charge or grenade). If the PCs have already defeated the Nazareem, they might be carrying the Akbar's biochip, in which case they automatically score a critical success on their attempt to open the door (0 TU).

5. **The Vault:** The vault of the Founders is an octagonal chamber with a semi-translucent calcite pillar in the middle, cloudy and glass-like. The walls and ceilings are covered in frost and the air is stale. Alcoves repeat around the eight facets in the wall, each covered by a membrane of black obsidian.
   - **The Lights:** The walls glow faintly, something **SCIENCE** can reveal to be the result of luminescent microbes living off the rock in the walls.
   - **Radiation (1 DP):** At the cost of 1 DP, the PCs feel heavy and nauseous as they enter. Their suit sensors warn of high doses of radiation in the room (Strong Radiation, Coriolis core rulebook page 99).



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- **Fatiman's Laboratory:** Analysis gear, sensors and lab equipment have all been set up around the room by the Akbar's engineers. DATA DJINN can tell the PCs that part of the bio cipher they need has been stored on the mobile lab's emerald disc. Several of the alcoves in the walls have been emptied and the black mineral has been drilled apart.
- **The Relic:** The key to the Armada of the Firstcome is stored in the biocode in the flute and amulet crafted from the bones of the Founder matriarchs. The flute can be found in the vault inside a locked vacuum box of hardened duralite, unless the Nazareem got here before the PCs and stole it. If the PCs perform no advanced actions in the vault, the encounter costs 0 TU.

6. **The Side Exit:** The side corridor used by the cultists begins at a second airlock in the vault and leads through winding tunnels through the mysterious home of the Founders. The area is unnervingly quiet and desolate.
   - **Through the Tunnels:** If the PCs aren't in a rush, traveling the tunnels is easy and costs 1 TU. If they need to move faster, one of them must lead the way by passing DEXTERITY at –1 due to the low gravity. An OBSERVATION test by another character can aid the guide (+1 per rolled 6).
   - **Ambush (1–2 DP):** If the PCs are right behind the Nazareem, the cultists may choose to try and ambush the pursuers. For 1 DP, the ambush consists of a large hashara swarm and at the cost of 2 DP, it's both a large swarm and the cultists themselves. Use this event if you want to end the chase before the Nazareem reach their ship.
   - **The Exit:** The PCs eventually reach a corridor containing twenty-something airlocks that only appear to open from the inside – possibly a station of long-since ejected escape pods. The Nazareem's ship is docked on the surface of the asteroid outside the airlocks.
   - **Hard Choices:** If the Nazareem manage to flee, the PCs must decide if they want to chase after them into the Mouth of Kandah or if they should turn around and leave the station, with or without the wounded Akbar (see Outcomes, page 166). If they have acquired the biocode key, they may now proceed to the Armada of the Firstcome if they like.

Cost: Varies (see description)

ALKAZU, NAZAREEM GRAND MASTER

Alkazu Eb-Shûdaar used to be the arch herat of the Nazareem's Sacrifice's fortress on Rusah in Odacon a century before the Portal War. He is a descendant of the nomad swarms but gave himself to U'Haya after having been rescued by the Serafs during a failed portal jump in Taoan.

FOLLOWERS: Alkazu went into hibernation deep in the Miran jungles. A cult of loyal settlers grew around him and sacrifices kept the cadaver clock ticking in his honor. Two of his devotees are with him on the mission to Djachroum – Alam Masheed and Tarek U'gava (see "Loyalist" below). The PCs might encounter Alam in the Twin Station.

APPEARANCE: Sacrificial killings have kept Alkazu alive over the centuries and his thin body is still strong even if the dark years have made him as pale as milk. The corrupting forces of the cadaver clock cause his chapped skin to flake like old parchment.

CHARACTERISTICS: Moves his hands slowly and deliberately in the air when speaking, as if playing an unseen musical instrument.

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5, WITS 4, EMPATHY 5**
HIT POINTS: 10
MIND POINTS: 9
REPUTATION: 8
SKILLS: Culture 10, Command 8, Mystic Powers 8, Manipulation 7, Dexterity 6, Observation 5, Force 4, Medicurgy 4, Melee Combat 4, Ranged Combat 3, Science 3, Technology 3
TALENTS: Heart of the Beast, Kinetic Absorption, Gaze of Madness, Bladestorm, Swarmsong
ARMOR: 5 (see Kinetic Absorption below)
GEAR: Thermal pistol, exo, dura knife, Judge bone amulet, bone flute and bio cipher emerald disc (if retrieved from the vault)

- **HEART OF THE BEAST:** Altered biocode. +2 HP, immune to stress but not stun weapons (The Last Cylade, page 113).
- **KINETIC ABSORPTION:** Bionic scale armor reduces damage taken from first hit every turn by 2 (***The Last Cyclade***, page 166).
- **GAZE OF MADNESS (1 DP):** Roll an opposed **MYSTIC POWERS** against one target within Short range. If Alkazu wins, the target suffers a

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mania (Coriolis core rulebook, page 337) plus 1 point of stress for each winning 6. If the target becomes broken by the MP loss, the mania becomes permanent.

- **BLADESTORM (1 DP):** The grand master uses all his AP and may attack up to five times within Short range using a melee weapon. The attack rolls use **DEXTERITY**. Each attack must succeed for the bladestorm to continue. If the attacks deal no damage at all, the grand master instead suffers 2 points of either damage or stress.
- **SWARMSONG (1–2 DP):** The grand master can call upon and command a hashara swarm (page 156). For 1 DP, a small swarm is summoned and for 2 DP, a large one. The swarm arrives after D6 turns unless already nearby.

THE OPERATORS

The operators are gangly, androgynous humanites with long limbs, heavily bio sculpted for a life in low G in the ancient engine halls of the Twin Station. They are sculpted from birth in labs that resemble the ones used to produce the humanites that first colonized the Horizons. They live their lives in the narrow, anthill-esque tunnels of the engine halls, wearing light, copper red exos (Talents: Exo Specialist). Their biological and linguistic origins can be traced to Uharu whose original settlers were relatives of the operators.

The operators are agile and move almost noiselessly through the tunnels (Agility 5, **DEXTERITY** 4, **FORCE** 1). They are so indoctrinated and focused on their tasks and purpose (Wits 4, **DATA DJINN** 5, **TECHNOLOGY** 5) that they hardly even notice visitors. Violence or an opposed **MANIPULATION** (+1) vs (Empathy 3, **MANIPULATION** 3) is required to make them stop and answer questions.

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LOYALIST

ATTRIBUTES: **STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 3, WITS 4, EMPATHY 4**
HIT POINTS: 5
MIND POINTS: 8
REPUTATION: 4
SKILLS: Culture 4, Infiltration 4, Manipulation 4, Technology 4, Data Djinn 3, Observation 3, Pilot 3, Dexterity 2, Melee Combat 2, Science 2
GEAR: Armasuit (armor 3), Vulcan pistol, Beast talisman (+1 to any one roll), thermal cutter, advanced tools, modulation mask
TALENTS: Third Eye, Judge of Character

THE FATE OF THE ARMADA

Depending on how the chase through the Twin Station has gone, the situation may look vastly different:

- The PCs might be chasing the Nazareem through space (use stats and plans for Birbasil's Dream, page 66) which may lead to space combat and boarding attempts (if the PCs wish to get their hands on the key). Alternatively, the PCs might try to blow up the cultists' ship to make sure no one can assume control of the armada. To make the chase and the combat more varied, use the ion storms on page 57.
- The PCs might already have defeated the Nazareem and found both relics, giving them the option to decipher the biocode key. For 2 DP, more agents may be hunting them and for 3 DP, they might even have to out-maneuver a butterfly ship (page 196). As above, use the Kandah ion storms to add flavor to the scene.

When the PCs reach the defensive perimeter of the armada (at least 2 combat units away), the cipher key can be prepared and transmitted using DATA DJINN. If the roll succeeds, the armada's response (interpreted using CULTURE at +1) is to ask for a meeting with the new commander. An airlock on one of the ships is activated for docking and a safe approach corridor is set up through the armada's defenses. The actual entry into the ship requires a spacewalk. After having walked across the hull of the ancient ship and entered the airlock, the doors close and lock and the character's biocode is scanned and registered as the armada's new commander. Then, the airlock door opens out into space again.

If the initial DATA DJINN test fails, the armada launches two antimatter torpedoes against the PCs' ship.

Cost: 0 DP

ENDING

The PCs leave Djachroum and their actions determine how the mission ends. If they have failed, part or all of the Rimward Reach will fall into enemy hands and the defense of Kua will be severely crippled. Their actions might also lead to a new fleet under the control of the Third Horizon alliance or to the rising of the Reach's corsairs under their Akbar in an attempt to reconquer Djachroum and purge it of the forces of evil.

THE SUGAR GLOBES

If this is the first scenario in which the sugar globes activate and hatch, you may decide that no Third Horizon fleet gets the reinforcements they called for during this War Turn. Alternatively, rolling on the table below can determine how much, if any, reinforcements arrive. Roll once for each allied fleet who called for reinforcements in the previous War Turn. The hatching of the hashara spreads death and chaos throughout the cluster.

OUTCOMES

- **Successful Coup:** The Yimon coup – aided by the Syndicate and the First Horizon – is successful and the body of Akbar Rakiv Fatiman is vented out of an airlock. Parts of the Purple Guard join the new rulers and bring back order to the station. Djachroum and the Rimward Reach assumes a neutral position in the war and the Kua system is no longer under corsair protection.
- **The Akbar Reinstated:** The ruler of Djachroum survives and returns to Djachroum with a fleet of loyal soldiers. They retake the station and drive the Yimon clan from the Reach. The hashara swarms are rooted out and the fleets of the Reach continue to protect Kua from enemy attacks.
- **The Armada Awakens:** If either side managed to activate the Armada of the Firstcome, huge numbers of ships now move through Kandah's darkness. If the Nazareem won the armada, an attack on Kua is imminent. If the PCs control the fleet, they decide which front to send it to.

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THE ARMADA AWAKENS

Unless the PCs claim the Armada of the Firstcome for the Third Horizon, they witness the Nazareem doing it for the Eternal Emperor from either the bridge of their ship or Mining Station 13. If the PCs chose not to pursue the cultists, you can still tell them about the activation of the armada to herald the coming threat:

"The ion storms of the Kandah cloud are reflected in the sculpted hulls of the battleships. Row upon row, dormant death waiting in the most inhospitable region of the Reach, a cemetery meant to guard the legacy of the Founders for all eternity. Suddenly, the ships come online, one by one lighting their anti-matter projectors. Armor sheets slide across the hulls to expose airlocks and torpedo batteries. Inside, the stasis units thaw out the crew – biosculpted constructs from a lost civilization. No outsiders are let onboard but the ships will obey the keybearer, the person who unlocked the cipher and brought them back to life – their new commander."

TABLE 32: THE HATCHING OF THE SUGAR GLOBES

D6	EFFECTS ON REINFORCEMENTS
1–3	The fleet receives the reinforcements they called for.
4	The fleet gets Strength +1 and Reinforcements -1.
5	The fleet receives no new units but must lower their Reinforcements score by 1.
6	No new units arrive, Reinforcements is lowered by 1 and the next fleet to roll on this table gets a +1 to their roll.

TABLE 33: METAGAME CHANGES

OUTCOME	CONSEQUENCE
The Akbar is killed and the coup successful	Djachroum is taken over by the Yimon clan who swear allegiance to the First Horizon. The fleets of the Purple Guard keeps out of the war and remains in the Reach.
The PCs fail to stop the Nazareem from activating the Armada of the Firstcome	The armada belongs to the First Horizon invaders and attacks Kua in the coming War Turn.
The PCs activate the Armada of the Firstcome	The PCs now control the armada and decide where to send it. Its starting position is Kua.
Regardless of outcome	Unlock a mini mission of your choice, for example A Ravenous Dark. Keep playing mini missions until War Turn 6 or 7 after which you prepare The Battle for the Horizon.

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SCENARIO:

THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON

Through the portal fields in Taoan, beyond the corrupting forces and dimensional streams of the dark between the stars, the fleets of the Eternal Emperor are waiting. In the ash belts that used to be the moons of Ainios, glittering cruisers and swarms of butterfly ships lie ready for when the bridge stabilizes. Smaller formations of ships jump through, their loyal crews risking certain death in the Void as they hope to reach the fronts in the distant Third Horizon.

On the surface of Ainios, below the ash and the fleets, a Monolith towers over a tempestuous ocean. It has been caged in dura steel and covered in glyph alloys to keep it from reacting against the centuries worth of dark corruption built up to feed the Emperor's power to change, warp and conquer the Horizons. The children of Ardha must be brought back to their home – and to their rightful ruler.

OVERVIEW

The First Horizon is pushing on toward Kua and there is no way to defeat them without taking out their way into the Third Horizon. A war council is convened together with the PCs to determine the fate of the Horizon. The bridge between the Horizons can be severed by destroying either the Monolith in Kua or the one on Ainios in the First Horizon (see below) as it will collapse the nearby portals. Then again, not many weapons are capable of destroying a Monolith…

THE DRACONITE AGENTS

Few people in the Third Horizon have caught as much as a glimpse of the First Horizon. In the vast darkness of the Void, however, the warrior monks of the Draconite faction have gathered forgotten technology and mythical artifacts and used the to capture and interrogate the agents of the Emperor. From the minds of their prisoners, they have extracted information about the coming darkness and formed a plan. From enslaved mystic gurus, the Draconites learned that the source of the Emperor's power is the bound Monoliths, and that the nearest one can be found in the Ainios system on the other side of the portal from Taoan. Ancient glyphs found in Portal Builder ruins indicate that the destruction of a Monolith would result in the complete collapse of all nearby portals. It would appear that this has never been attempted before, however. The prime objective of the Draconites is to liberate the Third Horizon from outside influence, preferably without placing themselves in the political limelight.

THE MONASTERY FORTRESS

The Amshaar monastery fortress can be found in Zalos and is the home of the war cult of the Cold Flame, led by grand master Samesh Alim. Deep inside the fortress lies the Naar-Abayda monastery cruiser, constructed around the devastating weapon that burned Rusah and ended the Portal Wars in Odacon. For the ship to be activated, the fortress must be destroyed – it has been constructed as a shield for the weapon until it fulfills its destiny: to cut off the Third Horizon from her enemies forever.

THE SPIDERS OF INDRA

The PCs will be given an old emerald disc from the days of Zalos' first settlement. It contains the code needed to awaken the Spiders of Indra, an ancient defense system lying dormant in Zalosian space. The Spiders are biomechanical constructs that consume all matter they come into contact with – something more than one reckless skipper has come to learn all too well. In the days of old, the Spiders led the followers of grand master Indra Ab-Shamoush, the original prophet, through the portals from the Second Horizon and into the protection of the Martyr's crown in Zalos. The Spiders of Indra can move through portals and surprise attack waiting enemies. Without them, the losses will be horrific.

THE ENTROPY OF PORTAL SPACE

The network of portals throughout the Horizons spans enormous distances and maps out the interstellar civilizations of the Portal Builders and their successors. The life that exists in normal space and the raw, dimensional chaos of the dark between the portals are constantly struggling, feeding the corruption referred to by most as "the darkness" – the madness and entropy ruling the black between the universe's tiny pockets of light.

THE MONOLITH NETWORK

Whole cultures were corrupted and fell before the Portal Builders created the Monoliths – a huge network of levelers, or lightning rods, designed to clear up corruption from the surrounding systems by attracting and burning it away.

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THE CAGED MONOLITH

The Third Horizon only contains two Monoliths but there are several others in nearby systems severed at the end of the Portal Wars. The nearest one can be found in the First Horizon system of Ainios, one jump from Taoan. The corrupting forces of the dark between the stars have been tamed by the Eternal Emperor and are used to fuel the Vestals' manipulations. The reality warping powers wielded by the First Horizon require a dampening of the Monoliths to work and a steel cage has therefore been constructed around the one in Ainios, made from unknown alloys that cancel out its reactive, leveling behavior. Centuries of corruption have built up inside the Ainios Monolith and if sprung from its cage, its discharge risks destroying what's left of the system.

THE MISSION

The remaining alliance admirals are discussing what looks like a hopeless situation. It has become clear that the fleets of the Eternal Emperor can't be defeated through conventional warfare. The texts from long since dead heroes of the Portal Wars all agree – the only way to stop the invasion is to attack the enemy in Kua and then once and for all sever the links between the Horizons.

THE ROAD TO VICTORY

Draconite agents have brought information about the Ainios Monolith to the Third Horizon's war council (see below). The PCs are tasked with luring parts of the First Horizon's fleets into an ambush by the Amshaar fortress in Zalos. Then, they will awaken the purging fires of the Naar-Abayda monastery cruiser and the ancient Spiders of Indra and lead the charge on one of the Monoliths.

MAJOR EVENTS

The campaign ends over a series of events where the PCs' choices lead the way. The scenario begins with the war council before the final battle after which the PCs act as bait to draw the enemy fleets away from Kua and into Zalos. During the ambush, the hidden weapons inside the Amshaar fortress are awakened. The alliance then brings all of their fleets into the final battle for Kua and the PCs must choose between space combat or a boarding attempt. Their objective is to get the Naar-Abayda to its final destination – the Monolith in either Kua or Ainios.

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MASS DEATH IN AINIOS

Attacking the Monolith in Ainios will lead to the destruction of thousands of Imperial troops (mainly humanites and Vestals) but the system also contains several inhabited planets and huge hubs of industry. Hence, the discharge from the Monolith won't only destroy the Imperial fleet but also lead to the deaths of almost fifteen billion people. It's up to you whether to inform your players about this or not.

THE PURPOSE OF THE MONOLITHS

NPCs close to the PCs – Foundation scientists, Draconites or perhaps grand master Alim – may entrust them with information and theories about the purpose of the Monoliths, the struggle between life and entropy and rumors about the Emperor's power source (see the headers "The Entropy of Portal Space", "The Monolith Network" and "The Caged Monolith").

THE MARTYRS OF THE CIRCLE

The circle shall close.
Under the Crown of the Martyr,
in the heart of Amshaar,
the cleansing fire awakens.
Indra's dark guides the spark
toward our enemy's pyre.
Lit by the flames, the Chosen,
the last and first Martyrs.

THE MARTYRS, IRIA URAHUK'S DECREES

⚙ THE WAR COUNCIL

After intense fighting, many of the allied factions are about to fall apart and some may already have lost their home worlds to the invaders. Choose a system near Kua still under Third Horizon control (but not Zalos). A battered fleet of flagships and torpedo ships gathers for a final war council and the leaders and admirals meet onboard the portal station. Soldiers from the participating factions line the halls and have taken over all local businesses, making the station into more of an army garrison than a trading post.

If the PCs managed to rescue the delegates during The Tenth Icon (page 49), the survivors may also be represented at the war council. Choose six to eight factionary representatives best suited to your campaign either from the list below or from your own gallery of NPCs. Use the delegates marked with asterisks (*) for the default makeup.

The Council convenes in a chamber packed with holo screens and armed guards. The sometimes hotly debated items on the agenda are:

- **Summary:** An overview of the current state of the fleets and which systems have fallen. The war so far.
- **Reinforcements:** It has become clear that the First Horizon appears to have endless reinforcements out of Dabaran and Taoan. New ships arrive or are produced behind the fronts.
- **United Front:** The allied fleets must give up on protecting their different home worlds and instead gather their forces for a joint attack to push back the invaders.
- **The Portals:** Several of the attendees warn that this won't be enough and either Eran Sidonna (the Foundation), Mandragor Ho (the Draconites), Samesh Alim (the Order), Azir Chabaun (the Order) or an NPC of your own says that there is only one option left – destroying the portals between the enemy and the Third Horizon.
- **More Time:** The enemy is so deep into the core systems that an ambush or a trap of some kind must be arranged to buy the alliance more time to gather for the final assault.
- **The Bait:** A character close to the PCs – for example Samesh Alim or Mandragor Ho – proposes to bait parts of the Imperial forces into Zalos and lure them into an ambush. They then turn toward the PCs and the room falls silent. The Third Horizon needs the bait to be valuable enough that the First Horizon would risk their fleets to destroy it: the PCs.

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TABLE 34: LEADERS OF THE WAR COUNCIL

NAME	DESCRIPTION
Khaleem Hydarnes*	The Martyr Council, the Order of the Pariah, former delegate
Mata Amri	The Church of the Icons, former delegate
Sandar Artabazus	Corsair akbar at the Alabaster Council, the Nomad Federation, former delegate
Ana Din Eusidia	Neo-Zenithian lobbyist, former delegate
Samesh Alim*	Grand master and member of the Martyr Council
Azir Chabaun	New grand master if Samesh Alim has died
Sadhi Bat-Erden	Aishan's Emporium, Draconite (present if Mandragor Ho is unavailable)
Mandragor Ho*	Lord Zazû of the Draconites, former patron
Faida Din Hrama*	Captain of the Asarita flagship, Zenithian, former patron
Eran Sidonna	Chief scientist of the Foundation's astronics division, Zenithian
Dinad Abarren-Quassar*	Council member on Djachroum, Zenithian
Azin Ghorashûd*	Janhagir admiral, the Nomad Federation
Fawzi Adani Edelaat*	Corsair captain in the Purple Guard
Jarouma Had Peleter	Former chief explorator for the Foundation, Zenithian

- **Guarantees:** Both the Draconites and the Order ensure the PCs that their remaining fleets will protect them and that they are strong enough to do serious damage to the First Horizon. The Order mentions the ancient weapon they keep in their home system and the prophecies that say it will awaken once war returns to the cluster. The PCs only have to name what they need and it will be theirs – a faster ship, new mods, a larger crew – there's nothing the mission isn't worth.

Let the PCs come up with a strategy for how to get the First Horizon fleets to chase after them. COMMAND or MANIPULATION could give them hints about their enemies and help them form a plan. If they roll well, answer their questions or present them with a plan you've already thought of – a blitz torpedo attack against a high-value target somewhere to attract attention, leaking information about their whereabouts to First Horizon agents or perhaps the location of a butterfly ship or naval base they can take out to provoke retaliation by the Vestals. If Zalos has already fallen, they will have little use for strategy – they will only have to jump in and make sure they are spotted…
Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

TRUE PROPHETS OF THE MARTYR

The crew of the ***Naar-Abayda*** follows the true prophets of the Martyr – the PCs. This gives them full control of the choice of target but they don't have to choose until after they have gauged the opposition. Make sure they understand that whoever leaves the Third Horizon through the portal to Ainios is very unlikely to come back.

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REFUSAL

If the PCs refuse to act as bait to lure the First Horizon toward Amshaar, it will alter but not ruin the mission. The Imperial blockade in Kua will be too powerful for the Naar-Abayda cruiser to break through to get to the Hamura portals, forcing the alliance to attack the Kuan Monolith and break apart the Third Horizon. If the PCs are hesitant to accept the mission to act as bait, the war council members will make it clear that their chances of even cutting off Kua are slim unless the enemy's forces are divided. By not luring away the Imperial fleets into Zalos, the PCs risk allowing the Emperor to win the war altogether.

REACHING AMSHAAR

When they finally reach Amshaar, the PCs and their ship might be in bad shape. As they will be taken onboard the fortress before the final battle, this doesn't mean they're doomed. If things really take a turn and they're forced to abandon their ship, courier ships from an allied fleet will come and rescue them.

DESPERATE TIMES

As the PCs get ready to depart, they're given some additional information, likely by Samesh Alim or one of the Draconites (but any other NPC trusted by the heroes works fine). The person takes them aside and stresses how dire the situation has become – the Third Horizon will fall to the dark unless drastic measures are taken:

- **The Monoliths:** Portal field research by the Foundation or the Draconites has determined that no conventional weaponry in the Third Horizon is strong enough to collapse a portal. However, a forceful enough attack against a Monolith can lead to the destruction of all nearby portals.
- **The Target:** Old lore and intel from the Draconites' network of informants (see Overview above) indicates that the Ainios system in the First Horizon contains a Monolith and that it is linked via a portal with Taoan.
- **The Choice:** Later, the PCs will be forced to choose between sending the fleet to attack either Kua or Ainios.
- **The Weapon:** Zalos is the key to victory. The PCs are instructed to lead the forces of the First Horizon to the Amshaar fortress, the home base of grand master Alim, and to the forgotten artifact weapons known as the Spiders of Indra. The PCs are then given what looks like a carved crystal amulet wrapped in velvet. It turns out to be an ancient emerald disk from the Belit-Sheri scroll ship holding a cipher they must beam out to activate the Spiders as they approach Amshaar.

If Samesh Alim himself was the one who gave them the information, he will offer to accompany them to Amshaar (*The Last Cyclade*, page 90). If he's still alive but not present at the war council, he might instead be waiting for them at the fortress already. Later on, the PCs will come to learn that choosing to attack Ainios is likely to be a suicide run. After learning this, they must make the final decision about how to end the war.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

BAIT

The PCs can requisition upgrades to the ship they have or demand a new, faster one. Whatever plan they come up with for the attack will be sanctioned by the war council – it's up to them to decide how they will try to agitate and provoke the Vestals into pursuing them into the trap. If their plan involves

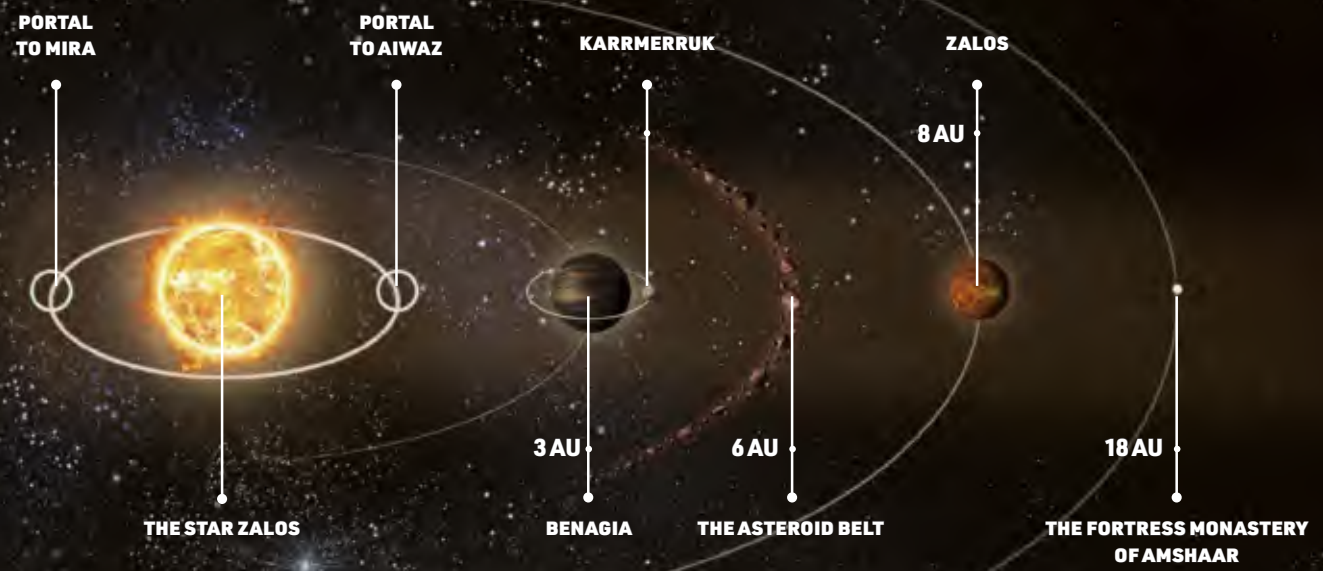
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an attack against the Imperial fleets to attract attention, play out a short scene where they fire a torpedo or deploy mines before they jump into Zalos.

If the First Horizon fleets are already present in Zalos, the PCs must break through their blockade. This will most likely require some help from one of the allied fleets such as the Draconites or perhaps the Armada of the Firstcome.

- **The System:** Karrmerruk is the moon of Benagia, 3 AU from the star. Farther out is an asteroid belt at 6 AU and the main world, Zalos, orbiting at 8 AU. The Amshaar fortress is even farther out, located at 18 AU from the star.
- **The Signal:** When the PCs arrive in the system, they should start broadcasting the cipher signal meant to awaken the Spiders of Indra. This will of course make it easier for the enemy to track them through the system but the Spiders might intervene on their behalf even before they reach the fortress (see the bullet "The Spider" below).
- **The Chase:** The vast emptiness of space means a blockading fleet can't be everywhere all the time. If the First Horizon has already invaded Zalos, the PCs might have to force their way through only a small blockade of ships before finding a couple of days of safety while the enemy scrambles to intercept. If Zalos is still free, the enemy jumps in right behind the PCs but the defending Order ships slow the pursuers down. Keep the PCs on high alert, their pursuers always just out of firing range. Introduce one or more of the events below to flavor the journey to Amshaar.
Use ship stats from pages 199–200).
  - **Torpedo (2 DP):** The PCs encounter a First Horizon torpedo ship that attempts to establish a lock on them to fire a fractal torpedo. The sensor operator (DATA DJINN) and the gunner (RANGED COMBAT) must work together to neutralize the incoming threat.
  - **Butterfly Ship (3 DP):** A butterfly ship is pursuing them and they are forced to perform evasive maneuvers using PILOT or roll TECHNOLOGY to spend all their EP on boosting their grav projectors to stay away from their hunter.
  - **Minefield (2 DP):** The First Horizon has mined the sector and the PCs must try to navigate through the field safely.
  - **Losses (0–2 DP):** The PCs are shielded by an accompanying fleet but see their protectors go down, one by one.

THE STAR SYSTEM ZALOS (A)



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NEW RULE: SLEEP DEPRIVATION

The PCs should be on such high alert that they don't dare sleep and resort to taking drugs to stay alert. For each three days without sleep, they must test Wits, **SURVIVAL** or **MYSTIC POWERS**. On failure, they suffer 2 points of stress that can't be recovered until they pass the next test after another three days or sleep for at least eight, uninterrupted hours. Stimulants give a +3 to the roll but for each test, roll a die – on a 6, the PC has developed an addiction and must consume her new drug of choice once every few days or suffer withdrawal (–1 to all rolls during one watch, activated using DP like a Problem).

For 2 DP, debris from a destroyed ally is hurled straight at them, forcing them to take evasive maneuvers at –2. The sensor operator may test **DATA DJINN** and negate the penalty if successful. If their ship is hit, it suffers 3 points of HP damage.

- **Atrocities of War (1 DP):** The enemy battleships are bombarding Zalos or Karrmerruk from orbit. The PCs can take a detour to attack the ships and spare civilian casualties but this reduces the cost of one of the events above by 2 DP.
- **The Spider (0 DP):** The PCs are in a tough spot but the signal they're beaming out does its job and the cipher



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activates one of Indra's Spiders. A cluster of shifting, asymmetrical monochrome specks unfolds to form long, spindly legs and glittering shields. It phases in and out of portal space as it moves (like the battleships of the First Horizon) and envelops the enemy ship in a torrent of rending arms within a matter of seconds. The hull is cut open and appears to be burned away by a bright light. Only twisted debris remains when the Spider is done. The weapon then folds back up and accompanies the PCs on their journey. More Spiders join along the way. Although powerful, the constructs aren't impervious and you can demonstrate this by describing how a fractal torpedo rips one of them apart to make sure the PCs don't feel too safe and sure of victory.

Cost: Varies (see list)

⚙ THE FALL AND REBIRTH OF AMSHAAR

The Amshaar fortress station has a wide orbit around the Zalosian sun. It's a relic from the Portal Wars that few but the followers of the Cold Flame have ever been allowed to visit. As the PCs begin their approach, they discover the fortress surrounded by torpedoes and acc fire. The enemy has either followed the PCs all the way here or already mounted a siege on the station.

- **The Fortress:** The martyr warriors onboard the station greet the PCs reverently and say they're ready to fulfill their destinies. The Spiders of Indra have converged around Amshaar and started tearing both the besieging fleet and the fortress itself to shreds. The fall of the station appears unavoidable. Emphasize the desperation onboard when people realize this, but the crew remain true to their oath and say that the fall of Amshaar signals the birth of their last hope. This is the end of days.
- **The Monastery Cruiser:** As the station is finally ripped apart, an enormous monastery cruiser bursts from deep inside the collapsing ruins. The ancient battleship has been constructed around a hollow lance painted in shimmering glyphs. This is Naar-Abayda, the weapon that burned Rusah and destroyed the Nazareem's Sacrifice in Odacon, the Cold Flame – the Lance of the Martyr.

  The PCs' ship is brought onboard and they are invited up to the bridge, a walk that takes them through the cruiser's gigantic prayer halls and arcades. They are given roomy cabins onboard, each with its own stasis unit. Teams of medicurgs stand ready to treat their wounds as needed. The ship is on high alert and engaged in active combat with the invaders as it tries to break through their siege. The Spiders surround it and tear incoming torpedoes and ships to pieces. The cruiser soon reaches the bulk of the enemy fleet in Zalos (which you can locate as you like – in the asteroid belt, around Zalos or near the star over Benagia).
- **The Lance:** The PCs are summoned to the bridge by grand master Alim (or his successor Azir Chabaun). They are to witness the rebirth of the Lance of the Martyr. The grand master speaks of the enemy's failed manipulations and futile stealth technology – nothing can save them now, the cleansing fires of the Martyr will burn away the dark between the stars (see quote).

  The gun crews sit before ancient control panels and after the grand master gives the order, one of them activates the weapon's firing sequence. Crackling static electricity and a blinding light fills the bridge and the air becomes heavy. The Lance firing shuts down the screens and controls for a moment and a blade of flames rips through the system. All worlds within 3 AU burn and ships evaporate within seconds. Then, everything goes quiet.
- **The Lance's Might:** After firing, the grand master tells the PCs that the weapon's remaining charge has been depleted but that this was only a small demonstration of the weapon's full force. For the final discharge, it needs to charge in the corona of the star in the system it will attack. Only this can make it powerful enough to have a chance of destroying a Monolith. The journey toward Kua, toward the final battle, begins.
- **Preparations:** The PCs are well taken care of and can rest up a little as the Naar-Abayda makes the final leg of the journey to Kua. More and more of the remaining allied fleets join along the way. Just before they make the jump from Aiwaz, the Janhagir fleet sends over a group of their star seers, the Kahin, who are capable of calculating safe jump vectors even through unstable portals. If the PCs were unable to persuade the entire Janhagir fleet to join them in Shinda, ten Kahin are sent over – otherwise, the Moguls send over twenty. The grand master makes it clear to the PCs that the crew are at their complete disposal as the Martyr's Chosen, foretold by the prophets, and that they will all follow them into death and beyond.

Cost: 0 DP (Mandatory)

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FORKED TONGUES

"Like snakes in the dirt they hide until it's time to strike. They think we can't see through their lies. Just because our sensors don't pick them up doesn't mean we don't sense their presence."

THE GRAND MASTER, NAAR-ABAYDA

THE LANCE OF THE MARTYR

"At the end of days, we shall look outside of time to vanquish our foes. We have the Lance of the Martyr, forged in the fires of Odacon and charged with the souls of burned heretics."

THE GRAND MASTER, NAAR-ABAYDA

THE FINAL VOYAGE

"Let us burn for the Horizon and together travel to Kua to face the heralds of darkness. May the glyphs on the ships of our descendants tell the future of our sacrifice!"

THE GRAND MASTER, NAAR-ABAYDA

⚙ THE BATTLE FOR THE HORIZON

The fleets of the Third Horizon gather to attack the Imperial fleet. If Kua has already fallen during the metagame, the blockade there is strong. If not, the warring fleets jump into the system right after one another. Torpedoes and acc salvos rip through the dark as butterfly ships and torpedo ships fire on the Naar-Abayda. The Spiders of Indra unfold and begin tearing up enemy vessels that come too close.

- **Survival:** The monastery cruiser is one of the most heavily armored warships in the Horizon (18 HP, Armor 12) and covered in an alloy designed to temporarily survive even the plasma of a star, as the ship charges the Lance in the corona. The PCs' mission becomes guiding the cruiser to its final destination. Along the way, the cruiser may both suffer damage and effect repairs.
- **Events:** Depending on the makeup of your group, the PCs' participation in the Naar-Abayda's final battle may vary. The tables 35 to 40 give examples of what consequences their actions may result in. Instead of ordinary combat turns, the battle is divided into six segments, each comprising a number of event suggestions.
- **Danger:** As the GM, you choose how many of the events from each of the tables below you want to control yourself and how many to offer up to the players. At the start of each segment of the journey and during some of the events, the cruiser risks suffering damage (see tables below).
  - (!) As a general rule, half of the events played during a journey segment should be marked Danger, indicated by the exclamation point in the table entry. Play these events in between the ones chosen by the players.
  - (#) A bracketed number in the description of an event tells you that it's an event the players can choose to activate and how many times they may do so. Let them know what events they can choose from and how many events they have time for before the cruiser reaches the next segment of the journey.
- **The weapon:** After arriving in Kua, the PCs are free to give the order to begin firing. The cruiser will then lower itself into the corona of the star and fire the Lance to cut the Dabaran Circle off from the rest of the Horizon rather than pushing on to sever the link between Taoan and Ainios instead. For the assault on the Ainios Monolith to even be an option, however, at least one of the PCs must lead the charge. The crew understands that it's a suicide mission but will follow the Chosen Ones.

Cost: See tables

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TABLE 35: SEGMENT 1: THE KUAN BLOCKADE

NUMBER OF EVENTS: 1 (players' choice)

DANGER (–5/0 HP): If the enemy is already present in Kua on entry, the cruiser suffers 5 points of damage. Otherwise, no damage.

EVENTS	DESCRIPTION
STRATEGY (1)	One PC may test COMMAND to strategically use sensor buoys and the Spiders of Indra to protect the cruiser. Each 6 rolled negates 1 point of damage suffered. Extra 6s after all damage has been negated may be given as bonus dice to another PC action.
ENERGY SPIKE (1)	The engineer PC can assist the engine room crew to hypercharge the antimatter projectors and speed up the cruiser. On a successful TECHNOLOGY roll, one Danger event during Segment 2 may be ignored.



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TABLE 36: SEGMENT 2: THE BATTLE FOR KUA

NUMBER OF EVENTS: 2 Danger and 2 players' choice if the enemy isn't blockading Kua, 3 Danger and 3 players' choice if they are.

DANGER (-1/-3 HP/EVENT): If the PCs carried out the bait mission earlier and diverted enemy forces into the ambush in Zalos, the cruiser suffers only 1 point of damage per Danger event as the invaders are still reeling from their losses. If they didn't do the mission (or if they didn't do it well enough), the cruiser instead suffers 3 points of damage per Danger event (no Armor rolls) in addition to any other damages described below.

ACTIVATING THE LANCE: The PCs may order the cruiser into the corona after all the events have been resolved. Go to Table 40 "The Lance of the Martyr" if they choose to activate the weapon.

EVENTS	DESCRIPTION
REPAIRS (3)	The PCs may attempt to help with the repairs of the cruiser. Roll TECHNOLOGY. Limited success restores 1 HP, critical success restores 3 HP. May be chosen up to three times.
PRAYER (2)	The PCs may spend one event praying in the temple. Gives all PCs a +1 to all rolls for one skill of their choice for the rest of the scenario, but as they are away praying, the ship suffers damage from continued attacks. Roll a die: 1–5) 3 points of damage, 6) No damage. May be chosen twice.
MEDICAL ATTENTION (1)	The PCs may seek medical aid if they have become broken or critically injured. They are treated by the medicurgs of the cruiser who restore D6 HP and all MP. All critical injuries count as treated and have their recovery times halved. The PCs may treat each other's wounds during an event, for example during a boarding, in which case this is included in the event itself. All MP are restored on portal jumps.
THINKING AHEAD (1)	One PC may test COMMAND to draw up new plans for the attack. A sensor analysis compiled by another PC may help (DATA DJINN, each 6 rolled gives the strategist a +1 to their roll. Failing the roll gives the strategist a penalty of -1 instead.) Each 6 rolled by the strategist translates to a bonus of +2 to a future roll by one of the other PCs.
FRANTIC BARRAGE (3)	The gunner PC can use her weapon station to protect the cruiser from incoming fire (RANGED COMBAT, treated as an armor roll against the Danger damage (-1/-3 HP) in this segment). If the sensor operator assists (DATA DJINN), each 6 rolled grants a +1 to the weapons roll. May be chosen up to three times.
TORPEDO STRIKE (!)	Danger (0/-3/-5 HP): Enemy torpedo ships try to break through the defense barrages. The PCs have two turns to neutralize two incoming torpedoes. If one of the torpedoes hits, the cruiser suffers 3 points of damage – if both hit, she suffers 5 points (roll Armor once). The PCs as crew: The captain may give orders once per turn (COMMAND), the engineer may distribute 1–3 EP (one for each 6 rolled on a TECHNOLOGY test), the sensor operator may lock onto incoming targets (DATA DJINN) and the gunner may fire (RANGED COMBAT). More than one PC may act as a gunner. Alternatively, they may choose to face the attackers in small, two-people Order fighters (*The Last Cyclade*, page 32).
BROKEN LANCE (!)	Danger: The Lance has been damaged by enemy fire and the PCs may attempt to repair it using exos to climb out onto the hull of the damaged section (DEXTERITY, zero G). The repairs are a TECHNOLOGY roll with passive assist from another PC with at least a skill level of 1 in SCIENCE (+2 dice) or RANGED COMBAT/TECHNOLOGY (+1 dice). If the Lance isn't repaired, it will need three events worth of charging time in the corona instead of one during Segment 6 (Table 40).
SWARM ATTACK (!)	Danger (0/-3 HP/turn): Wave upon wave of enemy fighter squadrons close in to cut up the cruiser's armor using their plasma weapons. The attack lasts for five turns or until the PCs have scored 8 points of damage on the attackers. Each turn, the cruiser suffers (3 minus whatever amount of damage is dealt to the attackers by the PCs) points of damage. The PCs as crew: Take out as many attackers as possible. The captain may give orders once per turn (COMMAND), the engineer may distribute 1–3 EP (one for each 6 rolled on a TECHNOLOGY test), the sensor operator may lock onto incoming targets (DATA DJINN) and the gunner may fire (RANGED COMBAT). Alternatively, they may choose to face the attackers in small, two-people Order fighters (*The Last Cyclade*, page 32).
BOARDERS IN THE HANGARS (!)	Danger (0/-3/-5 HP): Boarding shuttles make it past the defenses and bore into the hull of the cruiser. Hadid humanites (NPCs,page 97) fight their way toward the hangars to sabotage fighters and torpedo systems there. Have the PCs face off against the boarders in a corridor. The attackers outnumber the PCs by two, but they may try to set up an ambush. If more than half of the attackers make it past the PCs and into the hangars, the ship suffers 5 points of damage. If less than half make it past, the damage is only 3 points and if the PCs defeat all of their enemies, the cruiser suffers no damage.

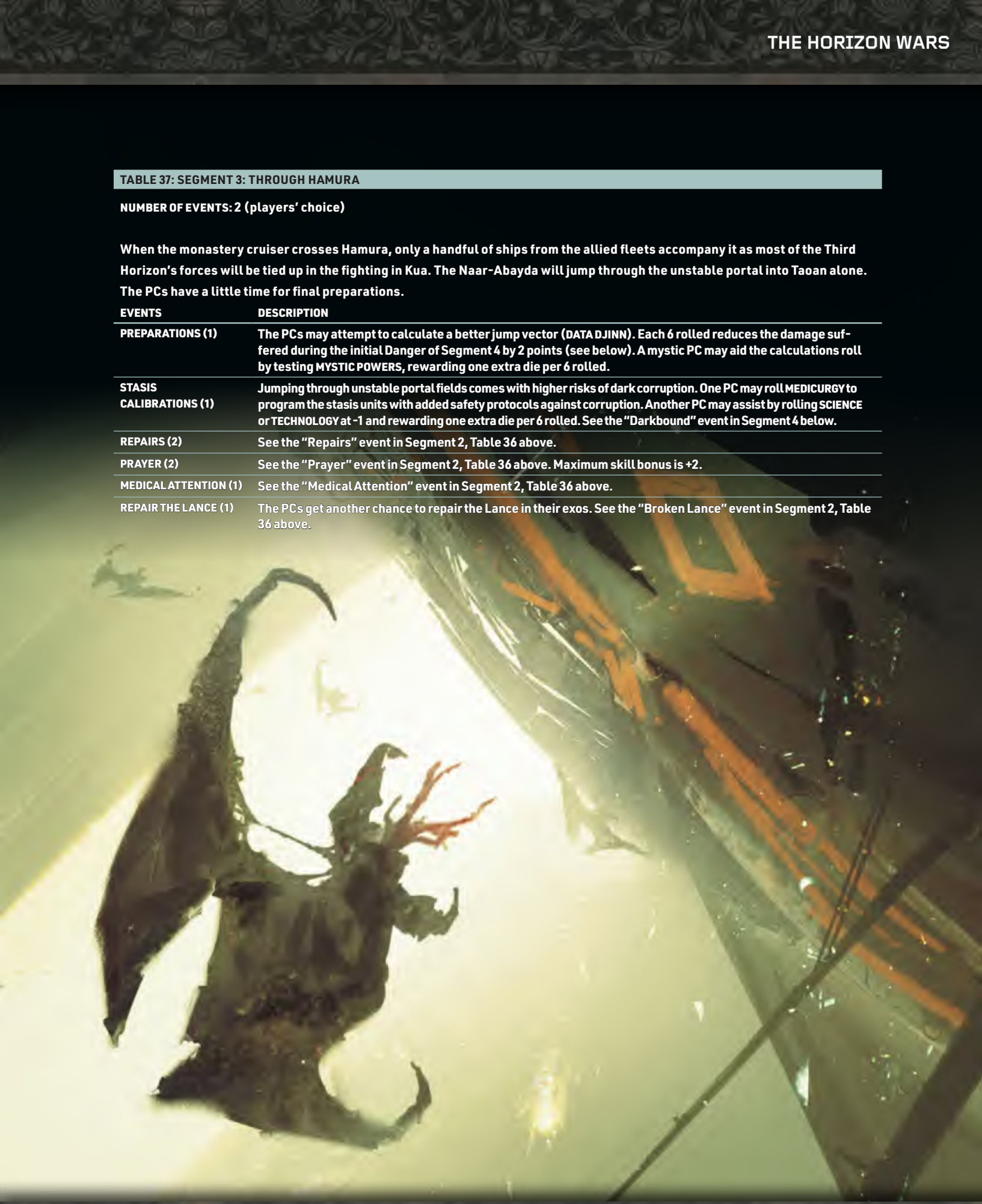
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TABLE 37: SEGMENT 3: THROUGH HAMURA

NUMBER OF EVENTS: 2 (players' choice)

When the monastery cruiser crosses Hamura, only a handful of ships from the allied fleets accompany it as most of the Third Horizon's forces will be tied up in the fighting in Kua. The Naar-Abayda will jump through the unstable portal into Taoan alone. The PCs have a little time for final preparations.

EVENTS	DESCRIPTION
PREPARATIONS (1)	The PCs may attempt to calculate a better jump vector (DATA DJINN). Each 6 rolled reduces the damage suffered during the initial Danger of Segment 4 by 2 points (see below). A mystic PC may aid the calculations roll by testing MYSTIC POWERS, rewarding one extra die per 6 rolled.
STASIS CALIBRATIONS (1)	Jumping through unstable portal fields comes with higher risks of dark corruption. One PC may roll MEDICURGY to program the stasis units with added safety protocols against corruption. Another PC may assist by rolling SCIENCE or TECHNOLOGY at -1 and rewarding one extra die per 6 rolled. See the "Darkbound" event in Segment 4 below.
REPAIRS (2)	See the "Repairs" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above.
PRAYER (2)	See the "Prayer" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above. Maximum skill bonus is +2.
MEDICAL ATTENTION (1)	See the "Medical Attention" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above.
REPAIR THE LANCE (1)	The PCs get another chance to repair the Lance in their exos. See the "Broken Lance" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above.



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TABLE 38: SEGMENT 4: DARKNESS IN TAOAN

Number of events: 1 or 2 (at least one marked Danger – two if they have done (too) well so far)

Danger (–6 HP): The jump through the unstable portal between Taoan and Hamura leads to 6 points of damage. A well-calibrated jump can negate the damage (see "Preparations" in Table 37 above).

Sacrifices: Onboard the cruiser, a group of ten to twenty nomad star seers are in a deep trance. The players may choose to sacrifice them to reduce the damage suffered by the Naar-Abayda. Let the players determine how many points of HP loss they want to negate and then roll a die for each point to determine how many stars seers die or become lost to the dark.

EVENTS	DESCRIPTION
MUZHADJAR (!)	Danger (-3/-6/-10 HP): The Vestals have filled the Taoan system with Muzhadjar (Coriolis core rulebook, page 324). The beings may attack in two ways: ◆ SWARM: The creatures attack in a large swarm (10 HP against ship weapons). They reach the cruiser after three turns and the PCs must try to defeat them before they do. Use the rules described under "Swarm Attack" in Table 36 above. For each of the Muzhadjar swarm's remaining HP when it reaches the cruiser, the ship suffers 1 point of damage (no Armor rolls). ◆ HULL LEECH: The cruiser has come too close to the creatures and two of them latch onto the hull. The PC must put on exos and venture out onto the hull of the ship to fight them off. When brought down to half of their HP, the creatures let go and fly away. If the PCs are forced to retreat before defeating both the Muzhadjar, the creatures do considerable damage before leaving on their own (3 points of damage for each surviving creature, no Armor rolls).
DARKBOUND (!)	Danger (-1/-3 HP): Several crew members have been taken by the dark between the stars during the portal jump. When the stasis units by the bridge open up again, corrupted darkbound slither out. ◆ STASIS CALIBRATIONS: If the PCs chose the "Stasis Calibrations" event from Table 37 above, they only encounter three darkbound on the bridge, otherwise there are a total of five darkbound for them to deal with. If they defeat the beings within five turns, morale onboard is raised and the martyr warriors manage to rid the rest of the ship of the corrupted quickly enough to limit the damage suffered by the cruiser (1 point of damage). If the PCs take longer, the crew panics and the darkbound run wild through the ship before eventually being hunted down (cruiser suffers 3 points of damage).
PREPARATIONS (1)	The PCs may attempt to calculate a better jump vector (DATA DJINN -3). Each 6 rolled reduces the damage suffered during the initial Danger of Segment 5 by 2 points (see below). A mystic PC may aid the calculations roll by testing MYSTIC POWERS at -1, rewarding one extra die per 6 rolled.
STASIS CALIBRATIONS (1)	See the "Stasis Calibrations" event in Segment 3, Table 37 above.
REPAIRS (1)	See the "Repairs" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above.
PRAYER (1)	See the "Prayer" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above. Maximum skill bonus is +2.
MEDICAL ATTENTION (1)	See the "Medical Attention" event in Segment 2, Table 36 above.

TABLE 39: SEGMENT 5: THE BATTLE OF AINIOS

NUMBER OF EVENTS: 0 (the cruiser begins its descent into the corona, see Table 40)

DANGER (–6 HP): Jumping through the officially dead portal field between Taoan and Ainios results in 6 points of damage. A well-calibrated jump can negate the damage (see "Preparations" in Table 38 above).

SACRIFICES: See the rules for sacrificing star seers in Segment 4, Table 38 above.

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TABLE 40: SEGMENT 6: THE LANCE OF THE MARTYR

NUMBER OF EVENTS: 1 or 3 (all Danger)

The weapon will charge for one event (three events if damaged, see "Broken Lance", Table 36 above). Each charging time event reduces the cruiser's Armor rating by 4 as the hull starts to disintegrate in the corona of the star. The cruiser needs at least 1 HP to be able to complete its firing (see "Ending", page 183).

EVENTS	DESCRIPTION
DESPERATE ASSAULT (!)	Danger (-2 HP/turn): The enemy sends fighters and torpedo ships in a final, desperate attack. The attack lasts for three turns and may lead to up to 6 points of damage. The PCs' gunner (RANGED COMBAT) and sensor operator (assisting with DATA DJINN) may try to protect the cruiser from the attacks. The gunner's roll is treated as an Armor roll to reduce the damage suffered by the ship once per turn. A critically successful roll breaks off the attack altogether.
MAYFLY (!)	Danger (-6 HP): A butterfly ship performs a suicide attack by ramming the cruiser to stop it from firing. If the ramming is successful, the cruiser suffers 6 points of damage (may test Armor). It's very difficult to spot the butterfly ship on the sensors, giving the sensor operator a –3 to DATA DJINN to lock onto the target. The PCs' gunner or gunners then have only one turn to score a critical success to take out the ship (if multiple PCs act as gunners, they may pool their 6s).
FRACTAL RAIN (!)	Danger (-12 HP): The Imperial battleships let loose a hail of fractal torpedoes against the cruiser. The PCs have three turns to take out four incoming torpedoes. If the gunner scores a limited success, she shoots down one torpedo – on a critical success, she takes out two. Each torpedo that hits the Naar-Abayda deals 3 points of damage (may test Armor). The PCs as crew: The captain may give orders once per turn (COMMAND), the engineer may distribute 1–3 EP (one for each 6 rolled on a TECHNOLOGY test), the sensor operator may lock onto incoming targets (DATA DJINN) and the gunner may fire (RANGED COMBAT). More than one PC may act as a gunner. Alternatively, they may choose to face the attackers in small, two-people Order fighters (*The Last Cyclade*, page 32).
BOARDERS ON THE BRIDGE (!)	Danger (0/-3/-5 HP): Boarding shuttles make it past the defenses and bore into the hull of the cruiser. Hadid humanites (NPCs, page 97) fight their way to the bridge to sabotage the Lance's firing controls. The PCs encounter the enemies on the bridge. The attackers outnumber the PCs by two and there is no time to set up an ambush. If the attackers aren't defeated, the firing controls are destroyed. ◆ MANUAL FIRING: If the controls are destroyed, the PCs' last chance is to go into the reactor and trigger the firing manually. See "Ending" below.
DARKBOUND (!)	See the "Darkbound" event in Segment 4, Table 38 above.
THE TEAR (!)	The First Horizon gathers its corrupting strength to open a tear into portal space and release the forces of darkness. This is recommended as the final event you play before the weapon activates. A creature similar to Ayaam'sha from *Emissary Lost* (page 183) breaks into the physical realm inside the cruiser. It's made up of strings of darkness bending around each other and interweaving to form a three-dimensional being. Light bends and breaks around it as it grows from a one-dimensional dot to quickly envelop the whole bridge. The PCs can either try to fight the creature or lure it into the focus chamber where it will burn away as the Lance fires. The being will follow a single PC if she rolls a critically successful MYSTIC POWERS test, or a majority of the PCs if they move together and pass a MANIPULATION test. ◆ MANUAL FIRING: The PCs can go into the cruiser's reactor and fire the Lance manually or lure the creature away from the bridge and use the firing controls there. See "Ending" below.

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ENDING

The PCs fight to keep the Naar-Abayda alive.

- **Defeat:** If the ship drops to 0 HP before the Lance fires, it's destroyed and the PCs most likely perish with it. Alternatively, they may flee in an escape pod if you want to continue adventuring in a lost Third Horizon. The Eternal Emperor is victorious. See the heading "Defeat: A Lost Horizon".
- **The Lance:** When the mega weapon is charged, it can be fired from the bridge by the crew unless a majority of them have become darkbound – in this case, the PCs have to complete the firing command themselves. The firing is a DATA DJINN test to calibrate the targeting sensors and lock onto the Monolith followed by a RANGED COMBAT test to fire. If either of the rolls fail, play one more event as the enemy is given a final chance to stop the PCs. If the firing controls have been destroyed or the bridge is lost, the PCs must fire manually from inside the engine room, in which case they roll TECHNOLOGY instead of RANGED COMBAT.
- **The Cold Flame:** The Lance's discharge and the collapsing of the portals will rip the cruiser apart. If the event takes place in Kua, the PCs might decide or be urged by the grand master to depart the cruiser in a fast courier ship and jump out of the system before the shockwave hits. If the end takes place in Ainios, their chances of making it back through the highly unstable portal to the Third Horizon become almost non-existent but you could decide to let them try – perhaps they miraculously make it back home, or disappear into the Void, living on only as legends. See the heading "Win: The Lance of the Martyr" and either "The End: The Fall of Ainios" or "The End: The Fall of Kua".

WIN: THE LANCE OF THE MARTYR

The cruiser shakes and you feel a great pressure over your temples. Your hearts race and a searing note, louder than anything you've ever heard, threatens to break open your skulls. For an instant, the projectors go offline and you float quietly through the carnage outside. Then, the Cold Flame rips through the system, tongues of fire lashing out against the enemy ships like the heads of a hydra. A spear of devastation is thrust deep into the planet and the Monolith. The ancient column, created by those who came before, stands unaffected at first, regal and invulnerable. Then, a tiny crack forms and runs downward into a network of fine fractures. After a last attempt to endure and remain, the failing Monolith discharges its harnessed darkness, breaking the planet's surface to release torrents of fire and lava.

DEFEAT: A LOST HORIZON

Red light fills the corridors. The projectors bleed antimatter and implosions start caving in the ship. The hull breaks open and lets the roaring darkness in. The old prophecies burn as glyph-covered debris is scattered through the night. The Naar-Abayda monastery cruiser's last voyage ends in tragedy, as a promise unfulfilled. You burn for the Third Horizon but history won't remember your names – the Imperial conquest of your home worlds reduces you to anonymous casualties in the Eternal Emperor's crusade for the glory of Ardha.

A wave of light and lightning shoots into the darkness of space to challenge the Cold Flame. The star behind you erupts in an ejection of plasma and a violent ion storm hits the cruiser. The grand master turns to you to speak for the very last time…

THE END: THE FALL OF AINIOS

"You truly are the children of the Martyr and the champions of the Third Horizon. It has been an honor to serve under you and a greater one yet to die by your side. The First Horizon is shut out for good and our kin finally awaken to a new dawn. We, the people, are finally the captains of our own destinies and may chart a path to new Horizons."

Everything fades to white as the portals collapse and you become one with the stars. You live on as legends to inspire

THE END: THE FALL OF KUA

"The Horizon must bleed for its new dawn but losing an arm is a small price to pay for freedom. The time has come for you to leave us to meet our destiny. Your ship is ready. Return to what remains of the Third Horizon and tell the people there of the heroes who fell today, of our martyrdom and how we severed the serpent's head, of how good people held fast against the night. You shall be the prophets of this new dawn. May the ships of our descendants wear our story as a warning to those who will live to see the wars of tomorrow."

The cruiser shakes violently as you make your way down to the waiting courier ship. You're soon on your way through a burning system toward the portals. Before cold sleep takes you, you see the followers of the Martyr perish in their own fire. As you slip under and jump out, you dream of a new Horizon.

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EPILOGUE

Nothing is forgotten,
as long as we remember.
Nothing is lost,
as long as we rebuild.
We fall,
and rise again.
Martyrs and idealists
become legends and dreams.
Dreams of the Horizon.

HOMAGE TO HORIZON, NEW CORIOLIS, C165

Patrick Carroll (Order #46211587)

INTRODUCTION

The proxy wars are over – at least for now. The circle has come to a close. The PCs have seen the arrival of the Emissaries, the rise of the Nazareem's Sacrifice and the devastation of the Horizon Wars. Old alliances have been broken and reforged. Whole factions are gone and the star maps look very different now. The fleets are decimated and those who stayed out of the war, or who at least backed down at the right moment, are perhaps coming out on top. The age of the Zenithians is over and a vacuum of power now exists, waiting for someone new to fill it.

AFTER THE HORIZON WARS, the Third Horizon is once again left alone. Seeing the true, treacherous faces of the Emissaries has upturned the lives of many of the previously devout. Some have had enough and give up – beyond Zhau's sister star, an unlikely fleet from all over the Horizon is gathering, led by the Nomad star seers. Hoping to reclaim the lost systems of the Third Horizon, they leave their homes behind for good. Meanwhile, a new hope is rising for those who stay. The Church of the Icons gather pilgrims once again and the temples are full to the brim. Mira, the Order of the Pariah and the clans of Khorsabad start salvaging in the wreckage belts and the furnaces of the smelteries burn with the flames of tomorrow. Old blueprints are dusted off and soon, a familiar shape appears in the night sky – a place of diplomacy, commerce and intrigue: the Coriolis space station.

AFTERMATH

The remaining forces of the Eternal Emperor are destroyed but beyond the collapsed portals, the First Horizon is already planning for the future. Enormous cruisers filled with sleeping butterfly ships burn through the dark between the stars to someday reach the Third Horizon again. The Santulans have either been ousted and returned to the home world or claimed a piece of the Sadaal Route as payment for their help in the war. In the latter case, Errai is now a closed system into which only Seeker gurus and certain Children of the Song mystics are allowed entry. Weakened fleets and armies leave room for new rebellions and freedom fighters but in all, nothing as dramatic as how the Imperial fleets were cut off happens. Kua is either still a shining beacon in the dark, gathering the Third Horizon around a new space station, or the systems of the Dabaran Circle are lost forever and New Coriolis is instead coming together above the jungles and floating temple cities of Mira.

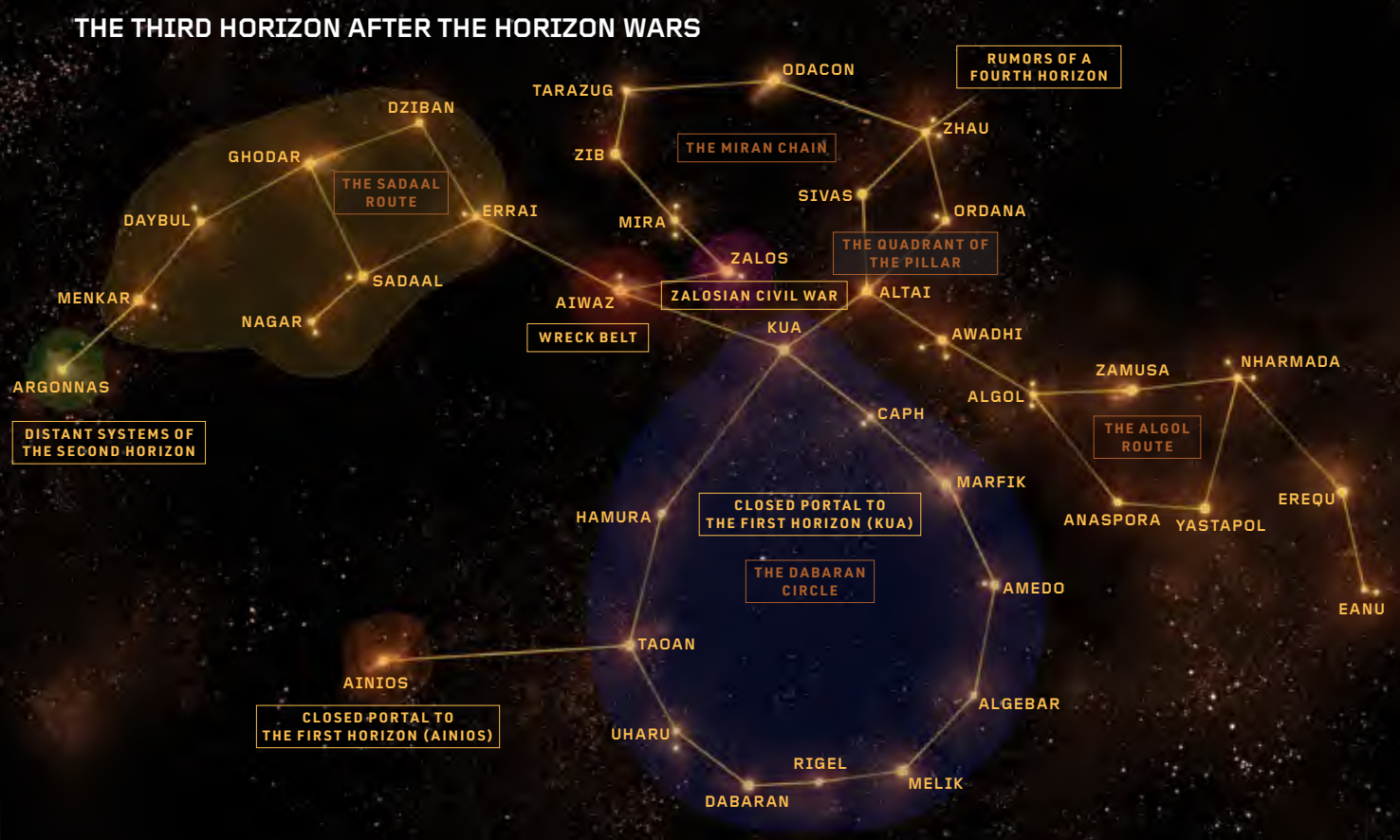
THE FACTIONS

The post-war map of the Third Horizon has been redrawn and the different civilizations are slowly starting to rebuild. Trade and diplomacy becomes more important than ever. Secret agents and political agitators position themselves to try and influence the political landscape of the new era. Secret organizations and dark pacts take shape in the shadows.

THE ORDER OF THE PARIAH

The followers of the Martyr made enormous sacrifices during the war and their home system of Zalos has once again been ravaged. The Zahedan rebels seize the opportunity to take

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over Zalos-B after a segment of bloody fighting. The two stars are now split between Martyr loyalists and "heretics". The Order's ties to the Church of the Icons grow stronger as joint construction efforts produce new shipyards above the moon of Karrmerruk. Both factions' fleets need rebuilding and they pay well for salvaged debris or weapon systems from any of the myriad of new ship cemeteries left behind by the war. Aiwaz becomes known as the first blood system and free traders and hopeful artifact hunters soon invade its vast wreckage belt – something that attracts the eyes of both the Syndicate and of other, hidden shipyards. The City of Foreigners grows and new domes open for business with visitors who swear not to deny the Martyr's importance in the Horizon Wars. The Judge is increasingly revered around the Horizon and many societies now pray to a new aspect – the Protector.

THE CHURCH OF THE ICONS

The Miran fleets weren't large even before the war and have since then lost much of their strength. In the religious vacuum after the unmasking of the false Emissaries, however, the Church of the Icons grow even more, uniting the sundered Horizon under a new, monotheist banner. All Icons are really just aspects of the One True Icon but the faith allows room for ancestral worship and local variations which appeals to both nomads and previously faithless neo-Zenithians. The Church grows and Mira's ancient temple societies are revitalized as colossal pilgrim ships start arriving via Zalos at regular intervals.

THE ZENITHIAN COALITION

The exiled Zenithians and the expatriates have gone one of two ways, either to Amedo or to Algol. In Amedo, they rebuild the dome city of Xhi and construct a new Dawn Palace for

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the prominent families on one of the nearby moons. White marble and salvage from Coriolis glow in the bright sunlight from the blue holo sky above. Alternatively, if the Dabaran Circle is lost and Kua closed, they instead go to the Algolan metropolis of AYM, the mega-city formed by the three cities Akhandar-O-Sharif, Yasul and Merkate. Colonial governor Abbaras Quam is removed, the Tanzim highlands are cleared of slavers and opor farmers and new terrace farms are founded to feed coming generations in a massive new scheme for Zenithian expansion. A new board of representatives from the different clans is formed, chaired in tandem by the Yriedes and Abbaren-Quassar families. The Dawn Palace towers in supreme splendor over the surrounding Akhander townships. The founding families of the Syndicate, Birbasil and Nyala, are now considered traitors and their importance in Zenithian history is retconned out. The faction's former members become free traders, corsairs or smugglers, forbidden from ever owning land or businesses again.

THE NEW LEGION

At the growing Aiwaz portal station and along the borders to the Old Horizons, Legion patrols keep a strict vigil but are now painted with nomad clan patterns or covered in Order glyphs. They are now the Third Horizon's first line of defence, funded by the Horizon Council and without any ties to the other factions. The Legion is rebirthed as a truly Firstcome faction and their network of naval bases offer help to the other factions with rebuilding their trade and military infrastructure – as long as they can pay, of course. Common people start referring to the New Legion as the junud-altair, the Merchant's Guns, and there are soon rumors claiming local groups within the faction have their own agendas: affiliated prospectors and colonists have been seen seeking fertile worlds out of sight of the other factions and brand new ships with new family colors are sneaking back from unknown errands in the asteroid belts beyond inhabited space.

THE NOMAD FEDERATION

The families of Khorsabad and the Janhagir fleet command are the ones who lost the least in the war. The star seers continue to operate the portal stations and the Quadrant of the Pillar starts to grow in power. The swarms start acting as bulk hauler escort along the trade routes again and the faction's demands for representation in the Horizon Council are heard. Accusations of corruption and war crimes are soon brought against the Federation by the Zenithian Coalition, however, proving that old prejudice dies hard.

THE DRACONITES

The Draconites remain in the shadows, working toward some unknown goal through their hidden cells of warrior monks, archivists and artifact tamers. Their bases remain undiscovered in the more remote systems but rumors spread that they have moved into Odacon and the ashes of Rusah to guard against future attempts by the agents of the enemy to taint the system with their malice.

LOST PEOPLES

The losers of the war are the worlds chosen as theatres of combat by the Old Horizons. Depending on how the PCs ended the war, the situation for the systems below might vary radically.

DABARAN

The desert home of the dars whose people and fleet were enslaved by the Vestals is either lost forever (if Kua is closed) or has a long road to recovery ahead. There is talk about whether the surviving dars should pay reparations to the rest of the peoples of the Horizon. Previously wealthy oases and desert towns are now partly destroyed or abandoned and the surviving population are the young and the old, all scarred by their ordeals. The survivors who evaded slavery instead carry the stigma of the mystic's disease. The thing that saved them from the Vestals' siren song is what made them susceptible to the lure of the Second Horizon Santulans. Fear that they might one day fall back under the Symmetry's control make them outcasts and many leave the planet to find a new life among the stars with the Exile Fleet.

SADAAL

The Sadaalian people adapted quickly to Santulan rule if that was the outcome of your campaign as they are used to being ruled with an iron fist. From Argonnas far beyond Menkib, the Second Horizon mystics divine the wills of the Icons and act as the spiritual descendents of the Portal Builders, demanding unwavering faith from their subjects. The Sadaal Route becomes a growing religious hub and the new mystics flock to Errai to seek permission to train with the masters

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of the Circle of Seekers. A massive project to re-erect the monolith in Menkar is begun in an effort to heal the Horizon of its dark wounds.

If the Sadaal Route didn't fall in the hands of the Second Horizon, a new leader emerges: Bahman Char-Aremerat. The tenth Icon, the once and future leader of the planet, has fallen and the population now rises from the ashes of the old order to welcome a new day of cultural revitalization and innovation. The Amesha Spenta are substituted for a council of technocrats from Sadaalian civil society but remain the Icons incarnate in the opinions of most common people. The new order isn't established without friction and a rebel alliance called the Eyes of Aremerat is formed, reportedly funded by the Amesha Spenta to reclaim their power.

NEW CORIOLIS

The Zenithian efforts to salvage as much as possible from the wreckage of Coriolis was hard but rewarding work. The station is rebuilt using the old blueprints to pay homage to the glory of days gone by. If Kua wasn't lost, the remains of the original station are melted down and become the new station's skeleton and hull together with what's left of the Net. The rest of the needed materials are scavenged from the wreckage belts left behind by the war. If Kua was lost, however, most of the new station is built from wreckages or from salvage kept in private Zenithian collections.

Eight long spokes – the Arms of the Icons – reach out into space from the Ring, ready for bulk haulers and other freighters too large for the space ports.

The new Core becomes a microcosm mirroring the rest of the Horizon with a section for each of the different cultures: the Nomads get a neighborhood nearest to the outer hull and name it the Second Home; further in you reach the temples of New Mira, the clutter of Little Algol just outside the Zenithian Arcade and finally the restored Mulukhad, the Little Horizon souks and the arts mecca of the Amphitheater. Encircling the Core Plaza in the very middle lies the Zalosian Academy and hospital in Samaritan City and the Horizon Blocks with their various institutes, news and media houses and archives.

Several floors of the Spire are constructed as parks or cultivated for farming but maintain their status as a home for the higher stratas. Not long after people start moving in, however, the words of the Machine Icon begin appearing in chalk and spray paint in back alleys and stevedore hubs.

YOUR HORIZON

Your Third Horizon will be heavily influenced by the actions of the PCs throughout the campaign. After the war, life returns to some kind of normalcy and the short epilogue you've just read can be used as a foundation for further scenarios. For the PCs, normalcy probably means going back to a life of mercenary work, commerce or secretive plotting: they may travel around and re-explore, make new factionary allies, stop attempts to sabotage the construction of New Coriolis, help civilians displaced by the war etc. Will the Nazareem's Sacrifice rise again, or will the last of the Imperial fleets be hunted down? Are there butterfly ships still hiding in the shadows, and how will the exiled Zenithians' plans for expansion affect the rest of the Horizon?

FIRST HORIZON DOMINANCE

If the PCs failed in cutting off the fleets of the First Horizon, they are most likely dead – but you can of course continue adventuring in a Third Horizon of your own in which the Eternal Emperor was victorious and the systems have fallen into chaos and lawlessness. Universal moral is now dead, might makes right, slavery and dominance is not only legal but encouraged and hedonism and exploration of the self have become virtues – as long as they don't threaten the agents or interests of the Emperor, of course.

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THE HORIZON COUNCIL

A new Council is convened even before the completion of New Coriolis in the Palace of the Martyrs in the Core. Two candidates from each of the larger factions plus an observer from the Draconites form a Council of nine:

- The Church of the Icons (Mira)
- The Order of the Pariah (Zalos)
- The Khorsabad Nomads and the Janhagir Fleet
- The Zenithian Coalition (one Hegemonist and one neo-Zenithian)
- The Draconites (Council speaker and observer)

CALENDAR

The completion of New Coriolis takes almost five years but even after that, the Coriolis Cycle calendar isn't re-instituted. After the war, people are reconnected with the importance of their history and the older way of measuring time since the Portal Wars is therefore kept. If Kua was lost, some (primarily Zenithian) populations will start referring to the new era as AK, "after Kua".

THE EXILE FLEET

During the first cycle after the end of the war, it becomes obvious that many people regardless of factionary ties are unable to cope with the losses and changes they have experienced – either because they are stuck in old prejudices and ways or because they soon see old hierarchies returning, despite everything that has happened. The Third Horizon's newfound hope is regarded as temporary and they believe the old oppressors aren't far away. The disillusioned are a diverse group – mystics, exiled Zenithians, Syndicate members, outcasts from Dabaran or Sadaal, Zalosians from war torn families or towns, humanites tired of living on a leash and pilgrims who won't bend the knee to the Church of the Icons – but they have a common dream and start for the distant Zhau-C star, more than 400 AU from the portals. The disparate fleet leave known space behind on a quest to rediscover lost civilizations and worlds and are never seen again in the Third Horizon...



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APPENDIX: SPACECRAFT

Below are stats for various new spacecraft you can use during the Horizon Wars in addition to the lists found on page 160 of the Coriolis core rulebook. An average crew will have attribute and skill levels of 3. The fleets' elite squadrons will have attribute and skill levels of 4. The stats in the tables below include modifiers from Features.

ORIGINS AND AESTHETICS

- **The Zenithians:** The Consortium champions function over form. Their steel gray research vessels and bulk haulers have hulls without ornamentation, instead covering their nakedness with sensor masts, exterior support beams and ceramic heat shields. The ships of the Foundation are more advanced and therefore look the part – white, streamlined vessels constructed from new materials and modern, experimental tech. The only soft shapes can be found in the fleet of the Hegemony, its sleek hulls sporting lavish decorations and gold panels.
- **The Draconites:** The exiled Zenithians turned warrior monks have rediscovered lost engineering from the days of the Portal Wars. Their black ships with ceramic modules are covered in both glyphs in dead Third Horizon languages and the scrolling, floral patterns of the Firstcome. Curious modules of unknown design and purpose hint at the faction's discoveries far beyond mapped space but in spite of this, the Draconites still keep in their design the memory of Coriolis and the Zenith of old.
- **The Legion:** With roots in the arms race around the Portal Wars, the mass produced warships of the Legion look a lot like bulk haulers. The dark dura beam ribs of the vessels give them an austere look but recently, a more Zenithian look has made an entry into the fleet and gold plated geometrical shields are becoming more common.
- **Ahlam's Temple:** Drawing inspiration from the original Firstcome settlers of Mira, the Temple keeps its ships rounded and somewhat insectoid, often covered in floral motifs. The hulls are sometimes painted or adorned with glittering scales.
- **The Order of the Pariah:** The base design for the fleet of the Order of the Pariah is the same round, insectoid shapes as Ahlam's Temple but the Order appears to build from stone rather than metal. Spires and domes cover the larger ships, like ribs or swollen growths. Large glyphs are painted on the hulls in the frantic handwriting of a madman. The escort fighters are the only vessels in another style – more modern and jagged in their shape, like winged, angular exos to refract and deflect sensor sweeps.
- **The Nomads:** The battleships of the Janhagir fleet are ancient shells covered in spiked blades and round shields, glowing with a greenish luster. The rest of the fleet is a mix of converted clan ships and cannibalized warships from past wars, their shapes jutting and multiform. Many different styles and eras meet in the nomad fleet, sometimes in the very same vessel. The ships are often painted in glaring colors that represent the clan or family living aboard. Decorations like these, reminding of tropical fish, are of course regarded as vulgar and uncivilized by the Zenithians.
- **Mira and Dabaran:** The Miran design is the original style of Third Horizon shipbuilding, sleek and rounded shapes to remind of scarab beetles or mayflies but without garish adornments. The Dabaran fleet looks much the same, but in the dars' quest for Hegemony

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approval, they have started adding more gold panels to their otherwise earthy color scheme.

- **Ardha (the Vestals):** White fishbone and seashell patterns form flowing shapes that remind of the Hegemony. The ships of the First Horizon are powered by the dark between the stars itself, channeled through shimmering butterfly wings or fins and scales covering the hull. Distorted light reflects off the ships like it would off mother of pearl.
- **The Second Horizon:** The ships of the Symmetry are inspired by the animal kingdom and borrow their shapes from exotic aquatic life or colorful, intricately patterned beetles. The origins of the floral patterns and insectoid shapes of both the Temple and Mira can be found here, as well as the vibrant colors of the nomad swarms.

SHIP CLASSES

- Class 0 (drones, probes, torpedoes): 1–3 meters
- Class I (fighters, breach torpedoes): 5–12 meters
- Class II (shuttle, torpedo ship): 12–20 meters
- Class III (patrol ship, destroyer, warship): 35–150 meters
- Class IV (cruiser, heavy destroyer): 75–350 meters
- Class V (battleship, monastery cruiser, flagship): 800–1,400 meters

NEW RULES: BREACH TORPEDOES

Breach torpedoes have Long range, damage 2, CRIT 3, Signature –1 and cost 7,500 birr. Instead of a conventional warhead, they typically contain chemical agents or breach commandos in stasis ready to attack the enemy craft from within. If the torpedo deals damage to its target, the contents activate. A torpedo can contain up to eight fully equipped soldiers in stasis, up to sixteen smaller combat creatures such as nekatra in gel pods or a chemical or biological payload. If the contents are living beings, the torpedo counts as Advanced tech. If fired on a planetary target, only the sensor locking needs to succeed for the contents to activate.

THE MYSTIC FLEET

The fleets under the Emissaries' control are made up of two parts: ex-Legion battleships commandeered by the Judge Emissary in the Rimward Reach patrolling the Quiet Zone in Xene and various deserter crews from the other factionary fleets. The former Legion battleships are famous for their huge numbers of stormtroopers and boarding parties ready to deploy via breach torpedoes. Use the battleships described below as well as ships from the exiled Zenithian, Order and Nomad fleets to make up the mystic fleet. Mutineer ships always have the Mystics and Mercy of the Icons Features.

NEW FEATURES FOR THE MYSTIC FLEET:

- **MYSTICS** (Feature: +2 to **COMMAND** when determining Initiative and +2 to **DATA DJINN** when rolling to portal jump thanks to the meditating mystics onboard. Additionally, all crew positions count as having performed preparatory prayer in a chapel, giving them a +2 to one prayer reroll per combat.)
- **MERCY OF THE ICONS** (Feature: When the ship suffers a critical hit, roll the dice twice and let the engineer onboard choose the least harmful result.)

NEW FEATURES FOR THE EX-LEGION SHIPS:

- **ADVANCED BREACH TORPEDOES** (Feature +10%: The Legion's advanced boarding and landing torpedoes are large enough to hold sixteen commandos or thirty two combat creatures. See the Breach Torpedoes box. Additionally, when they hit, the target may only roll half her Armor dice.)

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SHAHRAZAD, FLAGSHIP (EX-LEGION)

DOCKYARDS: Nodash Dockyards, Odacon (pre-Portal Wars) (+4 weapon systems, EP +1) (retrofitted at Alhudu naval base, Kuan asteroid belt) (Armor +1, –1 module)

CLASS: V (length 1,400 meters)

EP: 8

HP: 15

MANEUVERABILITY: –2

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 10

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×2, hangar ×3 (4 shuttles, 4 torpedo ships, 16 fighters), cabins (3×320 coffins for breach troops, 6×80 standard for crew, 1×20 suites for command), stasis hold (5×320), escape pods (8×16, 128 people), chapel, medlab, cargo hold (3×1,000 tons), mining station, service module, workshop

WEAPONS: Meson cannon ×2, autocannon ×2, countermeasure dispenser, torpedo room ×12 (36 breach torpedoes with soldiers or nekatra, 8 plasma torpedoes, 8 nuclear mines)

FEATURES: Robust hull ×3 (HP +3), Arboretum, Advanced Countermeasures (RANGED COMBAT +1), Advanced Torpedoes (–1 to countermeasures and defensive barrage), Bonus Modules ×2 (10 modules), Advanced Breach Torpedoes, Mystics, *Mercy of the Icons*

ADULAAZA & SHAHERESH, TYPICAL BATTLESHIP (EX-LEGION)

DOCKYARDS: Thalus naval base, the Rimward Reach (Armor +4 vs ion weapons)

CLASS: V (length 1,000 meters)

EP: 7

HP: 14

MANEUVERABILITY: –2

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 9 (13 vs ion weapons)

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×4, hangar ×2 (4 torpedo ships, 16 fighters), cabins (1×320 coffins for breach troops, 4×80 standard for crew), stasis hold (2×320), escape pods (8×16, 128 people), chapel, medlab, cargo hold (2×1,000 tons), service module, salvage module, workshop ×2

WEAPONS: Meson cannon, autocannon ×3, countermeasure dispenser, data pulse, data meme, torpedo room ×5 (8 breach torpedoes with soldiers or nekatra, 8 plasma torpedoes, 4 ion torpedoes)

FEATURES: ED Fields (bridge and standard cabins), Super Sensors, Robust Hull ×2 (HP +2), Arboretum, Advanced Breach Torpedoes, Mystics, *Mercy of the Icons*

THE NADIR FLOTILLA

The Nadir Flotilla is dominated by the heavy Eshim class destroyers and supporting squadrons of Dysil class torpedo ships. The Ilyo class fighters protecting the fleet from torpedo strikes are among the fastest ships in the whole Third Horizon. The battleships are smaller and more sleek than their siblings among the other factionary fleets of the cluster. Their bone-white hulls with golden ablative armor shields are covered in glyphs praising the origins of the Zenith. The Orizo-Jhadid flagship looks like the rest of the battleships except for being completely golden.

ORIZO-JHADID, TYPICAL BATTLESHIP

DOCKYARDS: Daharab, Bahram (Class number of extra weapon modules)

CLASS: V (length 950 meters)

EP: 7

HP: 14

MANEUVERABILITY: –1

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 9

SPEED: 2

MODULES: Docking station ×4, hangar ×4 (2×4 torpedo ships, 2×16 fighters), cabins (2×20 suites, 1×320 coffins), cargo hold (3×1,000 tons), escape pods (32 pods, 160 people), medlab, chapel, service module ×2, workshop, stasis hold (2×320 beds)

WEAPONS: Torpedo room (4×4 nuclear torpedoes, 2×8 ion torpedoes), heavy acc cannon ×2, light acc cannon ×3, countermeasure dispenser ×2

FEATURES: Ablative Armor ×3 (–3 damage to three hits), Turbo Projector (Maneuverability +1, Speed +1), Robust Hull ×2 (HP +2)

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ESHIM CLASS HEAVY DESTROYER

DOCKYARDS: Daharab, Bahram (Class number of extra weapon modules)

CLASS: IV (length 250 meters)

EP: 6

HP: 9

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: +2

ARMOR: 9

SPEED: 2

MODULES: Docking station, hangar ×2 (2×8 fighters), cargo hold (250 tons), cabins (1×80 coffins), stasis hold (2×80 beds), escape pods (4 pods, 20 people), medlab, service module, workshop

WEAPONS: Acc cannon ×2, heavy acc cannon ×2, torpedo room (2×4 ion torpedoes), autocannon ×2, countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Ablative Armor ×2 (–3 damage to two hits), Heavy Armor ×2 (Armor +2), Turbo Projector (Maneuverability +1, Speed +1)

DYSIL CLASS TORPEDO SHIP

DOCKYARDS: Daharab, Bahram (Class number of extra weapon modules)

CLASS: II (length 20 meters)

EP: 4

HP: 4

MANEUVERABILITY: +1

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 5

SPEED: 4

MODULES: Cabins (1×5 coffins), escape pods (1 pod, 5 people)

WEAPONS: Torpedo room (2×4 plasma torpedoes), ion missile, autocannon

FEATURES: Advanced Weapon System ×2 (RANGED COMBAT +1, ion missile and autocannon)

ILYO CLASS FIGHTER

DOCKYARDS: Daharab, Bahram (Class number of extra weapon modules)

CLASS: I (length 8 meters)

EP: 3

HP: 2

MANEUVERABILITY: +4

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 3

SPEED: 6

WEAPONS: Data meme, light acc cannon, countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Ship System: Gunner and sensor operator (Attribute 3, Skill 3), Turbo Projector ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2), Ejector

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THE FIRST HORIZON

The shell armor of the enormous Imperial cruisers shifts like oil as the ships flicker through the emptiness, traveling through flash tears into portal space. The rest of the First Horizon's invasion fleet is made up of smaller, insect-like ships that well from inside the cruisers to swarm around them in the darkness. The hard, angular shells of the termite destroyers are covered in spiky torpedo muzzles, the butterfly ships glitter in the night and countless solar drones surround them as tiny dots of pulsing light. The remaining Nazareem cultists accompany the fleet in civilian ships armed with hidden weapons.

NEW FIRST HORIZON SHIP TECH:

- **PORTAL FIELD PROPULSION** (Docks: The ship uses tiny tears into portal space for traveling which gives it a +2 to Speed and a –3 to Signature. Only for ships built on Ardha.)
- **SENSOR DEFLECTORS** (Docks: Advanced stealth tech, Signature –2. Only for ships built in Ainios.)
- **NANITE ARMOR** (Docks: Strong nano filament armor capable of restructuring itself and opening up portal space tears to rip apart incoming projectiles. Only for ships built in Karrash.)
- **MEDITATION CHAMBER** (Module: Meditation cabins that double as stasis holds. Equivalent of standard cabins in terms of size and number of beds per module.)
- **DARKNESS PROPULSION** (Feature +10%: A manner of propulsion based on ancient solar sail technology drawing power from the dark between the stars. Maneuverability +2, Speed +1.)
- **HIDDEN WEAPONS** (Feature +5%: The Nazareem ships are constructed to look like civilian craft. Only a critically successful sensor roll can reveal their hidden armaments.)
- **FRACTAL TORPEDOES** (Weapon system: Bonus +2, Range: Extreme, Damage: 4 HP and 2 EP, CRIT: 1, Signature: –4. See *The Last Cyclade*, page 39.)
- **HEAVY MESON CANNON** (Weapon system: Equivalent to regular meson cannons but with Medium range.)

IMPERIAL CRUISER, BATTLESHIP

DOCKYARDS: Almushtari dockyards, Ardha (Portal field propulsion, Speed +2 and Signature –3)

CLASS: V (length 1,100 meters)

EP: 7

HP: 15

MANEUVERABILITY: –2

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 12

SPEED: 3

MODULES: Hangar (8× gunships/butterfly ships, 5×16 solar drones), docking station ×2, meditation chamber (2×80 combined cabins and stasis beds), chapel ×2, cargo hold (4×1,000 tons), medlab ×2, workshop ×2, service module ×2

WEAPONS: Torpedo room (4×4 fractal torpedoes), countermeasure dispenser, meson cannon ×2, heavy meson cannon ×2, data meme

FEATURES: Stealth Technology (Signature –1), Ablative Armor ×3 (–3 damage to three hits), Heavy Armor ×3 (Armor +3), Robust Hull ×3 (HP +3)

TERMITE DESTROYER, GUNSHIP

DOCKYARDS: Wala dockyards, Karrash (Nanite armor, HP +3, EP –1)

CLASS: III (length 60 meters)

EP: 4

HP: 9

MANEUVERABILITY: +2

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 5

SPEED: 3

MODULES: Hangar (1 solar drone), docking station, meditation chamber (4×5 combined cabins and stasis beds), mining station, cargo hold (2×50 tons)

WEAPONS: Torpedo room (2×4 fractal torpedoes, 1×8 fractal torpedo mines, 1×4 breach torpedoes (five soldiers in each), meson cannon, data pulse

FEATURES: Stealth Technology (Signature –1), Sensitive Sensors ×3 (DATA DJINN +3), Darkness Propulsion (Maneuverability +2, Speed +1), Ablative Armor (–3 damage to one hit), Bonus Modules

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BUTTERFLY SHIP, COURIER SHIP

DOCKYARDS: Rosh dockyards, Ainios (Sensor deflectors equivalent to the Stealth Technology Feature ×2)

CLASS: III (length 40 meters)

EP: 5

HP: 6

MANEUVERABILITY: +4

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 5

SPEED: 5

MODULES: Cargo hold (50 tons), docking station, chapel, meditation chamber (6 combined cabins and stasis beds)

WEAPONS: Torpedo room (2×4 fractal torpedoes), meson cannon (no Armor roll), countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Super Sensors (8 CU), Advanced Countermeasures, Turbo Projectorer ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2), Darkness Propulsion (Maneuverability +2, Speed +1)

SUN DRONE, INTERCEPTOR

DOCKYARDS: Rosh dockyards, Ainios (Sensor deflectors equivalent to the Stealth Technology Feature ×2)

CLASS: I (length 6 meters)

EP: 4

HP: 2

MANEUVERABILITY: +6

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 3

SPEED: 7

WEAPONS: Meson cannon, data pulse, countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Advanced Ship Intelligence (Attribute 3, Skill 3, no organic crew needed), Supercharged Reactor (EP +1), Darkness Propulsion (Maneuverability +2, Speed +1), Turbo Projector ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2),

AB-MUSALAI, TYPICAL COURIER SHIP (NAZAREEM)

DOCKYARDS: Sahá dockyards, Zhau-B (RANGED COMBAT +2 when firing data meme)

CLASS: III (length 51 meters)

EP: 5

HP: 6

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: 0

ARMOR: 5

SPEED: 2

MODULES 10: Docking station, cabins (1×5 standard), chapel, cargo hold (2×50 tons), escape pods (2 pods, 10 people), stasis hold (1×20 beds), workshop, medlab

WEAPONS: Data meme, acc cannon, thermal cannon, countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Hidden Weapons ×3 (invisible module, can only be detected on a critically successful sensor roll), Atmospheric Entry, Bonus Modules, Research Computer, Blessed Ship

ALEA-QURAB, TYPICAL SHUTTLE (NAZAREEM)

DOCKYARDS: The abandoned Rashanda naval base, Melik (Maneuverability +2, Armor –2)

CLASS: II (length 18 meters)

EP: 4

HP: 4

MANEUVERABILITY: +3

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 2

SPEED: 4

MODULES 6: Cabins (5 coffins), chapel, escape pods (1 pod, 5 people), stasis hold (5 beds)

WEAPONS: Auto cannon, heavy acc cannon

FEATURES: Hidden Weapons ×2 (invisible module, can only be detected on a critically successful sensor roll), Atmospheric Entry, Precise Thrusters (PILOT +2 when docking, landing and taking evasive maneuvers)

Patrick Carroll (Order #46211587)

THE ZENITHIAN FLEET IN EXILE

The black and gold ships of the disbanded Legion have joined forces with the remains of the Hegemony's sleek fleet. The flagship Asarita – impossible to outmaneuver and crewed by three hundred top-trained veterans – leads the defense of the new home world, Amedo, together with the rest of the squadrons that survived the Fall of Coriolis.

- **WEAR** (Many of the ships were permanently damaged by the Monolith's discharge or have been in active service for far too long because of the decimation of the fleet. Make an extra roll on the Ship Wear table to account for this (Coriolis core rulebook, page 155))

JHADERA CLASS DESTROYER (EX-LEGION)

MODERN VERSION OF THE ZAFIRAH-CLASS DESTROYER.

DOCKYARDS: Sarinda naval base, Anaspora

(MANEUVERABILITY +1, EP –1)

CLASS: IV (length 300 meters)

WEAR: One roll on the Ship Wear table

EP: 5

HP: 10

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: +2

ARMOR: 7

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Hangar ×2 (1 shuttle, 4 fighters), medlab, workshop, cabins (2×20 standard), cargo hold, service module, stasis hold (80 beds), escape pods (2×4 pods, 40 people)

WEAPONS: Acc cannon ×2, meson cannon, torpedo room ×2 (2 nuclear torpedoes, 2 ion torpedoes, 4 plasma torpedoes), data pulse, countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Advanced Targeting Computer (DATA DJINN +1 when locking onto targets), Robust Hull (HP +1), ED Fields ×3 (stasis hold, bridge, cabins)

ASARITA, FLAGSHIP (THE ZENITHIAN HEGEMONY)

DOCKYARDS: Harima dockyards, Kua (EP +1, HP –1)

CLASS: V (length 1,000 meters)

EP: 8

HP: 14

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 9

SPEED: 3

MODULES 40: Docking station ×2, hangar ×9 (4 gunships, 4 shuttles, 64 fighters), cabins (1×320 coffins for soldiers 4×80 standard for crew), stasis hold (2×320), escape pods (8×16 pods, 128 people), chapel, medlab, cargo hold (2×1,000 tons), service module, workshop

WEAPONS: Nestera Mangler ×2, autocannon ×2, countermeasure dispenser, data pulse, torpedo room ×2 (16 nuclear mines)

FEATURES: Ablative Armor ×3 (–3 damage to three hits), Advanced Targeting Computer (DATA DJINN +1 when locking onto targets), Robust Hull ×3 (HP +3), Turbo Projector ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2)

JINAAN CLASS TORPEDO SHIP (EX-LEGION)

DOCKYARDS: Alhudu naval base, Kuan asteroid belt (Armor +1, –1 module)

CLASS: II (length 68 meters)

WEAR: One roll on the Ship Wear table

EP: 4

HP: 4

MANEUVERABILITY: +1

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 5

SPEED: 4

MODULES: Escape pod (1 pod), stasis hold (4 beds)

WEAPONS: Advanced torpedo room (4 torpedoes), torpedo room (8 ion torpedo mines), countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Ship System (sensor operator, Attribute 3, Skill 3) Advanced Countermeasures (RANGED COMBAT +1), Advanced Torpedoes (–1 to countermeasures and defensive barrage)

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MATAH CLASS FIGHTER (EX-LEGION)

DOCKYARDS: Alhudu naval base, Kuan asteroid belt (Armor +1, –1 module)

CLASS: I (length 11 meters)

EP: 3

HP: 2

MANEUVERABILITY: +3

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 4

SPEED: 5

MODULES: Acc cannon, data pulse

FEATURES: Ejector, Tuned Accelerator (**PILOT** +2 to the advance/retreat action), Turbo Projector (Maneuverability +1, Speed +1)

***THE GOSHAWK*, SIN-TASHAD CLASS GUNSHIP (THE ZENITHIAN HEGEMONY)**

DOCKYARDS: Harima dockyards, Kua (EP +1, HP –1)

CLASS: III (length 36 meters)

WEAR: One roll on the Ship Wear table

EP: 4

HP: 1

MANEUVERABILITY: +4

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 3

SPEED: 6

MODULES: Heavy acc cannon, autocannon, data pulse

FEATURES: Atmospheric Entry, Turbo Projector ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2), Precise Thrusters (**PILOT** +2 on evasive maneuvers)

***THE JUNGLE SWIFT*, AIB-ASWAD CLASS FIGHTER (THE ZENITHIAN HEGEMONY)**

DOCKYARDS: Harima dockyards, Kua (EP +1, HP –1)

CLASS: I (length 9 meters)

EP: 4

HP: 1

MANEUVERABILITY: +4

SIGNATURE: –2

ARMOR: 3

SPEED: 6

MODULES: Heavy acc cannon, autocannon, data pulse

FEATURES: Atmospheric Entry, Turbo Projector ×2 (Maneuverability +2, Speed +2), Precise Thrusters (**PILOT** +2 on evasive maneuvers)

THE FLEET OF THE ORDER OF THE PARIAH

The backbone of the fleets of the Order are the enormous monastery cruisers who led the exodus out of the Second Horizon to Zalos and the Crown of the Martyr. The original fleet suffered heavy losses during the Portal Wars but two of the legendary flagships still live: The Hammer of the Martyr, Shakoush-M'hatoun, and the Fire of Amshaar, the Naar-Amshaar. The other monastery cruisers, including the famous scroll ship Belit-Sheri, were built shortly before or during the Portal Wars to strengthen the Martyr's devotees against the assault of darkness. The cruiser crews number between eight and twelve hundred souls including ground and breach troops, many of whom live out their entire adult lives onboard the ships in service of the Martyr. More modern additions to the fleet include the Rumh and Altihl class destroyers – dark, decorated and heavily armored with terrifying torpedo lances – and the smaller, more mobile, Alnakhi patrol ships and insect-like Nasia class fighters.

NEW SECOND HORIZON SHIP TECH:

- **FRACTAL HULL** (Docks: The original tech on which the Order's glyph armor is based. Adaptive alloys in the hull strengthen areas about to be hit and form sensor absorbing surfaces. Signature –2, HP +2. Only for ships built in Aldaan-B. Can be combined with Glyph Armor.)

ORDER OF THE PARIAH SHIP TECH:

- **GLYPH ARMOR** (Feature +15%: Only for ship classes III-V. Painted fractal hull covered in Martyr praise that saps the kinetic energy from incoming fire as well as providing a +1 to Armor. Negates all damage from one ranged attack of your choice after normal Armor rolls. One use per combat. Generates 3 DP for a negated torpedo strike, 2 DP for other attacks. Only for ships built or retrofitted in Zalos.)
- **S PROPULSION** (Feature +5%: Only for ship classes I-III, requires Antimatter Rockets. Creates tiny quantum singularities to propel the ship forward. At the cost of 1 DP, the pilot may perform a free two segment move on the battle map once per turn (no **PILOT** roll, no EP cost). Only for ships built in Zalos.)
- **OSSUARY** (Feature +5%: Ships in classes III-V may have ossuaries instead of chapels onboard. Dead crew members are interred in the bone chambers. Deep, powerful preparatory prayer in the name of the Martyr grants a +3 to all Judge rerolls (**RANGED COMBAT** and **COMMAND**), +2 to prayer rerolls for one other Icon and +1 to all other prayer rerolls for the entire crew.)

Patrick Carroll (Order #46211587)

SHAKUSH-M'HATOUN & NAAR-AMSHAAR, FLAGSHIPS

DOCKYARDS: Sachara docks, Aldaan-B (retrofitted at Karrmerruk, Zalos) (Fractal Hull, Signature –2 and HP +2, plus the Antimatter Rockets Feature)

CLASS: V (length 1,800 meters)

EP: 7

HP: 17

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: +1

ARMOR: 10

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×2, hangar ×5 (1 destroyer, 2 patrol ships carrying 4 fighters each, 32 fighters), cabins (2×320 coffins for ground troops, 7×80 standard for crew, 1×20 suites for command), stasis hold (4×320), escape pods (4×16 pods, 64 people), chapel ×4, medlab ×2, cargo hold (4×1,000 tons), mining station, service module, workshop ×2

WEAPONS: Heavy acc cannon ×2, autocannon ×2, thermal cannon, torpedo room ×4 (8 antimatter torpedoes, 4 plasma torpedoes, 4 breach torpedoes for boarding), countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), Glyph Armor, Robust Hull ×3 (HP +3), Arboretum, Advanced Countermeasures (RANGED COMBAT +1), Bonus Modules ×2 (10 modules), Ossuary ×4

NABI-GHADIB, TYPICAL MONASTERY CRUISER

DOCKYARDS: Karrmerruk, Zalos (Feature: Antimatter Rockets)

CLASS: V (length 1,100 meters)

EP: 7

HP: 14

MANEUVERABILITY: 0

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 10

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station, hangar ×3 (1 patrol ship carrying 4 fighters, 32 fighters), cabins (1×320 coffins for ground troops, 6×80 standard for crew, 1×20 suites for command), stasis hold (3×320), escape pods (8×16 pods, 128 people), chapel ×2, medlab, cargo hold (2×1,000 tons), service module, workshop

WEAPONS: Acc cannon, autocannon, thermal cannon, torpedo room ×3 (4 plasma torpedoes, 4 standard torpedoes, 4 breach torpedoes for boarding), countermeasure dispenser, data pulse

FEATURES: Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), Glyph Armor, Robust Hull ×2 (HP +2), Arboretum, Salvage Unit, Ossuary ×2

RUMH CLASS HEAVY DESTROYER

DOCKYARDS: Karrmerruk, Zalos (Feature: Antimatter Rockets)

CLASS: IV (length 250 meters)

EP: 6

HP: 11

MANEUVERABILITY: +1

SIGNATURE: +2

ARMOR: 8

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station, hangar ×2 (16 fighters), cabins (1×80 coffins, 1×20 standard), stasis hold (1×80), escape pods (4×4 pods,16 people), chapel, medlab, cargo holds (1×250 tons internal, 1×1,000 tons external), service module, workshop

WEAPONS: Acc cannon ×2, autocannon, torpedo room ×4 (8 standard torpedoes, 4 plasma torpedoes, 4 breach torpedoes for boarding), countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), Glyph Armor, Atmospheric Entry, Robust Hull ×2 (HP +2), Advanced Torpedoes (–1 to countermeasures and defensive barrage), External Cargo, Ossuary, Bonus Modules (5 modules)

ALTIHL CLASS DESTROYER

DOCKYARDS: Karrmerruk, Zalos (Feature: Antimatter Rockets)

CLASS: III (length 120 meters)

EP: 5

HP: 6

MANEUVERABILITY: +2

SIGNATURE: –1

ARMOR: 6

SPEED: 2

MODULES: Cabins (1×20 coffins), cargo hold (1×50 ton), chapel, medlab, stasis hold (1×20)

WEAPONS: Acc cannon, ion cannon, torpedo room ×3 (8 ion torpedoes, 4 plasma torpedoes), countermeasure dispenser

FEATURES: Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), S Propulsion, Glyph Armor, Atmospheric Entry, Ejector, Stealth Technology (Signature –1), Super Sensors (Extreme range)

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ALNAKHI CLASS PATROL SHIP
DOCKYARDS: Karrmerruk, Zalos
CLASS: III (length 68 meters)
EP: 5
HP: 7
MANEUVERABILITY: +2
SIGNATURE: 0
ARMOR: 6
SPEED: 2
MODULES: Docking station, cabins (1×20 coffins), chapel, escape pods (2 pods, 10 people), stasis hold (1×20), hangar ×4 (4 fighters), service module
WEAPONS: Ion cannon
FEATURES: Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), Robust Hull (HP +1), Sensitive Sensors (DATA DJINN +1)

NASIA CLASS FIGHTER
DOCKYARDS: Karrmerruk, Zalos
CLASS: I (length 11 meters)
EP: 3
HP: 2
MANEUVERABILITY: +4
SIGNATURE: –2
ARMOR: 3
SPEED: 4
WEAPONS: Acc cannon, data pulse
FEATURES: Ejector, Antimatter Rockets (Maneuverability +2), Atmospheric Entry, Sensitive Sensors (DATA DJINN +1)

THE THIRD HORIZON AND THE NOMAD FLEET

The home of the Mogul clans, the gigantic flagship *Vaharwala*, led the nomad swarms into the Third Horizon together with her younger siblings *Bhartena*, *Ghôl-Sarbh* and *Magratûrk*. Council ships, armed family ships, converted destroyers, freighters and shuttles make up the multicolored frenzy surrounding the black, glyph-covered hulls of the majestic battleships like huge schools of tropical fish around a coral reef. The nomad fleet is larger than the rest of the Third Horizon's fleets combined but mainly consists of class IIIs and a couple of class IVs. Many of the ships listed below can be used as generic military, civilian and corsair vessels throughout the Horizon if you take away the nomad-specific Features.

NOMAD FLEET SHIP TECH AND FEATURES:

- **STAR SEERS** (Feature: Ship classes III–V usually have at least one Kahin onboard, a mystic trained by the Federation to interpret the streams between the portal fields. These crew members grant a +2 to **DATA DJINN** when calculating jump vectors and the Feature may be chosen up to (Class–2) times. This means a class V ship may have three tiers of the Star Seers Feature, for example.)
- **FRACTAL HULL** (Docks: Adaptive alloys in the hull strengthen areas about to be hit and form sensor absorbing surfaces. Signature –2, HP +2. Only for ships built in Aldaan-B which for the Nomad Federation means only the class V battleships.)
- **FAMILY SHIP** (Feature +10%: Nomad engineers and dock workers are skilled at turning cramped ships into homes for large families. Calculate the capacity of the cabins, escape pod and stasis hold modules as if they were one ship class higher. These three module types also count as being protected by ED Fields. Classes I–IV simply fit more people as per one entry higher on the tables and for class Vs, double the numbers listed. The ship gets a +1 to its Signature stat as the peculiar alterations made to the base design make them easier to spot.
- **SUPERCHARGED REACTOR** (Feature +15%: Centuries of expertise passed down through the generations have made nomad reactors and energy distribution systems veritable works of art. Each tier of the Feature gives the ship 2 extra EP. Class I ships may not purchase this Feature, classes II and III may purchase it once and classes IV and V may get it twice.)

Many nomad ships will have the Ship System Feature for the pilot, sensor operator and gunner positions so the ship can defend itself as it emerges from a portal, before the crew are fully thawed out.

Patrick Carroll (Order #46211587)

VAHARWALA, FLAGSHIP

DOCKYARDS: Sachara docks, Aldaan-B (retrofitted in the Quadrant of the Pillar) (Fractal Hull, Signature –2 and HP +2)

CLASS: V (length 1,600 meters)

EP: 11

HP: 17

MANEUVERABILITY: –2

SIGNATURE: +2

ARMOR: 9

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×2, hangar ×6 (2 light destroyers, 4 freighters), cabins (3×160 standard, 3×40 suites for elder council families), escape pods (6×16 pods, 960 people), stasis hold (2×640), cargo hold (5×1,000 tons), service module, workshop, medlab ×2, chapel ×2

WEAPONS: Ion missile, heavy acc cannon ×2, ion cannon ×3, autocannon ×2, data pulse ×2, countermeasure dispenser ×2, torpedo room ×5 (8 ion torpedoes, 4, standard torpedoes, 8 breach torpedoes with soldiers)

FEATURES: Fractal Hull, Star Seers ×3 (DATA DJINN +6 on portal jumps), Robust Hull ×3 (HP +3), Family Ship, Supercharged Reactor ×2 (EP +4), Ablative Armor ×3 (–3 damage to three hits), Ship System (Pilot, Gunner and Sensor Operator, Attribute 3, Skill 3), Arboretum, Bonus Modules ×2 (10 modules)

BHARTENA, GHÔL-SARBH & MAGRATÛRK, BATTLESHIPS

DOCKYARDS: Sachara docks, Aldaan-B (retrofitted in the Quadrant of the Pillar)
(Fractal Hull, Signature –2 and HP +2)

CLASS: V (length 900 meters)

EP: 9

HP: 14

MANEUVERABILITY: –2

SIGNATURE: +2

ARMOR: 9

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×4, hangar ×2 (2 corsair ships), cabins (2×160 standard, 2×40 suites for elder council families), escape pods (5×16 pods, 800 people), stasis hold (1×640), cargo hold (2×1,000 tons internal, 2×4,000 tons external), mining station, service module, medlab ×2, chapel ×2, workshop, salvage module ×2

WEAPONS: Acc cannon ×2, autocannon ×2, data pulse, countermeasure dispenser, torpedo room ×5 (8 ion torpedoes, 4 standard torpedoes, 16 mines)

FEATURES: Fractal Hull, Star Seers ×2 (DATA DJINN +4 on portal jumps), Family Ship, Supercharged Reactor (EP +2), Salvage Unit, External Cargo, Ship System (Pilot and Sensor Operator, Attribute 3, Skill 3)

TYPICAL COUNCIL SHIP

DOCKYARDS: Unknown

CLASS: IV (length 350 meters)

EP: 6

HP: 11

MANEUVERABILITY: –1

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 7

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station, hangar ×2 (2 freighters), cabins (3×80 standard, 4×20 suites for elder council families), escape pods (4×16 pods, 320 people), stasis hold (2×160), cargo hold (1,000 tons), workshop, medlab, chapel

WEAPONS: Light acc cannon, autocannon, countermeasure dispenser, data meme, data pulse

FEATURES: Family Ship, Star Seers ×2 (DATA DJINN +4 on portal jumps), Trauma Lab (MEDICURGY +4, CRIT +5), Robust Hull ×2 (HP +2), Bonus Modules (5 modules)

TYPICAL FAMILY SHIP

DOCKYARDS: Unknown

CLASS: IV (length 200 meters)

EP: 8

HP: 9

MANEUVERABILITY: –1

SIGNATURE: +3

ARMOR: 7

SPEED: 1

MODULES: Docking station ×2, hangar ×2 (2 shuttles), cabins (1×80 standard, 2×20 suites), escape pods (2×16 pods, 160 people), stasis hold (1×160), cargo hold (1×1,000 tons internal, 1×4,000 tons external), workshop, medlab, chapel, service module

WEAPONS: Autocannon ×2, countermeasure dispenser, data meme

FEATURES: Family Ship, Supercharged Reactor (EP +2), External Cargo

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TYPICAL LIGHT DESTROYER
DOCKYARDS: Unknown
CLASS: III (length 110 meters)
EP: 7
HP: 7
MANEUVERABILITY: 0
SIGNATURE: +1
ARMOR: 5
SPEED: 2
MODULES: Docking station, cabins (1×80 coffins for cattle or passengers, 1×20 standard for crew), escape pods (1×4 pods, 20 people), stasis hold (1×80), medlab, chapel, service module, cargo hold (2×50 tons)
WEAPONS: Light acc cannon, heavy acc cannon, torpedo room ×2 (4 standard torpedoes, 8 mines), countermeasure dispenser
FEATURES: Family Ship, Supercharged Reactor (EP +2), Robust Hull (HP +1), Super Sensors (Extreme range), Tuned Accelerator (PILOT +2 on the advance/retreat action), Ship System (Pilot, Attribute 3, Skill 3), Atmospheric Entry

TYPICAL FREIGHTER/CORSAIR
DOCKYARDS: Unknown
CLASS: III (length 40 meters)
EP: 7
HP: 6
MANEUVERABILITY: +1
SIGNATURE: 0
ARMOR: 5
SPEED: 3
MODULES: Docking station, cabins (1×20 coffins), escape pods (2×2 pods, 20 people), stasis hold (1×20), medlab, chapel, workshop, cargo hold (1×50 tons internal, 1×200 tons external), smuggler's stash (10 tons)
WEAPONS: Acc cannon, autocannon, countermeasure dispenser/ion missiles (depending on if primarily freighter or corsair)
FEATURES: Supercharged Reactor (EP +2), External Cargo, Tuned Accelerator (PILOT +2 on the advance/retreat action), Turbo Projector (Maneuverability +1, Speed +1), Atmospheric Entry

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METAGAME SHEET

CORIOLIS

FLEET:

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FLEET:

WAR TURN	SYSTEM	STRENGTH	REINFORCE-MENTS
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FLEET:

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Nightmares and premonitions wake you in a cold sweat, panic tightening your chest. "It began with rolling fields and an invitation. An outstretched hand – whose hand? Then a starry sky and the emptiness of space. You couldn't breathe, your heart racing as you recognized a planet – the emerald – Kua, waiting for you. Glittering wings in the darkness surrounding you. Hundreds of butterflies followed by enormous shell-covered titans. A locust swarm coming to devour the Third Horizon."

In dreams and visions, something calls out into the dark space of the Third Horizon – a new presence or something old? It may hold the answers for the future – about a prophecy, the Chosen and the coming Horizon Wars.

***The Wake of the Icons* is the third and final part of *Mercy of the Icons*, the epic and richly illustrated campaign for *Coriolis – The Third Horizon*. This book contains:**

- **Extensive background information for the Gamemaster, describing the events which threaten the Third Horizon.**
- ***A Song for Kua:* The first scenario starts with a series of visions, bringing the characters back to Kua.**
- ***The Tenth Icon:* The second scenario sets the characters on a diplomatic mission to Sadaal to acquire the Nadir Flotilla as war in the Third Horizon grows closer.**
- ***The Horizon Wars:* In the final climactic scenario war breaks out and the characters must lead the people of the Third Horizon to victory.**
- **The Metagame where the Gamemaster and the players can play out the fleet movements and clashes of the war.**
- **An extensive Appendix containing over twenty different ship types that take part in the war of the horizons.**

"The game's authors describe it as 'Arabian Nights in space' and it fulfills that brief marvelously. Style 5/5, Substance 5/5."

RPG.NET REVIEW





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